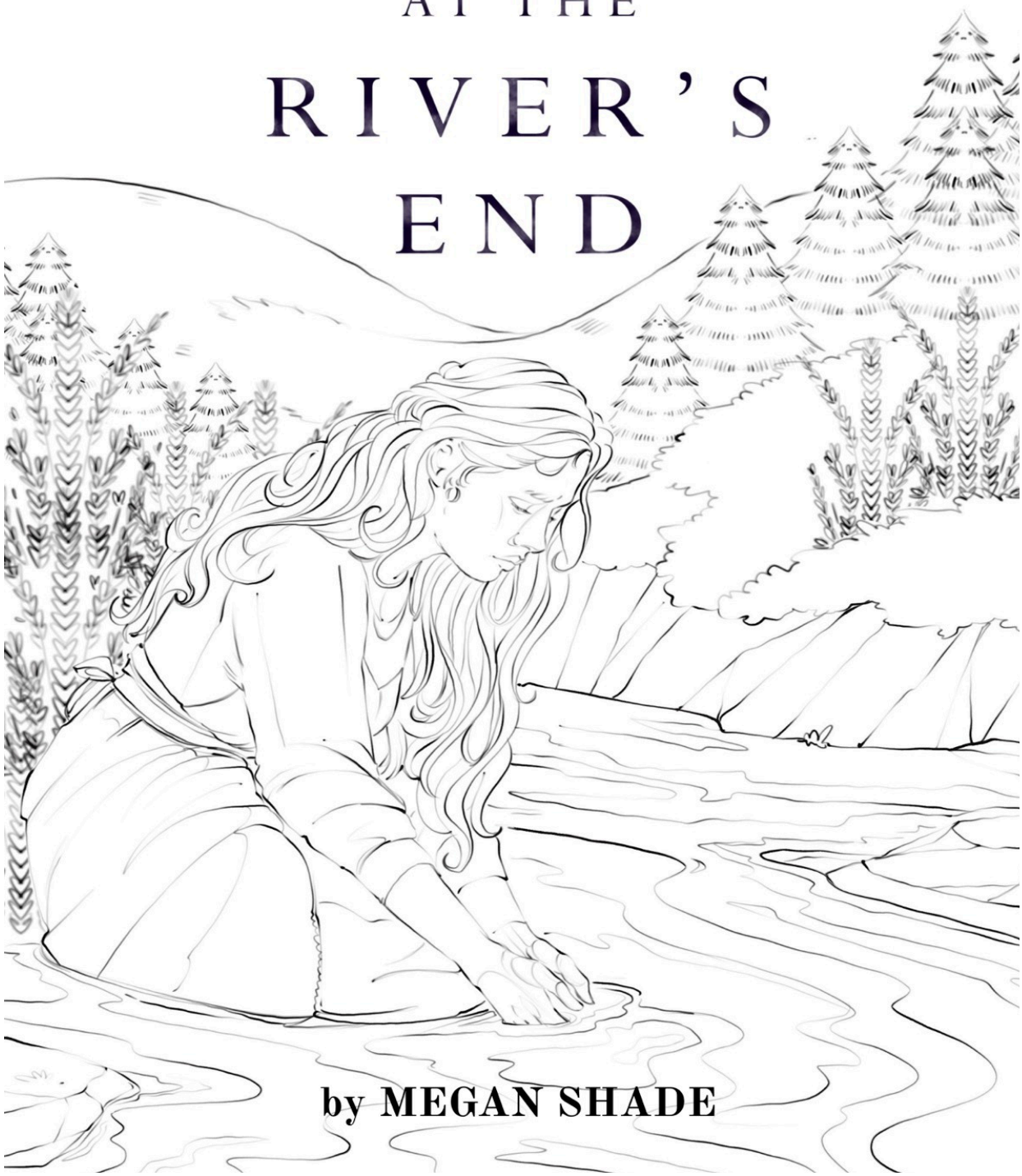

THE CURSE OF THE FATES SERIES
BOOK ONE
THE WASHWOMAN AT THE RIVER'S END
MEGAN SHADE

THE WASHWOMAN AT THE RIVER'S END



by MEGAN SHADE

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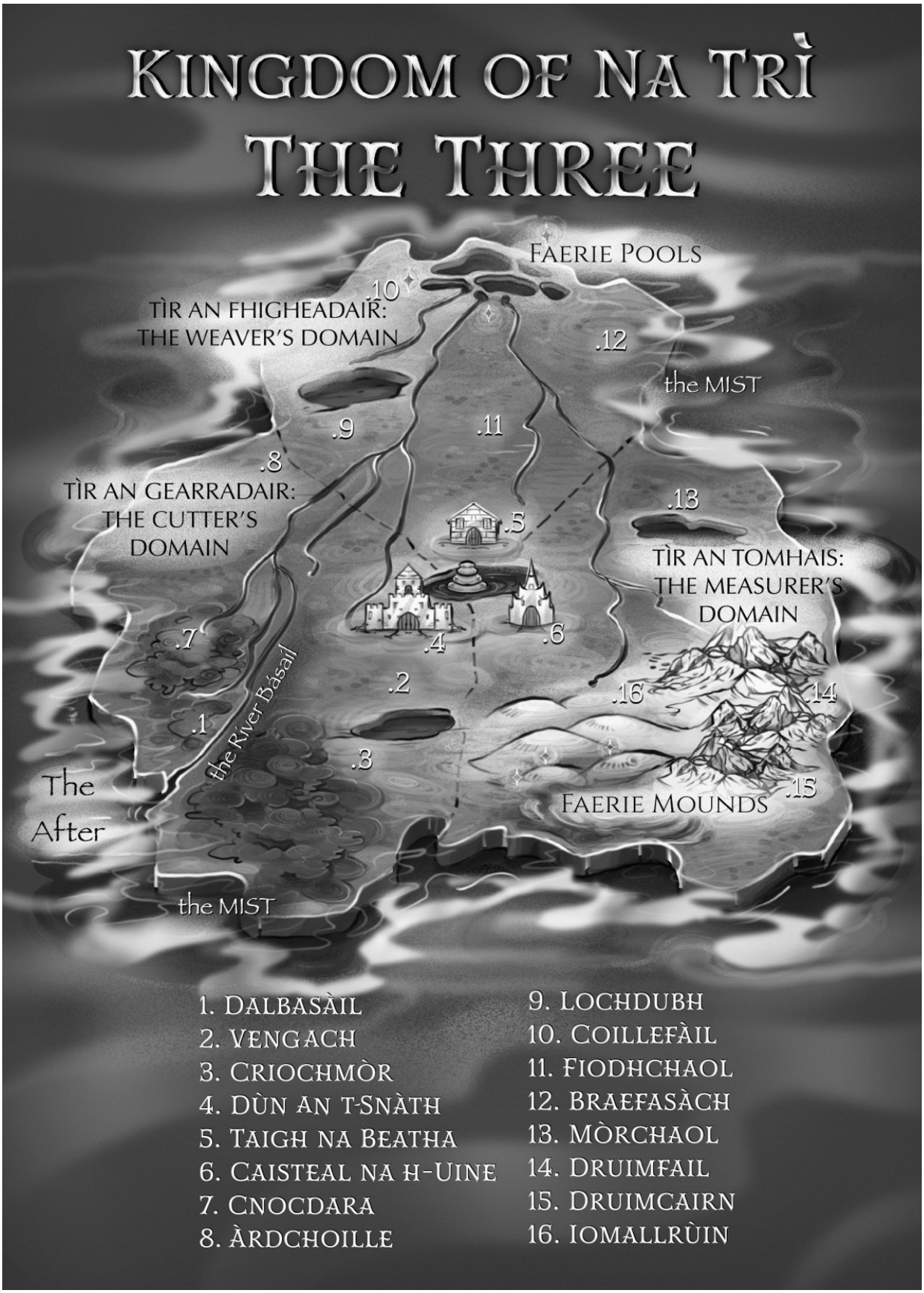
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This book includes adult themes, including language, severe physical assault, blood and gore, suicidal ideation, mention of child death, and sexual content, and is intended for readers 18+.


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AUTHORS NOTE

Language plays an important role in this story. Scots dialect is used in this book, and both Scottish Gaelic and Irish Gaelic appear at times as part of the beauty and magic of the world. All Gaelic phrases are translated within the text upon their first appearance.

Below are a few Scots words and phrases used:

No = Not

Didnae = Didn't

Couldnae = Couldn't

Havnae = Haven't

Isnae = Isn't

Fash = Worry

Ken = Know

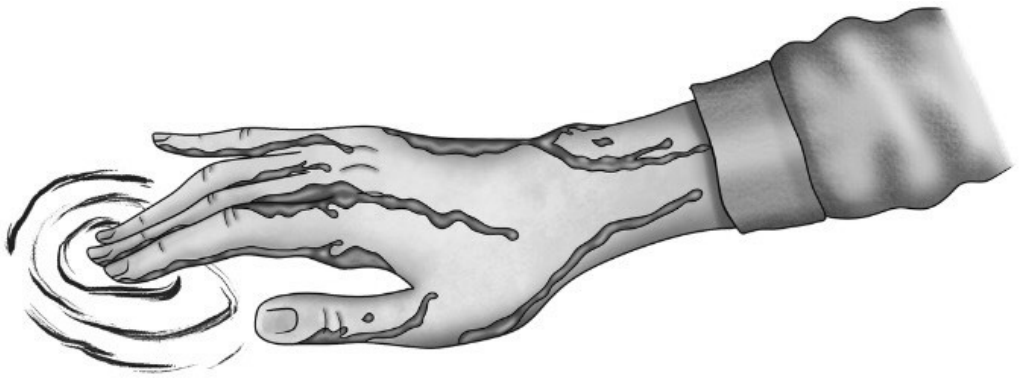
A glossary of terms is provided in the back matter for readers who wish to know the pronunciation of names, places, terms, etc, however, the glossary is not required to read and understand the story.

To Katie and Shanni, who truly helped make this book what it is.

And to Belmont Cameli, who I will forever dream will someday play Brennen in Washwoman's future film adaptation.

1

BEA



The blood on my palms will never wash clean.

Not in the frigid waters of the River Bàsail, where the valley descends into a rocky glen, and mist curls and creeps amongst the pines like beckoning sìth. And not with the tears that sting my eyes as I inspect the smattering of red in the soft infant dress in my hands.

It's a beautiful gown, the color of marsh marigolds, but dots of crimson mar the lace, their dark centers fading to rust as they spread outward like thistle crowns.

The blotches are stubborn, but I'm not discouraged. This dress, unlike my hands, I will be able to cleanse.

Magic slides along my tongue, cold and bitter, pulling my song from my throat as I work, but I do not fight it. Without my voice to call this soul home, she will wander the moors forever, unable to go to her rest.

Come follow the river. Do not be afraid.

Her mistress will find you by the end of the day.

You cannot escape her, be you goddess or maid.

So follow my river. Do not be afraid.

I continue to sing as I check the pockets, a heavy lump of disappointment settling in my stomach when I find them empty, but I'm no stranger to the feeling. I quickly push it away. This child's passing should not be tainted by my own selfish longing for freedom. Still, a sliver of it remains, lingering.

Clearing my throat, I begin my song again. I work the fabric along the pebbled riverbed, forcing myself to concentrate on the stains rather than my own misfortune and chastising myself for that flicker of hope. Why would an infant be carrying anything at all, let alone one of the relics needed to break this wretched curse binding me to this shore?

The blood finally loosens, unfurling into vermillion trails that dance like ribbons in the current as they float downstream and disappear into the dense black fog of the *After*. The place the river ends, where dark mist spills down into whatever comes after we take our final breath.

I do not rush the cleansing of the bairn's soul, inspecting every inch of the dress. If I've received her clothes, the Cutter will be preparing to sever her thread. She'll pass within minutes, as will the other souls I've already washed today. Souls that will soon rest in the old temple graveyard in Sterlargh, half a kingdom away.

A temple that, any moment now, will collapse, crushing every last person inside its hallowed walls. I've seen it in my mind thirty-three times this morning. Thirty-three faces twisting in terror as they reach for their loved ones. Thirty-three names softly spoken on the wind.

My grip tightens on the fabric as the disaster plays out in my mind once more, my vision blurring as tears spill over my lashes and trail down my cheeks.

It's not often I weep for the dying. Not anymore, at least. After a century of this endless loop, death has simply become a part of life—threads woven, measured, and eventually, cut.

But today is different. So many people will lose their lives at once, and their deaths will not be peaceful.

It's the worst part of my curse, I think. Being forced to know the cause of every death in the kingdom before it happens, but unable to stop it. Even a monster like myself isn't immune to such sorrow, and so I weep for the infant in the yellow-lace gown. For all of them.

It's not until I'm certain the clothing is pristine that I let it drift from my fingers and allow the river to carry it away. I stare after the dress, my heart

aching as long, inky shadows strain toward me, pulling the garment faster than the water can carry it until it disappears into the black mist.

I dip my hand into the river, then place my fingers over my aching heart. “An Glèidheadair, welcome her,” I whisper, then bring them to my lips. “An Treòraiche, guide her.” And finally, I touch my forehead. “Am Breitheamh, have mercy on her.”

The wind finally eases, the soft purple heather scattered along the glen going still, and I close my eyes, giving myself one final moment to grieve before pulling myself together to carry on. I sigh, sitting back on my heels and wiping my palms on my wool apron. It’s an old habit, and one that changes nothing. The deep red blood that stains my palms and trails up my forearms remains, as does the memory of where it came from. The reason I will be chained to this river for the rest of my immortal life.

It floods back to me with a startling clarity—the people I killed, their screams—as if the Cutter asked her sister to weave the sound into my memory to ensure I would never, ever, forget what I did.

As if I could.

I sink onto the cold stones, moving the heavy, thick chain around my ankle so I have room to curl my legs beneath me. Icy water soaks through my skirt, and I exhale slowly, giving the echo of screams ringing through my skull back to the river. It does no good to dwell on my past. Not when it cannot be washed away.

Closing my eyes, I try to remember a time when my washing felt this sorrowful. A day the dead’s faces remained in my mind for longer than the minutes it took to sing my song and cleanse their souls.

It was decades ago. Maybe longer.

Years and years that passed while I served my sentence, my pathetic excuse for a life becoming nothing more than a legend. A myth. A tale mothers tell their children at night to frighten them into behaving.

I am the Washwoman. The Murderess of the River Bàsail. The Bean-Nighe, and nothing more.

I glance toward the trees. At least no one has come to find me today. That part of my curse might be worse, actually, than the premonitions of death. The Fates’ way to ensure I’m always balancing on the edge of worry, never able to feel wholly at ease.

Find me, catch me, and I must answer your question. Anything at all, except how to stop death. It’s the question they almost always ask. The

reason most brave seeking out the monster at the river, and when I cannot help them, they do not leave me unscathed.

A shadow passes over me, and I shiver from the chill as I look up to where an enormous dragon, longer than a fir tree is tall, swoops across the sun. She's stunning, a blue so deep she's almost violet, with a long neck and spines from horns to tail. Here most days at sunrise and sunset, her wings are so thin and iridescent, it looks as if they're embedded with millions of tiny diamonds.

Sometimes, she stays above the valley for hours, and I imagine she's mine. In reality, I think she's here to ensure I don't escape again, merely following the orders of the Cutter's dragon, Athair, but I like to pretend otherwise.

Pretending is one of the few freedoms I have left.

I rise to my feet, holding out my arms and tipping my face toward the misty, cloud-filled sky. My heart surges, as if it's forgotten I'm chained to these rocks. As if it thinks that if I could only harness the wind, I could fly alongside my dragon, so far and high that even the Fates themselves wouldn't be able to find us.

As if reading my thoughts, the shadows of the *After* reach toward me in long, wandering ribbons. Stretching and twisting like they yearn to pull me down below. For the thousandth time, I close my eyes and listen to the water as it disappears down the drop off. It trickles rather than crashes, and even though there's not enough length on my chain to peer through the black, I feel like I can imagine it clearly—a series of steps climbing down until they reach the end of this realm and the beginning of the next.

The darkness is my friend, and these shadows my only company.

Come to me, they taunt, *and your pain will end. Come to me, and finally rest.*

And oh, how I long to. It is my perpetual wish—to end this cursed, immortal life. I've imagined death so often, it feels like an old lover. Someone I cannot resist pining for. Someone I'm so intimately familiar with, and yet, somehow, they're still a stranger to me, eternally out of my reach.

There was a time I thought I might be able to find my way into the *After* without the spell. Or at least, I hoped I would. Back when the agony of my imprisonment was stronger than my reason, and I hadn't yet cared about penance or redemption. When I'd felt nothing but utter defeat.

“Take me!” I would scream, begging, fighting against my chain in my desperation to reach it. Straining toward the darkness like a rabid animal, singularly focused on ending their relentless torture.

I have tried to end my life a hundred ways. Starving myself. Drowning. Slitting my wrists with the sharp edge of a broken stone. Others have done even worse.

But I no longer try. It doesn’t matter what I do to myself—or what anyone else does to me. I always heal, no matter the severity of my injuries. I may waste away until I am too weak to stand, but even then, my body does not change. I never die, and I cannot stop washing. The curse will not allow it.

The wind picks up again, and my arms fall back to my sides, heavy with defeat.

“Not again,” I whisper. How can there be another death so soon, when my fingers are still cramping from washing the souls from the temple?

Magic pulls at my tired body as I wade back to shore, grabbing my stone and leaning forward to place my hands in the stream. I wait for the clothing to appear as I have thousands of times. It’s always the same. A name on the wind. A face in the water, their death playing out in my mind and the knowledge of when it will happen.

Except this time, it’s not.

My vision tilts, my head swimming as the river fades away, morphing into a sunny hillside. I scramble to stand, the feeling of soft grass beneath my feet so foreign, it itches. There’s a young woman in green down the hill, and she twirls in the sunlight, smiling as she reaches for a pale pink wildflower. Bagpipes soar into the valley surrounding her, a tune I’ve never heard before. A mother pats her young son's blonde head, and he laughs, just for a moment before the joyful sound cracks, and the vision shatters.

Once again, I am at my river.

I scramble back, unease churning in my stomach. That wasn’t death I saw.

That was *life*.

“No.” The word slips out. My first refusal in over a century.

The water stills—too smooth. Unnatural, as if a sudden spell has been cast upon it, and I hold my breath, hope blossoming somewhere deep in my chest.

Is the river listening to my plea?

She churns in answer, an abrupt shift that smothers any shred of hope in an instant as the water swirls in unnatural eddies, mud kicking up and turning the river a ruddy brown. The scent of bog-myrtle spreads until I'm choking on it, and a strange undertow pulls at my waterlogged hem. Something appears upstream, and I recoil as the garment finds my hands—a dress the softest shade of green.

The exact one the young woman picking wildflowers wore.

I try to stand, to get as far away from the river as I can. Dread works its way through my blood, my body knowing before my mind that I cannot cleanse this dress.

This girl is not meant to die. I don't know how I know it, but I'm as certain of it as my own name. She's meant to *live*. To twirl to music and laugh with her family.

And yet, here are her clothes.

Pain sears through my muscles as I fight against the magic holding me in place. My body jerks forward, fingernails clawing against cold stone as I try to push myself back, but I'm yanked to my knees again as if pulled by a hook beneath my ribs. An ugly noise bursts from my throat, startling me, a mix between a scream of frustration and a sob of agony.

I hadn't wanted to wash the clothes of the ones currently being crushed to death in the temple. I don't want to wash *any* of them, but at least they, like all the others, were Fate-sealed. This death—it *has* to be a mistake. I should've heard her name. Seen the cause of her death.

Closing my eyes, I try to summon the fire that once lived deep in my belly. I need to stop whatever is happening, but that fire has all but died out, doused by the water I kneel in day after day, year after year.

My fingers protest, cramping as I tighten my grip on the fabric, my breaths coming in shallow bursts as I fight to pull the dress to shore. Is it possible the Cutter didn't sever this thread? It didn't follow the pattern. Maybe without her death-clothes cleansed, the woman will continue to live. Her soul won't be called to the *After*. An Glèidheadair will never know to wait for her. An Treòraiche will not guide her, and Am Breitheamh will not have to judge her.

Maybe she will live out the rest of her life as it was originally measured, and in many years, after a long, happy life, I will be called by the wind to wash her clothes once it is truly her time.

Straightening, I steady my breath, my resolve turning from twill to iron.

I will not send this girl’s soul below.

Using every bit of my strength, I bunch the fabric into a ball and pull, but he river fights back, refusing to let me take what belongs to her.

“Please. Let me have it,” I beg. My muscles burn as I grit my teeth and wrench it upward. The dress lifts from the stream, and for a single moment, I think I’ve won. That maybe I am stronger than I’ve been made to believe.

But the river’s power is greater.

Always greater.

A crack of magic bows my back and guides my hands to plunge the garment deeper into the water. I am nothing more than a puppet on strings as my song tears from my throat against my will, and my fingers work at the stains. Singing is raw and painful, but I cannot resist. I fight against it with the meager energy I have left, my muscles burning, blood coating my tongue as I bite my lip, but I cannot stop myself from cleaning this dress any more than I can stop the river from flowing into the misty darkness.

“Mallachd ort!” *Damn you!* It isn’t right that I have no free will. That I’m helpless.

The air shudders. High above, my dragon keens, and the water surges, rough and demanding. With an angry lurch, the river rips the dress from my trembling fingers like a starving wolf lunging for its prey. Sorrow crashes through me, and I brace against the riverbed, chest heaving as I watch it swirl in the current until it’s swallowed by the darkness.

“Tha mi duilich,” I whisper, *I’m sorry*, but my voice is lost to the river’s rush. I jump when a roar sounds overhead. Goosebumps rise along my arms as I look up. Something is different. My dragon is lower than usual, close enough to see a scar I’ve never noticed before—tight and muted along the underside of her belly.

She swoops again, even lower, and this time she lets out a despondent wail.

I scramble to my feet, ignoring the throb in my ankle.

The air beneath her wings pushes down into the glen. The water goes choppy, and the trees surrounding the river bend beneath the weight of it. My long red hair whips around my face, and my heart pounds against my ribs. Terror rises within me. Or is it awe?

Whatever it is, it’s magnificent.

My dragon roars, circles and arcs, swoops and twirls, her movements frantic, almost as if she’s searching for something.

Could she be searching for me?

The thought thrills me.

With another roar, she sends a bolt of fire through the sky, lighting up the twilight in a brilliant explosion of orange and gold.

I should be afraid. Her power is so immense, it stings my cheeks with a heat I have missed for so long, but I don’t have the urge to cower. Instead, I scramble up onto a small boulder to get closer. It’s the most incredible thing I’ve seen in a century, and I want to savor every second. Enjoy every moment of this beauty.

But beneath that beauty, I feel it. Something foreboding and dangerous. Something shifting. Why is she acting like this only now? For years, she’s been nothing but calm. A steady, persistent presence lazily exploring the foggy, grey sky.

“Did you feel it, too, Lolly?” I call up to her, hair still flying around my face from the whooshing of air beneath her wings. “That death… It wasn’t right.”

My dragon's head whips in my direction, and for a moment, I think she’s going to answer me. That maybe, after so many years of one-sided conversations, she’ll finally acknowledge my existence. But her eyes slide right past me, unseeing, until they land on the *After*.

I follow her gaze, wondering if the girl’s soul is already below.

An eerie, expectant silence descends over the glen, and I pause. When moments ago Lolly cried and beat her wings, there is now complete and utter calm.

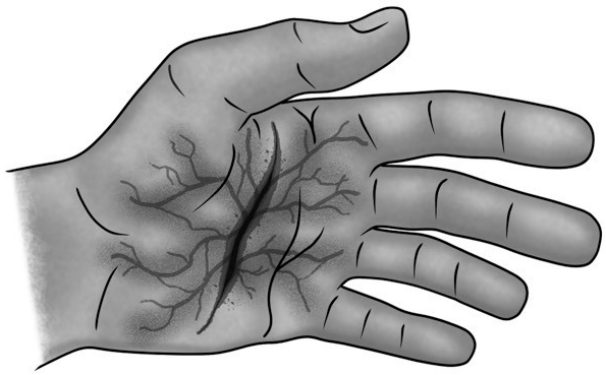
The hair on the back of my neck stands on end as I tear my eyes from the *After* and look back up.

For the first time in a century, I get my wish.

My dragon has landed.

2

BRENNEN



It takes six hundred and ninety-seven steps to reach the dead.

Each Samhain, I count them.

Every time I make the ascent—cursing the village elders for choosing a hilltop in the sky to bury those we've lost—I wonder, o' all places, why *here*? The first few climbs, I thought we must bury our dead on these hills to bring their souls closer to Solas, but that cannae be it. The only goddesses that care for them now are below.

My muscles burn with exertion as I continue upward, the need for vengeance that has made a home inside my ribcage the only thing carrying me forward. The trek is harder than any training exercise, and each time I make it, I wonder about those who do not have the youth or stamina to take the journey.

It's the real reason the cemetery rests in this place, I think. You must earn your mourning here, and then one day, as time passes and your body tires, you're forced to let it go.

Except, even when my body fails me, I will not.

Not in this life, or the next.

Grief is all I have left, and I willnae surrender it.

The fog grows thicker the higher I go, but my dàn of sight warms on my shoulder, cutting through the thick mist and darkness as I crest the dreary hilltop. Smirr chills my bones, and the wind blows my hair into my eyes, but I dinnae bother to push it back as I reach out to touch the gate.

It’s cold beneath my fingers, but it does nothing to cool the white-hot rage that burns through my blood each time I set my eyes on the stones within it.

“Sìth dhaibhsan a tha a’ gabhail fois an seo,” I whisper. *Peace to those who rest here.*

My voice is hard, my heart racing as I wrap my fingers around the iron with a bone-breaking grip.

The metal joints shriek like the wail of a banshee as I push it open, echoing through the plot of land that holds nearly seventy graves; some so old, they’re crumbling to dust, and others so new, they shine even in the barest moonlight. The smell of peat rises from beneath my boots as I make my way toward the back of the cemetery, stepping over uneven patches of earth and lichen-covered stones.

Cold stings my nose, and white puffs of air float from my lungs as I turn toward the grave of the woman I make this journey for.

Marsaili Lennox.

My vision tunnels as I read the name of my geallta—my betrothed—the memory of her gasping for air as blood gurgled from her throat drowning out my pounding heartbeat.

I will *never* forget that sound.

I crouch and, using my sleeve, wipe away the dirt clinging to the sides of the gravestone until it's unblemished. The tightness in my chest grows as I open my sporran and unpack the contents within.

The ritual is familiar now, but I dinnae find comfort in it. Not when five Samhains have passed, and the goddess of death has refused to hear my plea.

With shaking hands, I stack six smooth rocks into a cairn—one for each year since Marsaili’s throat was slit in the dead of night. In front of it, I place the other items: yew, juniper, heather, rowan bark, and a thick white ribbon that once adorned my love’s long blonde hair. My breaths go shallow as I push my fingers into the cold ground above her grave, grab a handful of dirt, and sprinkle it on top.

The last of the sun disappears beneath the rolling hills, and I place my hand upon the pile, drawing magic from my dàn of warmth and concentrating it into my palm.

I swallow. “As the veil thins on this blessed night of Samhain, A’ Bhandia a’ Bhàis, goddess of death, hear my plea,” I pray. The desperation lacing

every syllable sounds like begging, but I dinnae care.

If begging gets me the revenge I crave—no, the revenge I *demand*—then so be it. If I must tear the world apart stone by stone, root by root, clawing my way below until I am banging at Ban-dia a' Bhàis's gate, then that is what I will do.

Smoke drifts from beneath my fingers as the heat in my hand grows almost unbearable, and the pile ignites, orange flames licking at my skin.

Closing my eyes, I picture Marsaili's face. I drop my voice low, the darkness in my tone demanding the goddess listen. "A' Bhan-dia a' Bhàis, hear me. I have searched loch and moor, but the monster who killed my geallta remains hidden." A wave of fury surges through my blood, and I pause, taking a deep breath to steady myself. "She lurks in the shadows, out of reach of my vengeance. Vengeance that is owed to me. Set me on the path to find her. Allow me to give Marsaili the justice she is due."

The fire crackles, sparks flying into the sky and disappearing among the stars as I wait for the goddess to answer. I dinnae ken what I wait for—a pull, showing me where to go, the knowledge of where to search—but nothing happens.

"Èist rium!" *Listen to me!* I shout, wondering if I'm too high in the sky for the goddess to hear me down below, and I stand. "A' Bhan-dia a' Bhàis!"

The name echoes out into the night, soaring in every direction, my roar rumbling through the vast hills. "Hear my plea! I *will* have my vengeance. Set me on the right path! Send me to the one who killed my Marsaili!"

I stand there, arms wide, chest heaving. A curlew calls in the distance, and a cloud passes over the moon.

I hold my breath, but there are no whispers. No signs. And for a moment, I wonder if once again, I have come here for nothing. If another year will pass and leave me no closer to finding the monster I hunt.

But before I can even exhale, wind crashes through the cemetery, a gust so violent it throws me to my knees. It's cool against my skin, but the hope it ignites in my chest is hotter than flames, evaporating the chill in an instant. The fire goes out, smoke curling from a pool of burning embers as the wind ceases as suddenly as it appeared.

There's a long moment when the hillside seems to hold its breath alongside me. The stars do not wink, and the curlews halt their cries. A soft,

silver glow rises within the ash, glinting in the night, beckoning to me like a will-o'-the-wisp.

With shaking hands, I reach out and grab it. The heat of it blisters my skin, but I dinnae let go. The magic from my dàn of healing will remedy the burns quickly enough.

Holding my breath, I turn the item over—a dagger, ancient as the earth I kneel upon. I wipe away the soot and ash, examining the iridescent blade. My heart pounds as the magic inside it prickles against my skin, and I realize the blade isn't metal at all, but forged from dragon scales, and the brass hilt is carved into the shape of a raven.

I almost drop the weapon. One spoken of, but never seen.

Ban-dia a' Bhàis's own dagger.

The blade of binding.

The wind and cold and smir fade as my fingers wrap around the ornate handle.

I lift the blade into the moonlight, examining it. My eyes reflect back at me from the metal, the same green I share with each of my brothers and sisters. With little Saoirse, only five years old, who I practically raised after my parents died in a wagon accident only weeks after her birth.

The thought of her bright eyes and dimples makes me hesitate—possibly the only thing that could do so. She's the reason I'm still alive. Born only months after I lost Marsaili, she's the reason I didnae choose to follow my love into the *After* when she was taken from me.

She needed me then, but does she still? I picture my siblings' faces. Their hands, dirty from digging in the soil outside our home, from harvesting wheat and potatoes.

If I should make this bargain, this unbreakable vow with the goddess of death, and fail, it wouldnae only cost me my life, but my verra soul, along with any chance of ever being reunited with my family in the *After*. I would belong to Ban-dia a' Bhàis for eternity, never able to go to peace, trapped as her servant of death. But as I twist the dagger in the moonlight, determination builds inside me, steadying my resolve.

I vowed long ago I would have justice for Marsaili. That promise was already unbreakable to me. Let it be written in my blood and bound in a vow with Ban-dia a' Bhàis's blade.

I am not afraid, because I willnae fail.

As I once caressed Marsaili's cheek, I trace the letters of her name on her grave, then drag the dagger across my skin, carving straight through the skin that I'm certain, had Marsaili not been taken from me, would have one day been stained with the dàn of the Anam-Cara.

A symbol that would have confirmed what I already knew. That on the Beltane when the moon stills—the night lovers hold their breath to learn if their hearts were woven as one—matching dàn would have appeared on our palms, marking us as soul-fated, a binding chosen by the goddess of love herself.

I look down at that skin, bright red blood welling from the deep cut, and I cannae help but think about how fitting it is. Let my flesh be as marred as my heart. If I cannae have my Anam-Cara, let this be the mark that honors her.

The pool of blood in my palm grows until it drips from my fingers, and I drop the dagger, placing my weeping hand on Marsaili's tombstone. Deep green vines erupt from the earth as I begin to speak, wrapping around the weapon.

"Chan eil thu air do dhìochuimhneachadh." *You are not forgotten.*

Blood trickles across the arched top, and I watch as a single line drips down the front of the stone, trailing over her name until it reaches the earth.

"Air mo bheatha, nì mi dìoghaltas dhut." *On my life, I will avenge you.*

The blood begins to steam, then bubble, the grave growing as hot as a glowing coal, and I know with complete certainty that this is it. That there will be no going back from the next words that leave my mouth. "A' Bhan-dìa a' Bhàis, gabh ri mo gheall. Ron ath Shamhain, sgriosaidh mi ge bith cò a ghoid bhuam thu—no leig m'anam a bhith air a chall." *A' Bhan-dia a' Bhàis, accept my bargain. By Samhain next, I will destroy the one who stole you from me—or let my soul be lost.*

There's a snap in my chest. A hum that settles inside my lungs and squeezes my heart as my bargain is offered and accepted in blood and intention. The vines surrounding the dagger twist, pulling it down into the soft ground as the cut on my palm erupts with agony, traveling through skin and muscle and sinew to settle into my bones. For a moment, I cannae breathe. I nearly retch, the intensity of the magic changing my verra marrow intolerable, but I grit my teeth, refusing to cower to it.

Instead, I welcome it, bask in it, because this pain means something.

Finally, I will have my revenge.

I picture Marsaili's face in my mind—soft lips, brown eyes and blonde hair, a narrow nose—until the pain finally fades. Only then do I pull my hand back to examine the wound. The cut still bleeds, but the skin around it has turned darker than the night, and faint black lines snake through my palm like poison in my veins.

"Thank you," I whisper to the goddess, standing to leave. I dinnae wish to linger, now that my vow is finished. This may be where Marsaili's body rests, a plot of land she will never again leave, but it's no where her spirit lives.

Nor is it where my vengeance will be wrought.

"Your death will be repaid, mo rùn," I promise into the wind, wondering how long I will have to wait for Ban-dia a' Bhàis to show me the way to find my revenge as I walk through the cold iron gate. Hot blood drips from my fingertips, but I dinnae wipe it away. Let it mark each of the six hundred and ninety-seven steps back down to the living.

Let the earth hold my promise until I return.

"Brennen," a voice breaks through the night as I reach the final steps that lead to Vengach. To my family.

Adrenaline surges through my veins, and my head snaps up, my hand automatically reaching toward the long blade at my hip. I squint into the darkness, my dàn of sight warming.

"It's only me."

I still my hand. "Garrick? What are you doing here?"

I should feel relief when I recognize my oldest friend, but instead, my skin prickles with unease. I do not like that I didnae hear him approach. That I allowed myself to be so distracted, I was caught unaware.

I lift my chin, forcing my hand to lower as I wonder why he's returned home.

Garrick matches me in his Dìdeanair uniform—a black and red tartan with a broadsword strapped to his back. Of all the guardians I've served with, he and I are the closest. He's from my village, a friend who always has a jovial smile and a joke in his front pocket, which is why my chest tightens when I notice the grim line of his mouth and tense set of his shoulders.

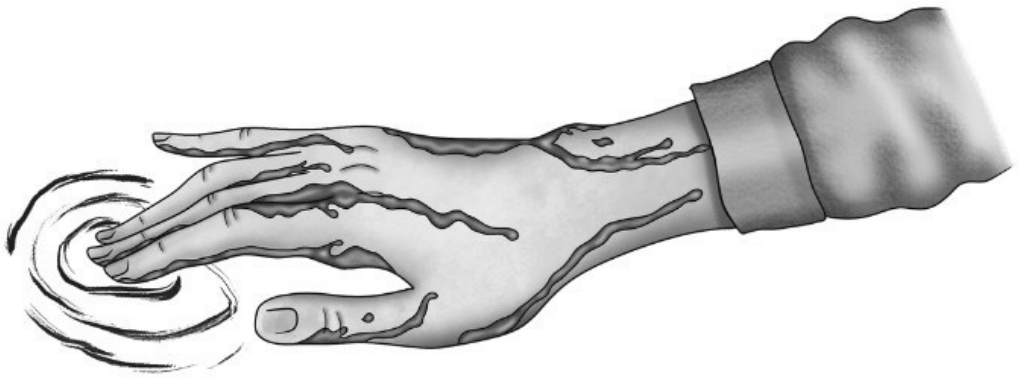
"What is it?" I ask, panic trickling into my blood. Has something happened to my family? To Saoirse? I cannae bear the thought.

He meets my eye, then delivers his message without preamble, as clean as the slice of Ban-dia a' Bhàis's blade through my palm.

"The Cutter has called for you."

3

BEA



Lolly sits on top of the ridge, only fifteen or so dragon-lengths away. Her claws dig into the stone, sending rocks crashing down into the glen, and my lungs seize with trepidation. With confusion and excitement. Not once in the century I've been tethered to this Fates-forsaken place has she landed, and I don't know what it means. Why now, only after the woman in green's death? Could it be a coincidence?

It seems unlikely.

She swings her head low, and I hold my breath as she lets out a deep, mournful cry that echoes through the valley. Slowly so as to not startle her, I climb down from my perch, careful to keep my movements soft and controlled, but even with her closer than she's ever been, she doesn't seem to notice me.

She swings her head around, searching. Is she looking for me?

"Lolly?" I call, but her eyes move right past me, all but confirming what I've long suspected. That through some sort of magic, she cannot see me. Maybe she really is only meant to should I escape.

Extending her neck, she roars again, and the ground trembles beneath my feet. I take a step backward, holding my breath, but instead of launching back into the sky, she lies down, steam rising from her nostrils as she rests her head on a thick bushel of heather.

I stand there, frozen, watching her breathe, the way her scales catch the fading light, and even though I should be, I find I am not afraid. I wish I

could go to her. Touch her shimmering wings and see if she's warm or cool to the touch.

Smoke curls from her nostrils once again as she exhales deeply, and then, she is asleep. I settle back onto the riverbed, watching her with fascination. Fatigue pulls at my body, a bone-deep exhaustion that makes me want to curl into a ball and shut out the rest of the world, but I can't seem to pull my eyes away from the magnificent creature. What if I sleep, and she's gone when I wake? What if this is my only chance to be this close to her?

"Rest then, Lolly. I'm tired, too," I say, but I don't lie down, instead sitting on the riverbank and wrapping my arms around my knees.

A deep rumble leaves the dragon's chest, almost as if she's scolding me.

"You're right. I'm sure you already have a name," I say, feeling foolish for wanting a friend so badly, I'm pretending I actually know this beautiful beast.

I stare at her in the fading light for what feels like hours, unable to settle my heart. The smir hanging over the dark water grows thicker as the sun dips below the horizon. An owl hoots in the distance, and the river is calm —so clear and still, I can count every freckle across the bridge of my nose in the moonlight. Can see my wild red hair and blue-grey eyes so clearly, it's as if I'm looking into a mirror.

Everything's as it's meant to be.

And yet, even with the distraction of my dragon, the woman in the green dress twirls through my mind. I try to force away the image of her long, slender fingers reaching for the vibrant wildflowers. Her wide smile as she tilted her face toward the sun.

Bile rises in my throat.

Why hadn't I seen her death? Was it a mistake, and the Cutter hadn't severed her thread? Or is she torturing me by showing me glimpses of joy and happiness?

I pick up a stick, dragging it through the mud. There *has* to be a reason. Even Lolly seemed to sense it. Every other time a soul has passed into the *After*, that's what I've been forced to see. Death.

So what did I witness? The woman's last moments? Happy ones, ended too soon? It bothers me, not knowing what ended her life.

She was on a hillside with wildflowers. Could it be a bee sting, perhaps? That's how my favorite friend Emma's father was taken when we were

children.

Maybe a fall?

I'll likely never know.

Maybe there isn't a reason at all. It could be that the Cutter is simply tormenting me. Changing the terms of the curse to cause me to question my sanity.

Still, I can't lose the sense of *wrongness* of it.

Desperate for a distraction from my whirling thoughts, I drag my stick harder against the ground—one long vertical stroke, then an arched one across the top. From the right edge of that mark, a line runs down at an angle, looping up at the bottom.

My hands pause. I can't remember the rest of the dàn. The half-finished symbol stares back at me, but it does nothing to distract me from my unease. The woman's face flashes in my mind again, and I close my eyes, trying to replace her smile with the rest of the drawing—the dàn I was given at my naming, the day I was dedicated to the Cutter, the same Fate who sentenced me here.

I work to picture the completed shape of the dàn—the black lines that once stained my skin, blessing me with magic I can no longer remember—but it's lost to me now like a raven's cry on the wind.

Shaking my head, I rub away the image with my bare foot, mud squishing between my toes, and begin again.

I shift, and my chain snags on a hole near the hem of my dress. With a sigh, I take my needle and spool from their hiding place beneath my stone pillow, removing the last of my thread. I'm not particularly worried about getting more. The dead rarely go to their rest with the things I *truly* wish for, but their pockets often hold needles and bobbins.

I lift the once cream-colored wool of my skirt into the moonlight, now stained with mud and peat. It hangs heavy in my hand as I search for the hole.

The skirt has thinned with time, tears appearing far more frequently than they did many years ago, and I wonder if a day will come when it can no longer be mended.

The thought makes me shiver as I press the needle through the damp fabric and weave the red thread through, pulling the edges together. It reminds me of a stab wound stitched closed—puckered skin with a red, scabbed center.

If only all wounds were so easily healed.

The wind picks up, and I squeeze my eyes shut, gathering my strength before tying off the thread and rising to my knees.

There is no rest for the wicked.

My eyes examine the water as I kneel. What if it turns muddy? I do not think I can bear to witness life again after so much death, but as clothing appears upstream, the river remains clear. There are no swirling eddies. No angry currents, and then a stab of pain blooms behind my sternum. The wind whispers a name, Victor, and I see a man's face in the ripples.

The relief I feel when I see his death—drowning—is staggering. This death is fate-sealed. It isn't a mistake.

This time, I do not fight the river.

I keep one eye on my sleeping dragon as I kneel, a blue tartan kilt and white tunic floating gracefully into my hands. Hands so stained with blood that, though I will spend eternity with my arms plunged in the River Bàsail, they will never wash clean.

I slip them into the pockets, and this time, they're not empty.

My heart bangs against my ribs as my fingers fumble along the object inside. Some sort of necklace, I think, based on the long chain brushing against my wrist. My breath quickens as I wrap my fingers firmly around it. The river pulls the kilt away, but I pull out the item before it disappears downstream.

The gold of an old locket glints in the moonlight as I lift it out of the water, and I freeze, my heart leaping out of my chest.

The item in my hand doesn't appear to be just a locket.

It looks like a naming pendant. I hold my breath, squeezing the necklace tighter. Every child receives one at their naming ceremony. A brooch or locket with the symbol of the Fate their parents chose to dedicate them to, along with the dàn that Fate blessed them with.

My heart rate quickens, a dangerous seed of hope sprouting in my chest. This could be it. A name given in love—the fourth of the five items I need for the spell to break my curse and end this immortal life of torture. Before I can beg Am Breitheamh for mercy for my crimes. Prove to him I've completed my penance for defying the Fates and ending those lives, and show him I've changed.

I examine the symbol of a circle with three lines engraved into the front—the dàn of dexterity. It's a unique dàn. While some of them require the

wearer to choose to activate it, this one would have simply become a part of them. This child would have been blessed with nimble, steady fingers and would likely have grown up to be a seamstress or dressmaker. Maybe a carpenter or an artisan.

Hands shaking, I pry the locket open, my breath coming in quick pants.

The locket clicks, and I hold my breath as I wipe away the water blurring the surface. The inside is worn, as if fingers have rubbed the metal in an unending rhythm like a talisman, with tarnished gold on the decorated lip surrounding a picture of a beautiful little girl. And on the other side—a name.

I suck in a breath.

Except… I wipe away the mud, dread pooling in my stomach—hot and acrid. Where a name had once been engraved, the letters have been smoothed away, only a D and an O still slightly visible.

I flip the locket over, searching for another place where the name could be engraved, because this has to be a mistake. This is a naming pendant. There *can't* be no name.

And yet, there isn't.

Defeat pierces my heart, sharper than a barbed arrow. I open the locket again, staring at the picture of the little girl. How could fate be so cruel as to bring me this pendant, and yet, I cannot use it? Stroking the tiny picture, I wonder where the child is right now. Have I washed her clothes already? Is that why her name is smoothed away, the metal around her picture worn?

Maybe I washed them years ago, and Victor chose to follow her into the *After* tonight because he couldn't bear the thought of being left behind any longer.

Once again, I fight to swallow down my disappointment. There's a reason finding the items for the spell isn't easy. I must suffer to find them if I am to be forgiven for my sins. Carrying my locket with me, I return to the mound of moss, bog cotton, bracken, and heather I use as my bed. It may not serve me in my spell, but it's beautiful, nonetheless, made of gold, and could be a potential bargaining chip to be used in the future.

Maybe a kind soul will stumble upon my river, and I can trade it in exchange for a loaf of bread. Some shoes, maybe, or a cloak. It's unlikely, but I'm close enough to Dalbàsail and a few other small villages that it's possible.

I lift the stone I use as my pillow, digging a few finger-widths or so into the damp dirt beneath to where the rest of my belongings hide. My possessions are few: a sewing needle made of bone and half a bar of soap, a few brass coins, a fragment of a beeswax candle—though I have no way to light it.

And then, hidden deeper beneath my collection, I find them.

Two old, rolled-up pieces of parchment. An old wood pipe, *a vessel that carries breath.* An adder stone, *a piece of home and hearth.* A rusted mourning brooch, *an ending mourned*.

The reason I search the pockets of the dead.

The words of the spell have long faded from the papers, but it doesn't matter. They are engraved in the depths of my soul.

Since the dawn of the kingdom of Na Trì, the magic of the Bàsail washed the sins of the dying of its own accord. For your crimes against the Fates, it is now your bones that will carry the task you stole. You will cleanse the death-clothes of the departed for eternity, the blood of each and every soul passing through your fingers, staining your hands forever.

Hands that will never again know rest.

You will wish for death.

May it never find you.

I can remember the moment I read it with perfect clarity. What a fool I'd been. I'd been certain I would *never* wish for death, and yet, now that I cannot have it, it is all I want. I close my eyes, picturing the second note I'd found tucked between two rocks a dragon's length away, as if the Fates hadn't wanted me to find it at all.

With every curse, there must be a counter.

Gather the pieces of a life completed—a vessel that carries breath, a name given in love, a piece of home and hearth, a promise broken, and an ending mourned. Bind them in tartan. Seal them in true faith and a changed heart, and send them into the After.

Only then, if the river accepts your plea, may you choose to follow.

A promise broken.

A name given in love.

That's all that's left for me to find.

With another surge of disappointment, I place the locket among my other treasures and wonder if the last pieces of the spell will ever find me, or if another century will pass without the things I need to send my own clothes down the river and set myself free. Will the Fates simply kill me once I do, taking another choice away from me?

I hope not. I'd like to go to my rest on my own terms, and only once I am certain I have done everything I can to atone for my crimes. I'd like to go to peace when I die. Not continue to suffer below just as I have above.

The wind gusts again, and I put my belongings back into the soft earth and turn to the river.

My song floats through the valley, a whisper on the water, and I stiffen.

Because *I* am not the one singing it.

There's no stab of pain. No name on the wind or death in my mind.

Just a melody, growing louder as it creeps along the rocks and wraps around my ankles. It slips up my spine, gooseflesh blooming across my skin.

I lift my head, turning toward the river's end. The melody soars, and then, I see her.

A woman, half submerged in the water, her black dress floating around her in a way that reminds me of the curling black fingers of the *After*. Her hair is so long, the ends meet the water, bright white strands that contrast her berry lips and light brown eyes.

“Who are you?” I ask, and her lips curve into a smile. She begins the song again, a melody that is mine.

Come follow the river. Do not be afraid.
Her mistress will find you by the end of the day.
You cannot escape her, be you goddess or maid.
So follow my river. Do not be afraid.

Come now, my darling. Down the river you’ll go.
I’ll wash you. I’ll cleanse you. Then she’ll hold you close.
The river will carry your soul down below.
So come now, my darling. Down the river you’ll go.

“Stop—” I say, frightened, but she raises her hands above her head, swaying to the haunting melody. The words of my song change, and I freeze.

He follows the river. He’s coming for you.
He’s angry, he’s eager, for what he has to do.
Be wary his sword, and be wary the truth.
He follows the river. He’s coming for you.

The final words of the melody trail away, echoing through the now silent glen.

I look back to my dragon on the ridge, but she seems no more aware of the woman’s presence than my own.

“Who are you?” I ask again, my voice shaking. “And who is *he*?”

She trails her fingers through the water, almost as if tickling it. She laughs, turning her head, and it’s only then that I notice her staggering beauty. She’s ethereal in a way that is not of this earth, with skin that glows with a soft luminescence, and eyes that aren’t brown like I’d thought, but pure gold. Her lips are full and her cheekbones high, with an angle to her jaw that somehow softens the sharp planes of her face.

“You’re a goddess,” I whisper, scrambling to my feet as the realization crashes over me.

She tilts her head. “I am many things. If you wish, you may think of me as the Muse of Love and Madness.” She spins in a circle and tips her head up toward the moon before stopping suddenly, her smile fading away. She narrows her eyes, an abrupt shift in demeanor. “That is not the question you should be asking. Do you know who *you* are?”

“I am the Washwoman,” I say, fighting to keep my voice even.

“Ahhh, but is that *all* you are?” She taps her chin, her eyes glinting with something I can’t quite place. Malice?

No. It’s just as she said—madness.

She tsks. “Why do you look so afraid? You and I are not so different, you know. Do you not remember what it feels like to be driven mad?”

Nausea churns in my stomach at her taunting. “What do you want?” I ask, wrapping my arms around myself. I do not want her puzzles. Her riddles.

She takes a single step forward. “I come with a warning. Be ready—for he’s coming.”

“Who?” I ask, my heart racing. “Who’s coming? Who sent you?”

The goddess's smile widens, showing too many impossibly white teeth. “Why, the one who will remember, of course.” Her voice drops to a cold whisper. “The one who will end the tale of your murderous reign.”

“I’ve murdered no one. Not since...” I can’t bring myself to say the word aloud. Vengach. The village where I committed my crimes the day my mind broke.

She throws her head back with laughter, and in an instant, the color of her dress shifts from black to…

Green.

The same dress as the woman from my vision.

My legs nearly give out. “No. I didn’t murder her.”

The goddess’s brows furrow with confusion. “And yet, is she not dead?” she asks, confirming my fears. “It is, after all, what has set everything in motion. He’s coming.”

“Who is *he*?” I shout, blood roaring in my ears.

“The one who will remember.” She tilts her head. “The one you destroyed.”

My blood runs cold. The one I destroyed? I’ve destroyed no one, other than those I killed. Their deaths may stain my soul, but they are gone. They cannot come for me.

Can they?

“You and I are not so different,” she says again, tilting her head, and my stomach lurches.

The vision. The dragon.

“Is it madness, then? Is my mind betraying me once again?”

“We’re all a bit mad, my dear," she says, her eyes twinkling. She giggles, the sound growing almost manic as she lowers herself into the water.

“He’s coming! He’s com—” her words choke out as she fully submerges. I stumble forward to grab her, but… She isn’t drowning at all. She’s fading. The white of her hair turns translucent, her body disappearing into curls of bubbles that drift into the *After*.

The current pulls at my legs, and I dive into the water to search for her, desperate to find the woman and demand she tell me more, but my hands touch only the stony riverbed.

I freeze, the goddess’s words circling in my mind.

The one who will remember.

The one you destroyed.

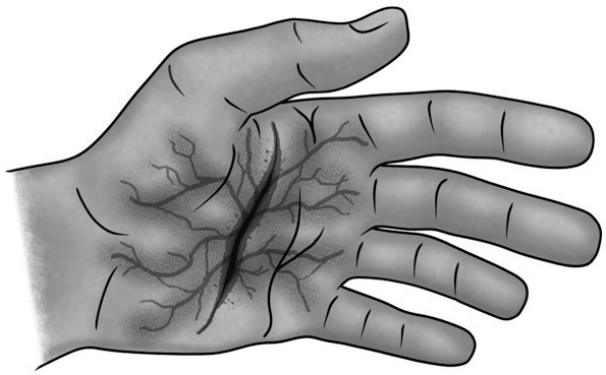
The wind goes unnaturally still, and in the eerie silence, I am left knowing only two things.

The goddess is gone.

And *he* is coming.

4

BRENNEN



I'm only partially certain I'm not walking into my own execution, though I cannae imagine what my crime would be. Not that Cailleach, the Cutter, needs a reason. Should she or her sisters, the Weaver and Measurer, have seen anything within my thread they didnae like, I'm as good as dead.

I find some comfort in the fact the branch-shaped dàn on the inside of my bicep that warns me of danger hasnae flashed with heat. Still, a shudder slides down my spine as I approach the enormous arched doors of the Cutter's cottage. That's what she calls it, but it's a castle, plain and simple, the "cottage" so large, it could house every villager within a thousand bowshots.

Ornate black doors loom before me, at least thirty feet tall and so heavy it takes four Dìdeanair to open each of them. I clear my throat and square my shoulders, not bothering to read my fellow guardians' expressions as they bow their heads and step back. It would be pointless to search for meaning in their faces. They willnae ken why I was called here any more than I do.

The power I feel when the doors open hits me like a dour wind. My heart shudders and my skin prickles, the power only growing more immense as I step inside the torch-lit room where thousands of shimmering threads hang from the ceiling, their magic a living, breathing thing. The

weight of it is so intense, I drop to one knee before I make the conscious decision to do so.

I close my eyes, fighting the pull to look up. Their magic calls to me. Testing me, but I dinnae give in. This is always the first test. Each time I have entered these chambers to be gifted dàn by Cailleach for rising in rank, they've sung to me. Begged me to look.

But no one has ever survived looking directly at the Cutter's threads.

I wait a moment, taking a slow, steadying breath, then lift my gaze to meet Cailleach's frost-blue eyes.

It's a bold choice, and a calculated one. I want the Cutter to know she has nothing to fear from me. That I'm nothing more than her loyal servant, here to perform whatever task she requires of me.

And if it *is* my execution I'm here for, I would like to see it coming.

"Come forward," Cailleach's voice is as cold as ice, but that isn't what causes my hair to stand on end. There has never been warmth to the Cutter. Of the three Fates, she's always been the most open about who she really is—ruthless to her core. Dangerous, and not only because of the black dragon towering over her.

Athair. The real reason my lungs refuse to fully expand.

He's massive, his head nearly reaching the vaulted ceilings—though I dinnae dare look up to see how close his horns are to reaching the threads in fear of accidentally looking at them—and his spiked tail wrapping around the throne from front to back.

I know *of* him, of course. I've seen Cailleach riding on his back through the sky, fire shooting from his mouth as he hunts, but I've never stood this close to the monstrous beast before.

The heat of his breath meets my face as I stand, so hot, sweat beads along my brow. I avert my eyes from him as well, struggling to find something I *can* look at. I've already made my statement to the Cutter. Continuing to stare at her would likely be taken as a challenge, and I'm certain Athair would take direct eye contact from me as an invitation to roast me where I stand.

I choose the safest option, training my eyes on the uneven floor created from ground-up bone and trying not to think about what, or *who*, I'm walking on. Athair's fist-sized silver eyes follow me in my periphery, smoke curling from his nose as he sways his head back and forth,

serpentine, his black, forked tongue flicking out as if he’s trying to *taste* my intentions.

I shift my gaze to Cailleach’s throne, an ornate spectacle built of bones, except, unlike the floor, the bones are not ground up, but whole. Seven skulls line the top in an arch, and I wonder who the unfortunate souls are that are forced to witness what happens in these chambers day after day.

Shaking away the thought, I continue to approach, focusing on the bones that make up her armrests.

Cailleach doesn’t so much as lift an eyebrow when I stop mere feet away and once again drop to one knee, briefly bowing my head in respect. I swallow when I look back up and meet her gaze. Her long white hair is braided today as if prepared for battle, a rare departure from her normal unbound look, and her eyes are especially bright.

She’s a wee woman, pretty in the same way a brand new dagger is, and her red lips are the color of the blood its sharp blade would spill, a stark contrast to her long black gown. So dark, it seems to absorb the light around her.

“Are you happy, Brennen?” she asks without looking up from the thread twisted between her long fingers. I do not look directly at it as she caresses it like a beloved pet—attentive and tender, but in my periphery, I’m able to see the shifting colors. Shades of black and blue and purple I’ve never seen before.

My jaw loosens in surprise at her question, and despite my efforts to keep my face neutral, my eyebrows furrow.

“Of course,” I say, bowing my head again in an attempt to hide my shock. This woman has the fate of the universe in her jewel-encrusted hands, and yet she called on me to question my happiness? I dinnae believe for a moment that’s the reason I’m here, but I dinnae dare call her out on it.

“You've made quite the name for yourself as a Dìdeanair,” she says, appraising me. She tilts her head to the side, her eyes trailing up my arms to the dàn tattooed on my skin—my dedication dàn of the Cutter’s sigil and the naming dàn of truth she gifted me that day. Above it are the ones I earned through service—dàn that disappear beneath my armor.

“You know, I was quite pleased when your parents chose to dedicate you to me over my sisters on the day of your naming. As soon as I saw you, I knew you were special.”

I swallow, unsure where this is going. “Thank you.”

“I trust the dàn I gifted you that day has served you well?”

She nods to my dàn of truth—magic that alerts me to falsehoods and allows me to seal vows as true.

“It has,” I say, infusing as much gratitude into my voice as I can.

She smiles. “I think I knew, even then, you would use it well. That you were destined for great things.” She shifts in her chair, leaning back. “I’ve been watching you,” she continues, and my shoulders stiffen. “It’s remarkable you made An Treas so quickly. But I can see why. You’re an unusually hard worker. You request the most dangerous assignments, the most unforgiving journeys. And you have used your dàn well, protecting this kingdom."

A hint of satisfaction, dangerous and rare, mixes with the confusion settling in my stomach. *Why am I here?*

The Cutter taps her fingers on her chair. “As I’m sure you’re aware, the continent of Na Trì is facing a period of great danger.”

I place my hands behind my back. “With the Epoch approaching, it’s to be expected,” I say, mentally tallying the days remaining until the moons will once again align in a perfect arc as they do once a century, bringing along with it the monsters that will claw their way from below.

“I’m told you’ve done well eliminating any ceatharnaich groups forming.”

“Aye. There have only been a few small pockets, as there always are before the Epoch. They were dealt with accordingly.”

My shoulders relax, my pulse returning to near normal. This line of questioning doesnae surprise me. I’ve spent the past two years gathering intel on these rebel groups.

Cailleach tents her fingers, shaking her head. “It is good to hear that. Because the threads have warned us of a threat to our continent even worse than the Epoch. And I think you should be the Dìdeanair to help me face it.”

She gestures to the strings hanging all around her, but I keep my eyes focused ahead.

Pride blooms in my chest, but unease prickles along my skin. The Epoch is known for its casualties. The thousands of men and women who will be culled by the monsters who descend upon the kingdom, seeking their share of flesh.

“Worse?” I can’t think of anything more dangerous to the people of Na Trì than the Epoch. The verra idea makes my stomach hollow.

Cailleach nods.

“How may I be of service?” I ask, keeping my face neutral to hide my concern, and she lifts a finger, indicating she’d like me to stand. A wicked glint of pride sparks in her eyes as she watches me climb to my feet.

“I’m sure you’ve heard of the women disappearing throughout the kingdom.”

“Aye. I have. Is there news?”

She resumes clicking her nails on the arm of her throne, and my skin burns as her gaze lands on my palm.

“You take frequent trips to Vengach. Why?” she asks, and I stiffen at the abrupt change of subject. I keep my eyes focused on her face as a thread floats from the ceiling, and without looking, she grabs it, sliding her fingers along its length. She pauses for a moment, narrowing her eyes, and in my periphery, I see her move her fingers up and down several times, then pinch. A sick smile twists her lips up.

I pause, the sight of her so casually ending a life making my stomach drop.

“Speak freely,” she says with a flippant wave of her hand. Her voice is light as if she’s encouraging me, but the hooks of her magic dig into my flesh, pulling the answer from my throat.

“It’s my home,” I say as the length of thread below her fingertips turns black and scatters into ash. “I like to visit when I’m not on assignment.”

“Is that the only reason?” she asks, her voice light, as if we’re discussing the weather.

I swallow. “I go to visit my geallta’s grave.” My chest tightens at the admission.

She places a hand over her heart. “Ah, yes. Your sweet Marsaili.”

I recoil at the sound of her name, so wrong coming from the Cutter’s cold mouth.

“Murdered, along with five others. Her family. Am I correct?” She reaches out to pet Athair’s spiked crown, her hand so small compared to the beast’s head, and a deep rumble leaves his chest as he nuzzles against her.

My jaw ticks at the levity of her tone when talking about the death of the woman I love, but I remain silent. There is no reason to speak. Cailleach knows the answer, and she is no stranger to death. She’s the one who sealed their fates, though I do not blame her. She may have cut their threads, but it wasn’t her hands that ended their lives.

It’s not even the Measurer’s fault. She may measure out our lives, but that is when the cause of death isn’t at the hands of another human. It is the one thing out of her control—murder. The thread simply would have floated to Cailleach’s hands at the time her life was ending, and she would have had no choice but to sever it.

“Yes,” I say, adrenaline coursing through my blood.

“Tell me about how they died,” the Cutter demands, her voice morphing into stone.

I stiffen, my heart racing as my mind fights to keep up with her line of questioning. It takes me a second to process her command—that she wishes for me to relive their deaths.

Athair stands when I don’t immediately answer. He lowers his head, smoke curling from his nostrils.

I grit my teeth as the magical hooks tug again. “It happened in the night. Her family was found dead inside their home, but Marsaili… She tried to flee. I was on my way to report to my post. I was to be gone for two months. I’d waited till the last possible moment, because she hadn’t wanted me to go.” I swallow down the memory of Marsaili asking me to stay a little longer. We'd only been betrothed mere weeks, and she hadn't been ready for me to leave yet.

If only I’d listened.

“I was just over the hill when I felt it. A tug in my chest, demanding I turn back. I couldnae explain it, but I had no choice but to listen. She’d tried to get to me, I think.” It takes every bit of my training to keep my voice detached, but my blood runs hot. “I found her lying in the grass outside her burning house, her throat torn open. She took her last breath in my arms. I was too late to save her, or the rest of her family.”

“Who murdered them?” she asks, and for a moment, I hesitate. My throat burns, and my lips feel sluggish. But the hooks tug again, and I realize resisting is futile. She will force me to say it one way or another.

The name I’ve refused to utter since I buried Marsaili.

I fight to push down the fury rising up my throat, but the taste of it already coats my tongue.

“The Bean-Nighe.” My voice comes out as almost a growl.

“Yes.” Cailleach leans forward. “The Washwoman.”

The name strikes like a spear through my chest, and I know with sudden clarity why I was called here today.

Fire surges through my blood. Ban-dia a’ Bhàis is keeping her promise.

“Has she escaped again?” I ask.

“No,” Cailleach snaps. Athair crouches, but she places a hand on his snout, calming him. She takes a deep breath. “Though I do see why that would be your concern, seeing as it was during the first, and *only*” —she throws the word at me like a dart— “time she escaped that she killed your precious Marsaili. Tell me. What do you know of her punishment?”

I want to hurl my dagger at her. To tell her to have respect when she speaks Marsaili’s name, but I bite my tongue. “She was bound to the River of Death after taking a life you had marked to die over a century ago—a friend who betrayed her. She saw a friend’s clothes she was planning to kill in the river and removed them so the death could be at her own hands. She interfered with fate and murdered both her friend and her lover, outside of your will. She defied you, so you cursed her to wash the clothing of the dead forever, cleaning their sins and allowing souls passage into the afterlife.”

The Cutter’s eyes sparkle. “A unique punishment, don't you think? I’m rather proud of it.”

I close my hands into fists to keep them from shaking.

“May I truly speak freely?” I ask, my voice tight.

Athair’s head swings toward me, and for a moment, I’m certain Cailleach will lift her finger, and I’ll be nothing but a smoking heap of ash, but she pats the dragon’s nose, nodding.

I let out a shaky breath. “Why not death?” I ask, looking directly at Cailleach. “Why not end her life?”

The Fate presses her lips together for a moment before speaking, and when she does, her words are as curt as ever. “I will tell you, but only so that you understand the gravity of the danger she possesses.”

I nod. “Of course.”

Athair snorts, but Cailleach holds up a hand. “Death is the sentence she was originally given, agreed upon by all three of us. But,” she pauses, her fingers tightening on her throne as if speaking the words is causing her physical pain, “when I tried to sever her thread, it would not cut.”

Her confession steals the air from my lungs. I don't dare speak, afraid that any question I ask will spark an outburst of anger that will end in my own thread being severed. The Cutter hides her shame well, her chin high and her shoulders back, but it's there, hidden in the shadows of her face.

She waves a hand as if unbothered, but the lines bracketing her eyes say otherwise. “How is that possible? That’s what you want to know, isn’t it?”

I open my mouth, but no words form. It *is* what I want to know, but I certainly cannae ask when Athair is lowering his head to my level, his claws digging into the marble as if he’s about to launch forward to grab me by the throat.

She pets his neck, soothing him as if that will stop him from turning me to a pile of charred bones, and lowers her chin. “I gave him permission to speak freely.”

He huffs, smoke curling from his nose.

“Do you know why the thread refused to cut?” I ask, choosing my words carefully, and the queen's lips tip up in an approving smile.

“No,” she says.

“Is there a chance Measaire didnae measure her thread to end at that time?” I ask, my mind shifting through the possibilities.

“It would not have mattered, even if she hadn’t. While I’m honor-bound to her measurements in most cases, the magic she uses in her duty is fluid and allows that measurement to change under certain circumstances. It is about intention. If I believed you to be a threat to the kingdom, the laws between my sisters and me would not apply. After what she did, I should have been able to end her life, and thus, that threat.”

She sighs dramatically, as if putting on a show.

“Alas, *none* of us has been able to determine why her particular thread cannot be severed. It has not happened before, and it has not happened since.”

I nod, taking it all in. “She cannae be killed.” The words burn as they leave my throat. “So you put her where you can watch her.”

Cailleach’s answering smile is cruel. “Precisely. And for more than a hundred years, she did not cause any trouble. But as you know, she escaped, fleeing to your village where she went on a murderous rampage. She was caught and is now not only bound with magic to that shore, but physically as well. An endless punishment. One, possibly worse than death.”

“I see,” I nod, but something tickles at my brain, the beginnings of a thought I cannot fully form. The Fates: the Weaver, the Measurer, and the Cutter. The ones who create the verra fabric of the universe, and yet, the answer eludes them. The thought makes me uneasy.

“Why hide her?”

Cailleach tilts her head. “The villages around the river know of her, but are prohibited by magic to speak of her whereabouts once they leave. As is anyone who stumbles upon her. She is a ghost lurking in the dark. A cautionary tale. A warning to those who would choose to defy my sisters and me. A threat is far more poignant when it haunts your nightmares. When you don’t know where the monster hides, don't you think?”

I look back to the throne as another thread floats from above, black ash falling from Cailleach’s fingers.

“You're being reassigned to the River Bàsail,” she continues before I can answer.

I still, my breath freezing in my lungs. “The River… What?”

“The River Bàsail. That is where you will find her.” She meets my stare, her eyes boring into mine. “‘*Chan eil thu air do dhìochuimhneachadh. Air mo bheatha, nì mi dìoghaltas dhut.’* Are those not your own words?”

The pledge I’ve made a hundred times as I stood on the cold ground in the clouds of Vengach floats from her mouth. The same one I turned into an unbreakable oath with Ban-dia a’ Bhàis’s blade.

My jaw opens in shock.

“Surely that isn’t surprise I see on your face. I am the Cutter. The most powerful of the Fates. There is nothing that happens in my kingdom I am not aware of.”

“Of course, my queen,” I say, dipping my head in reverence, though what she said isn’t the full truth. The Fates may be able to catch glimpses of a thread, moments in a person’s life, but they aren’t able to see all that will happen. Only the goddess of death can do that. The Cutter doesnae know a life is about to end until the thread floats into her fingers.

I dinnae dare correct her, a smile teasing my lips. Because this is it. Ban-dia a’ Bhàis has set me on the path to the Washwoman. To the River Bàsail. This is why I couldnae find her. The place she was sentenced to isn’t on any map. Only the villages surrounding her know where she hides, bound to a river I didnae ken existed until this moment.

The Cutter did not call me here to question my vow for vengeance. She called me here to *use* it.

My heart races, my muscles tensing as my hands curl into fists, and the vow on my palm burns.

“You said she couldnae be killed,” I say, leaving my question unspoken.

Athair growls, and Cailleach's eyes narrow. "I am confident you will find a way to rectify that." She leans forward, placing a hand on her chest. "I can *feel* the depth of your hatred. The need for vengeance inside your heart. You risked your soul to make an unbreakable vow to kill her, after all. I am certain you will find a way to do it."

She leans back in her chair. "You are to find out what she did to alter her thread. Any information that may be helpful. I want to know if she can change other threads. If she has. And after you have gathered all the information you can, you will find a way to kill her. Until that time comes, you will ensure she stays secure. As I said, women are going missing," she repeats, and it finally, fully clicks.

I swallow. "And you need me to make sure The Washwoman isnae one of them before you learn everything you need to know."

She nods. "We do not know where these women are. They can't be dead. I did not cut their threads. My sisters and I are unsure if their disappearances are the workings of ceatharnaich groups, or something else. But it doesn't matter. It is of the utmost importance that the Washwoman does not escape. You remember what happened last time."

Cold rage sears my lungs at the reminder, and that night flashes through my mind. Marsaili's blood. Her sister's scream when she'd learned the rest of her family hadn't survived.

"Aye. I remember."

"You'll be promoted immediately to An Àrd, of course, should you accept. Not only that, but I will also reward Vengach with extra weaponry and four additional wards at the location of their choosing."

My jaw drops. A promotion would mean a stone house for my siblings, rather than the hut they live in now. A monthly allotment of money for food and clothing. Schooling for the young ones.

A mercenary for them for the Epoch.

With the funds, as well as the weapons and wards, my village will have a real chance of safety.

Cailleach leans against the arm of her chair, picking at the edge of what appears to be a femur. "It's quite the jump from An Treas to An Àrd. But it is justified. The Washwoman is vile. Wicked and dangerous. She should not be underestimated. She will try to tempt you with her sorrow. Will tell you gorgeous, enchanting lies and prey on the kindness in your heart. She—"

“I accept,” I say before she can even finish her warning. “I won’t let you down.”

Cailleach nods, closing her eyes. Fire erupts along my ribs and spine, my arms and neck, as new dàn are inked into my arms, legs, and torso. My back. One by one, the blank markings ignite—and even though I don’t know what gifts I’ve been blessed with yet, their magic tunnels into my bones. I do not remember it at my naming, but I remember it when I was promoted to An Dàrna and An Treas. In an instant, I feel different—stronger. My sight grows sharper, and my mind more awake.

“I know you won't.” Cailleach smiles, but as she opens her eyes, I do not see kindness in them. She waves a hand above her head, and several threads float through the air, dancing and twisting until they fall into her long, claw-like fingers. I have to fight not to look. To count them. “But just in case you need an extra push to remain vigilant, I think I will keep these close by. Such long, beautiful strings,” she says. She plucks one, and it sings, clearer than a melody from a harp. “My sister doesn’t like when things do not go according to plan, you know. It’d be a shame if she decided to change her measurements because you were unsuccessful in your mission.”

Athair nuzzles the threads, smoke curling from his nose.

My mouth goes dry. Seven strings. It can’t be—

“Cillian, Aiden, Cian, Saoirse,” she continues.

The air leaves my lungs, a wave of dizziness hitting me so hard I miss the last three names, but I don’t need to hear them to know they are the rest of my siblings. Cailleach’s threat is clear.

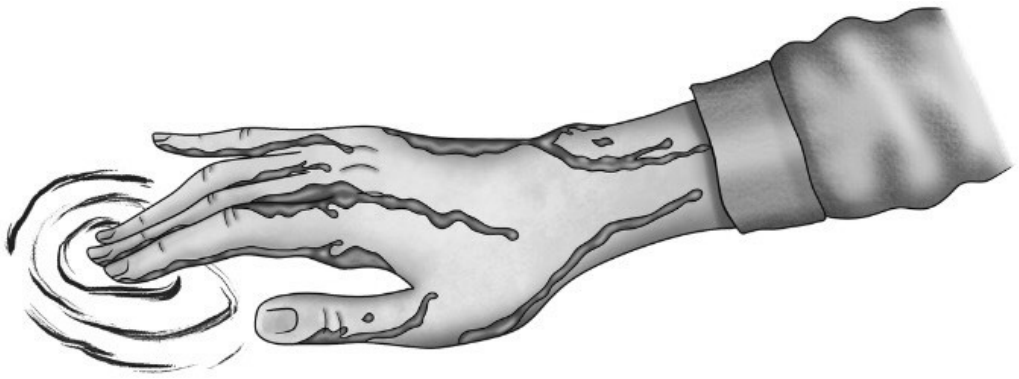
Fail, and she will sever the threads.

Fail, and the rest of my family will die.

Fail, and it will be all my fault.

5

BEA



I do not go back to sleep, and I do not stop thinking of the goddess. Not when the sun rises and Lolly leaps from the ridge to circle overhead, and not as I feel the first stab of pain and hear the first whispered name of the morning. I stare at the spot in the water where the goddess had stood, searching for a ripple. An overturned rock. Anything to indicate she'd actually been there. I'm desperate for proof I'm not going mad again, but I'm equally afraid to be sane.

Because if the goddess wasn't a product of my imagination, then neither was her warning.

He is coming.

I hear the words with every breath. Jump with every rustle in the trees.

And yet, no one appears.

I lie down on my bed, wincing as a rock digs into my ribs. With a heavy sigh, I stand back up. My body longs for rest, but the layer of flora that makes up my bedroll has become sparse, bare even, in spots, patches of grey rock showing through the plants.

If sleep is going to find me, it won't be until I'm able to lie on something soft.

Folding my apron into the shape of a bowl, I pluck my way along the river's edge, gathering every scrap I can find. My chain catches about two dragon's lengths away from where it's embedded into a huge slab of stone, forcing me to stop, and I look longingly at the greenery growing just

outside my reach, taunting me. It’s lush and thick, and would be so much softer to lie my head on than the thin scraggly bits in my apron, gathered before they were able to mature.

I grab a long stick, leaning forward to scrape the sharp tip against a sheet of green and blue moss. The edge of it lifts, but when I try to pull it toward me, it flips further out of my reach.

“Agh!” I scream in frustration, throwing the stick as far as I can, but it barely makes it an eighth of a dragon’s length, my body too weak to even allow me to expend my rage.

The wind picks up, and with a curse, I hurry back toward my bed to put the bundles of moss and heather down before the magic that forces me to wash pulls me to my knees. I’ll be damned if I let the river take even a single piece of comfort from me.

The water turns muddy, bog-myrtle permeating the air.

My heart skips a beat, fear prickling along my skin when no name comes to me. No face in the water or cause of death.

“No,” I whisper, my voice shaking. “Not again.”

In moments, the river turns angry, the current swirling in circles and eddies rather than a straight line. Mud churns up from the riverbed, and the scent of peat makes me gag.

My dragon roars above me as my hands are pulled into the water, and I steel myself for the vision I hope isn't coming. One was disturbing enough, but another? Twice is no longer a mistake I can explain away, but a pattern.

I fight the feeling of my head spinning and the world tilting, but in the span of a breath, I’m standing inside a warm cottage. My stomach growls as the smell of stew meets my nose. A woman kneels by the fire, toasting crusty bread. My mouth waters, and for a moment, all I can think about is the Fates’ cruelty.

Was it not enough to curse me to starve and freeze and live a life consumed by death, but never die? Must I now witness the lives I will end with the cleansing of their clothes?

The Cutter is tormenting me. I’m certain of it. But why?

The sound of whistling rises as the front door opens. The melody scratches at my memory, but I can’t quite place it.

A tall man enters the house, and the woman rises, beaming.

“Smells wonderful, mo chridhe,” he says, bending down and pressing a kiss to her crown. She stands, wrapping her arms around his waist, and the

tenderness in their embrace makes my heart ache.

“Caught them all?” she asks, standing on her tiptoes to peer over his shoulder through the still-open door. I follow her gaze to the moor beyond, where dozens of sheep as fluffy as cotton dot the bright green landscape, the bleat of ewes sailing on the wind.

“Aye. Fence went down in last night's storm. Shep herded them back, though. Speaking of the dog. Where’s he gone?” He looks out the door.

“I haven’t seen him. Probably tormenting the chickens,” the woman says, returning to the hearth and adding another log. The fire flares, and I take a step closer on instinct, greedy for its warmth. I reach a hand out, desperate to feel the delicious heat.

A loud whistle makes me jump, the man calling for his pet. I stumble back as it enters, a black and white dog with blue eyes, running directly toward me. It barks at me, and I jump back, the side of my hip slamming into the table. A pair of wooden candlesticks falls to the floor with a clatter.

Two pairs of eyes snap up to meet mine, and the man steps forward, shielding the woman with his body.

“Who are y—”

But before his sentence ends, I’m back at the river, my back aching where it hit the table. The sound of the man’s whistle, his sweet words to his wife, circle through my mind.

They *saw* me.

I *touched* the table.

How is that possible?

My heart pounds as I try to understand what’s happening. Is it really the Cutter torturing me, or is it something else? Because once again, this death feels horribly wrong. I’m so distracted, I almost miss the clothes as they drift past, but the magic of my curse bends me forward, forcing me to grasp them.

I do not look at the clothes as I wash them.

I cannot bear to know which of the lovers I saw will die.

The clothes float from my fingers, but even after they are long settled in the *After*, I am not able to make sense of the vision.

Those people *saw* me.

They spoke to me.

But how? Did I leave the river? I'd thought the first vision on the hill had been more like a dream. That I'd only gone somewhere else in my mind, but I *felt* the table behind me. Had knocked the candlesticks to the ground, and the dog had run straight toward me.

But if I'd been in that cottage, how was I now back in the river, chain as tight as ever?

My dragon roars, darting in tight loops. Can she feel the change in the air, too? The feeling of a storm approaching, the energy of lightning crackling in the sky? She must. She's becoming increasingly restless, her circles shrinking with each lap. Tighter and tighter she arcs, breathing fire in savage blasts, her keen shaking the rowan trees.

"What do you think is happening, Lolly?" I ask.

She roars, and I force a laugh, trying to brush off my heavy unease, but it sounds brittle. "Unless you tell me your real name, that's all I have to call you," I say. She doesn't answer, of course, but I watch her all the same.

I'm so focused on the shine of her iridescent scales glinting in the sun that I almost miss the snap of the branch. The rustle jolts me to my feet, my ankle crying out in protest as warm blood trickles from beneath the cuff.

"Who's there?" I call, straightening my spine.

Another snap. The shifting of clothing. A sigh.

Human.

Someone is here—*he* is here.

I nearly vomit. "Show yourself," I demand, unease pooling in my belly. I scan the pines, searching for any sign of movement. Is this it, then? The man the goddess warned me of? The one who will remember?

The one I destroyed?

A blonde head peeks out of the shadows, tentatively at first, and I hold my breath.

But it's not a man who steps from the treeline. It's a woman.

I suck in a sharp breath at the terror I see in her green eyes.

She's far too young to know such fear.

"Are you the Washwoman?" she asks, her voice shaking. Every few seconds, she glances over her shoulder, her posture tense as if she's preparing to run.

I exhale—not from relief that this isn’t the *he* the goddess warned is coming for me, though it does pulse faintly—but from sorrow.

Because the woman before me has been beaten so severely, I can barely see the bright green of her left eye beneath the swelling. Her lip is split and scabbed, and bruises bloom like flowers along her temple and arms. She doesn’t smile, but she doesn’t weep either.

She’s beautiful beneath the blood and bruises, with long butter blonde hair hanging in soft waves nearly down to her navel.

“I am,” I whisper.

She steps closer, her gaze flicking to my bloody ankle. For a moment, understanding passes between us—two women in pain.

Yet while I may deserve my suffering, she does not. A heavy sadness settles in my throat, squeezing my lungs until it's hard to breathe.

“You have a question,” I say softly, and she nods, her eyes never leaving mine. I hold my hand out, and she swallows, her brows drawing together as she takes a step back.

“You have to catch me to trigger the magic.” I soften my voice so as to not scare her. Most don’t know of this part of my curse. The only ones who seem to are those from the villages close by, as if they’ve chosen to keep it a secret from outsiders.

Her eyes go wary as she stares at my arm, but she steps forward anyway, gently wrapping her fingers around my wrist. Her dedication dàn to the Weaver stares at me, dark against her fair skin. “Tell me, Washwoman, the answer I seek.”

She swallows, her eyes filling with tears, and I nod in encouragement. “Tell me where I can go to be safe—from my husband.” Her voice breaks on the last word, a single tear sliding down her cheek. “Somewhere he will never find me.”

My heart shatters, but hope quickly seeps into the cracks. The answer floods my mind with complete certainty, the magic of the curse vibrating through my bones, humming inside my skull and threading through my bloodstream. A vision flashes, golden sunlight and glittering water. Rowan trees and sphagnum moss.

“The Faerie Pools,” I say. “Do not return. There’s a hut hidden atop the cliffs—shaded by pines. A kind woman lives there. She will help you.”

The young woman finally breaks, a sob bursting from her bruised throat.

“You’re sure?” she asks.

“Yes,” I breathe, grateful for my curse for the first time in a century.

I usher her forward, pointing her in the right direction, but my chain stops me short. Pain sears through my ankle, and I suck in a sharp breath. A buzz spreads through my mind, and a sudden terror grips my heart.

“Now. You have to go *now*,” I say. I don’t know how I’m so sure, only that I am. Whoever did this to her is coming.

He is coming.

She hesitates, her eyes flicking to my chain once more. She gestures toward it. “Is there anything I can—”

The buzzing in my mind grows louder, painful, vibrating against the inside of my skull.

“You have to go,” I repeat. “Now.”

Her eyes glisten, but she nods. “Thank you.”

The buzz becomes a roar, and black spots dot my vision as I shove her forward.

“Run!” I shout, an urgency building within me like I’ve never felt before. I can’t explain it, but terror surges through my veins, chased by the impossible feeling that I’ve lived this moment before and already know how it will end.

Her eyes widen, but she doesn’t waste a second. The woman vanishes into the trees as if she were never here.

I rush back to the river’s edge, splashing cold water on my face in an attempt to calm my heaving breaths.

If whatever is about to happen was bad enough that the muse of love and madness came to warn me about it, it surely is going to be painful. I try to fold inside myself. To force my mind to go somewhere I can endure the agony I'm certain is coming.

And then, I hear it.

The birds singing the morning’s song go quiet.

The sound of someone moving through the forest makes my hair stand on end, and dread wraps around my heart as I rise to my feet.

My eyes flick to my chain, my tether to this Fates-forsaken place. I cannot run. I cannot hide.

A man staggers into the glen, a vein in his forehead bulging, and his face red with fury. I take a step back, my blood running cold at the undiluted rage in his eyes. I whisper a prayer under my breath.

It is not often I speak to the goddesses. They turned their back on me long ago, but this intercession is not for me.

It is for the woman, for Dìonadair to keep her safe. That this man does not ask me where she is going. That he does not say the words that will make me tell him the truth.

“Where is she?” he says, stalking closer, his head swiveling side to side.

“Who?” I ask, feigning innocence, but I have to squeeze my hands together to stop them from trembling.

“I know she came here,” he spits, jabbing a stubby finger in my direction. “My wife, Kenna. She was coming to find you. The butcher in Dalbàsail said she left in this direction. And the only thing out here is *you,*” he spits. “Tell me where she is.”

I shake my head, backing away. “No one has come to see me in weeks. I don't know what you're—”

“Tell me, Washwoman, the answer I seek!” he roars.

Dread, hot and oily, spills into my blood as he staggers forward, and I fumble away from him, desperate to put distance between us. I will not tell this man where Kenna went. I will fight the magic that would force me to do so.

“I asked you a question! You *have* to tell me!” he screams, slapping me across the face hard enough to make my ears ring. Blood coats my tongue, so much of it, I gag, but he doesn’t reach for me. Doesn’t wrap his sweaty fingers around my arm.

The man doesn’t move again, his chest heaving and his nostrils flaring as he breathes in and out, waiting for my reply.

I don’t dare speak, pressing my lips together to hide my smile. Utter relief and joy dampen the pain in my jaw.

I do not have to give him an answer.

Not unless he catches me.

“I don't know what you're talking about,” I finally say, blood dribbling down my chin.

“Liar!” he hisses, but I see the doubt in his eyes. I cannot lie, it is said. That is part of the tale of the Washwoman, even if it isn't true.

“I'm sorry, I—”

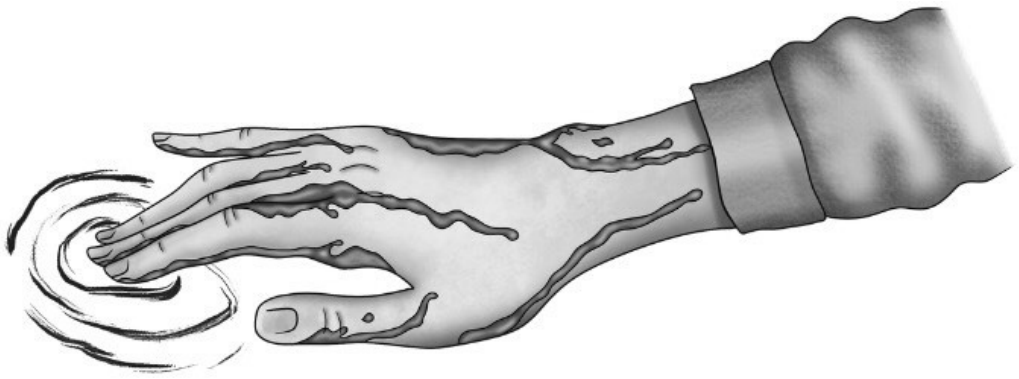
He rears back, and this time it is not a slap. He punches me, a hook to my temple, and as I crumble to the ground, I set my smile free.

I have finally done something good. And as everything fades to black, I sink into the comfort of knowing Kenna is safe.

The darkness is my friend. And I cannot be forced to answer if I am lost to it.

6

BEA



When I wake, my cheek is pressed against the cold scree of the riverbed, my hair drifting in the current. For a moment, I cannot place why I'm here. This isn't my bed, nor do I have any memory of falling asleep.

The smell of copper meets my nose, and all at once, it comes back to me. The woman, Kenna. Her husband. His attack.

I scramble to sit, ducking my head and raising my arms on instinct, but nothing happens. Tentatively, I crack open my eyes, my shoulders relaxing when I find I am blessedly alone in my valley.

The man is gone.

And so is Kenna.

A smile of triumph twists my lips as I stand and hobble to the shallow part of the river, though it doesn't last long. A jolt of agony shoots through my head, and I wince. As slowly as I can, I lower myself down, letting the cool water wrap around my body to take the edge off my pain.

My tongue is as dry as tree bark, and a dull ache throbs at the base of my skull and in my temple. I twist, taking stock of my injuries. My ribs are tender from where the man must have kicked me after I fell unconscious, but it's mild compared to what I've experienced before, and a small price for the woman's safety.

I lie back on the rocks, letting the sun warm my face, my torso and legs still submerged, and revel in my victory. Hours pass, my dragon dancing

overhead, and I’m grateful that there are few deaths. More grateful that none are unexplained.

My eyelids grow heavy and are beginning to close when my dragon’s head swings to the left, a blast of fire shooting from her mouth as if in warning. Before I have time to even sit up, to look in the direction of whatever she's alerting me to, she disappears beyond the ridge. A sense of rage fills the valley, hot and pointed as a newly forged blade. The birds caw as they leap into the air and dart away, and the fish duck into their holes.

The glen goes completely, eerily silent.

Even the air feels wrong, the sun’s rays somehow unable to combat the icy chill creeping up my arms.

My skin turns to gooseflesh as I slowly stand, unease settling on my shoulders. What could possibly cause my dragon to react so strongly?

Is the husband returning to try to finish what he started?

Fear slides through my blood, but it isn’t for myself. It’s for Kenna. He hadn’t caught me, but if he does? I’ll be forced to tell him exactly where she went, no matter how much I don't want to.

But would he return so soon? Maybe it’s not him at all. Maybe this is someone or something else entirely. I hope it is. I will gladly take another beating over giving Kenna’s location away.

Unless… What if the husband wasn’t the *he* the muse was speaking of at all? What if *he* is still out there?

I hold my hands out in front of me, hoping the blood stains might scare away whoever it is that’s coming.

Because they *are* coming.

I feel it with every step closer they take. It’s in the thickness of the air. The way it presses against my skin, so hard, it’s difficult to breathe. A buzzing pulls at my skin, demanding I pay attention.

Hatred seeps into my bones. A pounding wrath that makes my heart race and my lungs constrict.

“Who's out there?" I call, but there's no answer, only the most intense silence I've ever experienced. There's a weight to it—a promise of something to come, and whatever it is, I don’t think it will be pleasant. I infuse as much confidence into my voice as I can. If someone has come for their pound of flesh, I refuse to make it easy on them.

“If it's the answer to a question you seek, you need only ask it,” I say, purposefully leaving out the part about catching me. My voice shakes,

betraying me, and frustration swirls in my chest. I learned near the beginning of my sentence that showing my fear makes things worse. That it is only kindling for a man's fury, and yet, the rage in the air is so potent, I'm unable to stop it. Whoever is coming *wants* to hurt me.

I'm more certain of it than the fact that I'm cursed.

But *why*?

I wait, but whoever's watching doesn't speak, and the tight, dense silence causes the overwhelming urge to flee to skitter through my entire being. It's a feeling I'm not used to. I'm no stranger to people hating me, but I've accepted it. Have even accepted the attacks that come along with it. People do wild things in their grief, but this feels like more.

"Anything at all," I say again, fighting to keep my voice steady. I peer through the birch and rowan trees that surround the river, searching for anything that might indicate what, or who, is watching me. Is it even human? Or could it be an animal?

My first instinct was that it was rage I was feeling, but could it be hunger?

For a moment, I almost hope that's it. That an animal will leap from the forest and end this curse. I know I cannot die, but if I'm devoured by a wolf or a bear? How would I live then, dismembered and digested? Would only my consciousness remain here, tethered to this shore? It would be better, I think. My consciousness could not be attacked. Maybe if it were just my soul, I could fly above the valley with my dragon.

Maybe…I'd be free.

I picture my bones picked clean and scattered among the heather. And yet, as the feeling intensifies, I know it isn't an animal.

Men are the only creatures capable of a hatred so bone-chilling.

I shiver as I squint into the shadows.

"Tell me who's there. What do you want?" I ask, raising my chin. I refuse to look weak.

And I will not be prey.

He's close now—his rage pulsing angrily against my skin to the rhythm of a heartbeat.

I clench my fists, so very tired of being hunted, and something snaps within me. It's one thing for someone to come here to enact whatever revenge on me they think is owed for washing their loved one's clothing, but another altogether to toy with me. I'd rather face what's coming and

move forward. Not stand here waiting for whoever’s out there to find their courage and get whatever cruelty they’re planning over with. My own fury flares in my chest.

“Stop being a coward, and face me!” I shout, spinning in a circle, scanning the valley.

There is a beat of complete silence, weighted and foreboding.

And then one of the shadows thickens. My stomach twists as it morphs from a vague smear of darkness to a large, broad-shouldered man. He stops, just far enough inside the shadows that I can't fully make out his features.

It’s terrifying, the way I can sense him watching me. Examining me like he’s searching for weaknesses. Assessing for vulnerabilities.

I stand taller and try to do the same. The man is tall, with thick, corded arms and a muscular chest, and even without seeing his face, I know his jaw is set into a hard, tight line. The shadow steps closer, and the details sharpen.

My breath hitches. The man is striking, his imperfections making him appear almost otherworldly. It is clear his nose was broken at some point and never set, the bridge slightly crooked, and a faint scar runs from his right eyebrow into his hairline. He’s tan, as if he spends most of his time outdoors, and thick waves of brown hair fall into his eyes.

A dark tartan kilt is wrapped around his waist, deep greens and thin stripes of blood-red, belted at the waist and falling in pleats to his knees. Over it, he wears a fitted wool tunic, reinforced with leather at the shoulders, forearms, and wrists.

The clothes of a warrior. A Dìdeanair.

Dàn are inked on his arms—more than I’ve ever seen before. One peeks from his tunic at his chest, and another jumps with the pulse in his neck.

True fear flickers in my chest. There are very few people in this kingdom who have that much magic. Magic that could *actually* hurt me. Make me wish for death even more fervently than I do now.

“Who are you?” I ask, but the stranger doesn’t answer, only his eyes moving, trailing down my body from head to feet.

I fight the urge to squirm beneath the man’s furious gaze. He remains deadly still, as if daring me to challenge him. *Answer me!* I want to scream, but the darkness in his eyes stops me cold.

“I have nothing for you to take,” I suppress a shiver as his hatred sharpens to a point, aimed directly at my chest.

The man doesn't turn away. Doesn’t move at all. He’s still studying me, his forest-green eyes heating my skin as they bore into me, but what he's looking for, I don't know.

His angular jaw bunches, and the hair on the back of my neck prickles.

“Whoever’s clothes I washed, I cannot take it back,” I say. My voice comes out weaker each time I speak, and while I hate it, the weakness I sense in my tone, I can’t seem to stop it. Why isn’t he answering me? What could this man possibly want?

He finally moves.

Fear pounds like an axe in my chest, and my sense of dread and danger grow larger than my dragon’s wings as the man stalks forward, purposeful, his plaid swishing with every step, boots crunching on the rocks.

Absolute loathing radiates off him in waves as his eyes meet mine, his teeth clenching so tight, I wonder if they will crack under the pressure. The emotion doesn’t feel vague, but targeted. Sharp and aimed directly at me, and I take an involuntary step back.

The man’s hand shoots to his hip where a long, glinting dagger sits in a leather holster, and the air is stolen from my lungs. I search the man’s face for any hint of recognition. Did I wash the clothes of someone he loved recently? I don’t think so. His features are wholly unfamiliar.

His fingers hover just above his weapon, but he stops himself from grabbing it, instead clenching his hand into a fist—a movement that doesn’t feel like hesitation but control. As if the impulse to draw blood is something that has been trained out of him.

“Are you her?” he asks, finally speaking. His voice is deep. Strong, and the roughness of it rumbles through my bones almost painfully.

I don’t answer, certain if I try to speak, my voice will shake and betray how afraid of this strange man I truly am.

“The Washwoman of the River Bàsail. The Bean-Nighe. Are you her?” His tone lowers.

The question has an obvious answer, and I want to snap back at him. *Do you see any other women with blood-stained hands chained to this shore?* I *almost* spit out the retort, but hold my tongue when his eyes darken.

“Are. You. Her?” He punctuates each word with a slow, deliberate step forward, his gravelly voice wrapping around my body and squeezing, rough and furious, demanding answers. I press my lips together, and this time, he does draw his dagger. In a breath, he’s standing in front of me, the tip of his

blade pressed where the skin of my neck meets my chin. He tilts the dagger, forcing my head back to meet his eyes, and the metal nicks my throat as I swallow.

I lean back, but I cannot escape the pressure of the weapon. “Aye," I say, my own voice barely a whisper. There’s no use denying it. I am the only one chained to this shore, after all.

He watches me, his jaw so tight, I think his teeth might crack. His chest rises and falls with rapid breaths, but the hand holding the dagger remains steady.

“Whoever you’re trying to save, I can’t help them,” I repeat.

The man narrows his eyes, his silence only setting me more on edge.

“Aye. I ken better than to expect help from monsters.” He spits the last word, but abruptly pulls the dagger away, and I almost sob in relief. I am so tired of being beaten. Of being an acceptable place for the grieving to come to release their anger.

He takes a second to appraise me, his steely eyes skating down my entire body until it reaches my chain. It lingers there, where blood trickles from where the cuff has grown tighter with every attempt to escape, cutting so deep into my ankle my skin has begun to heal over top the metal. After a long pause, he turns, placing his fingers in his mouth and whistling.

“Who are you calling? Why are you here?” I ask, searching the glen and the trees. I wait for more soldiers to come, but instead, a horse as black as night appears, overfilled satchels strapped on each side.

Even through my fear, my eyes snag on the bags. Could the items I need to complete the spell be inside? Maybe he has his naming pendant…

He pulls his sword from a sheath on the saddle, and all thoughts of the spell dash from my mind. A tremor wracks my body as the memory of the last time a sword was plunged into my chest flashes through my mind.

“If you’re going to hurt me, get on with it,” I say, voice shaking. Any attempt at begging for mercy in the past has only spurred on my attackers, like ignoring my pleas gives them an extra thrill. I do not want that from this man. Not when he has so much magic and a heart full of hate.

It’s in every line of his face. The tension in his posture. The way this stranger despises me is so visceral, it feels as if his rage is wrapping around my heart and gripping, trying to stop its steady rhythm.

“I willnae hurt you,” the man says gruffly, stabbing his sword into the ground and grabbing a canteen.

Disbelief courses through me. Is it possible he's telling me the truth? He hasn't asked me a question. So if not to hurt me, why is he here?

"You won't…" I say, watching his rigid, calculated movements. The sword is still too close for my comfort, and I learned long ago never to trust a man at his word. I take a subtle step away from it.

His jaw bunches, and he rubs his forehead, but he doesn't look at me. "There's no valor in attacking a woman in shackles," he says.

The statement gives me pause, because if he means it, he is the first in a century to think so. I have been harmed more times than I can count, and each time, my attacker clearly felt it justified.

He eyes me as he takes a swig of water. His throat bobs as he drinks deeply, the muscles in his neck contracting as he swallows. It only emphasizes how strong he must be. The pain he could inflict on me if he decided to do so. The man puts the cap back on the bottle and tosses it onto the ground with a thud.

His gaze settles on my split lip and bruised temple. "What happened there?" he asks, wiping his mouth.

"Besides another man coming to assault me?" I snap before I can consider if my anger might cause him to reconsider his words.

His lips curl in disgust, and it stokes the fire deep within me. Will nothing ever be enough for these men who come here, seeking revenge for something out of my control?

"What? Angry he didn't do worse? That he didn't kill me?" I add, my instincts of self-preservation dashing away in my frustration. What's the worst he can do to me? Nothing I haven't already lived through.

His shoulders straighten. "It is my understanding that you, Washwoman, cannae die."

My lungs constrict, the glen suddenly feeling too small. "Who are you?" I ask again, but he remains silent, defiant. Is that what it is? Is killing me a challenge for him? "Is that why you're here, then? To torture me until I beg for the death I cannot have? To see for yourself if the rumors are true that only the Fates can end my pathetic excuse of a life?" Revulsion churns in my stomach.

He crosses his arms across his broad chest, his muscles bunching and bulging, and an image of his hands wrapping around my throat flashes through my mind. He could break my windpipe. Do actual damage that

would take far longer to heal than bruising. I straighten my spine when he doesn’t answer.

“If that’s why you’re here, get on with it then,” I say.

If I *could* be killed, the look he gives me would certainly do it. “Let me be clear,” the man says, leaning down until his nose is so close to mine, I can feel the warmth of his breath on my cheeks. His body heat wraps around me, but even so, I shiver. “I have no sympathy for murderers, but unless I am ordered to hurt you, I won’t. My restraint, however, ends if you try to harm me or anyone else. Do you understand?” He doesn't break eye contact as he stands back upright, and I let out a shuddering breath.

“Unless you’re ordered to…” I say, not backing down from his stare, even though confusion swirls in my chest. “Who would order you to? Who are you?”

He looks me dead in the eye. “Brennen.” It’s nothing more than a word —a name, but somehow, it feels like a threat. My heart constricts as he continues. “I was sent by the Fates.”

“The Fates— What?” I stutter, shock overriding my anger. The Fates have never sent anyone after me, so why now?

Nausea churns in my stomach, and my throat burns, because if they’ve decided to kill me now, I won’t finish collecting the objects for my spell, and any chance at redemption will be snatched away in a breath. And though entering the *After* is my deepest wish, I do not want to go at *their* hands.

“But… Why?” I ask, breathless.

The man appears completely unaffected, giving me nothing but an icy glare that says more than any words could.

That *he* is in control here.

Breathe, I remind myself, but the world spins around me, my mind racing.

The man turns, grabbing an apple from his bag and feeding it to the horse before unclipping the other bags from its side. There’s a bedroll, along with what looks like a tent, several weapons, and a sack of food.

“You’re staying here?” I ask, my eyes darting around, looking for some other reason he might be pulling out so many supplies.

“Do you ken other uses for a tent?” he spits.

I don't know if I'm blinking. I don't know if I'm even breathing. I’m stuck, frozen in a horrific, endless moment in time.

The horse whinnies as she's set free to graze on the riverbank, and only then am I pulled out of my shock enough to notice the six golden stripes on the hilt of the sword strapped to Brennen's back. A Dìdeanair's sword, adorned to show he is a general of the highest order. And then at the base—a skull—a symbol that he serves Cailleach above all else.

A pit bigger than my fist forms in my stomach, and my eyes flick to his left wrist, where I suspect a dedication dàn will mark his skin. Just as I thought, the Cutter's sigil—the Fate who sentenced me here—stares back at me, just below what looks to be a dàn of truth.

I was once dedicated to her, too, before I was sentenced here, and any dàn that adorned my skin were stripped from both my body and my mind.

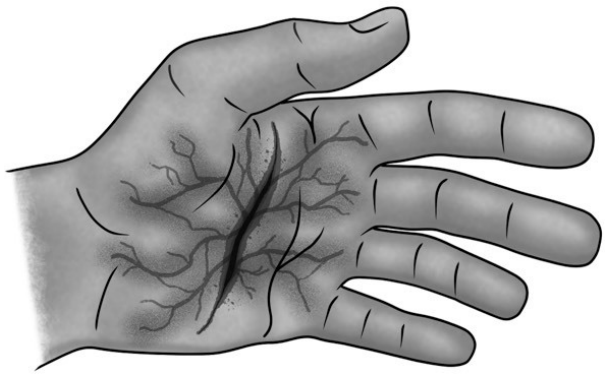
I turn around, needing a moment to think. To calm my racing heart, but the hair on the back of my neck stands on end at the feeling of his eyes on my exposed back. That same hatred I'd felt as he neared only grows, pressing outward until I wonder if it will wilt the trees.

"Tell me why you're here. Why did the Fates send you?" I whisper, unable to calm my racing mind.

His footsteps approach from behind, and the air crackles between us as he leans forward. His breath tickles my neck when he speaks. Too close. "The Cutter assigned a guardian to you to ensure you don't escape. But as to why *I'm* here," he pauses, leaning even closer until his lips nearly touch my ear, his voice dropping to a deep, deadly rumble. "I said I wasnae going to hurt you. But I *am* going to find a way to kill you."

7

BRENNEN



"To kill me?" she breathes, her hand settling on her sternum. "Why would you want to kill me?"

I ignore her, my arm jamming into her shoulder as I return to my things. The oath on my palm burns like fire, and I pointedly turn my back on her false shock. I willnae be fooled by the lies coming from her pretty mouth.

Yanking my tent from my rucksack, I toss it onto the rocks, the thud echoing through the glen, and try to pay no attention to the unease creeping through my blood.

I shouldn't be so on edge. Ban-dia a' Bhàis has upheld her end of our bargain.

But the woman staring at my back is nothing like I expected—the cursed, decaying monster with lifeless grey skin and claws for fingers, or a hag with dagger teeth and long, greasy hair hanging in strings to her knees—and it's thrown me off kilter.

I'd been prepared for both iterations and anything in between. But this? The terrified woman with hair the color of rowan berries and a face so ethereal that, despite the split lip and bruised temple, it looks as if it was crafted from morning dew and starlight? She is *nothing* like the stories mothers tell their children to scare them into behaving.

It had startled me when I first saw her appear through the trees, so wholly human, so fair and bonnie. Disgust churns in my stomach that I'd

noted her freckles or gentle eyes at all. Her smooth skin, the color of a lily. But hadn’t the queen warned me of exactly this?

She will try to tempt you with her sorrow. Will tell you gorgeous, enchanting lies and prey on the kindness in your heart.

I keep the Cutter’s warning in the front of my mind as I unfold my tent.

It doesnae matter what the woman looks like. Beautiful things can kill you just as well as the ugly. Easier, even, because they surprise you. A bolt of lightning in the night. A gilded sword at your throat.

The Washwoman may appear weak and incapable of violence, but I willnae be fooled. She is a killer.

The evidence is right in front of me in her blood-stained palms. In the shackle around her ankle, so tight, her skin has begun to grow around it.

It looks agonizing, but there’s a reason she’s imprisoned this way.

I watch her as I get out the rest of my things, forming my plan.

Check the wards surrounding the river meant to keep her contained, should she somehow escape her shackles. Examine her chain. Ride to Dalbàsail for supplies. I’ll need to talk to the villagers to learn what they know of the Washwoman. Someone must know why she cannae be killed, and I will do whatever it takes to find out.

She claims ignorance herself, and my dàn of truth did not warm, which means either she can somehow lie to me undetected, or she truly doesnae know. Either way, I will do whatever it takes to find out.

My family’s lives depend on it.

The thought settles like a stone in my stomach, and I force a wall of iron around my mind. I cannae afford to be distracted by Cailleach’s threat. Not when that distraction might be the verra thing that causes me to fail.

I scan the shore for anything that could be used as a weapon, as well as possible escape routes. My dàn of warning hasn't alerted me of danger, but that doesnae mean much. Just because she doesn't intend on attacking me now doesn't mean she won't. We're deep within a massive valley, rocky hills soaring around us, and while riding in on my horse hadn't been particularly difficult, climbing out by foot would be a challenge, especially without sturdy footwear.

And that’s if she could even get the chain off her leg.

The Washwoman stiffens as I approach, but I do not meet her gaze, keeping my eyes on her hands as I crouch next to the interlocked ovals of iron embedded in a slab of river rock.

She scoots away slightly, pulling her knees to her chest and sucking in a deep breath, as if afraid of what I'll find. There are chips in the stone where it looks like she's tried to chisel away the shale over time, but the metal appears too firmly fixed in place to pull out, and the hum radiating from it tells me it’s been reinforced with magic.

I try to lift the stone, activating my dàn of strength, but even with it burning on my ribs, it barely budges. It must weigh at least thirty-five stones. Completely impossible for this tiny woman to lift or drag.

“Was this added after your escape?” I ask, wondering if it’s a century or six years old.

Her cheeks turn red, but she nods.

Good. Less of a chance it will break or fail.

“Hold out your ankle,” I order, and she finally meets my gaze, her expression hard as stone.

“Why? So you can make sure my shackle is tight enough? I promise you, it is.” Her words are angry, but her voice is tired.

My hands curl into fists, tight enough my fingers cramp. “Hold out. Your ankle. *Now*.”

She flinches, only hesitating for a moment before shifting to extend her foot to where I can see it. An echo of pain spreads through my own ankle as I look at the bloody, marred skin beneath the shackle.

The metal is as thick as my thumb and appears to be welded by dragon fire. There’s no lock to pick. No bolts to unscrew. Pulling as hard as I can, I test each link in the chain.

The Washwoman studies me as I work, her posture and expression the picture of neutral indifference, but there’s a slight tremble to her lips that betrays her composed exterior.

I dinnae allow it to bother me.

Let her be angry.

Let her be terrified, just as I’m sure Marsaili was at the end of her life.

I dinnae try to picture her face, but it comes to me nonetheless. Her slender nose and blonde eyelashes. The wisps that framed her delicate face. Something in my chest cracks, and I force the image away, focusing on the task at hand. I pull harder, testing the last links, but the metal appears in pristine condition.

Satisfied the chain is stable, I grab her arm. “Stand up,” I order, but she resists.

“What could you possibly want now?" she asks, her voice exasperated.

I squeeze tighter, and she winces. “I dinnae enjoy repeating myself. It’d serve you well to learn that.” I drag her to her feet, and her knees almost buckle, but I hold her up until she stands on her own. “Arms out,” I bark, and this time, she listens.

Starting at her shoulders, I search her for weapons, keeping my hands confined to where clothing covers her skin. My hands slide down her arms to the cuffs of her long sleeves, then back to her armpits.

She sucks in a harsh breath as my touch lowers, grazing the sides of her breasts, then again as it slides beneath them. She shifts away from me, but I hold her in place, ignoring the way her body stiffens beneath my fingers.

When I look up, there are tears in her eyes.

If she were anyone else, any other woman, I’d stop. But she’s not, and in the end, I will do far worse to her than this.

I search the pockets of her mud-stained apron and step back.

“Satisfied?” she asks, her voice tight as if she's trying to hold back tears. Or at least, pretending to, because while her forehead is creased and her lips tremble, no tears have fallen.

I ignore her, refusing to acknowledge her show of distress. True or forced, I dinnae care. I didnae come here to have pity.

The wind picks up in a melodic gust, the trees surrounding the river bowing as if in deference to the magic it carries, and the Washwoman sucks in a sharp breath, her hand going to her sternum. She drops to her knees, the current pulling at her dress as she lowers her hands into the river.

It only takes a moment for something to float from upstream, and I squint, trying to make out what it is. It's some sort of fabric—a soft linen, stained a deep plum. My mouth goes dry as it floats directly into the Washwoman’s fingers, and she begins to scrub.

I shouldn’t look, but I cannae tear my eyes away.

It’s horrifying to watch. And yet, there’s something sacred about it. Beautiful and tragic in equal measure. I back away, the sudden need to give her space nearly overwhelming. Not because I feel sorry for her, but because standing this close to death feels wrong.

There’s a reason the River Bàsail is hidden from sight. Watching the Washwoman now, I dinnae think mortals are meant to witness this cleansing of souls. Not when it feels like an invitation for death to look my way.

The Washwoman begins to sing, a haunting, soft trill that turns my skin to gooseflesh.

Come follow the river. Do not be afraid.
Her mistress will find you by the end of the day.
You cannot escape her, be you goddess or maid.
So follow my river. Do not be afraid.

Come now my darling. Down the river you'll go.
I'll wash you. I'll cleanse you. Then she'll hold you close.
The river will carry your soul down below.
So come now, my darling. Down the river you'll go.

She hums the tune as she continues to rub the dress along the stones, and as I watch her, I feel like I cannae breathe. The sorrow in the song is so potent it feels like a wound has opened in my own heart because of it.

My blood runs hot with anger, and I want to go to her. To rip the stone from her hands and force her to stop. Because this wicked woman has no right to touch these souls.

It is a punishment, yes, to be bound here forever.

But it's also a gift to be the one to cleanse them, one that someone with a tainted heart doesnae deserve.

She finishes scrubbing, and a shiver runs down my spine as the garment trails from her fingers.

Sleep now, you're ready. It's your time to die.
The river will find you. Close your weary eyes.
Don't worry. Don't tarry. Don't weep, and don't cry.
So sleep now, you're ready. It's your time to die.

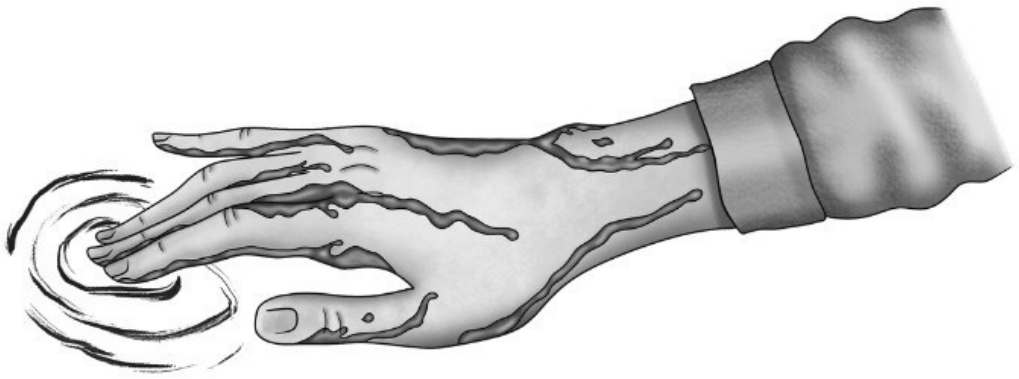
The last of the song fades into the valley, leaving behind a heavy silence. And then, she smiles. Only for a fraction of a second, but it is there, as unmistakable as the blood staining her hands.

Before I can blink, the smile is gone, the Washwoman's mask of sorrow back firmly in place.

But if she thinks I dinnae notice, she’s mistaken.

8

BEA



I stare at the plum dress as it floats away. My ma had owned one so similar. The moment I'd touched it, the memory of her letting me try it on as a little girl had wrapped around my heart. If only those days could have lasted.

But even my memories can’t distract me from the guard behind me for long.

I feel him with every breath I take.

The dress disappears around the bend, and I close my eyes, waiting for the pain in my sternum to pass. It only takes a few seconds, but it’s enough to ground myself.

With a deep, steadying breath, I whirl around to face him. I square my shoulders, steeling myself to demand he leave. This may be a prison, but it is *mine*. My river. My glen.

“You—”

“Stand up,” he snaps, interrupting me.

Rage surges through my blood. How dare he come here and order me around like a child. I remain as I am, defiant, and Brennen’s eyes flash with anger.

He stalks forward, grabbing me roughly by the arm and forcing me to rise. His chest presses against mine as he leans down to hiss in my ear. “I dinnae think you understand. You belong to me, now. You’ll obey, or I will make you.”

I do not back down from his fury, instead straightening and crossing my arms. “I belong to no one. I haven’t in a very long time, and the Fates sending you here will not change that now.”

Brennen seethes with rage, his jaw tight and eyes wild. I use his distraction as an opportunity, slipping my other hand into the pocket of his kilt. It’s empty.

“Mallachd ort!” he curses, shoving me back. Pain shoots through my ankle, but I do not show it. “What do you think you’re doing?”

“You searched me for hidden weapons. Seems only fair I should be given the same opportunity,” I say, though it wasn’t a weapon I’d hoped to find in his pocket.

His entire demeanor hardens into suspicion, his eyes narrowed and his chin tilted down. He stalks forward, grabbing me again, rougher this time. “Dinnae test me, lass.” His fingers tighten painfully around my arm. “Keep your bloody hands where I can see them, and walk. As far as that chain will allow.”

He shoves me forward, but I dig my heels in.

“You seem to mistake me for someone who will obey the orders of brutish men,” I say, forcing bravado into my voice. He may be assigned here by the Cutter, but I have no obligation to make it easy for him. My job is to wash the clothes that come down the river, and nothing more.

A muscle jumps in his jaw, his nostrils flaring as his expression turns lethal. “You will do as I say!” he roars, and it takes all my effort not to flinch. “One way or another, I will know how far you can go, so you can walk, or I will drag you to your boundary by that verra chain around your ankle.”

I hold his stare. “You wouldn’t dare.”

Darkness flits through his green eyes, and his fingers curl as if he’s imagining wrapping them around my neck. “Dinnae underestimate what I’ll do when it comes to you. Now walk.”

My eyebrows raise. “Why would you care if I can reach it?”

He pins me with a stare. “Because I dinnae think you are the fool you pretend to be, and I am *certain* I’m not. If you can reach my tent, you can reach those weapons you were just trying to swipe like some common thief.”

I wave away the accusation. It’s not his sword I want. “I have no interest in your weapons.” I eye the bags resting on the ground once more.

He’s already clearly decided he needs to store his supplies out of my reach, but if he *does* have something I could use for the spell, there must be other ways for me to get it.

“Even if I did,” I continue, “I cannot go beyond the hollow log. Set your things up there.” I say, feigning disinterest as I point to a fallen tree two dragon's lengths away.

He scoffs. “You think I'm just going to take your word for it?”

“Why would I lie?” I ask, silently cursing the Fates for sending this insufferable, stubborn man here.

“Why would you kill?” He almost growls the words. “Now, I’ll not just be believing you. If you truly cannae go past the log, you should have no problem proving it.”

I open my mouth to argue, but before I can say a word, the dàn on his neck illuminates, shimmering faintly. Dread washes over me, so intense, my stomach feels as if it has fallen into my feet. My hands begin to shake as he grabs my shoulder and spins me around, the tip of his sword pressed directly against my spine.

Already know the mood: werewolf, vampire, or billionaire?

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He pushes me forward, and while the sword doesn’t cut through my dress or skin, the pressure of it against my bone stings.

But even worse is the humiliation of it. Each time I think there is nothing left to be taken from me, I’m proved wrong.

This time, as I take the first step forward, it’s my pride.

His blade never leaves my back as I slowly walk toward the log, careful to remain steady so I don’t stumble and fall backward. My chain catches just before it, and pain shoots up my leg. I bend down to grab my ankle, hissing.

“Satisfied?” I ask, gritting my teeth.

“Keep going,” he says, and despite the dread fading away, I stiffen.

Is he truly going to make me try to continue when my chain is clearly taut? “I can’t go any further.”

He tilts his sword, forcing my body to turn. “Not forward. That way. I want to see your boundaries.”

I shake my head. There’s no way he truly expects me to parade around like a show hog to prove where I can and cannot go. “You want me to walk in a circle?” I ask, my brows furrowing. Surely he can figure it out based on where I’m standing now.

“Aye, that’s exactly what I want you to do.”

Anger flashes in my belly, and I meet his eyes. Very determined eyes. His jaw is set in a hard line, his shoulders tight. It’s clear he will not be backing down, but I will not give him the satisfaction of my reluctance, nor do I wish for him to activate his dàn of dread again. “As you say, *Warden*,” I say, infusing as much venom into my voice as possible.

I keep my chin held high as I walk the perimeter of my prison, my chain pulling with every step, the tension on the length of it causing the shackle to dig into my skin so much more than usual. Every so often, Brennen leans down and picks up a stick, stabbing it into the earth just beside my foot.

A visual reminder of my limitations.

I almost laugh at his caution. Probably would, were the pain in my ankle not causing my head to spin, because what does he possibly think I could do that would make this necessary?

We wade into the water, and I’m thankful my chain aligns with a more shallow area so we’re not forced to swim. I complete my walk on the far side of the river, the few feet of space I’m able to reach. We turn to go back across. The metal slices into my skin, hot, sticky blood seeping from beneath the cuff, and I stop.

“I’ve shown you enough,” I say, biting back tears of pain. It’s getting worse by the moment, my vision going fuzzy at the edges.

Brennen doesn’t press his sword harder into my spine, but he doesn’t back down either. “We’ll no be stopping until I know exactly how far this chain allows you to go. Best get on with it.”

I shake my head. It’s clear arguing will change nothing, so I continue back across the river, picking up my pace. If there’s no other way to end this torture, I’d at least like to get it over with as quickly as possible. The blood from my ankle swirls in the river as we cross back over, my limp becoming more prominent with each step. I fight to hold back my tears, but the pain is too intense, and by the time I complete the circle, I’m unable to stop them.

He stabs the final stick into the ground, looking around to examine the markers. Finally, he lowers his sword.

I turn from him, limping toward the river where I drop to sit and place my foot in the cool water. The relief is subtle, but welcome.

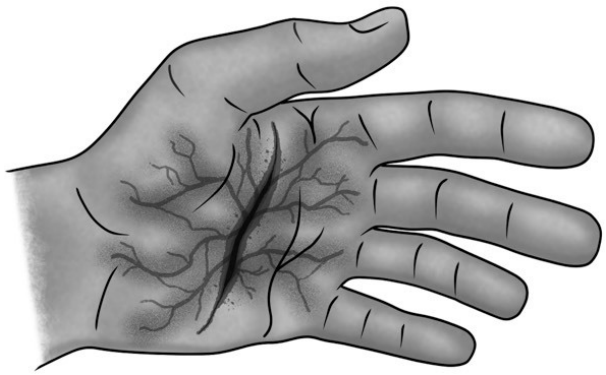
“I hope you feel safe now,” I say, doing my best to seem unbothered. Brennen doesn’t answer, but I sense his anger burning hotter. A satisfied smile tugs at my lips. Good. Let him be angry. I did not ask for him to come, nor do I want him here.

“I’m going to check the wards,” he huffs. “For your sake, pray they havenae been tampered with.”

My satisfaction only grows. I’m getting under his skin. “Have a nice walk!” I call after him. “I’ll just stay here then!”

9

BRENNEN



I watch from the trees after I leave the Washwoman. I'd expected her to scream. To throw rocks at my tent, or to curse the goddess.

But she's just sitting there, soothing her foot in the water and using a stick to draw slow, deliberate lines in the mud.

Blood still swirls from her ankle downstream, and I rub my forehead. She doesn't even seem bothered by the pain she surely must be feeling. Pain I inflicted, but refuse to regret.

I am *nothing* if not a man of my word. I've prided myself on it my entire life, and I'd promised not to hurt her. But it hadn't been without reason that I'd made her walk her chain length. I'd needed to know her *exact* boundaries. How could I sleep without knowing precisely how far she could go? It was necessity that had caused me to plot the border out, not cruelty.

Another point of pride. I do not believe in brutality.

I turn from the Washwoman, heading deeper into the trees, scanning the bark for the dàn engravings that ward the valley from her escape, the memory of the time I spent in Lochdubh flooding my mind.

I'd been only a boy, but Da had allowed me to come along on his trade route. I'd been so proud sitting next to my father on the wagon, ready to convince people to purchase his carvings and furniture. I was of the opinion that he was the best carpenter in the kingdom, and my excitement had grown by the minute as we made our way into the Measurer's domain.

Until we arrived at Lochdubh, where outside the village gates, a man was nailed to a wooden post, arms overhead, shoulders wrenched from their sockets, feet kicking, reaching for the ground several feet below him. My da had shielded my eyes, but the damage had been done. I'd already seen his pain. Heard his suffering.

He'd stolen half a bushel of apples, I later learned. Such a small crime to justify inflicting so much agony, and yet that is what the village elders had chosen.

When we left two days later, the man was still there. Still *alive*. He'd cried out for us to help him, the sound so weak, and I'd covered my ears, unable to bear it. But my father had stopped and pulled a dagger from his waist.

"Dinnae look," he told me, climbing out of the wagon, but I hadn't listened. I watched as he approached the man, looking him in the eye. Giving him dignity.

"Do you want me to end it for you?" he asked.

"Please," the man begged.

Begged.

His pain and suffering had been so intense, he had *begged* my da to end his life.

So, with a nod and a prayer, my father swiftly pressed his dagger through the man's heart, remaining by his side until the light left his eyes.

And as I watched, I swore to myself I would be more like Da. That I would never again stand for acts of cruelty like the one the poor man had suffered through. And for twenty-eight years, I have kept that promise.

I close my eyes, pushing the image from my mind. At some point during my remembering, I'd stopped moving. I'm not sure what exactly triggered the memory. What I put the Washwoman through was nothing like what had happened to that man. Her suffering was simply the unavoidable cost of protecting myself, along with anyone else who may stumble into her valley of death.

Straightening my spine, I turn back toward the water, climbing up until I can look down upon it with a bird's-eye view. The river appears around a crooked, sloped bend, dropping down a series of small waterfalls that empty into churning white foam. The water clears as it flows over the stony bed, creating shallow stretches that vary from shin to waist deep. The Washwoman still sits with her ankle dangled in one of the shallower areas,

drawing in the mud, but on either side of her are sections of deeper water where it’s difficult to see the bottom.

It’s stunning, almost as if it was plucked from a storybook. Marsaili would have loved how peaceful it is. The harsh beauty of it.

The thought comes, sudden and unwelcome, and I shove it down. Thinking of her will only distract me, so I focus back on the environment around me, noting every detail.

The Washwoman twists, looking up at the sky. I follow her gaze, but am unable to see anything through the thick canopy of trees. When I turn back to her, I realize she’s talking to herself. Muttering like a madwoman. I activate my dàn of hearing only to pick up ramblings about making jam.

Frustration builds within me. How can she speak so casually of a luxury such as jam after what she did? I force my gaze away from the Washwoman, focusing again on her surroundings. I need to learn the land if I’m to make sure she truly cannae escape.

Small cairns dot the shore, what must be nearly a hundred of them, ranging from no higher than a hand width to stacks taller than my waist. The banks vary from wide, stony shorelines with clusters of marsh violets and patches of grass, heather, and moss to steeper, rockier areas, and the current seems to grow stronger as the river narrows closer to the *After*. I lean forward, peering into the darkness. It’s the same black mist that surrounds the boundaries of the kingdom, where land falls away into nothing, and far below lie shadows so black, they could only have been created by the goddess of death herself.

I close my eyes, straining to hear the water as it trickles down, but I cannot tell how far it goes before it stops.

The sight is comforting. There is an order to it. A firm boundary, and that is something I understand. Something I respect. I take another moment to enjoy it, noting the sun's position in the sky. It will dip below the horizon in a few short hours, and I still need to set up my tent.

I’d hoped to make it into town today to procure a writing desk, but I no longer have enough time before the sun will set, and I dinnae wish to return to the monster in the dark. With a sigh, I try to temper my frustration, shifting my focus back to the task at hand.

I refuse to let my mind stray as I pick my way down the rocky terrain back toward the base of the glen, crossing the river upstream to locate the warding dàn in the trees on the other side. I complete the circle, all twelve

symbols clearly visible in the trunks of the thickest, sturdiest trees. The wards hold firm, and it bolsters my confidence, though only slightly.

Because I still do not know how she escaped six years ago.

10

BEA



“Can you believe he actually made me do that?” I ask Lolly, sketching with a stick in the mud. “As if he cannot see how far my chain will go without making a whole spectacle of it.” I glance around at the stakes circling my river, and a spark of anger heats my belly. I’d never thought this place could feel like even more of a prison, but the visual of my boundaries makes me feel like a trapped animal.

I force the thought away, looking down to my still-submerged ankle, the cold water easing the sting as I watch Lolly twist through the air. She banks to the left, and I pretend it's her agreement.

“Right? Surely he knows I don't have any magic. Does he think I can manipulate metal or something? Make my chain grow longer?” I scoff, and a rumble leaves the dragon’s chest.

“Exactly!” I say, dropping my stick down. I lean back on my elbows, watching her as righteous indignation washes through me. My stomach grumbles, and I look at the bramble berry bush to my left. It’s so far away, and I’m not ready to pull my ankle from the cold.

“Hey, Lolly. Have I ever told you about the time Ma taught me to make jam?” I ask. She doesn't answer.

“I'll take that as a no.” I smile at the memory, my mother's face once again popping into my mind. She had red hair, just like me, and somehow even more freckles, but it's her eyes I remember most. They’d been the clearest shade of blue I've ever seen.

“I told her I was old enough to do it myself,” I start. “I'd watched her make jam start to finish a thousand times, so I went out and I picked the berries by myself. A whole basket full. It took hours, but I was so proud that I didn't eat a single one.” Lolly swoops over the ridge, but doesn’t land.

“How old was I? Hmm…” I tap my chin, following her path through the sky. “Maybe five? Ma made the fire for me, and I put the berries on the stove with two cups of sugar. I was proud of that, too, that I remembered how much sugar to use without her having to tell me.” The horse whinnies somewhere behind me, and I turn. Brennen’s bag catches my eye, just beyond the hollow log. With a groan, I pull my ankle from the water, grab the longest stick I can find, and limp toward it. “I watched them cook for an hour, hardly even blinking, then mashed and mixed them.”

Leaning forward, I reach out with the stick, trying to hook the strap of his satchel. My shoulders ache, and sweat trickles down my back as I extend my arm as far as it will go. I’m close. Only a few finger-widths from the bag. The pain in my ankle is once again near unbearable, but I ignore it. What if it contains one of the spell items? It’s possible this is the closest I will get to Brennen’s belongings without him watching me, and I refuse to give up the opportunity to find what I need over a little pain.

“I was doing so well,” I continue, telling the story to distract myself from the throbbing joint, “and Ma said she was proud of me. She left me on my own while she was hanging laundry on the line. And guess what happened. I fell asleep!” I shake my head, widening my stance. I move my grip to the very end of the stick, then lunge forward, trying to hook the bag with momentum. “Right there by the fire. Burned the jam so bad, it was unsalvageable.” Just thinking about it makes my stomach rumble again, louder this time, and I glance back at the berry bush.

Focus, Bea. I scold myself. *The berries will still be there when you’re done.*

“Oh, Lolly, what I wouldn't give for some jam. Have you ever tried it?”

She disappears over the ridge.

“Guess my story’s over, then,” I grumble.

Footsteps approach from within the forest, and I fumble back, using my stick to disturb the ground around me so Brennen doesn’t suspect I was up to something.

I’m just settling back down to pretend to be drawing when he stalks from the trees, his movements efficient and precise, eyes sliding throughout

the glen as if once again searching for threats. I fight to keep my voice even, out of breath from scrambling to cover my tracks. “Back so soon?”

“Washwoman,” he starts, likely to order me to complete some new ridiculous task, but I hold up a hand. I can't bear to be called that for however long this man will be my shadow. The constant reminder that the washer of souls is all I am, and all I will ever be.

“Bea,” I say. “Please. Call me Bea.”

Brennen’s jaw bunches, but he does not acknowledge my words. Doesn’t move at all, as if hearing my name had been a shock. Is it because he doesn’t want to humanize me? It’s easy to end a life when you believe it belongs to a beast. A monster. To not have to look your fellow man in the eye as you swipe your blade across their throat.

But why does he want to end *my* life at all?

I clear my throat. “Now that we’ve been properly introduced, are you going to tell me why you want to kill me?” I ask with a surge of bravery. It would certainly be easier to tolerate his presence here if I knew the reason, at least.

Brennen studies me for a moment. “Aye, *Washwoman*,” he says, drawing out the word, and I grit my teeth. “I’ll tell you.”

Shock ripples through my entire body. I hadn’t thought he’d agree so easily. Had been certain, in fact, he’d argue, or maybe not say anything at all.

He crouches in front of me. “I’ll tell you why I’m going to kill you if you tell me why you murdered the people of Vengach.”

My stomach plummets. I should’ve known better than to think he’d actually be amiable, willing to answer without torturing me first.

“Tell me,” he demands. I wait for him to catch me. To demand an answer, but it never comes.

“It’s none of your business,” I say, growing bolder by the second.

His jaw clenches. “The bloody hell it isnae. It’s why I was sent here. To make sure you cannae escape and go on a murderous rampage again.”

I close my eyes, “It was a long time ago.” I stagger to my bed, bracing myself for the echo of screams beginning to clang through my skull. It happens every time I think about that night. My mind’s way of protecting me from the horrors of what I did, I think.

Suddenly, I don’t have the energy to try to get him to leave or answer my questions. The past days have been draining. The deaths and the

goddess. Kenna. Not to mention Brennen's abrupt appearance. I don't want to think about any of it right now, let alone my past. I lie down on the matted grass and moss, rolling to my side, trying to block out his voice. Hoping the pain will ease.

It doesn't work. Just as I knew they would, the screams grow louder. The sound of my hands ending innocent lives.

Brennen's boots click against stone as he moves to stand in front of me. "It will be easier for both of us if you tell me on your own."

I squeeze my eyes shut, the screams now a cacophony in my skull, pain radiating into my temples.

Brennen's voice is closer when he speaks again, just behind my head. His breath is warm on my neck, and I shiver. "Dinnae force me to pull the answer from you in other ways," he says, his voice dropping. There's a threat there, sharp and pointed, and I hear the word he doesn't say—torture, as if the pain his questions bring isn't torture enough.

I shake my head, covering my ears as the agony dives from my temples to burrow deep into my brain.

"What was your reason for slitting their throats?" he says louder, forcing me to hear his question.

"Stop." The screams grow impossibly louder, unbearable, and my vision tunnels.

"Why did you end their lives? A mother. A Father. Daughters. A family that did *nothing* to harm you or anyone else?"

"Stop!" I beg, images now flashing through my mind that threaten to bring the bile in my empty stomach up my throat. The glint of a blade. Blood on my hands.

"Tell me," he growls, his demand rumbling through my body.

Somewhere beneath the screams, I wonder if he's holding his dagger. Maybe this time, he'll use it. I hope he does. The pain of a blade is predictable. Sharp and grounding, and so much more tolerable than this phantom, magical agony skating through my flesh and blood and bone.

"Tell me why you *murdered* those people without reason," he continues, unyielding. "Tell me why you burned them alive. Slit their throats." The fury in his low tone grows, pushing into my skin until it is hard to breathe. I can *feel* the tension in his muscles, even with my back turned. Blood trickles from my nostrils, the pain growing so unbearable, I explode.

“Stop!” I scream. I wipe my nose, then sit, turning to him. I straighten my spine, forcing my voice to steady. “No matter how you ask, I won’t tell you, so if you’re going to hurt me, just get on with it,” I say.

His mouth closes, jaw going tight. His eyes are so dark, so utterly furious, I’m certain he will make me regret defying him. I brace for a kick or a shove.

For whatever form of torture he thinks will break me.

It never comes.

Shock ripples through me as he turns, stalking back toward his supplies.

“I told you I wouldnae harm you,” he says through gritted teeth.

“But you wish to kill me?” I ask, my words raspy with disbelief.

He pauses, and his voice drops. “It’s no a wish. I *will* kill you. But when I do, it will be swift.”

My throat tightens at his words. Not if. *When*.

He speaks of ending my life as if he’s discussing the culling of a beast, a predator stalking a village, rabid and starving. Like my death is necessary to keep others safe.

That’s not how I’d like to go to my rest, either. Not because of the Fates, and not because of this guardian.

When I die, it will be because I completed the spell. Because I paid my penance through my own dedication, and set *myself* free.

His footsteps retreat, and even though his threat of killing me still circles through my mind, I relax a fraction. He’s keeping his word not to harm me. For now, at least.

But everyone has their limits.

I know that better than most.

I lie back down and close my eyes, but even as the screams and pain fade away, sleep evades me.

All I can focus on is the furious rage threatening to choke me. I tunnel inside myself, hoping that if I become smaller, less of his anger will be able to penetrate.

Lolly appears over the ridge again, crying out—the only thing that could make me open my eyes. She dives down, her call desperate. She swoops again and again, her long neck swiveling from side to side as if searching for something.

The scrape of metal tells me the Dìdeanair has drawn his weapon, and I laugh. Does he think he can take on a massive dragon with a single sword?

“Did the queens not tell you about my other guardian?” I ask, and the shockwave of fury I feel from him takes my breath away. I consider this for a moment. Why *wouldn't* the Fates warn him?

“You can put your sword away,” I say. She can't see me—us.” I sit, picking up nearby stones and beginning to make a cairn. “At least, I'm pretty certain.”

“It's never landed here?” Brennen’s words are sharp, calculating, and I wonder how long he’s been in the Queen’s army. For all I know, he was born and raised in it, based on the way he speaks and holds himself.

“*She*. And never.” It’s not technically a lie. Lolly landed on the ridge, not within the valley, and even then it was only once. “I think she’s meant to eat me should I escape again. So, An Àrd,” I say with a slight curtsey of mock respect, Brennen’s nervous energy giving me a surge of courage. Of *life*. “If the Fates have placed her here to keep me from running, what do they need you for?”

11

BEA



Brennen’s anger doesn’t fade as he sets up his ridiculously large tent just beyond the hollow log, his mare set free to graze the forest as she pleases. It gives me a sense of satisfaction, proving that I was telling the truth about how far my chain would allow me to go, though it’s hard to appreciate it with the pain still throbbing in my ankle.

I try to ignore it, focusing instead on my guardian. Every few seconds, his eyes flick to me, his hand going to his dagger, and my lips tip up in a smile.

It’s only grown more comical as the evening has passed, how seriously this man is taking his safety around me. He spent hours overturning rocks, searching between stones and in bushels of heather for hidden weapons. He’d even flipped over my pillow. My heart had lodged in my throat as he stared at the dirt, but by the blessing of Dìonadair**,** the goddess of protection, he hadn’t thought to dig.

Even with solid proof I cannot reach him, he’s on edge. It’s absurd, his fear of me.

Not to mention he’s covered in dàn, and I’m over a head shorter than him. Weak and exhausted, the only dàn on my body the one of immortality between my breasts. There’s no world in which I could overpower him enough to even leave a scratch.

He looks at me again, and I turn toward him, giving him a cheery wave. “You’re doing a great job over there,” I say, trying not to giggle as the fury

on his face intensifies. He ignores me, driving the last stake for his tent into the ground, and I roll my eyes. If he doesn’t want to be here so fervently, why did he accept this position? Why not pass it along to someone else?

Though I must admit, if the Fates were going to send a Dìdeanair to guard me, at least they sent one who’s pleasant to look at.

He looks like a god as he expertly ties the tent to the stakes, his brunette hair perfectly windswept, and his muscles defined in a way I don’t think I’ve ever seen. He’s undeniably handsome, so much so that not even his constant sour expression and gruff exterior are able to hide it. My stomach flutters, and I look away.

I bet he’s not actually handsome at all. Not really. I’ve been starved of company for so long, I’d likely find beauty in a horse’s arse. My eyes dart to the mare, and while I cannot see anything but her head peeking out between the trees, she *is* a stunning animal.

I whistle, and her ears perk up.

“Dinnae talk to her,” Brennen snaps at me, then gives the mare a stern look. “You ken better, Sable.”

The horse whinnies as if arguing, but turns and disappears into the forest, giving me a clear view of her backside.

Hmm... Not so beautiful.

I sigh and pick up a stick, drawing my half-finished dàn in the mud again. I stare at it for a long moment, but as always, I’m unable to complete it. With a groan, I stand. The light is beginning to fade, and while watching Brennen scramble to get his tent up before dark has entertained me for a bit, I’ve already grown tired of it.

I sense Brennen stiffen as I walk across the shore, searching for a flat pebble. I pick up a few contenders, pocketing them and moving upstream to nearly the end of my chain. Pulling out a stone, I turn toward the *After*, drawing my arm back. I hold my breath and let it fly.

It hits the surface of the water exactly where I hoped and begins to skip. “One, two, three, four,” I count, my voice growing louder with every hop across the surface. “Nineteen, twenty, twenty-one!” I shout as the rock disappears into the black mist. “A new record, Lolly!” I shout toward the sky, pulling out another rock.

I sense Brennen’s gaze on me at the use of my dragon's name. “Do you think I can beat it?” I ask, looking back at him. His jaw ticks, but he doesn’t answer, working on gathering firewood now that his tent is set up.

I grit my teeth, exasperated. Is he going to either question and torment me or remain completely silent his entire time here, with nothing in between?

I pull my arm back again, but this time when I throw the stone, it lands too far in front of me. “Eighteen,” I sigh. “That's usually about what I get. There’s not really enough space before the drop to get many more, though if I aim just right—”

“I dinnae care how many times you can skip a bloody rock,” his gruff voice stops me.

So he *will* answer me.

I place my hands on my hips, turning to where his hands hover over the mound of sticks. They ignite, smoke curling into the air as the flames grow taller.

I gasp. Not at the knowledge that he has a dàn of warmth, though I do tuck that piece of information away, but at the beauty of the flames, flickering blue at the base, the color morphing into yellows and oranges in the middle and top. It’s stunning, and a sight I haven’t seen in so very long. Not since…

I shiver, forcing away the memory of flames heating my skin.

I clear my throat. “Would you care to try?” I ask, holding out a pebble, but Brennen doesn’t even look at me, sitting down and resting his back against a log near the fire. He pulls out an apple, some dried meat, and what looks to be a block of wood.

My stomach rumbles, but I'm too far away for him to hear. Either that, or he’s ignoring it. I haven’t had an apple in *years*. Not since a half-eaten one came down the river in the apron pocket of a maid some time ago. It had been the sweetest thing I’d tasted in so long, and my mouth actually waters at the memory.

He takes a bite, then picks up the wood, twisting it around in his hands. The sun dips below the horizon, and I drop the rock, moving back to my bed to stare into the flames, growing more and more vibrant by the moment.

“What are you carving over there?” I call. His eyes flick to mine, but he remains silent as ever.

“Goddess below,” I grumble under my breath. If the Fates were going to send someone to watch me, they could've at least sent a decent conversationalist. Someone who might make my endless days a little more entertaining.

“I never got into wood carving myself,” I say, keeping my voice light. “I used to enjoy sewing, though. You know. Embroidering little flowers on blankets and handkerchiefs. That kind of thing.”

Brennen scrapes his blade across the wood, a sliver dropping to the ground. I peer at the hunk of wood more intently, but I cannot seem to make out what it is.

“Are you sure you wouldn’t like to tell me what you're carving?” I ask, and his nostrils flare as he sucks in a deep breath. His frustration brings a smile to my lips. Maybe, even without him speaking, I can find some entertainment in his presence after all.

I sigh dramatically. “I don't have many hobbies out here, you know. The Fates didn't send me with dice or books to read. I do like to look at the stars, though.”

Scrape.

“That one right there, those six that connect,” I draw with my finger overhead. “That's the Bonnie Milkmaid.”

His hand stills on the carving for a moment, and my lips twitch.

“And that one over there, that's the Kilted Warrior.”

He looks where I’m pointing for the briefest moment. “You're talking shite," he says, going back to his carving, but the scrape of his knife becomes rougher. A smile tugs at my lips.

“Well, of course I am. It’s not like I studied the stars before I came here. I don't know their real names.”

Scrape. Scrape. Scrape. The cadence grows faster. Sharper.

“That one over there, I like to call the annoyed guardian.” I point at a spot in the sky directly over his head, and I swear he actually growls.

A flicker of triumph settles in my chest, and I smile. I’m getting to him.

“That one—”

“Is there one called lass who doesnae know when to keep her mouth shut?” he asks, and I laugh out loud, a true, genuine laugh. It feels good. Another experience I haven’t had in the longest time. “No, I haven't spotted her yet. I'll let you know if I do, though.”

He shakes his head, gritting his teeth.

“That one over there—”

“I dinnae care what you call them!” he says, dropping his wood carving.

I lean back, unbothered by his anger. “You could tell me their *real* names.”

He huffs, snatching the carving off the ground, growing more furious by the moment, and yet, he clearly doesn’t see the humor in his behavior. “Or do you not know them, either?” I tease, unable to stop myself. I lay my chin on my hand. “That would make sense. You're a warrior after all, not a scholar.”

Scrape. Scrape. Scrape.

“You could tell me something else. Anything would do, really.”

Scrape.

“Like the village. Dalbàsail. What's it like now? It's been so long since I’ve been there.” He freezes, narrowing his eyes as if he doesn't believe me.

“What? Not the village, then? What about you? Do you have a family? A lover perhaps?” I wiggle my eyebrows.

His hand jolts, and he breaks a chunk off the wood with the edge of his knife. He curses under his breath, throwing it in the fire. “Dammit, woman,” he says. “Stop talking!”

The look he gives me is anything but playful. I want to fight back, tell him to get used to it. That it’s not my fault he’s stuck here with me, but I bite my tongue. Something has shifted in his energy, and for some reason, it feels unkind to push him further.

For tonight, at least.

If he thinks I will remain silent for his time here, when I’ve had no one to speak to but myself for years, he's sorely mistaken.

I pretend to yawn, stretching out my arms. “All right, enough with your chattering. Who knew they'd send such a loose tongue to guard me? I’m sure this will be a shock to you, but I do need my beauty rest,” I say.

He huffs, and I can tell based on his fisted hands that he’s barely containing his retort.

I lie down and close my eyes, listening to the chirping of crickets and croaking of frogs. The scraping of his knife on wood interrupts them, but I find the rhythmic earthiness of it soothing. I’m almost asleep when his rough voice pierces the night.

“Do you ever dream of them?” he asks, and I stiffen in shock, my eyes popping back open at his unexpected question.

He doesn't have to say who. I know instantly who he's speaking of, and I wonder, why is he so focused on the ones I killed? Is that why he was sent here by the Fates? To learn the reason behind my crimes? If so, both he, and they, will be sorely disappointed.

I pretend I’m him, and remain silent. If he doesn’t have to answer my questions, I don’t have to answer his. I owe this man nothing. Certainly not explanations. But he doesn't move, waiting for my answer, and the prickles of his eyes on my back make me restless.

I sigh. “I picture their faces every day," I admit, closing my eyes against the wave of sorrow suddenly threatening to swallow me whole.

He takes a few moments before responding, as if considering my words. “Do you know their names?” he asks, and once again, I’m thrown off guard. It feels personal to him.

“Where are you from?” I ask him.

The night goes still.

“If you tell me where you’re from, I will answer your question,” I say, keeping my voice measured.

He pauses for a beat, but he finally answers. “Fiodhchaol. The very edge of the village near the big hill,” he says, and I relax. It’s on the other end of the kingdom, firmly in the Weaver’s domain.

I steel myself to keep my end of the bargain. “Helen, Hannah, Katie, Amanda.” A lump works its way up my throat, but I push past it. “Patrick, and Marsaili.” My voice cracks on the final name, the last of my victims, and I sense him stiffen, but I can’t tell if it’s from the pain of hearing me speak each of their names out loud or surprise that I remember them.

Hatred emanates off him, pulsing waves that dig into my skin, needling beneath it, but I find it does not make my shame worse. He can't possibly hate me for what I've done more than I hate myself.

When he finally speaks again, his voice is rougher than before. “Go to sleep,” he orders, the scrape of his knife on wood the only sound for several long moments before the crunch of rocks beneath his retreating boots tells me I am finally alone. But even with the distance between us, his hatred doesn't dim. If anything, it's thicker than before. Heavier and so potent, I wonder if he's only a hair away from coming back and breaking his promise.

If he will slice my throat to test if I really can’t be killed.

I hope he isn't.

It would take quite a long time to recover from such a thing.

I have not dreamt since I was a child. Not once since the day I was sentenced here at twenty-three. Since the day I was cursed to this riverbed. It’s as if everything froze. My body. Time. My memories. I assume it’s all part of my punishment—an inability to escape, even in rest. A reminder that I will never see anything other than the trees that surround me and the sky that makes up my prison.

But tonight as I fall asleep, something’s different.

Faded, muted colors dance in my periphery, the beginnings of a painting. I reach to grasp them, but they're like fraying strings, and the harder I pull, the faster they unravel.

A noise swims through the thick, hazy fog in my brain.

A memory?

No. It doesn't tug at my heart the way something from my past might. I can’t make out the sound, but it’s soft and rhythmic. And there’s a voice. A woman, I think, based on the pitch. I reach toward it, tentatively this time, trying not to scare it away, but even with the gentlest prod, it shatters.

12

BRENNEN



I'm grateful for the rugged terrain as Sable maneuvers between the trees. It's a needed distraction after hearing Marsaili's name come so casually from the monster's mouth last night. I'd tossed and turned for hours, unable to get the sound out of my head. Even today, as I'd observed the dragon as well as the Washwoman, it stayed with me.

Her voice had cracked as she'd said it. A false display of regret, but why had it been *her* name that she had chosen to show emotion on? Is it possible she knows more than she's letting on? Could she somehow know who, and what, Marsaili was to me?

Sable leaps over a fallen branch, and I kick her sides, urging her faster.

I duck as a craggly stick appears in front of my face, but I'm too slow, distracted, and it scrapes across my forehead. I feel the heat of blood before the pain, and I wipe it from my vision with my forearm.

Do not let her pull your focus from what matters. Cailleach warned that she would trick you, did she not? my subconscious reminds me.

"She did," I say, though I'm not sure if it's out loud or in my own mind.

I dinnae allow myself to think of the grey blue of her eyes or the soft cupid's bow of her upper lip. That I even noticed anything other than her blood-stained hands is a betrayal, and I force myself to picture the way the blood drips up her forearms as if she'd relished ending their lives. To commit the image to memory.

I slow my horse as Dalbàsail comes into view. I'd ridden straight past on my way to the river, eager to set eyes on the monster for myself, but I realize now it had been a mistake. Rage could fuel me, but it could also blind me.

I need to know exactly who I’m dealing with.

My dàn of sight sharpens the break in the trees where a crumbling stone and iron gate sits open in the distance. I ride straight through it, finding an older man gardening in front of the closest house. He tilts his hat as I approach, revealing receding grey hair and sunspots on his face. I hop off Sable and take her reins, grabbing a few sugar cubes from my sporran and patting her mane as I feed them to her. The man stands, taking off a pair of faded canvas gloves and lifting his chin.

“We dinnae allow trouble here,” he says, eyes fixed on my bleeding forehead. I raise my hands.

“I’d only like to trouble you for a place for a meal, and maybe some bandages to clean up the aftermath of my fight with a tree branch,” I say, keeping my tone light.

The man takes a moment to assess me, and I take special care to not let my dàn of dread activate. After a few long breaths, his shoulders lower, and he nods.

“Those woods do like to fight. Especially if you dinnae ken your way through them.”

“So I learned,” I say, touching the cut, already scabbed over from my dàn of healing. “Is there a tavern in town? I don't need lodging, just somewhere to fill my stomach.”

“Wouldn't turn down an ale, would you?” he asks, raising a bushy grey eyebrow.

I give the old man a warm smile. Something about him reminds me of my da, and I have the overwhelming urge to oblige him. “I think I could be convinced.”

“Follow me, then. I was just about to go get one myself. You can leave your horse. It’s not far,” he says, raising a hand as he turns to leave his garden. “My great-grandson, William, will tend to her. I’m Harold, by the way.”

He whistles, and a young red-headed boy pops out from behind a small bush. He's young, maybe eight or nine, and is staring at Sable as if she's the most beautiful creature he's ever seen.

“You’re good with horses, then, lad?” I ask, and he nods, excitedly rolling up his sleeve to show a dàn of beasts just below his elbow.

“I take care of all of the dogs, plus the donkeys and gran’s cow. That's what I want to do when I'm older. Take care of animals.”

I smile at the boy. Sable will take to him easily.

“Right then. I'll be back, girl,” I say, dropping the reins and catching up to the old man in just a few long strides. I have to slow down my pace so he can keep up with me, but I don't mind. I’m confident enough the Washwoman willnae figure out how to escape in the next few hours, and having a local's favor might help the other villagers feel more comfortable opening up to me.

The town is bright, with abundant wildflowers and colorful gardens, far less cold and dreary than the river. I take in the stone cottages with thatched roofs as we walk the cobblestone street, noting a spiked iron door in the ground between two houses.

“A cellar?” I ask, tilting my head.

“Aye. We have a few of them around the village.”

“Are they warded?” I ask, and he scoffs.

“One of them is.” He nods to another tucked about ten dragon-lengths toward the fence surrounding the village. “That one there. We were short on rent this year. Had a poor harvest, and the Cutter took the other wards away. But they’re stocked with food and water. Enough for the entire town for a week, if everyone can make it to the one they’re assigned to. Should be enough to get us through the surge,” he says.

“Whose idea was that?” I ask, impressed. The first few days of the Epoch are by far the most deadly, when the monsters that descend upon the realm first appear, flooding the land and mad from starvation.

“You’re about to meet him,” Harold says, pushing open the sturdy wooden door to the tavern. It’s packed, men and women, old and young, gathered in the dim light. A few weary eyes find mine as I enter, but they see my company and move on. A trusting sort, it seems, that they have no fear of a stranger simply because he's with one of their own.

Harold leads me along the bar, the finished wood worn away, leaving splinters sticking out at odd angles, until we come to two empty stools. The barkeep wastes no time, filling a short tumbler with ale and plopping it down in front of Harold, foam splashing over the rim and down the sides of the warped metal.

“Here’s the mastermind,” Harold says, nodding toward the barkeep—a thin but muscular man around my age and height who would be better suited to serve the Fates than ale in a dark tavern.

“Another stray, I see,” the man says. There's no malice to his words, but it makes me wonder how often strange visitors pass through here.

Harold leans toward me, the wrinkles around his eyes becoming more pronounced as he gives me a mischievous smile. “I've become somewhat of a guardian myself," he says, and I stiffen. I’d purposefully left my sword and dagger in my tent, and I’m not wearing my uniform.

“I dinnae ken what—” he waves me off.

“You’re a Dìdeanair bound to the Fates if I've ever seen one. And it's no matter. We're not a pocket of ceatharnaich holding secret meetings out in the forest. We have nothing to hide here. I tend to spend a lot of time in my garden. I grow all the vegetables for the tavern there,” he says with pride. “And seeing how I’m outside all the time *and* the first house you come upon as you enter the village, I've taken it on as my own personal mission to get a sense of the visitors before they can make trouble. The ones I like, I bring here,” he says, inclining his head for the barkeep to pour another ale.

“And the ones you don't?” I ask, oddly charmed by the old man’s honesty.

“Well, that's why my great-grandson was hiding. He's quick and quiet. One signal from me, and he goes and gets his father, who promptly comes out with the crossbow.”

“You shoot the visitors you don't like?” I ask as the barkeep gives me a short tumbler of ale to try.

Harold shrugs, his bushy white eyebrows raising. “Well, I ask ‘em to leave first. If they don't, that's their choice.”

I laugh, taking a sip of my drink. It's tart, like it was made with berries alongside the wheat, and I nod in appreciation.

“My own special mash,” the barkeep says.

“It's excellent…”

“Theron,” he says, holding out a hand. “But call me Theo.”

I shake his hand, noting his firm handshake. “It’s excellent, Theo,” I say, and he pulls out a large tumbler matching Harold's and fills it to the brim. “You’re the one who built the cellars?” I ask.

“Och.” He waves me off. “Not alone. I came up with the idea, but the entire village worked on them,” he says, voice full of humility. Sensing his

discomfort, I move on.

“Do you serve food?” I ask.

“We do.” He runs a hand through his short red-brown hair, then leans against the counter. “Whatever the cook decides, though. No choosing here.”

“All right. I'll have one of whatever the cook decides, then,” I say with a tight smile of thanks. Theo walks away, and I realize I should ask his name so I can check his history. Based on his size and temperament, Theo could be an asset, if it comes back that he’s not being watched as a potential ceatharnaich or enemy of the Fates.

“So,” Harold says, leaning back in his chair. I go to do the same, then realize Harold’s is the only one with a back, and I can’t help but wonder if it's reserved for him.

“Tell me why you're really here. It's been ages since we've seen a guardian. Even longer since one came in disguise.”

“I was sent by the Fates,” I say plainly. I see no reason to lie, since my being here has nothing to do with them at all.

“Is it the Epoch? It's about that time,” the old man says sagely.

“You know much about the last one?” I ask him.

“I remember it well. Not the actual day, of course, but the aftermath.” He nods grimly. I was young, born only a hair over a decade after it ended. A long one, that Epoch.”

I nod, impressed with how much he knows. The Epoch usually lasts a year, maybe two, but the last one took nearly ten years to end.

He takes a sip, then continues. “Too much violence. Too much bloodshed.” He levels me with a look, and I put my drink down, giving him my full attention. “You'll find no ceatharnaich here. We're just men and women who want to live a simple life.” Harold holds my stare as he says it—a brave man.

“I can see that,” I say.

“Then be straight with me.” He meets my eyes, holding them as if searching for any hint of a lie. “Are we a target for the Fates? Do they think something's happening here that isn't?”

I shake my head, placing a hand on Harold’s shoulder in what I hope is comfort. “No. You're safe. Your family’s safe. My being here has nothing to do with the goings on of this village.”

The man's throat works as he swallows, relief flooding his features. “Good. But then why *are* you here?” he asks, apparently still suspicious.

I take a large swig of ale. “Women have been disappearing throughout Na Trì. Have you heard?”

He nods. “There have been rumors for weeks. But what does that have to do with us?”

“Nothing. Not directly. I’m here for the Washwoman.”

The man's eyes widen, and the tavern goes silent, a wave of quiet washing outward until even the darkest corners are void of sound. For a moment, I wonder if my dàn of dread has activated, but it remains sleeping on my neck.

“Why would the Fates send you to find *her*?” Harold whispers, and I clear my throat, uncomfortable with the number of ears listening in. “Why would you want anything to do with that horrible monster? Have you not seen the dragon that flies above her river? Even she doesnae get close to that cursed creature,” he says.

Grateful for his confirmation the dragon willnae land, I continue. “The missing women are vanishing into thin air, leaving no trace behind. I'm here to make sure the Washwoman isnae one of them.”

“It’d be a blessing from the Fates if that witch disappeared,” he says, spitting at his feet.

“Maybe. Except we dinnae ken where the missing women are. The Cutter didnae sever their strings. And the last time the Washwoman escaped…” I trail off, closing my eyes against the onslaught of memories.

“Aye.” He presses his lips into a grim line. “I’m not a betting man, but I’d bet everything I’ve earned that she’s behind those disappearances. That Washwoman is evil. I’d kill her myself if I could.”

“I’m going to try.”

Theo stiffens, only for a moment, his hand pausing its wiping of a glass. He swallows, turning, then resumes his cleaning, but it feels forced.

“If she doesn’t kill you first,” Harold says.

“You fear her then?” I ask the question to Harold, but watch Theo from the corner of my eye. I can’t discern if his reaction was for the missing women or the Washwoman, but based on his tense posture, it’s clear he knows *something*.

“Fear her? Fear isn't the word.”

Theo walks away, his shoulders rigid.

“We lock the gates at night to keep her out. Pray to the goddess to keep her bound to that shore. We don't drink the water from her river. Not even upstream. You wouldn't either, if you were smart. Nothing good can come from finding her.”

“Why do you lock your gate against her? She’s chained to the river.”

“So she says. You say you’re here to make sure she doesn’t escape, but she already has. I’ve seen her. A woman in the dark, dripping with water. Did you notice the fence encompasses the entire village?”

“I did. I thought it was to keep out the wild boar.”

“Och. The boar we can handle. It’s *her* we’re keeping out. She cannae cross a locked gate. A closed door. She has to be invited in.”

Theo returns, popping a plate of creamy broth with leeks and potatoes, along with some crusty bread, down on the rough wood in front of me. “Alright, back to your drinks. Give them some privacy, eh?” Theo says, waving a hand at the eavesdropping patrons. A tense, dull chatter returns, and while I nod in thanks, I can’t help but wonder if it's because he doesn’t want more people focused on the Washwoman.

“It's all nonsense,” Theo says. “I’ve lived here my whole life and never seen a thing. It's just visions created by fearful minds.”

“You don't believe in her?”

“I believe she's real. I believe she's there. But I think she's just a woman paying for her crimes. There's nothing more supernatural about her than the rest of us.”

Harold shakes his head, making an X over his sternum, a protective symbol. “And that's how she'll get you," he spits.

“Have you ever gone to find her?” I ask Harold.

“I'm not fool enough to try. No one here is. We've seen enough—the men and women who did find her, running away with tears in their eyes and grief in their hearts. That's the real secret. There are no wishes to be granted. No questions to be answered. Try, and she sets a curse on you. Go to interfere with her washing, she’ll kill the one you love most. My advice? Eat your fill, and go home. There's no wish worth the pain she’ll cause should you be unlucky enough to find her.”

I busy my mouth with another sip of ale, savoring the way it makes my throat burn as I consider his warning.

“You don’t believe me? It’s the truth. I saw her the night before my Isla was taken from me.” He says, eyes glazing over. He looks down at his

drink, twisting the cup in his hands.

“I’m sorry for your loss,” I say, pushing as much sincerity as I can into my voice. “Are you sure it was the Washwoman you saw? What did she look like?”

He rubs his temples, almost as if he wishes he could take the pain of the memory away. “She was a slight thing, frail. Not thin, really, but weak. Hunched over, with long black hair all the way to her waist. I saw her standing behind the garden gate. Only for a moment, and then I blinked,” he closes his eyes as if reliving the memory, “and she was gone. The next morning, so was my Isla.”

I tuck that piece of information away. Black hair—except Bea’s is red. So vibrant and wild, it’d be impossible for someone to mistake it for black. I consider telling him this, but stop myself. I’ll get more information if Harold feels the need to fill the silence.

Theo leans forward, and it seems as if the walls he was erecting have fallen as he pats Harold’s hand and refills his tumbler. “Now, you know Isla was sick for a verra long time, Harold. The healer had given her only days, and she lasted a full week before she passed. It was no more the Washwoman’s fault than it was yours or mine.”

I expect Harold to argue back, to resist, but he's too lost in his memories, continuing to spin the tumbler around and around, thinking of the woman at the river and the way she destroyed his life, just as she destroyed mine.

13

BRENNEN



The Washwoman’s bright red hair comes into view as I approach the river, Sable’s saddlebags full of not only supplies, but the components of a writing desk Theo kindly procured for me.

I keep my eye on her as I unpack it, thick pieces of wood that clatter as I lay them out. She doesn't acknowledge me, too focused on a small pile of twenty or so stones. She sits on a flat part of the riverbed and is stacking them into a cairn, humming some sort of sing-song.

With a remarkably steady hand, she adds a tenth stone, then an eleventh. The tower starts to wobble, and she presses her lips together, as if her breath might be the thing to knock it over. It topples to the ground anyway, one of the stones tumbling into the river.

She reaches forward, whispering something under her breath as she plucks it back out, lines up the stones, and begins again.

What is she doing? What are the cairns for? I’d noticed them when I’d explored the valley, but hadn’t given it much thought. They're everywhere, some just piles that have fallen over since they were built, others standing strong.

I grab the two pieces of wood that make up the main writing surface of my desk, fitting the pegs and holes back together like the carpenter showed me, and wait for the Washwoman to look at me. To acknowledge me in any way, because surely she senses my presence by now.

But she simply begins again, stacking the stones in a different order. I stare at her as I hammer one leg on, then another. Is it some kind of ritual? A sort of magic I don't understand?

Harold’s words circle in my mind. His description of the Washwoman—a slight woman with black hair. Cairns often hold magic—or, they can. Is it possible she's found a way to shape shift? To change her appearance? But that doesn't feel right. Even if she could, her chain is strong. My eyes flick back to it, and I lean forward, searching the links for weaknesses. The metal looks no different from when I checked it before, but maybe I should check it daily, along with the wards.

“If you're waiting for something interesting to happen,” she says, her voice breaking through the silence, “you’re going to be sorely disappointed.” She continues to stack, not bothering to look at me. Once again, the cairn falls.

The image of the cairn of stones marking the entrance to Vengach flits through my mind, Marsaili leaning against it the day we shared our first kiss, but it’s quickly replaced by the image of her lifeless body. I close my eyes against the stab of pain in my chest that accompanies the image, a vice that wraps its fingers around my heart and squeezes until I’m nearly breathless.

“What are you doing?” I ask, the words leaving my throat without my permission. I don't want to talk to her. Would rather spend my time gathering information and completing my vow, but in this moment, I need to find a way to make her stop. I dinnae want those pictures in my mind.

“I'm stacking stones,” she says, biting her lip as she balances one on top precariously. “I thought that would be obvious.”

I bite my tongue, not wanting to let her know exactly how much her insolence infuriates me. Looking back down at the desk, I click together the final pieces, all the while watching her out of the corner of my eye. Her stack falls again, and she narrows her eyes, rearranging the stones.

“Stop,” I snap, but she ignores me, continuing her building.

I storm into my tent, bringing the desk inside and setting it in the corner. Surely if I give her a few more moments, she’ll get it out of her system. I wait five minutes. Ten. But when I emerge again, she’s still there, stacking.

Anger surges in my blood as they fall, and she begins again.

And again.

And again.

And every single time they tumble to the ground, clunking and rattling.

“What in the Fates’ names are you doing that for?” I finally ask.

“Why do you care so much that I am stacking stones?” she retorts, not bothering to look up at me.

The fury that rises within me is so intense, I’m unable to give a name to it. I activate my dàn of dread, and she stills, hand hovering over the cairn.

“Stop,” I say, my voice a lethal whisper.

She finally meets my gaze. “No.” She punctuates the word by placing another stone on top with a shaking hand.

I grit my teeth. Braver men than her—men I have fought alongside in battle—have had stronger reactions to me using my dàn around them before. How is she barely affected?

“Stop using your dàn on me. It won’t work,” she says as if reading my mind.

I do not deactivate the dàn. Even if she pretends it doesnae bother her, it has to. The stack tumbles to the ground, and she begins again. “Why are you stacking those bloody rocks?” I hiss, my frustration growing and growing until it’s intolerable. Not only because she willnae listen to me. Willnae obey my orders. But because it willnae work. Will she spend the rest of the night endlessly stacking when for them to remain standing is impossible?

“What else would you suggest I do?” she asks, tilting her head and placing another rock on the structure. It falls, and she sighs, beginning again. “It's too cloudy to see any constellations.”

“You have too many rocks. And they're too close to the same size. Too rounded. They’ll just keep falling.”

“You don't know that,” she says, beginning again.

“Aye, I do. How can you not see it?”

She rolls her eyes. The stones fall. Then again. And again, my anger growing with every attempt. Why is she doing this, when it most certainly won’t work?

“Is this not the very definition of madness?" I ask, stalking toward her. Because I cannae take it anymore. The sound of stones falling making my blood boil. “Doing something over and over, expecting a different outcome?”

“Maybe I'm mad, then,” she says, and I pause. Could that really be it? That a century with nothing to do has driven her to insanity? Perhaps, but I

dinnae think so. She’s smarter than this. Clever, and I willnae underestimate her. It *has* to be something more.

“Why do you build the cairns?” I ask, needing to know. Not just because it could potentially be vital information, but also because I want to understand her, if only so I can fully destroy her. She doesnae answer. “Why do you not get new rocks? And why are there so many of them?”

“Why does it bother you so much?”

I press my lips together, and she sighs.

“Because I’m *bored*,” she says, finally turning to me. “You could let me look through your packs and see if there's something more suitable I could use to entertain myself?”

Pressure builds in my chest. She knows what's in my bags—weapons. Things she could use to harm me or someone else.

“I'll take that as a no,” she mutters in answer to my silence. The cairn falls, and she starts over, seemingly unbothered. Again, it tumbles, and the cycle continues, building and falling until I cannae take it anymore. I stand, desperate to get away, but as I walk to my tent, the clink of stones grows slower, and I find myself subconsciously counting. Fourteen. Fifteen. She pauses, and I stop, turning my head. Sixteen. The Washwoman rises to her knees. Seventeen. Eighteen. Nineteen.

I hold my breath as she picks up the last rock, turning to meet my gaze. Without even looking at the stack, she places the twentieth stone on top with ease, defiance sparking in her eyes when it holds.

“You were saying?” she asks. I clench my jaw, refusing to answer. I willnae give her any more satisfaction than she's already feeling by proving me wrong.

“No? All right, then,” she says, and then she drops to her knees, kicks over the cairn, and begins again.

14

BRENNEN



The sound of clattering stones haunts my dreams, an unending loop of torment until dawn finally breaks through the glen. I try to sleep despite the light streaming into my tent—I need rest to keep my mind alert, but it's no use. With a sigh, I rise, dressing and eating a quick breakfast of fruit and dried meat. I'll likely return to the tavern for a hot meal later, but for now, it's enough.

I barely spare the Washwoman a glance as I begin my loop around the valley, checking each ward to ensure I can feel the buzz of magic beneath it. I take a moment to study the last one, a carving stained a deep red. It hums beneath my touch, spreading through my fingers into my palm, making my vow ache.

"Curious," I say to myself, turning back toward camp, and then I hear it.

"An diabhal dubh ort! An diabhal dubh ort!" *The black devil on you!*

It's the voice of a child, and fear spikes inside me. Forgetting the last ward, I sprint back to the Washwoman. If she is harming a child… I cannae even finish the thought.

But as I stumble toward the river, the glimpse I get through the trees isnae what I thought. The Washwoman isn't attacking the child. She's cowering as he attacks *her*.

"An diabhal dubh ort!"

The words the boy hurls at the Washwoman sound wrong coming from such a young mouth. He looks so innocent, all blonde curls and apple

cheeks, but his insults would make grown men blush. And yet he has no difficulty speaking them, again and again, hatred bursting from every syllable.

I can *almost* excuse the child's behavior, knowing he was likely spurred on by an insult or a dare from an older boy, along with a century of rumors about the Washwoman and her crimes.

That is, until they fully come into view. White-hot rage shoots through my veins at the sight, unwanted as it is, and my body moves before my mind can catch up.

The Washwoman's on the bank, curled into the smallest ball possible. Blood trickles from a gash on her arm, and bruises bloom along her skin from where the boy has hit her with rocks. Thrown not just in her direction.

At her.

Fist-size stones that hit her flesh with sickening thuds over and over. And yet the Washwoman doesnae fight back.

Her head is covered with her stained hands, and even without seeing her face, I can tell she's crying from the way her shoulders shake. How could she not be? The pain would be unbearable. Before I have time to process any of it, I jump off Sable, a growl leaving my throat.

"Stop," I hiss, and even I'm surprised at the fury in my tone. My dàn of dread flares on my neck, and the boy's eyes go wide, the rocks falling from his hands.

I stalk toward the child, his curly hair falling into his brown eyes. His palms are dirty, and a dàn of strength is inked on his collarbone. Rage surges in my chest. Stones thrown by a regular hand would be painful, but with the magic of strength behind it? It'd be *excruciating*. I glance at his wrist to his dedication dàn where The Measurer's sigil stares back at me.

"You dare use the power Measaire gifted to you for harm?" I spit, grabbing him by the front of his shirt and lifting him to meet my eyes. "What in the Fates' names would make you do this?" The boy pushes back, trying to escape my grasp, but my own dàn of steadiness keeps my feet planted firmly in place and my grip tight.

"Do you not realize what you've done?" I ask. "The consequences of your foolish actions?"

"She's a monster!" he spits. "She deserves it. I came here to help you!" The words turn my vision red.

“I didnae ask for your help. What about whoever will die because you saw her face? Do *they* deserve it?” I ask, even though I’m not sure if this part of the curse is even true. My intuition says it isn’t. Surely Cailleach wouldn’t send me here if it would end someone else’s life each time I looked upon her. Even if she would, I think she would at least warn me of it, but the villagers clearly believe it, so I bite out the words anyway, making sure every single one lands.

The boy’s face goes white.

“Tell me. What happens when you look upon the Washwoman?” Making him say it is a punishment he deserves.

“Someone you love dies,” he croaks, tears welling in his eyes.

“Did you not think of that? Did you not even consider what could happen?” I drop him down with such force, his shoe tumbles off and rolls into the water. I glance at the Washwoman from the corner of my eye. She hasnae moved, but has lifted her head and is watching me intently. Her eyes are red and her breaths heavy, mud and dirt smearing her arms and face. Blood trickles from her lip, and another flash of fury works its way through my bones.

Vampires make terrible promises and even worse exes.

That is exactly why they make good stories. Pick one at **Lokepub**.

It's not anger *for* her. It’s fury at seeing the thing I hate most—pain inflicted for nothing other than pleasure or fear or anger, as if this child is owed a pound of flesh and blood for her crimes.

If anyone had an excuse to harm her, it would be me. And I *will* kill her, it's true. But I will do it swiftly. And I certainly won’t torture her in the meantime just for the sake of it.

“I'm sorry,” the boy whispers, and my head snaps back to him. He looks to the Washwoman. “Really, I’m sorry. Please don't kill anyone. I didnae think. I just—”

The boy’s crying in earnest now, fat, ugly tears streaming from his eyes and snot running from his nose.

The Washwoman’s expression softens. “No one will die because you saw me," she says quietly, almost gently, and any sympathy I might have

felt for the Washwoman a moment ago disappears completely.

Because she doesn't mean it. She *cannae* mean it. She’s lulling this child into a false sense of safety. I’m certain of it.

No one would be this forgiving of someone who had just assaulted them so violently, and I do not believe her for a single moment.

The boy tries to stand, but he slips on a rock, tumbling backwards into the water. The current is swift, and it carries him away before he can find his footing.

I race after him, searching for a deeper area to dive into, but before I have a chance, the Washwoman scrambles forward, plunging into the water herself. The boy screams, sputtering, but Bea’s not fast enough, and when her chain catches, she lets out a scream of agony.

“Help!” the boy cries, and the Washwoman kicks against her restraints, seemingly desperate to save the boy who had just shown her such cruelty. I run in after him, activating my dàn of speed. It comes to life on my arm with just a thought. The burn of it energizes me, and I reach the boy in only a few strokes, a heartbeat from the black mist and drop-off into the *After*.

The boy sobs in earnest now, and he feels so small in my arms I almost feel guilt for the intensity of my anger toward him. None of this was right. Children shouldn’t be capable of such cruelty. Shouldn’t even know it exists.

And they certainly shouldn’t be anywhere near the Washwoman.

The boy’s teeth chatter as I pull him back to shore, his tired arms clinging to my neck, sobs bursting from his throat.

“I'm sorry! I'm so sorry.”

“Dinnae fash. You’ll be alright,” I say, making it onto dry land. The boy shivers, and I look up at the sky, the sun about to disappear. The Washwoman pulls herself out of the water, wrapping her arms around her waist, her lips nearly blue.

“You need to get him home. He'll freeze,” she says, her own teeth chattering.

“I'm sorry,” the boy cries again, this time looking the Washwoman straight in the eye. “Don't hurt anyone. Please.”

She gives him a gentle smile. “I'm not as wicked as people think. It’s only a tale. You can gaze upon my face, and nothing bad will happen. I swear it to you.” I hear the honesty in her words, a steadfast resolve.

But more importantly, I realize my dàn of truth has not alerted me to a lie in this entire conversation.

Either the Washwoman is telling the truth, or she is more cunning than I could have possibly imagined.

“Go,” she says.

I nod to her, unsure what I would say even if I could speak. I pull the boy closer to me.

“Let’s get you home…” I trail off. “What was your name, lad?”

“Billy,” he says, his teeth chattering.

“Well, let's go then, Billy.”

He nods against my neck. “You know what's strange?” he says, calming as I carry him back toward home. “I think I believe her. That she won't hurt anyone.”

I stiffen, tightening my grip on the boy, but I remain silent. I dinnae want to frighten the child, so I let him believe the Washwoman isn't a monster. Children believe all sorts of foolish things.

I willnae make the same mistake.

15

BEA



Each ragged breath is agony. My right ribs seize with every inhale, and I wonder if they're broken or simply bruised. At least the added weight of Brennen's hatred dims a bit as he disappears through the pines, boy in tow.

For the first time since he arrived, his loathing doesn't feel aimed wholly in my direction. He'd been so angry with the child. Too angry, really. He was just a lad, and he'd only behaved that way because he learned it from someone else. Children are not born with that kind of cruelty within them.

But Brennen hadn't seemed to even consider why the child would have behaved the way he did. He'd simply reacted, acting as if it were an affront to *him* that the boy had attacked me. Is it because he's here to guard me? If he saw the boy getting to me as a failure, it would certainly explain his anger. Would align with how he reacts when I speak about him hurting me.

There's no honor in attacking a woman in shackles, he'd said. *If I hurt you, it will be because you left me with no other choice.*

Is it possible the Dìdeanair is *actually* an honorable man? One who doesn't crave power? I didn't think such men existed.

I shake my head, the pain in my ribs and back growing unbearable. I won't figure out Brennen's motivations right now. Not when I can hardly breathe.

As slowly and carefully as I can, I inch my way to my bed to lie down, biting my lip as I move to hold back the scream fighting to escape my throat. I’m still soaking wet, but it’s the least of my worries. I will dry eventually, but this pain will take far longer to fade.

Lolly roars as I roll onto my left side, the pain lessening as I finally still, and I flick my eyes up to see fire dancing across the sky. She's angry today.

It seems everyone is.

She disappears over the horizon, and I look back to the river, reaching out to place my fingers in the water.

“Please,” I say, “No deaths right now.”

The water ripples, caressing my skin, and I hope that’s her way of accepting my plea.

I close my eyes, taking stock of my injuries for the second time in the last few days. While my ribs seem to bear the brunt of the damage, my lip is swollen, and there's a goose egg on the back of my skull. My arm throbs, as does a spot on my lower back. The boy had thrown the stones surprisingly hard for a child. For an adult, even. A dàn of strength, Brennen had said. But even worse were the things he said to me.

Insults that remind me the entire kingdom despises me. Not just the ones who show up at the river, desperate and grieving.

Everyone.

It hurts almost more than my battered body, knowing there is nothing I will ever be able to do to change what they think of me. My legend will only grow, and who I really am, every last piece of me, will cease to exist altogether. How long until I forget myself, too? Until I’m lost to my own mind and that very legend defining me?

The wind picks up, the river recoiling from my hand as if ashamed of her lie, and tears burn my eyes. I'm unable to keep my scream contained as I’m dragged to my knees by invisible hands.

My body sags, but the magic of the curse holds me upright, and for once, I’m grateful for the force that bends to its will. At least I don't have to use what little strength I have left to pull myself to kneel.

The river is freezing as I lower my hands into the water, and I shiver.

The scent of bog myrtle permeates the air, and the river turns brown with mud. The world tilts, and suddenly, my pain is gone. I take a full, deep breath, my vision steadying and dizziness fading.

I’m in a candlelit pub, the patrons around me several drinks deep and belting a lively tune, glasses raised. The melody scratches at my brain, but I can’t quite place where I’ve heard it before.

Come take off yer coat. Set yer boots by the door.
There's room at our table and a song or two more.
The night's in no hurry. The door’s still ajar.
And nobody's counting how long here yeh are.

There's wine in our mugs, and there's ale in our glass.
And no need to dwell on the sins of your past.
Our lives might be measured, but don't hold yer tongue.
For nobody's counting the verses we've sung.

A woman stands behind the bar, her pale cheeks flushed and eyes bright as she sings. A man leans over, beaming as she hands him the drink. He pays with a kiss, and my heart aches at the simplicity of it. The ease of their love. What would I give for even a crumb of something like that?

The melody shifts to the chorus, and they both join in, their eyes shining as they lift their glasses.

A song cannae tell you the time it will end.
As long as you sing, a new one can begin.
We hoped you were coming. We've waited all night.
Held off on the last verse until you arrived.

I pry my eyes away from the couple, eyes darting around the room. There has to be a reason I’m here. A reason I’m having these visions, but what is it? It’s hard to see through the dim lighting, but nothing stands out as unusual. I’m jostled forward, and I catch myself on the back of a chair.

“Sorry, miss,” a man says, and I freeze. Is this a clue? Is he the one who will die?

“Sir,” I say, my voice coming out hoarse.

“Yes, lass?” he says, and even though I suspected he'd be able to see me based on my last vision, I'm still surprised. My heart cracks at the kindness

in his tone. If we'd met at the river, surely that kindness would be gone.

“Be careful tonight,” I say.

He lowers his brows, stepping forward as if to ask me more, but the scene fades, and once again the world tilts. My head swims, and then, I’m back at the river.

The pain returns, blinding, and I try to lie down, but my curse does not allow it. Agony sears through each of my injuries, so intense, it makes me nauseous. I dry heave, my stomach already empty, but the magic doesn’t give me even a moment to recover. It presses against my skin, heavy and persistent, guiding my hands to grab the garments floating downstream, and I stop resisting.

I’m not able to see the clothes through the thick tears in my eyes, not only from the pain of my injuries, but confusion and shame. These visions feel wrong. I can sense it in my bones, so why am I being brought into them, and why can’t I seem to stop whatever is happening?

Is it as I thought? That the Cutter is torturing me, showing me someone’s life and joy before forcing me to wash their clothes? Is it to show me what I am missing here, trapped and away from the rest of the world?

Or is it something else entirely? Am I supposed to do something to stop these deaths that feel so wrong? Is this a test? Could this be my penance for Am Breitheamh to judge me well and allow my afterlife to be peaceful? Maybe if I can stop these visions—save these people who aren’t meant to die—I’ll be forgiven.

I hold onto that hope as I check the pockets and finish washing the clothes, closing my eyes so I’m not forced to witness the proof that I failed to save the man.

When I let go, the magic lifts, and I collapse back onto the bank, my cry of pain echoing through the glen as I fall, but I can barely hear it past the melody of the song still ringing in my mind.

16

BEA



The stone is cool against my cheek as I watch the river calm. The scent of peat and bog myrtle eases, and the mud settles back to the riverbed.

Something dark twists in the shallow water, and I reach out to grab it. Even my pain can't stop me from trying to find the pieces to the spell.

It's cold and slick—a broken shoe, the sole pulled away from the fabric that makes up the body. The leather is worn, a hand-me-down, I think, based on the several rows of replaced stitching.

The image of Billy's shoe tumbling off his foot as he fell flashes in my mind, and a pang of sadness for the boy settles beneath my sternum.

It's what I thought when I first saw the child emerge into the valley with hate in his eyes. That he was nothing but a lost boy, looking for something to distract him from his hungry belly—a feeling I know well. It's been weeks since I've been able to catch a fish, existing on nothing but berries and water.

His clothes were worn, threadbare, and his cheeks gaunt. It sours my stomach, knowing the way the Fates bask in luxury in their gilded palaces when there are children who go without food in the very same kingdom they claim to love.

I wince as I scoot back to my bed, biting my lip against the pain. It takes several minutes to slow my breathing and heart rate, but eventually the pain

dulls enough to allow me to raise my arm to remove the small strip of leather binding back my unruly hair.

Picking up the moon-shaped rock I use as a pillow, I sift my fingers through the soft peat to search for my needle. It’d been a gift from the goddesses, I’d thought, when I found it between the rocks on the river's edge. Likely from a time long before it became my prison, when women would do their mending and washing on this shore. I was once one of those women, trading stories and laughing with friends as we went about our daily chores, ignoring the clothes floating down the stream as if turning an eye would keep death from coming for us. The memory is like a splinter in my finger, a dull and persistent sting. If only things had remained that way.

I thread the thin strip through the needle and begin to work on the boy's shoe. The leather is brittle when the needle punctures it, but somehow, it holds, and I wonder if Brennen would be willing to spare some oil from his lantern to soften it.

Brennen.

Thinking his name sends a shiver down my spine, but I’m not sure if it’s from apprehension or wonder. I can’t stop thinking about the way he’d stopped the attack without even a moment’s hesitation. I know it couldn’t possibly have been for *my* sake, but it makes me once again wonder what he experienced in his life to react so viscerally to witnessing violence. And yet, he joined the Dìdeanair—chose to serve the Cutter—the most violent Fate of them all.

“What’re you doing?” A gruff voice skates along the back of my neck—Brennen’s—and I stiffen. My heart rate picks up as, with deliberate, commanding steps, he stalks around me, eyeing the needle in my hands.

“Where did you get that?” he snaps, his mouth pressed into a tight line.

Even with pain radiating through my entire body, a smirk tugs at my lips at the distrust in his eyes.

Good. Let him wonder where I found it. The needle hadn’t been on me when he’d searched my body yesterday, his invasive hands touching places he had no right to feel. Though, will this lead him to search harder? Will he somehow think to look beneath my pillow?

The thought is too horrifying to even entertain, but I don’t want him to see my fear.

“Why?” I ask, slipping a hint of amusement into my words. “Are you afraid I'll fell you with a mending needle?”

He doesn't answer, hand on his sword as he stops directly behind me. “You're fixing a child’s shoe,” he says it as a statement, his voice clouded with disbelief.

“Excellent observation. No wonder you made An Àrd,” I say, giving him nothing more. He doesn’t seem to notice my taunting.

“Is it the boy’s?”

I lift it up slightly to show him. “Aye.”

There are several heavy beats of silence, but I sense when he drops his hand from his waist.

His brows pull together in obvious confusion. “Why?” he asks. The word doesn't sound angry or taunting, but like genuine confusion, and I take a few seconds to think of my answer, wondering how much I want to say. I’m rather enjoying him being so afraid of me. It brings a humor to his presence here that makes it almost tolerable. Will telling him my true intentions make him think he has nothing to fear from me? That I’m not quite as dangerous as he believes me to be?

Or maybe it will humanize me a bit. Maybe if he’s not afraid of me, he’ll be willing to have actual conversations with me. That would be even more enjoyable than watching him fear me.

Hope flickers in my chest at the thought. Maybe I can convince him to tell me stories. Things I’ve missed in the kingdom over the last century. It would certainly be a preferable way to pass the time than drawing a half-finished dàn over and over in the mud or skipping rocks for the thousandth time.

Honesty it is, then.

“I don't think his family has much,” I say, my eyes never leaving the shoe as I weave the needle in and out.

I feel his eyes shift from the shoe to my back, and it takes everything in me to not flinch from the way his gaze burns my skin.

“Dinnae pretend to care for the child.”

His words are a punch straight to the gut, another blow to add to my already battered body.

“I’m not pretending,” I say, keeping my voice light, fighting to appear to be unaffected by his verbal jab.

He lets out an exasperated breath. “Do you know the lad? Has he been here before?” I can't trace what's in his tone this time. Maybe anger? Confusion?

“No. It’s been a very long time since a child has visited here.”

“Then how could you possibly know his family’s means?”

I was right. It is anger lacing every word, though it's heavier than before, mixed with a sharp frustration.

I turn to meet his steely gaze. “His clothes were worn bare. Did you not notice how thin they were? And there was hunger in his eyes. And this shoe,” I lift it again, showing him the back where a tartan patch has been placed over a hole, “It’s a size too small, and has obviously been worn by many pairs of little feet.”

His jaw ticks, and he tilts his head back, looking at me as if I’ve grown an extra set of arms. “But… Why are you mending it?”

I stop my movements, sorrow twisting between my ribs. Not for the boy this time, but because it’s clear this man doesn’t just fear me. The possibility that I might want to help a child is an impossibility to him.

I straighten my spine. “I’m not so much of a monster that I don't care if a child goes hungry. If his feet will be cold without footwear. If they don’t have the money for warmer clothes or food, how will his family buy him new shoes?” I ask, stabbing the needle through one last time, then tying off the leather. Several finger lengths of the string are left hanging, and I look at them longingly. Who knows the next time I will find something that will suffice to bind back my tresses.

He shakes his head, grabbing the shoe from my hand, forcing me to look at him.

“No. I mean, after what he did to you. Why would you help him?”

I hold his gaze, hoping he’ll see my sincerity, because suddenly, the idea of even a single person in this kingdom believing I am something, *anything*, more than the murderer of the Bàsail is intoxicating.

“He’s a child,” I say. “I know what I am—or at least, what people think I am. But the boy was only behaving as he was taught. It’s not his fault, nor is it his fault that his family goes without.” I reach back out and snatch the shoe, then pick up a rock. Maybe I can saw the rest of the leather off. There’s just enough left to still use, I think, but the rock isn’t sharp enough to break through the tough material.

Brennen steps forward and crouches down. He pulls the dagger from his waist, and despite myself, I flinch.

He freezes, giving me a moment to see his intentions, then, so slowly it’s as if I’m an animal he’s trying not to spook, he takes the shoe back and

cuts off the extra leather. He hands it back to me, and the simple gesture brings a sting to the backs of my eyes.

Is it possible it worked? That being honest about my intentions caused him to, if not have pity for my situation, at least understand I’m nothing to fear?

“Thank you,” I say, using the palm of my hand to wipe the tears away before he can see them. I clear my throat. “Would you take it to him? The shoe?”

He hesitates for a long moment, rubbing his forehead, then nods.

“Thank you,” I say again.

He starts to turn but stops, holding out a hand. “The needle,” he says.

I squeeze my fist around the bone, my heart sinking, not only because I need the needle, but because it’s clear my honesty didn’t change a thing.

“I can't escape with only a sewing needle," I say, gripping it tighter. “And unless you plan on buying me new clothes, I have to mend the ones I have.”

He doesn't speak, unyielding as he continues to hold his hand out.

I study the scar running through his palm, puckered and angry. Black lines trail from the wound like poison seeping through his blood.

For a moment, I almost ask him about it, but his hard stare causes the words to freeze on my tongue.

“Washwoman,” he says. An order, and I grit my teeth. His eyes are hard, his jaw growing tighter by the second.

“It’s Bea,” I say, dropping the needle into his hand. He ignores me, swiftly pocketing it. Disappointment curdles in my stomach. How will I mend my dress now?

He stalks toward the forest, his movements strong and intentional. The fabric around his arms bunches as he puts two fingers in his mouth and whistles, and only a few seconds later, his beautiful black horse appears.

Brennen mounts her, turning her away from me. I barely hear him when he speaks again.

“If you need to mend something, you may ask for the needle,” he says, kicking the horse's sides, and even though I keep my expression neutral, I smile inwardly.

It’s such a small concession, but it feels like a victory all the same.

17

BRENNEN



I approach the boy's house with new eyes.

Mismatched drapes cover the windows, holes spotted throughout. The front garden is overgrown, and the trim is weathered and rotting. It could use a new roof, the patches haphazardly slapped on, peeling away in strips.

I pause at the front entrance and am raising my hand to knock when I hear it. A crash. Bottles shattering and a cry of pain.

“Bloody stupid boy, going to see the Washwoman! And you, for allowing it!” There’s another crash and a scream—this time, a woman's.

I kick in the door in one swift motion. A large, pale man, his face near purple with anger, stands over a crying woman lying on the ground, holding her cheek. A bruise already darkens the skin around her eye, and in her lap is Billy, trying to shield her with his body.

The man turns to me. “Who the fuck are you?” He starts towards me, but I get to him first, slamming his back against the wall, my forearm pressed against his throat.

“Who the bloody fuck are *you*, hurting a woman and child?” I push harder against his airway, and his face turns red. My dàn for strength flares along my ribs, and it takes all my restraint not to keep pushing until I crush his windpipe.

“They're my family,” he spits out. “Is my job—”

“It’s your job to love and provide for them.” Disgust laces my every word. It’s no wonder the boy learned such cruel behavior.

A baby wails from a bassinet I didnae notice, and I see red. I awaken my dàn of dread, and the man pales, sweat breaking out on his bald head.

“Gather your things,” I say to the woman, shifting to block her husband from view. “Anything you might need.”

“If you think for a second—” the man starts, but I push harder. He grabs my arm, panicking as I cut off his oxygen completely, but he’s nothing more than a gnat. An inconvenient pest.

I ignore him, glancing over my shoulder at the woman.

“Do you want to be free of this life?” I ask. She hesitates for only a second. Her throat bobs,` but she squeezes her trembling hands together, meets her husbands furious gaze, and nods. “Yes.”

A wave of admiration washes through me. It takes a brave woman to look her attacker in the eye and say she’s done.

The relief that swells in my chest dulls the anger enough to allow me to make a plan. “Fetch me your handfasting tie.”

Her husband arches against me. “You have no authority—”

“I am a servant of Cailleach, An Àrd. I have the authority to end your marriage *and* your life. One of the two will be ending today. I will allow you to choose which.” He opens his mouth to argue, and I activate my dàn of dread once more. His face pales, and he swallows.

“Bastard,” he says under his breath, his voice shaking, but I ignore him, taking the still-tied handfasting ribbon from the woman. There is no ceremony as I hand my dagger to her.

“Cut through it.”

On trembling legs, she follows my instructions, and I take the severed rope from her.

“As it was written in the threads, so has it ended,” I say, sealing it with my dàn of truth. It’s not often I get to use this part of the dan’s ability, the sealing of vows, but I’m especially grateful for it as the rope turns black in my hands. I hand it back to the woman. “In case anyone questions if your union is truly over.”

Billy darts around me, grabbing a rucksack and throwing a book and a toy horse inside, and I wonder if he chooses only those items because he’s wearing the only clothes he owns. “Come on, Ma!” he says, pulling at her arm. The man suddenly leans to the side, kicking out with his feet and

kneeing me in the groin. The pain is instant, breathtaking, but I don’t let it stop me.

I take a quick step back, and the moment he moves to strike me, I slam his arm against the wall. His hand opens, and I spear the razor-sharp tip of my dagger through his palm, bones crunching as the blade embeds into the wood, nearly to the hilt.

If it is only fear and pain that will stop him from coming after them, so be it.

The man howls as I back away. Blood trickles down his arm and onto the floor, a drip, drip, drip that makes me sick to my stomach almost as much as this man himself.

“Dinnae try that again,” I say, turning my back on him.

“You stabbed me,” he says. “You fucking stabbed me!”

I ignore him. “Are you ready?” I ask the woman. She nods, tucking the bundled-up baby tightly against her chest.

“I'll find you!” he shouts. “I'll *always* find you!”

I usher them outside and turn around, leveling the man with an icy glare.

“If you even think about going after them, this blade—” I stalk to him and yank it from his hand, “severs your spine. Understood?”

The man doesn't answer, cowering instead, holding his bloody hand to his chest.

I push away from him, sheathing my dagger. I don't bother to look back, certain the coward won't follow.

Closing the door behind me, I take the few belongings they packed.

“What is your name?” I ask.

“Anna,” she says softly, and I have to force my face to remain impassive. She has the same name as my mother, and yet she’s living a life so verra different from the one Ma lived. One where she was cherished and loved. A memory of her working in the garden flits through my mind, her laugh as clear as the tinkling of a bell.

“You're safe now,” I promise, placing a hand on her shoulder, but the fear remains etched in every line of the woman’s face.

“We have nothing. Nowhere to go. No other family,” she says, pulling the bairn closer to her chest. I study her for a moment, this woman who has endured so much. Deep bruises mark the deep tan skin of her arms, her

chest. And yet, there isn't a single mark on her children. Somehow, she protected them.

"I know where to take you," I say, leading them toward the tavern in a stiff silence.

I'm grateful when I push through the door to see it's nearly empty, the only other patron an older gentleman who appears lost in thought, sitting in the back near the fire. Theo smirks as I walk in, closing what looks to be a sketchbook.

"Back so soon? Tell me. Did the Washwoman kill all those who looked…" his words trail off as Anna and Billy enter behind me. "What's happened?" he asks, stalking forward to peek out the door into the courtyard beyond.

"That bastard of a man who called himself her husband is what happened. Did you know?" I ask.

Theo ignores me. "Edgar hurts you?" he asks, incredulous. Anna looks away, and I hate the shame I see in her hunched shoulders. She's making herself small. Something I'm sure she's learned to do to survive.

"What do you need?" Theo asks.

"A room for them, for as long as they need, and for you to keep that sorry excuse of a man far, far away from here." I remove the pouch from my pocket, the coins inside jangling in the silent tavern. "I'll arrange something more permanent when I can," I say.

"How can I repay you—" Anna starts, but I stop her.

"It's nothing." I turn and sit at a stool, ending the conversation as Theo gathers their things, grabs a key, and heads to show them to their room. I'm lost in thought when he appears again, placing a generous serving of ale in front of me.

"Keep your money." Theo tosses my bag in front of me. "She's not the first woman I've helped in a situation like this, and she won't be the last." He pulls the collar of his shirt to the side, showing a dàn of empathy on his chest. "They're drawn to me. It will get worse as the Epoch approaches. Already, men are staying longer. Drinking more."

He nods toward the gentleman in the back, and it's then that I notice his glassy stare. "Fighting even more than that." He sighs. "Too many men are able to hide their true selves. Until life gets hard, at least. It's disgusting, if you ask me."

It's more than disgusting. It's evil, but I don't correct him, partly because of the respect budding from his confession of helping women such as Anna before, and partly because my dàn of truth has remained silent. Theo hasn’t lied to me once since I arrived. Anna and her children will be safe here.

I lean back to assess him, once again getting the feeling he would be far better suited as a solider than a barkeep. He looks physically fit, and is obviously smart, coming up with the spiked cellars to protect the village from the Epoch.

Though he doesnae have the hardened look of a warrior. There’s a kindness in his brown eyes I find I’m not used to. A gentleness, likely from his dàn of empathy.

He tilts his head. “Why did you return to their house, anyway? Did you see something when you dropped the boy off? Harold said he was delivered safely some time ago.”

“No. The father wasn’t home when I returned the boy.” I take a long drink of ale. “He lost his shoe,” I say, rubbing a hand down my face. “The Washwoman mended it.” Even just saying the words sounds strange. The murderess of the River of Death, mending clothing for a child.

Theo doesn’t say anything, wiping the counters with a wet rag.

“I mean, the lad was beating her bloody, throwing stones like she was nothing but a mound of peat,” I continue. “And she didn't fight back. Not a bit. Then the boy fell in the river, and she tried to save him, and—” I shake my head.

“So the Washwoman isn't quite living up to the horrors of her legend. Is that what you're saying?” Theo raises his eyebrows.

“She’s certainly different than I expected, but it doesnae change what she did. The people she killed.”

“Aye. It doesn't,” Theo says softly, almost as if he feels sorrow for the monster. “Though a century of being bound to that freezing river could change anyone, I think.”

“She deserves every minute of that century and more,” I say, and I mean it. “But the rest. I don't… I don't like that the boy knew such violence. That he seemed to view her as less than human.”

“Well, she's not human at all, is she?” Theo walks around the bar, pouring his own drink and sitting next to me. “She’s immortal. Cursed. The ghost of the river Bàsail**.** They fear her, and so they hate her.”

“I hate her. I *loathe* her. But I would give her a swift death. I believe even the monsters among us deserve that.”

Theo studies my face for a moment, assessing my sincerity, I think. But he’ll find no reason to doubt me. I mean every word. Cruelty disgusts me, and I have no use for it. Let the wicked fall with a single, efficient arc of the sword, and let it be done.

“It seems as if you dinnae like suffering,” he observes, and I nearly laugh.

“Who does?”

“Those who’ve had suffering inflicted upon them. Sadists. There's no lack of suffering in the world, and someone always causes it.”

“I've experienced enough. I don’t relish in anyone else being able to say the same.”

He takes a second, pretending to clean an already spotless glass. “You’d truly kill her then, if you could?” he finally asks.

The answer is automatic. “Of course I would.”

He nods, not judging, but not agreeing either.

“Wouldn’t you?” I ask. Once again, I can’t shake the feeling Theo knows more about the Washwoman than he’s letting on.

He shakes his head, an odd look crossing his face. “No. I dinnae think I would. But I can't blame you for wanting to. For you, it’s personal. She's never hurt anyone I've cared about.”

I stiffen. “How could you know—”

Theo holds up a hand. “You seem like a good man, Brennen. I think you want to do what’s right. Wouldn’t relish in taking a life. There's only one thing that turns good men into killers.”

“What’s that?” I ask, finishing my drink in two large gulps.

He tilts his head, finally putting the glass down. “Love.”

I spin my glass around.

“I’m right, aren’t I?” he asks.

My heart squeezes as I picture Marsaili’s teasing smile. Hear her melodic laugh. There’s a flash of anger, and I swallow tightly. The unexpected reminder of the woman I loved is like being thrown into a fire, and I stand, not answering him. This wound is mine, and mine alone. I do not wish to share it.

And I refuse to reopen it. Not when I fear it would bleed me dry.

“Thank you for helping them,” I say, tossing several more coins on the table than needed to cover the ale. “I’ll let you know when I find them other lodging.”

“I'm sorry. I didnae mean to pry,” Theo says, and I hold up a hand to stop him.

“Let me know if the husband shows up,” I say, my palm burning as I stalk back to Sable to return to the woman who stole everything from me.

18

BEA



Sunlight filters across thick planks of wood, the floors swollen with time and slightly warped. I’m in an empty room, one that feels ancient in a way I can’t put my finger on. Dust motes dance in the slanted light from the window, and there are symbols carved in long lines around the hearth. There's a heaviness in the air, mixed with a faint dampness that clings to the walls.

A cloud passes over the sun, the scene darkening, and my vision shifts. The room is no longer empty, but I can’t make out what else is here. It’s fragmented. Vague colors and shapes with pieces of the image missing.

Then I hear it. Rhythmic tapping. The toe of a shoe against the floor.

And above that, a hum.

A shape moves, and I see a curtain of blonde hair, the color of gold, long and straight. It falls forward, blocking the woman’s face.

I try to speak, but my voice doesn’t comply, sticking in my throat.

The hum slows, and the tapping suddenly stops.

The woman shifts, and the vision cracks, splintering like broken glass, the pieces refusing to align. I try to gather them, to piece them back together, because this is important. I *feel* it. But they continue to crack and spread.

There's a sharp thud and then—blood.

The room goes completely silent as the crimson puddle spreads, pooling across the warped floorboards. Too much of it, and I’m certain whoever it's

coming from is no longer alive.

The woman.

I try to get to her, but my body doesn't move. I'm trapped inside myself, unable to do anything but witness the bloody horror in front of me. A scream rips from my throat, but it is silent.

Until it isn't.

Because I am no longer screaming in my dream. I am back at the river, and the scream is real.

I scramble to my feet, to run, the vision of blood—so much blood—fresh in my mind. My ribs seize, and my ankle throbs as I twist, collapsing back down, my tired mind slowly turning back to reality.

The river rocks are cold beneath my cheek, and the smell of peat fills my nostrils. The sound of the rushing water and heather rustling in the wind grounds me. "A nightmare. It was only a nightmare," I whisper, still breathless from fear.

But was it?

I turn toward the river, waiting for the clothes of the woman I saw slaughtered, but they do not come. Relief floods my entire body.

It hasn't happened yet.

The thought comes unbidden, and yet it feels right. Goosebumps rise on my arms. Surely it won't happen at all. It was only a nightmare, brought on by the guardian's presence. Wasn't it?

"Dreaming of the ones you slaughtered?" I stiffen at the tone of his voice—Brennen's voice—deep and raspy.

The hair on my arms stands on end. He must have returned from the village sometime in the night, but my body and mind had been too tired to realize it. I roll over, a groan leaving my throat as the pain in my ribs flares.

Brennen sits a few yards away, his fire going strong—flames of yellow and orange, a foot high and just out of reach—taunting me, and I shiver. What I would give to experience that heat, if only for a moment.

He sits with his back against his sack of food, knees bent, arms draped across them, hands folded, staring at me with an intensity that makes me want to scurry backward.

I almost do, but even the slightest movement brings tears to my eyes. My body is still so sore from being beaten, almost worse now that I have lain still for so long. We stare at each other in silence for a few moments until I can't stand it anymore.

"Did you give the boy his shoe?" I ask, my voice hesitant.

His jaw tightens, but he nods.

There's more, I can sense it. His eyes are tired, dark circles evident in the firelight, and his shoulders are tight. He's holding his small knife and a block of wood in his hands, and every so often, he makes an angry scrape across it, a sliver of wood falling to his feet.

The silence sits heavy on my shoulders for a few moments, and I shrink under the discomfort of it.

"What are you carv—"

"Why do the villagers think someone will die if they see your face?" he cuts me off.

I lay my head back down, studying him. He's angry, but it doesn't feel pointed directly at me. The rage that follows him everywhere isn't as suffocating, though I still see it in the lines of his face and stiffness of his shoulders. Still feel it radiating off him in waves that needle beneath my skin.

I sigh. So much for pleasant conversation. "People fear what they don't know. Somewhere along the last century, the tale of my curse has changed. I know the cause of every death in this kingdom. Almost," I add the last word under my breath. "And never once has it been from looking at me."

He chews on my answer for a minute, his eyes bouncing between my bruised face and the river.

"I deserve to be here," I say softly, "but that doesn't mean I'm a danger to anyone. I don't *want* to hurt people. I never did. If you believe nothing else, believe that."

His hands still, and he sets his carving down, standing and stalking toward me. He crouches down to eye level. When he speaks again, his voice is dark, his eyes searching.

"So you *can* answer my questions," he says, and dread wraps around my heart. I know where this is going.

"Do not ask me why I did it. I won't tell you." I fight to keep my expression neutral.

He shakes his head, standing.

“You’re a coward,” he spits.

I close my eyes, relief that he did not try to catch me flooding my chest, but shame quickly replaces it. He’s not wrong. I *am* a coward. A monster. But I’m also just a woman trying my best to atone for what I’ve done. It has to be enough, because it’s all I *can* do.

I pick up a few rocks and work to stack them.

“I am many things,” I say, echoing the words of the muse of love and madness. The wind picks up, the stab of pain behind my breastbone following right behind it. I want to cry as I drag myself to the river’s edge. Everything hurts, and I am so very tired—but the river doesn’t care. Death doesn’t sleep, and certainly not just because I long for rest.

Clothes drift nearer, and I’m grateful when I find the dress and shawl of an elderly woman. She will die of a failing heart in her sleep, but I do not feel sorrow for her. Based on her smile lines, she’s lived a long, good life.

I try not to let my disappointment win when there are no pockets to search for the items to my spell, finishing my song and sending her clothes down into the *After*, taking an extra second to send a prayer for peace behind them.

My stomach growls, and, biting through the pain, I prepare to stand. It’s been days since I’ve eaten. If I’m to heal, I need something to nourish my body, but I do not have the strength to try to catch a fish today. Nor the stomach to eat it raw.

With a sigh, I turn toward my bramble berry bush, a little more than a dragon’s length away. Even starving, it doesn’t sound appetizing. Nor does it sound filling, but it’s *something*, and just like always, I can’t afford to hope for more.

I make it to my knees, crying out as I try to put one foot forward to stand. I can’t stop the tears that spring to my eyes—not of pity for myself or frustration, but pure agony.

Somehow, I manage to get almost upright, but the anguish of my ribs twisting overwhelms me, and I stumble, unable to find purchase on the mossy, wet surface beneath my feet. My arms flail as I tumble backward, and I brace myself for impact, but Brennen catches my hand, yanking me up.

The moment our skin touches, fire erupts between us. But as hot and intense as it is, it isn’t painful. The burn grows by the second, shooting up my arm and settling in my chest, plummeting into my belly.

I suck in a sharp breath, and his green-eyed gaze snaps to mine, wide and wild.

He feels it, too.

His eyes trail down my nose and across my lips and jaw, and for a single second, I think he sees me. Not the murderess. Not the Washwoman.

Bea.

For one impossibly long moment, something flickers in my chest. Something dangerously close to hope. He's not looking at me with his usual anger or frustration. It's something different that hides deep within his eyes. An emotion I can't name, but that makes my skin tingle.

The top of my foot grows warm, and this time, the heat does sting. The pain grows agonizing, forcing me to break eye contact as I reach down to grab my ankle. It feels as if someone is pressing a brand into my skin, and I hiss, pulling my skirts up to look.

I suck in a sharp breath.

On the top of my foot, wrapping up the front of my ankle, is a long, straight line with three wavy strokes running through it. Confusion twists in my gut. It's a dàn. A dàn that hadn't marked my skin only seconds ago.

So how in the goddess's name do I have it now?

"Mallachd ort!!" Brennen curses, yanking his hand away, and I nearly fall again. I should. But I don't. Somehow, I remain standing.

"What have you done?" He stares at my skin for a long moment, then drops to one knee and unlaces his shoe, ripping it off. Beneath it, the skin is bare. I see nothing—and yet the look he gives me is of such fury, I physically recoil.

"How did you do that?" he says, jumping to his feet.

"Do what?" I ask, stepping back. I lift my arms for balance, but this time, the rocks don't feel slippery, and it takes far less effort to keep myself standing. *What's happening?*

"Give it back." Brennen takes an aggressive step toward me, and I hold my hands up to stop him. He's shown me he doesn't plan to hurt me, but the fury in his eyes is different now. Less calculated anger and more feral, wild rage.

"Do not come even a step closer. I haven't done anything."

"You stole my dàn." He says it like I'm daft, and a flash of anger surges in my blood. Why is every problem always my fault? Without fail, every piece of blame falls to me, no matter the situation, and I'm tired of it.

“*You* grabbed *me*.”

“You took my dàn of steadiness.”

I scoff, my anger only growing at his insistence. “I did no such thing!”

“Have you done this before? Taken magic from anyone else?”

“What? No!” I say, but he’s no longer listening. He pulls up his sleeves, examining the inky marks on his hands and forearms.

“Six, seven…” he says under his breath.

He pulls off his tunic, revealing a broad, muscular chest covered by what must be close to a dozen more dàn, wrapping around his ribs and across his muscular chest. My mouth goes dry at the sight. At the sheer *power* of him. This is the body of a warrior. Someone who has seen battle and won.

His eyes sharpen as he examines the dàn, his nostrils flaring as he turns his back to me.

“What do you see on my back?”

I don’t answer as I take in the masterpiece that is the broad plane of his shoulders. The way his muscles taper in as they descend toward his waist. It’s as if he has been carved from stone. A statue, erected with the singular intent of demanding worship.

Three thick black lines run the length of his spine. Across each defined shoulder is a different symbol, dàn I don’t recognize. A fourth curves beneath his arm to run down his ribs. And several more fill the empty space around the others.

“I see your dàn,” I say, my voice coming out shaky, but it’s not from fear.

“How many?” he snaps.

I count, trying to ignore the way my stomach and tongue seem to have twisted into knots.

It is the most of a man I have seen in quite some time, and yet he doesn’t seem to notice my discomfort, his hands clenched into tight fists and rising and falling with heavy breaths.

“Um, seven, I think,” I say, my voice shaking.

Brennen turns, his nostrils flaring as he tries to control his rage.

“Tell me how you did it.”

He stalks forward, pulling out his dagger again, and this time, I’m not so sure he won’t use it.

I force my feet to remain firmly planted. “I did nothing. I don’t know how to take magic—”

“Dàn cannae be *taken*. They cannae be transferred. They are given by the Fates, and the Fates alone. So how did you do it?” He places his dagger against my throat, but I refuse to show him my fear.

“I. Didn't," I say, chest heaving with shallow breaths. “Do you not have a dàn of truth?” I ask.

His eyes narrow, his other hand clenching into a fist in frustration.

“Hear me clearly this time when I say it. I. Did. Not. Take. It.”

He doesn’t respond, nostrils flaring as he waits for me to give in. For me to break.

“I didn’t steal it, and I don’t need or want it. Feel free to take it back,” I say. I hold out my leg, but he stares at it as if it is coated in poison.

“Don’t touch me again,” he spits, his words clipped and furious. He lifts my chin with the dagger, and I stare directly into his eyes. I refuse to back down from him. Not when I did nothing wrong. Why is he accusing me of ill-intent when he could just as easily be to blame for what’s happened?

His eyes flick down to the dàn on my ankle for several long moments, his grip growing impossibly tighter before lowering his dagger. He curses under his breath, grabbing his shoe and disappearing into his tent.

Once again, I feel his rage—but it’s muddied, mixed with confusion and uncertainty.

I stare at the tent, searching for flashes of his shadow to see what he might be doing. Maybe he’s packing his bags, preparing to leave.

Or maybe, he’s plotting his revenge.

My stomach growls, my hunger louder than Brennen’s anger, and I swallow down my own confusion, slowly picking my way through the rocks. There’s nothing more I can do to convince him it isn’t my fault. I’m not sure that, were our positions switched, I would believe him either.

If there is one thing I’ve gathered about Brennen since he arrived, it’s that he thrives on control. Craves it, even.

Might as well give him the illusion he has it at this moment.

The ankle carrying my dàn—*Brennen’s* dàn—feels stronger as I walk. More sure. The slippery rocks beneath my feet do not cause me to wobble or fall again. Brennen might be furious with me, but at least I won’t fall and further injure myself.

Steadiness.

Closing my eyes, I lift one foot, but I do not so much as wobble.

Not bothering to fight the smile the feeling of having magic brings to my lips, I settle down next to the bush, picking berry after berry, but I barely taste the tartness of them as my mind spins. The swirling lines across the top of my foot are dainty and delicate compared to the dàn on Brennen’s arms and neck. As I reach down to feel it, it sparkles and warms, an iridescent glow that reminds me of my dragon's wings.

But how is it on my skin? How has its power seeped into my bones?

It’s clear Brennen didn’t give it to me willingly. Is it possible I'd somehow wanted steadiness so badly in that single moment that I *had* somehow subconsciously stolen it? I shake my head. No.

I will not start to blame myself for things that aren’t my fault, too.

19

BRENNEN



I don't bother to spare a look behind me as I leave my tent and make my way along the river, sticking to dry land until I'm out of the Washwoman's sight.

The water is more shallow upstream, and I find a line of slick moss and algae-covered rocks. I hesitate for a moment, afraid I'm about to confirm what I already know. That the magic given to me by the dàn of steadiness truly is gone, but waiting to prove it will change nothing. With a deep breath, I step onto the slippery rocks.

My foot slides before I'm even fully on the stone, and I'm forced to throw out my arms to keep myself from plummeting into the water. I pause, trying to find my center, then take another tentative step. I don't slip this time, but it still takes significant effort to maintain my balance.

"Mallachd ort!," I curse, a mixture of unease and anger churning in my stomach.

That was *my* dàn. One *I* earned through years of service to the Cutter. Years of sacrifice and pain and dedication.

And she took it with a single touch. It shouldn't be possible, and yet, my ankle is bare, and my balance is shite.

I cannae bear to try again. Not when I feel like a bairn learning to walk. Foolish. I had been so incredibly foolish to not just let her fall. Why had I helped her? Because she'd sewn Billy's shoe? One singular act of kindness doesn't mean anything. That is, if she even did it out of kindness. What if

she'd somehow made him slip so she could put on a show of selflessly trying save him?

I pin the Washwoman with a furious glare as I make my way back into the tent, refusing to allow myself to pause when she looks…confused. Regretful, even.

It's all an act, even if it's a convincing one.

I sit down at the writing desk I procured in the village and pull out a jar of ink.

The quill shakes in my hand, ink splashing and staining my skin as I dip it too forcefully into the bottle. I don't bother cleaning it up as I grab a piece of parchment.

Cailleach,

I write to you as your humble servant, wishing to share an update on the Washwoman. I'm concerned she may have magical abilities unknown to us. She—

I pause, unsure what more I should say. My hand hovers over the parchment, but my fingers refuse to write the words.

She took my dàn. There's no denying its lack of presence on my ankle. But *how?*

One moment, she was falling. I'd caught her on instinct, and then my mark was simply gone.

I had touched *her*, not the other way around. In fact, she's made no effort to touch me since I've been here. If she knew touching me would give her magic, magic that could potentially help her to escape, surely she would have tried by now? Or is she trickier than she seems, biding her time while she waits for my defenses to drop before striking?

Cailleach could give the dàn back. Imprint another on my skin with ease. She has that power. But will she lose faith in me if I ask her to? Would she doubt me if I needed her assistance this soon into my post? And more importantly, would she consider this a failure? This assignment is everything I've been working toward. My only opportunity to find justice for Marsaili.

And it’s not only my revenge that hangs in the balance. It's my family's lives.

Cillian, Cian, Saoirse, Aiden.

Cailleach’s voice as she stroked their threads echoes like a drum, and my heart nearly stops. I crumple up the paper and toss it to the side. I need a moment to think. To clear my mind.

I pull out my block of wood and knife, my breaths slowing as I whittle away tiny pieces. The robin is taking shape, its beak dainty and wings spread wide, as if soaring above the loch near home.

I’ve been working on this carving since I arrived here. The need to get it perfect has been a constant ache in my chest.

Marsaili loved robins—how they symbolized those we’ve lost visiting us from beyond. How ironic that I search for her in every robin I see now. I never find her, and so I try to make her, but I can never seem to get it right. Somewhere along the way, I ruin it.

A cut too deep, too long, and I have to begin again.

Maybe it’s impossible to create a tribute to the woman I loved while the woman who killed her rests only feet away. I angrily scrape off a sliver near the tail, deeper than I’d intended, and sigh, setting the bird down before I can ruin this carving, too. I will not allow the murderess to ruin anything else.

And I will not allow her actions to harm my family.

Pulling out a fresh piece of parchment, I begin again.

Cailleach,

I write, as you instructed, to let you know I have found the Washwoman. She is still firmly imprisoned. The magic of the curse, as well as her chain, holds strong, and as you stated, the villagers are fearful of her. She is as vile and cunning as you warned. I will remain vigilant and am eager to report back as I learn more.

Your humble servant,

Brennen

I seal the parchment with wax, then pull on my shirt. I don't have to look back at the Washwoman as I leave to confirm she remains where she belongs. I can *feel* her there. Feel the heat of her gaze between my shoulder blades like a hand pressing against my skin.

I stop, turning to face her.

She’s no longer looking at me, but is staring upstream, waiting for clothing. She grabs a kilt and tunic, her movements slow and tired. Even from here, through the fog and smir, I can see the bruises on her face and neck from the boy’s attack.

I turn to whistle for Sable and my foot slips on the wet earth, not enough to send me falling, but enough to remind me of everything she’s taken from me. Not just my dàn, but Marsaili. The life we were going to have together.

The thought plagues me as I ride, refusing to leave my mind, but as the tavern comes into view, it scatters like dust in the wind.

The building is full, men and women huddled outside the door, heads bowed together with fear in their eyes.

Something is verra wrong.

20

BRENNEN



Harold leans grimly by the front door with a younger man I don't recognize, his long face somehow even more wrinkled than usual, and I push my way toward him, villagers parting for me before I even have to ask.

He stands up straight when he sees me. “Brennen, there you are. You've heard, then?”

“Heard what?” I ask, endless possibilities running through my mind.

His lips press into a grim line, his eyebrows furrowing. “Another woman has gone missing,” he says. Dread slips down my throat, hot and oily.

“You’re certain?” I ask, hoping it’s only a rumor, because if not, the disappearances are picking up at an alarming rate. The last one was only a few days ago.

“Aye,” he says grimly. “The third in the last fortnight that’s disappeared from a village within a two day’s ride. And there are whispers of another in Braestill.”

I run a hand across my scruff, trying to think of any similarities Braestill might have with the other places the women have disappeared from. “Has it been reported to the Fates?” I ask.

“Of course it has.” He leans back, his brows drawing together as if affronted I asked.

I lift my hands. “I’m just doing my job, Harold.”

He sighs, rubbing the back of his neck. “Aye. I know. But it has me—has all of us—on edge. And understandably so. What if our daughters are next? Our sisters and mothers?”

The question hits me like a throwing knife in the center of my chest, and I take a deep breath. “Of course.” I nod. “I didnae mean to imply anything. Only that the Fates need to know so they can stop it. So what you’re afraid of *doesn’t* happen.”

He nods. “Aye. They’ve been told,” he says, more calmly this time.

“Good. Did they have any answers for what might be happening?” I ask, and Harold laughs.

“You think the Fates discuss their threads with any of us?”

Frustration prickles along my skin. How am I to solve these disappearances with no information to go on? “What do we know, then?” I ask, trying to keep my voice from becoming harsh. It’s not Harold’s fault the Fates keep their secrets close.

“She was from Donsgraff, a three-hour ride away. Her husband came looking for her. Said she came through here days ago.”

“Her husband?”

“Aye. Angry fellow. Theo took care of him.” He leans closer, his voice dropping low. “But it seems he’s back. Insisting she never left this village.”

My stomach drops at the implication. “I don't understand. He thinks she’s hiding here? Or that someone has her?”

“No. He thinks she's dead.” He says it so bluntly, I physically recoil, scanning the room.

“Why? Did he find blood? A body?” My mind races, trying to decipher what Harold’s telling me.

“No. But she was here, and now she’s gone.” He sighs, pulling me inside and to the bar. “You want to know what I think?”

I turn my palms up, gesturing for him to continue, and he leans forward, his voice dropping low.

“I think the Washwoman got her.”

“Excuse me!” Theo calls out, climbing up on the bar. “We're closing for the afternoon! Everyone, go home. Check on your families, and for anything that might appear different. Signs of a struggle. Blood. Anything that could be helpful. If something seems amiss, report back immediately.” He hops down, his eyes locking on mine. “Brennen. A word?” He inclines his head toward the back of the bar.

The patrons grumble, but no one argues as they gather their things and begin to file out, and I take a seat as Theo ushers out the last of them.

He grabs a bottle, along with two glasses.

“Is that a robin?” he asks, and I look down at my hands. I hadn’t realized I’d even grabbed my carving, but there it is, twisted in my fingers. I pocket it.

“Aye,” I say. Sharp. Definitive. I have no interest in discussing the carving with him, and I want him to know it.

“My ma loved robins,” he says, lifting the bottle to pour me a drink, but I raise a hand, stopping him. I want to keep a clear head. I’m unsettled by the missing women. From losing my dàn, not to mention the letter to the Cutter sitting heavy as a stone in my pocket.

“Suit yourself,” he says, putting one of the glasses back behind the bar. I take the letter out and set it on the counter, tapping it a few times on the rough wood.

“You have someone who handles the post here, I assume?”

Theo holds out a hand. “He comes through every four to five days. I’ll see it gets delivered.”

“It's important,” I say, handing it over. Theo nods, pouring his own ale and moving around the bar to sit next to me. “What did you want to speak about?” I ask.

He takes a sip. “A few things, really," he says, tenting his hands together. “First, I wanted to apologize.”

“Apologize?” I furrow my brow.

“I overstepped, asking about— When we were talking about loss. It was none of my business. Sometimes, I find myself trying to figure out what makes people work. Why people do what they do. I think it’s my dàn, and it's not intentional. I tend to get too involved. I’m only trying to help, but it doesnae matter. I overstepped.”

I wave a hand. “It's fine. I—” I clear my throat. “Is there something else?”

A fake marriage, real jealousy, and one hidden heir waiting to complicate everything.

See where the trouble starts on **Lokepub**.

Theo’s jaw ticks, and he grips his ale with both hands. He pauses, as if carefully weighing what he wants to say. “The woman who's missing from Donsgraff…” He sighs, putting his mug down and crossing his arms. “I didnae want to tell her husband… I mean, I don't trust him. There's something off about the man.” He rubs the back of his neck, nervous.

“What are you saying, Theo?” I ask, leaning forward.

He meets my eyes, lifting his chin, but I can’t tell if it’s in challenge or an attempt to show sincerity. “I know where she went.”

My body goes rigid. “Where?”

He meets my eyes, and it’s then I see the flicker of hesitation.

“Where did she go, Theo?” I ask. My dàn of dread flares of its own accord, and Theo’s face goes white.

“She went to the river.” His voice shakes when he speaks, and I force the dàn to dim, even though my hands clench into fists.

“How do you know?” I ask.

He looks away for a brief moment, but when he meets my gaze again, there’s a resolve in his eyes that wasn’t there before. He squares his shoulders. “Because I’m the one who sent her there.”

I stand on instinct, hand flying to the hilt of my sword as the stool crashes to the ground behind me.

“You sent an innocent woman, alone, to a *murderer*?” I bite out.

He holds his hands up. “Brennen.” I stiffen at his casual use of my name. “She came here asking about the Washwoman. Her face was bloodied. Her eye black and swelling shut. Her lip was split, and she kept looking over her shoulder as if she thought someone was chasing her. The woman was terrified. She wanted to know if the rumors were true. If the Washwoman could answer a question. I told her it was, and I told her how to get there.”

I do not miss that he believes parts of the Washwoman’s tale after all—that she can answer your questions. How many questions have I asked that she’s refused to entertain, just another part of her legend twisted over time?

He swallows, and I force myself to wait, sensing this isn't the end of the story.

“I made her promise to come back after she saw her. Said I would help her. I told you when you brought Anna here, this isn't the first time I've helped a woman in a situation like this, and it won't be the last. I already

told you, people in need of help seem to be drawn to me. I'd say this is half tavern and lodging, half safe house, at this point."

"And it's getting worse with the Epoch approaching," I finish for him.

He nods grimly. "She promised she'd come back, and I was preparing a room for her when her husband tore in here, furious. Hamish, he said his name was. I wouldn't tell him where she went, and he was in an absolute rage when he left. Bloody drunk, screaming at me and my patrons. He broke a chair, and I had to threaten him to get him to leave. The woman never came back."

I clench my teeth against my anger. Violence is bad enough, but when it's against a woman? I can *almost* forget my moral compass. "Do you think he found her?"

"I dinnae ken anything about either of them. But Brennen, I don't want that man here."

I look over my shoulder.

"No. Not here, in the Tavern. Here in the Dalbàsail. He keeps coming back, drunk and ranting. Breaking things. He willnae listen to me. But maybe he'll listen to a Dìdeanair."

I pick up the stool from the floor and sit back down. "Aye. What does he look like?"

"Tall, with dark hair. Heavy build. Bloodshot eyes and a ruddy face. There's a scar from some sort of burn on his hand."

I nod, grabbing Theo's ale and taking a swig. If he minds, he doesn't say anything. "You're asking me to find him and convince him to leave?"

"If you would."

"I'll talk to him," I say, wanting to get both sides of the story. "And if I get the sense you're right about his character, then I'll handle it."

"Thank you," he says, relief flooding his features.

I nod. "Does anyone else know you sent her to the Washwoman?"

Theo shakes his head. "No. I thought it best to only share it with you. The town fears her enough. Maybe you can find her. But Brennen, I don't think the Washwoman hurt her."

My dàn of truth remains silent, and my intuition tells me to trust him. But how can it be a coincidence? The woman goes to the river, and now, she's gone.

"That makes one of us," I say. And this time, my dàn flares.

I'm lying to myself.

The thought sends a wave of fury through my blood. I know what this woman has done. I witnessed it myself as Marsaili bled out in my arms.

A woman leaves to find her and doesn't return—disappears without a trace. There cannae be no connection.

"I'll take care of it," I say, my hands clenched and muscles tight as I stalk toward the exit.

"Brennen," Theo calls as I'm pushing my way through the door. "What are you going to do?"

I turn back to him, assessing. It's clear he's afraid for the Washwoman. That he truly doesnae believe she had any part in this.

A plan begins to formulate in my mind, and I hold Theo's stare. "Whatever I have to."

21

BEA



A pale purple dress floats in the dark of night into the *After*, a broken piece of chalk clutched firmly in my hand. It's not an item for my spell, but it is still a ray of sunshine in the otherwise cloudy sky that has been the past few days. Dropping down next to a slanted rock, I begin to trace out the half-finished dàn in my mind. I pause where I always do, my hand hovering over the stone, and I look at my ankle, the dainty lines wiggling across it.

Closing my eyes, I try to picture the rest of the shape. Nothing comes to me. Frustration swirls in my belly, and I open one eye, peeking at the drawing.

I reach out and add another line haphazardly, a downward arch, and tilt my head to examine it. Staring at it, I bite my lip, waiting to see if anything else comes to me, but as usual, my mind remains completely blank.

With a huff, I add another line, right in the middle, but it just looks crowded and unlike any dàn I've ever seen. I sigh, taking a scoop of water in my hands and washing the drawing away. Scooting back to another rock, I begin again, but this time, I don't even attempt to draw the dàn. I sketch out the night sky above me. The stars that have shone over my head for a hundred and three years. They remind me of freckles sparkling overhead, and I have memorized them the way a mother would her child’s.

A throat clears behind me, and I startle, pulling my hand back.

I turn to find Brennen standing a few feet away, his arms crossed and his jaw tight. His eyes are harder than usual, but they aren't brimming with the cold rage I'm used to, and it makes me uneasy.

Something's happened.

"Inspecting your stolen magic?" he asks, and a shiver skates down my spine. Not at his statement, but the tone of it. It's taunting. Angry and accusatory. *Always* so accusatory.

I pull my dress down to cover my ankle. "I already told you, I didn't steal it from you. Not on purpose, at least," I say, racking my brain for a way to get him to believe me. I need for us to find some common ground here. Some reason, any reason at all, for him to trust me, even if only a fraction. I don't want to spend every day he's here on edge, walking the thin line of trying to keep him from getting angry or accusing me of wickedness.

He studies me for a long moment before taking a step forward, rocks crunching beneath his boots. "I just returned from the village," he says, his eyes narrowing. "Have you ever been?"

"Not since I was sentenced here." I tuck my hair behind my ears, grateful for the change in subject. "But children come here sometimes. I remember it isn't too far. It can't be, if little feet are able to make the journey."

His eyes follow my hand to my bruise, and something flickers in his expression. Guilt? Frustration? I can't feel either specifically, the emotions radiating from his body too tangled to interpret.

The look is gone too quickly to determine, and it only adds to my discomfort. I'm not sure what I could have possibly done now to have caught the attention of his ire. I've been doing nothing today but washing clothes and drawing, for goddess' sake.

He tilts his head. "It's interesting you should say that. Because the villagers say they've seen *you* there. At night, waiting outside gates and windows, dripping with water."

I laugh, a bitter sound, annoyance building in my chest. Is it not enough for him to accuse me of everything less than perfect that happens? Must he go to the village and search out rumors, too? Things to blame me for that aren't even true?

"They say a lot, don't they?" I lean back, examining him for a moment. His posture is tight, the muscles in his arms bunched as if he's holding

himself back. I tap my foot, impatient for him to get to the point. “If you have a question, just ask it.”

He unfolds his arms, walking to his tent and grabbing an apple from his nearby rucksack. My mouth waters as he sits down, feigning nonchalance, but it doesn’t fool me. I can *feel* how unsettled he is. It prickles at my skin, and anticipation twists in my gut. What is he doing? Pretending to be unassuming so I will let down my guard? If he thinks he will surprise me with some sort of attack, verbal or otherwise, he is sorely mistaken.

He takes a bite. Casual. Calculated, and I lean back against the rocks, imitating his posture.

“Women have been going missing. Have you heard?”

My body betrays me, and I stiffen, confused. Is he actually asking me if I’ve heard, or is he accusing me of something?

“How would I have heard that?” I ask. “From the children who come here to beat me? Or do you think I receive updates in the post on the ongoings of the kingdom?”

His eyes flash at my sarcasm, but he quickly slips his mask of calm back on. “It’s one of the reasons the Fates sent me here, you know.” He takes another bite. “They want to make sure you’re not one of them.”

Annoyance flares in my chest. How could I possibly disappear when they’ve shackled me to this valley with wards to keep me put and a dragon to turn me to ash should I escape? “I think they’ve ensured that well enough, don’t you?” I rattle my chain. “Is that what all this” —I wave to him, pointing out without words that I don’t believe for a moment that he is unbothered— “is about? Women I’ve never even met disappearing?” The flash of anger that rolls through my body is white hot. “Not everything horrid that befalls the kingdom can be my fault, you know. I am not the only one in this realm who has been touched by evil.”

I don’t try to say the words with such fire, but they tumble out with venom behind them nonetheless.

“See, that’s what I’m not so sure about,” he says, taking a bite of his apple. “The husband of one of them, Hamish—he seems to think you had something to do with his wife disappearing. Said she came here and was never seen again. Long blonde hair. Green eyes. Vanished into thin air?”

Kenna’s face flashes through my mind, and I struggle to keep my face from betraying me. I can picture her perfectly. Long blonde hair, matted. Green eyes, bruised and swollen. Fear creeps along my shoulders, but I

keep my spine straight and squeeze my hands together to keep them from shaking.

Brennen cannot learn where she went. No one can. I swore to myself I would keep her safe, and even if I think Brennen is trustworthy, I'm not willing to risk it.

"Like I said, it's only the children who come. I've not seen anyone—"

His eyes flash to his wrist, and the corner of his lips twitch into the slightest smile. It's the first one I've seen, but it doesn't bring me any joy. There's too much triumph in it.

He lifts his arm, showing me his dàn.

Shite.

"Do you lie often?"

My breath stalls, my stomach plummeting as I realize my mistake. "I…" I stare at the dark lines, swallowing down the rest of the lies dancing on my tongue.

"It can't be just children who visit, can it? You told me yourself when I arrived it was a man who'd caused your lip to bleed. And yet you say you've not seen anyone. He was the one who hurt you, wasn't it? The woman's husband?"

"I didn't think—" I stumble over my words, my heart pounding. "You said *women* are disappearing."

He shakes his wrist, giving me a closed-lip smile and tilting his head. I bite my tongue, afraid to admit more, but he simply sits there, waiting. But what can I say? That I sent her away but am not willing to tell him where to?

"He— The husband must be mistaken, if he thinks I did something to her," I say, choosing my words carefully. "I am bound to this shore. How would I make her disappear?"

"Ah, well, you see." He stands, brushing off his kilt, the movement so casual, I want to throttle him. *Just ask your damn question,* I want to say. I start to, but the smile falls from his face as he crosses his arms. "He doesn't think she disappeared. He thinks you killed her."

The words are a punch that steals the air from my lungs, and fury ignites in my blood. I did everything in my power to make sure she *didn't* end up dead. Because I'm certain that's how Kenna's story would have ended if she hadn't escaped. I had allowed him to knock me unconscious, had rejoiced in that pain because I knew it meant she would be safe, and here this man is—

a man who knows nothing about me—accusing me of being the one who harmed her.

"How dare you?" I hiss.

Brennen gestures to the water. "What? Don't act like it's not a reasonable thought. Here's a whole river for you to drown her in, and the *After* waiting right there," he says, tossing his apple up and down as he stares into the black mist.

"I would never hurt someone," I say, but the words have no sting to them. He knows it's not the truth. Even without his dàn, he knows what I've done.

Brennen wades into the water, and I hold my breath as he moves beyond my chain length. Shadows twist near him, but he stops just short of them, leaning forward to attempt to peer down into the black. He throws the half-eaten apple into the *After*, and it vanishes into the mist without a sound.

"See?" He turns to me, gesturing to the darkness. "The water keeps going. You could've killed her and sent her body downstream, and no one would ever know."

I bristle, trying to come up with a reason why what he's saying couldn't be true. Because I know what he sees. A prisoner with blood-stained hands. One the villagers talk about with terror. Why would he believe me? I've lied to him, and he knows it.

"I haven't seen anyone—" I say, no longer caring what his dàn tells him. I made the decision to keep Kenna's secret, and I will continue to do so, regardless of the consequences.

His voice drops. "Do you think me a fool? I ken you're lying. I ken she was here." Brennen's hand moves to his waist, and his dagger is in his grasp before I can blink, sharp and menacing, but he makes no further moves toward me.

And as he stands there, chest heaving and eyes dark with anger, I realize that even though I should be, I'm not afraid. I've faced threats far more terrifying than him before, and survived. I don't care if this is what causes that control of his to finally slip. I made a promise to myself. To Kenna. And I will not break it.

Brennen's nostrils flare at my silence. "If you didnae harm her, why not tell the truth? She was seen coming this way. Was sent to you by the village barkeep so you could answer the lass's question." He takes a step forward. "She promised she'd return, and she never did."

I tilt my head. Why would she promise she'd return if that was never her intention? But even more interestingly, why would the barkeep send her here, knowing my legend? I do not have an answer, so I don't even try to give him one, instead pressing my lips together.

The silence that stretches between us is suffocating, but Brennen doesn't flinch. Doesn't blink, and I'm certain he'll stand there all night if he has to. My body aches, and my mind races. I'm not sure I have the strength, nor the energy, to continue this dance much longer. He's too focused. Obsessed, even, with getting an answer. But maybe if I give him just a hint of truth, something his dàn can confirm, he'll let it go. Or at least, I can hope he will.

"The woman is safe," I say, my voice shaking with the admission.

His eyes widen, and I almost laugh. He'd accused me so confidently about knowing what happened to her, and yet, there's no way his surprise is an act. "What?"

"She's safe," I repeat. "*Alive* and safe. She came here, and I helped her. That's all you need to know."

He grips the dagger tighter, crouching before me as he holds my gaze, refusing to let me look away.

"Tell me where she is," he demands, the words rough as gravel.

"I didn't hurt her. I *helped* her," I say, pushing every bit of conviction I have into my words. How can he not see it on my face or hear it in my voice? I have done nothing to warrant his suspicion, and yet it is sharper than his blade was against my back.

"Can you no see I'm trying to help her, too?" he shouts, and I pause. *Could* he help her? I do believe he'd want to. But I also can't be confident that, in trying to help her, he won't tell someone something he shouldn't. What if he tells the wrong person, and it gets back to the husband, Hamish?

"If you want to help her, let this go," I say softly, keeping my voice even. "I won't tell you where she is, no matter what you do." I stand, turning away. He reaches out as if to stop me, but pauses, his eyes flicking to the dàn on my ankle. He lifts his dagger.

"Tell me," he says, and the meaning is clear. Will he actually follow through with his implied threats one of these days? Or are they empty?

Either way, I do not care.

My voice shakes, but I remain firm. "You can beat me bloody, plunge that dagger into my chest to the hilt, but it will change *nothing*. The woman

is safe. And because I want it to stay that way, I'll not tell you, nor anyone else, where she is."

"Was she in trouble then? Is that it? Tell me, and *I'll* help her!" he shouts, a crack in his constant control. "Tell me or I'll—"

"What?" I throw my arms out. "Stab me? Do it!"

His fingers flex around the knife, knuckles going white. "There's no reason you wouldn't tell me where she is, what she wanted from you, unless you were responsible—"

"I won't tell you, because it is the only way I can be absolutely certain she remains hidden!" I scream. It tears out of me, a century of helplessness behind it. My hands shake, and my breaths heave. It feels good to lose my temper—to let rage replace the endless guilt and shame and hopelessness constantly eating away at my soul.

So I let it burn.

I stand, wading closer to him and jabbing a finger in his direction. "Do you want to know why I won't tell you?" He scrambles back, eyes flicking to my hand, afraid of my touch. Of another dàn transferring.

Good. Let him be the one afraid for once.

He keeps retreating, stumbling as he tries to keep space between us.

"I won't tell you because that husband who seems so concerned about his precious wife was beating her to near death! Is that why he's worried, you think? So he can find her and finish the job before he's punished for what he did?" The words come out raw and wild, and in the back of my mind, I wonder if I finally look as terrifying as I'm said to be, my red hair whipping around my face in the moonlight, my bloody hands reaching out toward him, pure rage in my eyes.

I lower my voice. "I won't tell you because she came here with more bruises on her body than I've ever seen. Because she begged me, *begged* me, to help her hide, and I promised I would protect her."

I continue forward, my courage growing by the second. Damn common ground. Damn this man who cannot see beyond his duty to the Cutter. "You want to think I'm a monster? Fine. Everyone already does. They always will. If the only way that woman stays safe is for me to endure whatever torture you have planned to extract that knowledge from me, then pull out your knife. I will not yield. I have failed too many people. I will not fail her."

My chest heaves as I hold his stare.

“And what do you suggest I tell Hamish?” he finally asks. “What do you suggest I tell Cailleach when she asks me where the woman has gone?”

“Tell them whatever you like. Tell them I murdered her, for all I care. But hear me when I say, there is *nothing* you can do to me that will make me change my mind.”

For a long moment, he just stares at me. Not with anger or suspicion, but something different.

“You…” He swallows, looking down at his dàn of truth. “She’s actually safe? You truly helped her?”

“Of course I did.” The anger deflates out of me, and my voice comes out softer. Quieter. Relief that he’s finally listening floods my body, my shoulders sagging, exhaustion pulling them down. “I might be a monster, but do you not think it’s possible I’m more than *only* that?” I ask, and before he can argue, I dive into the river.

The cold is a shock to my tired body, but it clears my mind. I did what I thought—no—what I *knew* was right. I protected Kenna the best I could, and so I welcome the chill. The way it makes me feel alive in a way I haven’t in a very long time.

I swim hard and fast until my fingers reach the opposite bank. I climb out and walk until my chain goes taut with a jerk, stopping me mid-step.

I am as far from him as I can be, and through the grace of the Fates, he does not follow me.

22

BRENNEN



I stand at the river's edge, staring at the dripping figure pointedly ignoring me on the other side, her chain taut in her desperation to get as far away from me as possible. She looks so small, building a cairn and mumbling under her breath.

And while she is all righteous anger and indignation, the only way I can describe myself is speechless.

She would truly rather be tortured than give me information on the missing woman. I'm certain of it. The anger in her voice. Not even anger. Fury. It had penetrated my skin with ease, tunneling into my bones until it was undeniable, as if she couldn't possibly understand why I wouldn't just trust her word that the woman was alive and well.

But why would I? She's a prisoner. A convicted killer.

Except, not once had my dàn of truth flared to life to indicate she'd lied to me.

Not until today. Until I'd questioned who'd visited her. Which means everything else she's told me is true. That Hamish had been beating his wife, and the Washwoman helped her escape. That she's only staying silent to protect the woman.

Though... Can I trust the dàn at all now?

If she can take them from my skin, maybe she can control them in other ways. Suppress them or manipulate them into silence.

But that doesn't make sense, either. The dàn had *only* flared when she lied about no one coming to the river. If she could control it, wouldn't she have suppressed it then, too?

I rub my forehead as I head back to my tent, pulling out my half-finished wood carving. I need to think. To calm this storm of confusion in my mind so I can see clearly.

The knife in my hand carves through the wood like butter as I consider the Washwoman's words. Marsaili would have protected Kenna, too. Without hesitation, she would have taken her in and found a way to help her escape.

Disgust hits straight between my ribs, the thought of the two women having something in common unbearable, and I scrape too hard, almost taking off the bird's beak.

I freeze, setting the carving down and grabbing a stack of parchment instead. I need to write down my thoughts before I second-guess what I saw. To document everything that's happened since I arrived.

I was sent here to gather information. To find a way to kill her, and until then, to ensure she doesn't disappear. Her connection to one of the missing women is too close, and I dinnae like it a bit. Is she connected to all of them, somehow? Or worse, could she be the one helping them disappear?

I shake away the thought, the mystery too big to solve right now, and begin with something smaller. Taking a deep breath, I write down the dates the women went missing, listing the details of what exactly happened when she took my dàn. How she'd protected Billy, mended his shoe. How she'd claimed to help the woman escape her husband.

I write down her words.

You want to think I'm a monster? Fine. Everyone already does. I will not yield. I have failed too many people. I will not fail her.

The image of her standing there, hair whipping around her face, bright eyes wild with angry determination, flashes through my mind.

I might be a monster, but maybe it's possible I'm more than only *that,* she'd said.

I write it down.

Once it's all on paper, I read it through. Then again.

Leaning forward, I press the heels of my hands against my eyes. If what she told me is true, and she really helped Kenna escape Hamish at the risk of her own safety, how can this be the woman who killed her friend and her lover a century ago. The woman who killed six people in a single night? Who killed Marsaili?

But she's admitted it. Has never denied the murders.

She did it.

And yet, I don't see how she was capable.

The two thoughts refuse to exist together—that this gentle, bonnie lass could be the brutal murderer I've hunted for years. No matter how hard I try to mix them, they separate like oil and water.

I push the confusion away because, in truth, it doesn't matter.

I am here to complete a mission and fulfill my vow. It nearly kills me that I cannae just do it now and move forward. Though even if I still dinnae know how to kill her, there is something I *can* do. Something that might take my mind off the conflicting emotions swirling through my entire body.

I grab a second dagger, sliding it into my boot, and am buckling my sword belt when I hear it—a shout, then a splash. I rip open the tent flaps, my hand going to my blade. The Washwoman is in the water, finishing her song and her washing. She stands, wading back to this side of the river, her hands clutched to her chest.

"What's happened?" I ask, my head swiveling, searching for threats.

"It's nothing," she says, but her voice is choked with tears. A kernel of guilt settles in my stomach, hot and unwanted. She's crying. Is she upset over my anger? My accusations?

For a moment, I'm compelled to tell her I believe her. That I don't think she killed the woman, and that I plan to take care of Hamish immediately. That, in this particular instance, she did the right thing.

But I don't allow myself to. Not when my head is still spinning, logic and reason battling against emotion. Carefully, I walk around her, giving her a wide berth. Not because I think she will attack, but because I worry if I'm too close to her sorrow, it will further cloud my judgment. She wipes at her eyes with her sleeve at her shoulder.

Her hand is cradled to her chest as she climbs out of the river, blood seeping from her closed fist and staining the dingy white of her dress.

“You’re hurt.” My chest tightens unexpectedly.

“I’m fine,” she says, but she won’t look at me. “There was a knife. In the pocket of a pair of trousers—” She nods to the clothes floating downstream. “I reached in to check for—” She stumbles over her words, “coins. Thread. But I found a small dagger instead. It cut my palm.”

“Is it deep?” I ask, the bloody stain on her chest growing larger by the moment.

She hesitates, then nods. “To the bone. But I will heal, just as I always do.”

My thoughts turn toward my tent where my supplies are, years of training telling me to grab something to stop the bleeding, though, with my dàn of healing, I didnae think to bring bandages. Still, I could use some cloth to tend to the wound. Wash it and wrap it to make sure it doesn’t fester. The river may seem clean, but there are animals that live in it. Dirt and bugs.

I take a step toward her, but stop. I cannae touch her and risk another dàn transferring.

I open my mouth to speak.

“Don’t,” she cuts me off. “I know what you’re going to say. That I deserve this. That it’s a fitting punishment, the Washwoman injured by the very clothes she washes.” Her voice is bitter through her tears. “Satisfied?” She holds out her hand, and blood drips onto her bare feet. “I threw the knife in the river when it cut me. Dive in and find it, if you don’t believe me. Or don’t. I don’t care what you do. Just leave me alone.” Her hands fall into her lap.

I watch the blood spread through her apron for a long moment, an uncomfortable pressure building between my ribs. It would be honorable to help her. Would align with the code I live by.

Instead, I sigh, wading into the water to retrieve the knife. It takes some time to find, and when I pull it out, I realize why. The blade is small and rusted, the brown blending in with the river floor. I pocket it without a word.

“Make sure you take it with you,” she says, her words as sharp as the knife in my kilt. “Wouldn’t want the monster at the river to gut you with it, would we?”

23

BRENNEN



The ride to the village is short, but it gives me time to think. To calm my mind and prepare for what I need to do next.

I'm just about to walk through the doors to the Tavern when Harold catches my arm. "Brennen, a word?" he says, shuffling foot to foot, his eyes darting around nervously. I look around to confirm there are no threats, even though my dàn of warning remains silent.

"Everything alright?" I ask.

"Och, Fine. I um— Am I correct in thinking you'd like to gather information on the Washwoman?"

He doesn't wait for my answer, instead turning to walk in the direction of his house. I follow, allowing him to continue his nervous rambling.

"You see, I need to do what's right, I think." He wrings his hands together. "The Washwoman. Well, she's the reason my wife died. I ken Theo doesnae think so. You probably dinnae either, but I saw her that night. I *know* it was her."

I take several long strides to catch up to him. "Theo said Isla had been sick for some time—"

"Aye. She was ill. But she didnae pass until the Washwoman appeared." His voice cracks. "I saw her standing at our garden gate. Right here, watching."

He stops just outside the gate, turning to me. "You seem like a good man, Brennen. So I'm going to show you something and trust that you will

do what's right with it."

With a deep breath, he opens the gate and leads me straight into his house. It's cozy inside, with touches of his late wife everywhere. In the scalloped edges of the curtains and the floral teapot sitting by the hearth. In the dried flowers hanging above it.

"Would you like tea?" he asks, but I shake my head, too interested in what's got him so on edge.

"Right, then." He hesitates for another long moment before moving to the bookshelf and pulling out what looks to be an old leather journal. It creaks as his fingers grip it, hesitating again, but he meets my eyes and hands it to me.

Immediately, I feel it. The reason he was so nervous.

Magic, buzzing within the fibers of the parchment. The binding.

"Harold—"

"I know it's a risk, having it."

"A risk? It's illegal—"

"It's been in my family for centuries, and there's nothing dangerous in it. Look for yourself. Honestly, I can't even bloody read half of it."

I flip open the cover of the spellbook, running my fingers along the name scratched into the first page. Benjamin Treestrom.

"Why are you giving me this? You know I'm honor-bound to report it. Do you want Cailleach coming here? She'll think a ceatharnaich group is forming. Or that you're—"

"That I'm what?" he asks, voice sharp. "That I'm a sentimental old man who wants to hold onto something of his da's? He asked me to keep it safe before he died. I vowed to him I would, and I'll no be breaking it. It was written by his da. And his before that, and on and on for generations. It's my family's history. A few spells to help us survive the cruel winters here."

"Spells that have been eradicated, and for good reason. Spells you have no business performing."

"And why not? Because the Fates deem it so? Because they want to control all magic and leave none for the rest of us?"

I stiffen at his treasonous words.

"Now, you'll not find a ceatharnaich group here. Frankly, all we want here is to be left alone. But I am an honest man, and while I have resigned myself to live peacefully under the rule of the Fates, it doesnae mean I have

to agree with them. And it certainly doesnae mean I'll allow them to pull wool over my eyes. I'd rather go blind."

My lungs seem to go stiff, discomfort filling the space between them. I dinnae want to turn the old man in for his words. Not when he's shown me such kindness. "You know why the Fates control magic, Harold. What happened when they didn't?" I say, hoping I can make him see reason.

"I know what *they* say happened—"

I cut him off before he can say something even more incriminating. "Wars. *Death*. That's what happened. People are hungry for power, and when they have too much of it, they abuse it."

"The Fates must be starving, then."

His sentence slams directly into my chest, and I shake my head, remembering the stories I've read about the time before the Fates. A time of greed, when magic went unchecked completely, and to get it, you had to take it. "There's a reason they control what power is given to each of us."

He holds my gaze, but doesn't seem convinced.

I sigh, swallowing down my frustration.

He taps the book. "You and I want the same thing, Brennen. That's all this is. It is my job to protect the people of this village. I want the Washwoman dead. I willnae allow her to take another soul."

He opens the book to the middle. "Somewhere around here, the Washwoman came. My family wrote about her, generations ago." He flips until he reaches a water-stained page. Slanted handwriting fills it, the letters cramped as if whoever wrote them was preserving paper.

We attempted to drown her today. Held her underwater for near an hour, just to be certain she was well and truly gone. When she floated to the top, her lips and skin were blue, the whites of her eyes bloodshot. We thought we'd finally done it. And then, the creature rose from the dead before our verra eyes. Water poured from her lungs, blood dripping from her nose. It was unnatural. But even more, it shows her true wicked nature.

My stomach turns sour, but I take the book from Harold's hands and force myself to keep reading.

Burned the Washwoman. The fire made her skin bubble, but it never progressed past that. The inferno was so hot, we couldn't stand within two dragons of her. It burned out after half a day, but in the ashes, the Washwoman remained. Once again, she didnae die.

I almost drop the journal, so I grip it tighter, knuckles white.

Stabbed, over a hundred times.
Attempted with swords—
Daggers—
Dirks—
Axes—

The list goes on and on, and my hands tremble with rage, the taste of bile coating my tongue threatening to bring the contents of my stomach up. I picture Marsaili. All the blood that had poured from the single wound in her neck. To be stabbed so many times, it must have been agony.

Slit her throat to the bone—
Poisoned her with belladonna—
Stoning—

I snap the book closed, rubbing my forehead, unable to stomach another word.

“Brennen?” Harold’s voice comes from somewhere verra far away, hard to hear over the rush of blood in my ears.

I close my eyes, trying not to picture the brutality of what the Washwoman endured. When I’d pulled my dagger earlier, she hadn’t even flinched. Hadn’t cowered away from it.

Now I see why. It was nothing compared to what’s been done to her before.

“This is—” my voice comes out as a growl, and I clear my throat. “This is savage. Ruthless.”

“The lass is a murderer!” Harold says, incredulous.

“Aye. So you torture her for decades? A *century*? She deserves death for her crimes. But a clean death. Not… Not this.” I shake the book with disgust. “This isn’t justice. It’s bloody sadism. It’s…”

I can’t finish the thought, because how else could I describe it, other than pure evil?

I open the book again, finding the final entry.

> *Consulted texts lent to me by scribes. Those with the immortality dàn cannot die by conventional means, but the runes themselves are vulnerable. Destroy the rune, destroy the power. We carved the dàn from her skin, but it appeared even in the layers below her flesh, down to the bone. It appears the texts were incorrect.*

My vision goes black at the edges as I imagine the unfathomable pain actions as violent as this would have caused. They hadn't just tried to kill her. They’d carved the verra flesh from her body. Through muscle and bone. Did she beg for death then?

Harold keeps talking, but I barely hear him. My mind is spinning, my thoughts circling like the deep blue dragon above the glen, constantly dancing in the hazy sky.

These people had tortured the Washwoman beyond belief. Drowned her. Burned her and stabbed her and slit her throat to the bone—and she was

forced to survive it. To wake up and face something even worse the next day.

No one deserves that kind of torment.

And it wasn’t these villagers' right to enact it. This—what’s written on these pages—isn’t the punishment the Washwoman was sentenced to by the Fates. She was sentenced to wash the clothes of the dead, not to be endlessly tortured.

I lift the book. “I cannae condone this.”

“No one asked you to. It cannae be taken back.” Harold straightens.

“Then why show it to me?”

Harold points to the page. “Because it will help you. You say she cannae be killed? My granda didnae believe it, and neither do I.”

I force myself to focus on his words, though my thoughts are still tangled. “The Cutter herself said—”

“And does the Cutter always tell the truth?”

His question hangs between us for a moment, heavy as a stone, then falls. The first drop of rain landing on a loch’s surface, ripples spreading outward.

Does she?

She sent me here to kill the Washwoman, knowing it’s impossible. If even *she* cannae kill her, how does she expect me to?

Harold must see the change in my expression.

“You see it. Don’t you? Magic isn’t absolute. Power doesn’t work like that. You can extend a life, but every spell, every curse, *must* have a way to break it. There is no true immortality.”

I freeze. Immortality. The words in the journal finally register in my mind. *Those with the immortality dàn cannot die by conventional means, but the runes themselves are vulnerable.*

“Is that why she cannae die? Because she has an immortality dàn?” I ask.

Harold nods, and my chest tightens. “If that’s true, why would the Cutter not have told me about it?”

His eyes flash with pity, and it fills me with rage. I am a Dìdeanair of the highest order. A warrior who has earned his magic. And yet, he looks at me as if I’ve been wearing a blindfold my entire life.

“Who gifts our dàn to us, Brennen? Tell me,” he says, like I’m a child. I want to leave. To demand respect, but something in his tone pulls at the

strings of my mind. Harold's line of thinking makes sense.

My eyes flick to his dedication dàn. "The Fates."

"But it doesn't take all three of them, does it?"

I swallow instead of answering. I don't have to. I know where he's going with this.

"The Weaver spins our threads, and the Measurer decides how long our lives will be. But it's the Cutter who ends our lives at the time of her sister's choosing." He pauses, watching my expression.

I dinnae answer him, but he doesnae back down from my stare. "Are you hearing me, lad?" The word makes me feel three feet tall. "The Cutter cannae cut what her sisters do not measure and weave."

His words fill the small cabin, a pressure building in my skull. What he's saying makes sense. If the Weaver or the Measurer gave Bea a dàn that makes her un-killable, it could be why the Cutter's attempts failed. Why Harold's grandfather's attempts failed.

"But why? Why would they do that? Why hide it from Cailleach?"

"That's the question, isn't it? The Fates are the only ones who can give dàn, but they're also the only ones who can take them away. The Cutter either doesn't know about the immortality dàn, or she doesn't actually want her dead and is lying to you. If you ask me, I think it's likely you're just a piece of Cailleach's game. Figure out her next move, and maybe you can beat her at it."

I tighten my hands into fists. "You're getting awfully close to treason, Harold," I warn, even though he's already well past it. I could imprison him for life, based on what he's already shown and told me.

He shakes his head. "I dinnae have to like her to follow her laws. I told you. I'm an honest man, and I've spun it round in my mind a hundred times. There is no higher power than the Fates, other than the Goddesses. But we all know they dinnae care about us anymore." He meets my eyes. "The *only* answer is that one of the Fates made her immortal. All magic can be undone. There has to be a way to kill her." He taps the book. "This might help you figure out how to do it."

I stand still, my jaw tight and my mind spinning. I have no doubt the Cutter wants the Washwoman dead. It was clear as glass, her hatred for the lass.

Could it be the Weaver then? The Measurer, somehow overruling the Cutter's powers? The two of them together perhaps… I grip the book

tighter. I shouldn’t take it. It will only offer me trouble.

Or, it will help me discover the truth.

“It’s all in there, Brennen. A list of every way they tried to kill her.”

My stomach churns. “Does that not prove she cannae be killed?”

“It only proves no one has tried the right method,” he says. “You know I’m right. Take the book, and find a way to end this. Dinnae let her hurt anyone else.”

My chest rises and falls with tense breaths for several moments as I weigh my options, but before my mind can even catch up, I’m shoving the journal into my bag and stalking toward the front door.

“Brennen?” Harold calls. I turn.

“If you do decide to turn me in,” he meets my eyes, holding my stare, “know my son and grandsons ken nothing of the book. They dinnae ken it exists at all. You’ll leave them out of it.”

I raise my eyebrows, a smirk crossing my lips. “Threatening a Dìdeanair?” I ask, but I dinnae blame him. I’d lie to protect the ones I love, too.

“I like you, Brennen. I think you know it’s no me who’s the threat.”

I look down at the journal in my bag, noting its heaviness. Not just the physical weight of the pages, but what it represents.

Years of torture, listed out in neat, organized lines.

A woman who cannae die, despite all of the ways they tried.

A Fate who claims she wants that woman dead, but sent me with a threat to my family looming over my head to accomplish what these villagers have been unable to do in a hundred years.

"I dinnae ken who the threat is anymore," I admit, then turn and walk into the night, the journal bumping against my side with each step.

I should hate the Washwoman. I *do* hate her, and I will still kill her. The vow on my palm hasn't changed, and neither has my desire for vengeance. But as I walk through the darkness back toward the tavern, all I can think about is the entry I'd read: *Slit her throat to the bone.* The same wound that killed Marsaili. Except Bea had felt the blade slice through her skin and muscle until it scraped her spine. Had drowned in her own blood and then been forced to endure the pain of healing, only for them to stab and burn and stone her.

What kind of monster could endure that and still show kindness to a child who'd beaten her? What kind of monster could survive a century of

torture and choose to risk more pain to protect a stranger?

Not any I'm aware of.

I picture her as I walk, her freckled nose and wild red hair, slight beneath that threadbare dress she wears, her hands always plunged into the river, and try to reconcile it with what I just read. Fire blistering her skin. Daggers etching into bone.

Without thinking, I push my hand into my pocket, the wood of the robin I've been carving scraping against my scarred palm.

I find the junction where the robin shifts from a bird in flight to unwhittled, angular wood.

A reminder that no matter what appears to be on the outside, there can be something else hidden inside entirely, like a woman who was tortured relentlessly, but who, six years ago, murdered my geallta.

That's the only truth that matters. It has to be.

24

BRENNEN



The tavern patrons are already several rounds of ale deep when I enter, based on their red faces and raucous conversations. Theo nods as I approach the bar, his eyes flicking toward a large man sitting at the end of it. I know what he's saying before he has the chance to speak—not because I can read his mind, but because I noticed the man the second I walked in.

He's drunk. Too loud and slurring his words, and exactly as Theo described. But more than that, there's an aura of danger about him, as if he could switch at any moment from a jolly drunk into a raving lunatic.

I slide up next to him, placing my forearms on the bar. "I think it's time to go," I say.

"Och, piss off," he says. "You're not me mam. Another," he stares me straight in the eyes, slapping his hand on the counter so hard, the mugs sitting on it rattle, and ale sloshes onto the wood. Several patrons glance over, but quickly look away. It seems they know trouble when they see it, too.

My already strained patience thins, and I grit my teeth. This man is no different from the men in that journal. I have no doubt of it. He doesnae care about his actions. Doesnae care how they affect anyone other than him.

"He's finished," I tell Theo, then use my foot to push back his stool. The man nearly falls. "I dinnae think you're understanding me. You're leaving."

He stops, putting his glass down, and turns to face me slowly. “I’ll drink as much as I please. Try to stop me again, and we’ll have a problem.”

I take the glass, moving it out of his reach. “Threaten me again, and you’ll see how big of a problem we can have. I couldnae care less how much you drink, but I do care about keeping people like you out of this village. You’re leaving. And you’re leaving *now*.”

He starts to stand. “Who the fuck do you think you—”

My control snaps, and I pull my dagger out, pressing it against his inner thigh near the groin, right where his blood pulses beneath his skin. One slice, and he’ll bleed out in minutes. Seconds, even. He freezes at the pressure of my blade, and his eyes go dark.

“Who the fuck do you think you are?” he says again, a low hiss, and I allow my dàn of dread to unleash its power.

The bar goes silent, the man’s face draining of color.

“First,” I say, brushing a speck of dust off my pants, “I’m a general of the Cutter. You’d do well to be a bit more respectful. Besides that… Och, well, I’m a man who would never beat my wife. Or any woman, for that matter.”

His face turns red, and he bares his teeth, but his eyes flick to the dàn on my neck. “How dare you?” he hisses. “My *wife* is missing. Probably dead by now. This is how you speak to a grieving man? Threatening me? I came here for help!”

“You came here to find her and drag her back to whatever hell she escaped from to finish what you started,” I say, echoing the Washwoman’s words. I press the dagger harder against his leg, dropping my voice low. “I ken what you did to your wife, and I willnae allow you to harm anyone else. Not here. Now leave. Go far away, and do not look for her again.”

His nostrils flare as he breathes in and out, his hands tensing into fists.

“You cannae keep me from finding *my* wife.”

“Oh, I think I can. There isnae much I can’t do. I’ll ken if you look for her,” I say, leaning forward. “I’ll leave my warning at that.” I pull the knife away, rolling up my sleeves to show him my numerous dàn. Battle skill. Tracking. Precision. “Now go.”

“Foul fucking bastard,” he says, stumbling off the stool. “You’ll regret this.”

I raise an eyebrow, giving him a cold smile. “No. I don’t think I will.” I stand, nearly a head taller than him, and nod toward the door. “Out.”

He storms from the bar, spitting at my feet on his way.

The patrons look down at their drinks as he passes them, and I take a deep breath, shaking off the interaction. I turn back just as Theo places a pint in front of me. “Thanks for that,” he says.

“Aye. How’s Billy and his mum?” I ask, changing the subject and forcing my dàn of dread to sleep once more. Theo visibly relaxes, exhaling.

“Good. Safe, thanks to you.” He gives me a nod, turning to walk away, but I stop him.

“Why is it you don’t fear the Washwoman?” I ask, surprising myself.

“Who says I don’t?” He leans against the wall. I tap my fingers on the bar, raising my eyebrows and waiting for him to answer.

Theo sighs. “What do you know about the Washwoman?” he asks, and I shrug, taking a sip of ale.

“She’s a murderess. Bound to the river and all that.”

“Aye. But I’m not speaking of her tale. I’m talking about *her*. She’s never seemed like a monster to me.”

“And how would you know that?” I ask.

“Because Billy’s not the first child to stumble into that glen.”

I still, tilting my head. “You’ve met her?”

“Aye. I was no older than five. I went to find her, but when I got to the river, I thought I saw a kelpie in the water.” He laughs. “Ma had told me stories of them, and my imagination ran away from me. I was frightened, crying, and she held me until I calmed. She seemed genuinely worried about me being out in the woods alone so young.”

He pauses, meeting my eyes. “I’ve always had a hard time reconciling the woman who soothed me so gently with the one who murdered all of those people.”

“You don’t say.” I sigh, rubbing the back of my neck. “Wait. You touched her. What happened when you touched her?” I ask, looking at the dedication dàn to the Weaver on his arm.

He leans against the bar. “Nothing. Like I said. She held me until I calmed.”

“Are those your only dàn? Your dedication dàn and your naming dàn of empathy?” I ask, and he shakes his head.

“I have another on my shoulder. A travelers’ dàn. I can find my way anywhere you ask with my eyes closed.”

I nod, impressed. Most people are blessed with a single rune, unless they join the Dìdeanair. The Weaver must have seen something special in his thread to gift him more than one.

"And the Washwoman…she didnae take them when she touched you?" I ask.

Theo looks at me as if I suddenly grew a second set of arms. "No. But she asked me not to tell anyone I'd found her. Said she was afraid I'd get in trouble if I told them where I'd been—and she was right. I dinnae think my parents would have let me leave the house until I was twenty if they'd known who I'd snuck off to see."

He leans forward, bracing his forearms on the counter. "You know, I wasnae afraid when I saw her, and I haven't been since. No one died from me seeing her face. Nothing happened at all, actually."

I tuck away his words, more proof that the tale of her legend has been twisted into something it isnae. "Were you here when… Six years ago, when the murders happened. Were you here?"

Theo nods, his eyes flashing with something akin to regret. "Aye. But we didnae know anything had happened until after. Didnae know the Washwoman had been gone at all. To me, it never made sense. For someone to kill so many people, there has to be a wickedness inside them," Theo says, shaking his head. "An evil that cannae be tamed or fixed. I dinnae ken how to reconcile the woman I met with the stories of what she's done. Maybe it's as easy as what the rumors suggest. A century at the river turned her mad. Far less believable things have happened."

I don't say what I'm thinking. That I, like Theo, have yet to see an ounce of evil in the Washwoman. She's hard-headed, for sure. Stubborn as an ox, in fact. But not a single thing she's done has shown she wishes to cause anyone harm.

"Maybe," I say, finishing my ale. I stand to leave, but hesitate.

The Washwoman's hand was cut to the bone when I left. I shouldnae care. I *dinnae* care. But I can't stop picturing the blood seeping from between her fingers, along with the dozens of images that filled my mind as I'd read the journal. A hundred stabs on her body. A slit throat. Burned skin.

My stomach lurches because, even though I shouldn't, it seems I do care about her pain. At least a little. "Mallachd ort," I curse under my breath, placing my palms on the bar. "Do you have any bandages? Or clean cloth? And a bit of willow bark?" I add, unable to stop myself.

“I do,” he says, eyes quickly scanning my body. “Are you hurt? I can send a healer.”

“No,” I say, not offering any more information. Theo doesn’t ask further about who the supplies are for. I think he already knows.

He taps his hand on the bar a few times. “I’ll be right back,” he says.

The half-carved block of wood is heavy in my pocket as I wait for him to return, and my fingers itch to grab it. To take out every bit of my frustration on it, but Theo’s back before I even have the chance.

“Here you are,” he says, setting down a neat stack. Added some yarrow to help with clotting.”

“Thank you,” I say, standing.

“It’s kind of you. To help her.”

His words stop me in my tracks. “She’s a murderer. I dinnae think she’s anything more.” I say, but my dàn of truth flares.

“Didnae say you did.” Theo studies me for a moment. “But it takes integrity to separate justice from cruelty.”

I toss a few coins on the bar. “Aye. But it shouldn’t.”

25

BEA



I don’t see Brennen for hours, and in that time, I let myself pretend he won’t come back at all. That he’s returning to the Cutter to tell her the Washwoman is secure, and his duty here is done. I could return to being alone, unworried about stolen dàn and angry guards. But even as I think about his absence, something deep in my stomach calls me a liar.

My dragon roars, as if she's agreeing.

“You hush, Lolly,” I scold, though she’s right.

Even when he’s angry, which, admittedly, is most of the time, it’s nice not being alone. Having someone other than my dragon to talk to. Someone who, when he wants to at least, talks back, even if most of the time he’s cross with me. So when Brennen’s footsteps return, the flicker of relief I feel doesn’t surprise me.

I turn as Brennen clears his throat and freeze.

He looks wrong. His tired eyes are bloodshot, but it doesn’t seem to be from exhaustion. Not when his teeth are clenched so tight, the muscles in his jaw are jumping.

But it’s not just his expression that catches my attention. It’s the way he looks at me, eyes scanning my body, fingers flexing at his side. He looks bigger in this moment, somehow. Stronger. His shoulders are stiff beneath his tunic, the muscles in his arms bunching as if he’s holding himself back from something, though I can’t place what.

“Are you alright?” The question slips out before I can stop it, and I almost wish I hadn't asked. Based on the haunted look in his eyes, I’m not sure I want to know.

“I’m fine.” He looks away, and something tugs in my chest. An urge to go to him. To demand he tell me what’s wrong.

He sits down, farther away than usual, like he can’t stomach the thought of being within a dragon’s length of me. It’s painful, the distance, though I don’t know why. A stitch in my side, sudden and sharp.

Had he not believed me about helping Kenna? I’d been certain he did, even if he was too stubborn or proud to admit it. I’d thought, when he’d left for town, a sort of understanding had grown between us. He’d been annoyed, as usual, and I’d been angry. Sure, we’d just fought, but the argument felt at least somewhat resolved. I thought he knew I’d helped her, even if I wouldn’t tell him where she was, and that he didn’t need to fear me hurting him or anyone else.

But now he can hardly look at me.

Is it something else? Could he have found out about the spell? That I’ve been trying to sneak through his belongings to see if he has any of the things I need to complete it?

No. That can’t be it, either. I’ve never spoken aloud of the items I need. Never asked anyone who has visited to locate them for me, worried that if I didn’t suffer to find them myself, the *After* wouldn’t accept them. That if it was easy, there would be no penance.

“What happened while you were gone?” I ask, unable to bear speculating any further.

He doesn’t look at me, instead pulling out his wood carving. “Nothing of importance.” His voice is tight.

I hug my arms around my waist, trying to still the nerves fluttering there. “Someone told you something about me. Didn’t they?”

His eyes snap to mine, and I see it there. The change. There’s the usual anger in them still, but beneath it, there’s…pity.

I hate it even more than the anger. “What did they say?”

He shakes his head, violently slicing away a chunk of wood. “It doesnae matter.”

“It does,” I say, my voice firm. “If someone is telling you falsehoods about me—”

He holds up his hands, shaking his head. “It’s nothing like that.”

I exhale. “Then what is it?”

He continues carving, the edge of a wing taking shape.

“I need you to tell me the truth,” he finally says. “Did you take my dàn on purpose? And have you ever done it before?” He looks up at me, and the intensity in his expression takes my breath away. The question catches me off guard. I thought we’d moved past this, too. Established that I didn’t care about the dàn, and that he could try to take it back if he wanted. So what’s changed since he left that he no longer believes me?

“I cannot keep having this conversation. No, Brennen. I didn’t take your dàn on purpose. I don’t know how it happened, and it’s never happened other than when you touched me.” I hold his gaze, willing him to believe me this time.

He takes a moment before responding, chewing on my answer. “Do you have any other magic I dinnae ken of?”

Shock ripples through me. I’d expected him to call me a liar. To insist on it, even. But his response is more tentative, like maybe he *does* believe me and is only being thorough in his questioning.

Hope bubbles in my chest. His presence would be so much more pleasant if he didn’t view everything I said through a haze of distrust.

“No,” I say. He looks at me with continued doubt, and I pick up a stick and draw the first few lines of the dàn in my mind, trying to think of how I can convince him. “We’ve already established you have a dàn of truth, have we not?” I ask. Going for reason seems like a smart move with this man.

“Aye. But if you can take dàn, how am I to know you can’t do other things to them? What if you can overpower their magic somehow?”

I sigh, rubbing my forehead. It’s a valid question, but he’s thinking about it too hard, and though I think he wants to believe me, his Dìdeanair mind will not allow it.

“Think of it logically. If I chose to steal your dàn, I wouldn’t have taken the one for balance, would I?”

He tilts his head. “Why not? Seems a good one to take, seeing as I was stopping you from slipping on the rocks and cracking open your skull.”

I wave him off, rolling my eyes. “Och. I’ve navigated these slippery rocks for years. I never fall. I only slipped because I was in pain, and pain is fleeting. I don’t *need* a balance rune.” I pause, an idea forming. Maybe the way to build his trust is through honesty. Brutal, unfiltered truth. I square

my shoulders. “I would’ve taken that one,” I say, pointing my stick at the dàn peeking out from his tunic on his shoulder.

His hand goes up to touch the dàn. “Warmth?” he asks.

My gaze lingers a beat too long on the line of his throat. The broad plane of his chest beneath the symbol.

“Umm— Aye,” I stutter, peeling my eyes away to focus on my drawing. “That one, I would take on purpose. See, hunger you get used to. But cold —especially when winter comes in earnest…” I shiver.

He leans back and crosses his arms, and the dàn of healing on his forearm flashes. “Hmm. Might’ve taken that one, actually,” I say, tapping my chin.

“Why? You already can’t die,” he says, a flash of pity flickering in his eyes.

“That’s not a rune for immortality, is it? I already have that one.” I point to the center of my chest.

His eyes flash, but not with surprise like I expected. It’s recognition I see in them. Somehow, he knows about my dàn. I pull down the top of my shift to where the dàn sits between my breasts, careful to only show him the swirling silver marks.

He looks for a moment too long, almost as if searching every bit of skin surrounding it, and my body prickles with awareness. Fighting the urge to cover myself from the intensity of his gaze, I allow him to examine the dàn.

“Is that what you learned, then? That I truly cannot die?” I ask. His jaw ticks, all but confirming it. Is that what I’m sensing from him now? Despair that he *actually* cannot kill me? That he will fail in his duty? It doesn’t feel like it, but what else could be causing his strange reaction?

“Who gave you that dàn?” he asks, surprising me.

I pull my dress back up, confused why he cares. “I don’t know. One of the Fates, surely.”

“How can you not know?” he asks, his eyebrows furrowing. “It’s painful when dàn appear. Enough that I remember every single one.”

I try to think, but a stab of pain shoots through my head. “I can’t remember. It was here when I woke up, cursed to the river.”

“Who told you of your sentencing?” he asks, leaning forward.

Another stab of pain shoots through my head, sharper this time, and my vision goes fuzzy. “I don’t remember that either,” I say, wincing.

He climbs to his feet. “But how can you not know? Why are you chained to this river?”

“Because I’ve committed crimes against the Fates. You know this. Why make me say it again and again? I woke up here, dàn between my breasts and a letter tucked into my apron.”

He pauses. “A letter? What did it say?”

I shake my head, closing my eyes and rubbing my fingers where the pain pounds in my forehead. It grows sharper by the second, screams ringing in my ears.

“Dinnae make me—”

“Nothing you don’t already know! It said I was to be sentenced to the river. Cursed to wash the death-clothes,” I say, leaving out the part about the spell.

He stops. “You mean the Fates never came here?”

I shake my head, closing my eyes. Nausea roils in my stomach, the pain spreading to the back of my skull. “I have never seen the Fates. Not once in my entire life.”

He pauses. “You’ve— Never?” The surprise in his voice is unmistakable.

“Never. Not that I remember, at least.”

He doesn’t answer, and in the long silence, the pain begins to fade. My shoulders lower, and I take a deep breath. When I finally open my eyes again, Brennen is staring at the center of my chest.

“I was told,” he hesitates, rubbing the back of his neck. “I was told that, many years ago, the village was… unkind to you. That they tried to carve the dàn from your flesh.”

The memory hits me with staggering force, and my hand comes up to rest on my sternum, an echo of that long-ago pain scraping along my bones.

“They did,” my voice comes out hoarse.

“Yet you have no scars.”

I shake my head. “My body has not changed since the day I was first sentenced here. Well…except for the bloodstains. That’s happened over the years. Part of the curse.” I look down at my hands, picturing the sloping lines of the letter I found when I woke up here. *You will cleanse the death-clothes of the departed for eternity, the blood of each and every soul passing through your fingers, staining your hands forever.*

At first, it had been a dull red, growing a bit more visible each day as I washed. It wasn't until that night six years ago, when hot, thick blood soaked my hands and dripped down my forearms, that the stains had become so deep. My stomach twists, and I push the image away, shaking my head. "Any scars that mark my skin are from before."

He seems to weigh my answer, his eyes trailing along my body as he sits back down. The heat of his gaze brings blood to my cheeks, and I look away, grabbing a handful of small stones from around me and stacking them into a cairn. In my periphery, I see his hands clench into fists, but he stays silent, so long I cannot take it anymore.

"Most people aren't trying to kill me when they come here, you know. They just want to hurt me. Make me pay for washing their loved ones' clothing. They think I'm a liar. A murderess and a liar."

Brennen's gaze lifts. "And are you?"

My throat tightens. "You know the answer to that," I say. "As we've established, you have a dàn of truth." I gesture to his wrist.

He nods, but pauses, his eyes narrowing. "How did you recognize the dàn of truth? It's not one gifted by the Fates often."

"No, but I studied dàn, once upon a time. A book came down in a kilt pocket, and I read it until the pages crumbled to dust. And you're not the first Dìdeanair to visit me. Their loved ones are no safer from the Cutter than a lonely farmer's. I think most men with dàn of truth are drawn to military service."

He looks surprised, but people do irrational things when they're desperate—even soldiers.

He shakes his head. "That's against our code. Dìdeanair dinnae harm people for no reason."

I laugh, an ugly, bitter sound. It's unexpected, the anger his words stoke inside me, but it's justified. How is this grown, adult man so naive? A man who has seen battle. Death. And yet, he does not see the shades of grey that exist in the world.

"Is that why you're bothered by the things the villagers did to me? Because you're not supposed to harm people without orders? You don't know the half of it, and it seems you're the only one who lives by that code. Tell me, aside from saying I hadn't seen the woman who disappeared, have I lied to you since you've been here?" I ask calmly, trying to force him to follow my breadcrumbs of reason.

“No,” he says, but the word is tight, as if it pains him to say it.

“So to answer your question,” I say, “I may be a murderer, but a liar, I am not.” I cross my arms and take a deep breath. “My offer stands. You can touch the dàn if you’d like. See if it will transfer back to you. But I don’t know what will happen—and that’s the truth.”

I hold his stare, daring him to challenge me.

“Alright then,” he says, picking up a new block of wood and beginning to carve.

I lean back, stunned. Does he actually believe me? Is he truly letting this go?

I look back to my hem, my anger fading. “Alright then.”

A heavy quiet descends upon us, and while it’s a bit uncomfortable, I don’t feel the need to fill it this time. It’s almost like we’ve made some progress toward understanding one another. Not toward fixing anything, or him hating me any less, but at least now we’ve spoken our minds.

“I went to find him,” he says, breaking the silence. “The husband of the woman.”

My fingers still on my skirt. “He’s still here?” I ask, my heart rate picking up. The longer that man stays, the more likely it is he’ll figure out the rule he missed—that he did not catch me—and if he does… I don’t even want to think about it.

“I believe you,” he says. “About Hamish. He isnae a good man, and I willnae allow him to hurt anyone else.” His eyes darken, his throat working as he swallows. “You dinnae need to worry about him,” he says. “I took care of it. He’s on his way out of the village as we speak, and he willnae be returning.”

I almost shudder with relief. “Thank you,” I say, and it’s genuine. Brennen may want to kill me, but I deserve it. The woman I saved did not.

“Bea?”

I freeze at his use of my name. Not Washwoman or murderess.

Bea.

Tears sting my eyes, but I do not allow them to form, worried they’ll scare him into pulling back again. When I look up, my own emotions hidden, his hard exterior has softened slightly, and where his eyes once held only anger, I see true sorrow.

“Yes?”

“Why did you do it?” His voice is quiet this time. “Why did you kill all those people?” he asks again, and my heart aches, because I feel like I finally *see* him. Finally know why he asks so often. Why he needs the knowledge so fervently.

This man believes there is right and there is wrong. That there’s no in-between, and if he’s going to kill me, he needs to know I’m a monster who deserves it.

And yet, I cannot tell him that.

I meet his gaze as the echo of screams grows in my ears, but even so, I try to find the words to make him understand. Like always, I can’t.

“I wish I hadn’t,” I whisper. The screams grow louder, and I wince.

“That’s not an answer.”

I pick up a stick to draw in the mud, then throw it down and grab a handful of rocks, building a cairn. “Does it even matter? I can’t take it back.” I finish the stack, then knock the cairn over and begin again. Then again, the repetitive motion taking the edge off the chaos in my mind. I'm almost pleading, but I need this conversation to end before the screams make me ill. Before I feel their blood between my fingers. Before it runs from my nose.

He shakes his head, his eyes flashing with sadness. But I’m not sure if it’s because of my answer, or lack of one.

“I’m sorry,” I say, covering my ears. “I’m sorry.” My voice cracks.

He doesn’t respond, and in the tense silence, the screams fade away. I uncover my ears. The sound of his heavy breathing is the only noise in the glen, as if his presence made the birds and fish scatter. Even the river seems to be holding its breath.

I look up at the sky as the screams fade, searching for Lolly.

He stands abruptly, and for a moment, I think he’s going to leave.

Instead, he grabs the satchel and holds it out to me, careful not to touch my skin. His movements are sharp. Almost rehearsed.

“For your hand.” He looks at my scabbed palm, his voice rough. “That much bleeding—” He clears his throat. “I dinnae want the wolves to smell it. You might not be able to die, but I can.”

Shock ripples through my chest. Even if it really is only for his sake, which I don’t believe it is—Brennen could take down a whole pack of wolves without breaking a sweat—it’s a kindness. He’s seeing me as a human, and the dignity that gives me is a balm itself.

I reach for the bag, my fingers stopping just short of his, close enough to feel his heat in the space between us. “Thank you,” I say.

He doesn’t acknowledge me, instead turning and stalking toward the trees as if to gather firewood, his shoulders tight with tension.

I open the satchel, and my heart stalls. There are bandages, clean and white, as well as yarrow to cause clotting. It will speed up my healing considerably.

But that’s not what causes my breaths to turn shallow and my heart to flutter.

It’s the willow bark.

A lump forms in my throat.

Brennen said he’d brought me these things to stop the bleeding. To keep the wolves at bay. But willow bark does not deter wolves, and pain is not what draws them to feed.

So why is it, then, that he brought it to me?

BRENNEN



Tension creeps into my shoulders as I lift the cover of Harold's journal. A volume that shouldn't exist, and not only because it's illegal. It's a crime punishable by death, and even though it could contain information that could help, I can't shake the feeling that I should throw it in the fire, as well as turn Harold in for hiding it.

And yet, even though that's what duty is calling me to do, I don't.

Harold is a good man. And it's clear, based on the aged parchment and fading ink along with the multiple different styles of handwriting, that the book really has been passed down through generations.

If these were Marsaili's words, written by her own hand, I would do everything I could to hold onto them, too.

I flip the page to where the list of spells begins. Simple runes I haven't seen before, with instructions on how to use them.

For a good turnip harvest: Coat the end of a rowan branch in honey, and carve three spirals into the dirt, moving counterclockwise.

To cure a fever: Steep nettles in hot water beneath the moon until the water turns cold. With a healthy hand, use the tea to draw a circle on each temple and the center of the forehead.

My shoulders relax as I turn the pages, carefully reading each one. If nothing else, I can feel relief that the magic inside the book, if it even works, is harmless. To relieve hunger. For fair weather. Harold hadn't lied when he said the spells were only to help them survive. There's nothing in here that even hints at taking power or harming others.

It's still illegal, but these spells will not help a rebellion form. They do not reveal ways to gain *real* magic.

I flip the page.

The Epoch is approaching, but with magic becoming scarce, I'm not sure how we will survive it. It's foretold this one will be worse than the last, and if so, how will we bear it? My grandfather told me stories of the monster who hunted him last time, and it still haunts my nightmares—its gaping, bloody maw and bright yellow eyes imprinted on my mind forever.

It is cruelty in its most evil form—to take our magic and leave us to fend for ourselves against the creatures that will come. For how can you leave your kingdom so defenseless?

"What is this man talking about?" I mutter under my breath. The words are senseless. Take our magic? The Fates are the ones who *give* us our

magic. Is it just the ramblings of a madman? Perhaps someone sick in the mind, hallucinating or fabricating memories?

I start the passage over and am looking for hints of sanity in the words when the valley goes unnaturally still, only for a moment, before the wind picks up and the river changes. I jump to my feet, the change so abrupt, I'm afraid it is about to flood the valley.

The blue dragon roars overhead as the water turns a ruddy brown, swirling and thrashing, the current so unnatural, I'm certain nature alone couldn't have created it.

Whatever this is, it's caused by magic.

I turn to the Washwoman. "What's happening?" I ask, but she doesn't seem to hear me. Her eyes are wide, and in them, there's fear—sharp, genuine fear—but what I don't see is surprise. She drops to her knees, her movements unnatural and stiff as if she's straining against her movements, and places her hands in the water. Running to kneel in front of her, I reach out to grab her face to force her to look at me, but stop just shy of touching her skin.

I cannae risk it.

"Washwoman," I say, crouching down, but she doesn't see me. Her eyes have gone glassy. "Bea!"

Her lips open, but she doesn't speak. Instead, a melody floats from her mouth. It's different from the song she sings while washing. This sounds like a pub song, but there's no joy in it. She rocks, her eyes rolling back in her head.

There's friendship in bushels and tales long been said.
Let's trade our stories before we fall dead.
Can happen in moments, the blink of an eye.
The river will find you when it's time to die.

A song cannae tell you the time it will end.
As long as you live, a new one can begin.
We knew you were coming. We've waited all night.
Held off on the last verse until you arrived.

I grab her arms and shake her, making sure to only touch where clothes cover her skin. Heat flares in my palm, but I hardly register it as, in my periphery, I notice something floating from upstream—red fabric that slowly drifts toward Bea.

Her eyes remain glassy, a single tear slowly rolling down her flushed, freckled cheek.

“Bea?”

She sucks in a sudden breath, blinking rapidly as her eyes come back into focus.

“What happened?” I ask.

Her eyes slide straight past me to the dress, and she’s so focused on it, it’s almost as if she doesn’t know I’m there. Her hands tremble. “Please,” she whispers. “Make her stop this.”

I shake my head, confused. “Stop what?”

With a snap, her back bends, almost as if shoved forward by invisible hands, and she cries out in pain. Her breaths grow rapid as she washes the dress, her face creased with despair when she lets it go.

“What was that?” I ask, my heart rate picking up. I look around, searching for anything that could have caused her to behave so strangely, but nothing else is amiss. I shift back a fraction, checking my dàn of warning. It remains silent, but it doesnae do much to settle me. What I just witnessed was unnatural.

Was it the monster inside her trying to break free? The thought has my hand drifting toward my dagger.

She curls her legs beneath her, shoulders hunched. She looks defeated—more so than I’ve ever seen her, even after being attacked by Billy.

“Tell the Cutter to make it stop. I can’t take it anymore. My curse was bad enough. I’ve done nothing to deserve it changing now.”

My confusion only grows. “Changing what? What are you talking about?”

Bea meets my eyes, something akin to betrayal in them. “Don’t pretend as if you don’t know. You’re her right hand, are you not?”

The words sound like an insult more than an honor. “I’m her loyal soldier. Nothing more.”

She scoffs, but I don’t let it bother me. Something is wrong with her. Sweat beads her brow, and her skin is ashen.

“Cailleach tells me only what I need to know for my mission. If your punishment has changed, I wasnae made aware of it,” I continue.

She doesn't answer, but it's clear based on the hurt in her eyes and the angry set of her jaw that she doesn't believe me.

“What’s changed?” I probe.

Bea sniffles, looking toward the *After*, and I follow her gaze. “The Cutter used to only show me deaths. But now she’s showing me people’s lives. Forcing me to watch their joy before they—” Her voice falters. “I feel like I’m going mad. I’m used to seeing death. It has become my entire life, but this? Making me watch their final moments of happiness—mothers kissing their children, lovers embracing—only to wash their clothes moments later? It’s *torture*.”

Her voice cracks, genuine pain etched into every syllable.

On instinct, I reach out to comfort her, but she scrambles back.

“Don’t touch me,” she says, holding her stained hands in front of her. “The dàn. I don’t know if… Just, don’t.”

“Okay, I willnae touch you,” I say, my mind spinning. Is this the proof I’ve been searching for that she doesn’t want to take my magic? That even as she sits here unable to contain her fear, she had the forethought to stop me?

She relaxes slightly, lowering her hands. “Will you ask her to stop? Please? She must respect you, to make you An Àrd.” The request causes my chest to tighten. She hasn’t asked anything of me since I’ve been here. Not for a morsel of food or a warm blanket. A fire or torch. She’s too proud, I think, but here she is, practically begging me to stop whatever just happened.

“I don’t want to see their lives anymore.” She starts to rock, her eyes haunted.

“Make her stop,” she says, struggling to breathe. Panic overtakes her, and my body moves before I think. I step forward, reaching out a hand to help her—and I hate myself for it.

This is not where my loyalties lie.

“Breathe, lass. I dinnae think the Cutter is trying to torture you,” I say, grabbing her arm over her sleeve. “There’d be no reason for her to change the curse.” Not when she’s too busy trying to figure out how to kill her. Not when the terms of her punishment were settled over a century ago.

“Of course she is! Can’t you see? That’s why she sent *you*! Nothing will ever be enough to satisfy that woman. She wants me to suffer? *You* want me to suffer? Well congratulations. I’m suffering. I’ve *been* fucking suffering!”

Her words churn in my stomach. Have I not proved I am an honorable man? That my intent is not to cause her pain or harm, but to enact swift, warranted justice?

“I dinnae want you to suffer,” I say, like it’s nothing, keeping all emotion from my tone, but it feels vulnerable. Like an admission I shouldn’t be voicing aloud.

She looks up, dark clouds reflecting in her tear-filled eyes. The wind gusts, and thunder cracks in the distance. A storm is coming.

“If that’s the truth,” she looks up, meeting my gaze and taking a steadying breath, “then make her stop. That, or do your damned job, and find out how to kill me.”

27

BEA



Thunder cracks again, closer this time, as I stare out at the Bàsail, the rain beating down on me sharp and cold as shards of ice. The wind blows my hair wildly, and my clothes are soggy and stuck to my skin.

Though, the weather is fitting for my mood.

Find out how to kill me, I'd told him. The shock on his face would have been comical, had I not been in the midst of my panic. I'd surprised myself, saying the words aloud, but witnessing that mother kissing her bairn… Knowing one of them would die.

It had nearly broken me.

Once again, the final two items of the spell pop into my mind. I could tell him about it right now. Have him retrieve them for me, and try to send them down the *After*. Except, I feel more certain than ever that, if the *After* is to accept me, it must be my hands that find the items.

Because what of my penance? Or is that not the problem at all?

Could it be that maybe now that death is a real possibility, I'm no longer so sure I want it.

I close my eyes, prodding the thought. Do I still want to rest?

Yes, I decide. I do. But I wish to go to my rest on my terms, the spell completed by my own hands and with a changed heart. It is the only chance for Am Breitheamh to judge me well. Every decision in the past century has been taken from me.

I will not allow my final choice to be taken from me, too.

The river laps at my toes, rising higher by the hour.

At least I am not alone out here. My dragon rests on the ridge again, her new perch. She's seemingly unbothered by the rain, though I cannot say the same. It's been a long time since I've seen a downpour like this, and I curl in on myself, shivers wracking my body. What I would give to have a longer chain. To be able to reach the trees or curl inside the hollow log. Anything to give me respite.

The river finds my hem, too fast, and I shift again, scooting back a few hand-lengths, my waterlogged dress heavy and hard to move.

Brennen has disappeared inside his tent, dry and warm, and I envy him for it. He'd been smart to set it up not only out of my reach, but on high ground. He can ride out the storm in peace, safe from both me and the elements.

Though, I do not think Brennen fears me hurting him anymore. The look on his face when I'd told him to kill me had been a mix of shock and frustration, though I'm not sure what had unsettled him more—the desperation in my voice, or the truth lacing every word.

I close my eyes against a gust of wind, and something heavy lands on my shoulders.

I stiffen, my hands coming up to find a wool blanket, thick and sturdy. I suck in a sharp breath of surprise. Not just that he brought me the blanket, but that he left his dry tent to bring it to me.

I turn to look at him standing over me. His muscular chest rises and falls with heavy breaths, and his jaw is tight. He's soaked through now, hair hanging in his eyes and his tunic clinging to his body, emphasizing his corded arms and broad chest.

My fingers tighten on the blanket.

"It's not much," Brennen says, his voice rough, hard to hear through the patter of rain. "But I dinnae have anything else to offer."

"It's plenty," I whisper, lifting the blanket, my cold fingers fumbling as I wrap it around me, pulling it up to cover my head. The heavy weight settles over my body, protecting me. At least for now.

It will get soaked, too, if this rain continues much longer, but it's *something*. If not shelter, then kindness. A gesture I haven't experienced in the longest time, and it means more to me than he could possibly know.

“Thank you,” I say, though I’m not sure if he can understand me through the tightness in my throat and my chattering teeth.

“It should end soon,” he says, walking back toward his tent stiffly, but really, he doesn’t know that. It could last days, and the thick blanket will give me relief for an hour at most.

I will gladly take that hour, and the warmth bubbling inside me brought on by his thoughtfulness will last far longer than that.

The sound of rushing water fills the glen, sudden and unexpected, and I turn toward the noise, scrambling back as a surge of water appears from upstream.

“Washwoman!” Brennen shouts. “Bea! Move!” But it's too late. Within seconds, the valley is flooded. Muddy water surges around me and drags me under.

I don’t have time to take a last breath as my head is pulled under, the current carrying me swiftly toward the *After*. I open my eyes to search for the surface, but the water is brown, full of mud and debris.

My chain snaps tight, and the pain is blinding. I scream as absolute agony rips through my ankle, bubbles pouring from my mouth as I sob. My body forces me to breathe. Freezing water fills my lungs, sharp and wrong.

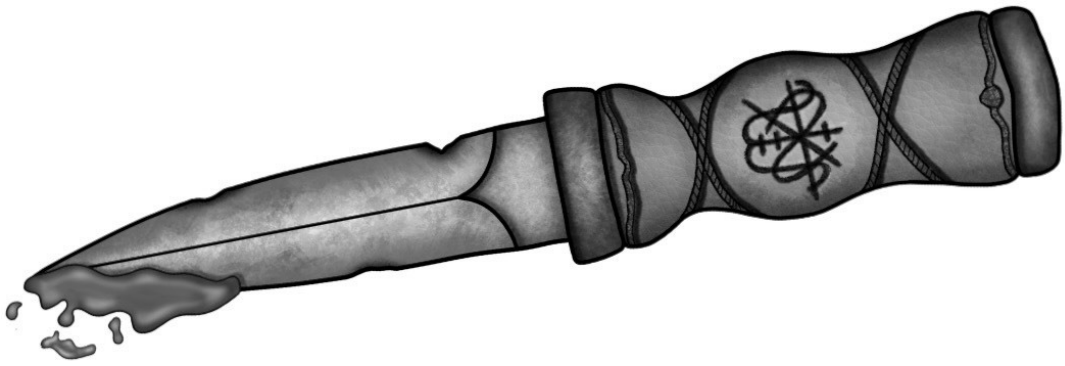
Memories of drowning fill my mind, and I fight harder. Through my panic, I hope Brennen ran. That he’s high up on the ridge with Lolly, safe.

Trying to push upward, I kick, but my limbs grow cold and my vision tunnels. It is excruciating, the pain surging through my entire being, my lungs desperate for oxygen, pinpricks of torment spreading through my blood until finally, my body gives in, and the world goes dark.

Once again, I am no match for the river.

28

BRENNEN



I dinnae think of Marsaili.

I dinnae think of my family.

I dinnae think at all.

I dive.

Before I can form a single thought, I'm fighting against the surge like there was never another option. My dàn ignite on their own. Courage first, burning along my spine, then endurance. Speed. Strength.

I fight against the current until I reach the stone Bea's chain is embedded in. Rising to the surface, I take a deep breath and dive back down, following the chain until my lungs burn. I have to come up for air, but hold tight to the metal, refusing to let go. My grip slips, and for a heartbeat, I lose the chain. Terror claws its way up my throat as I dive toward it, my arms flailing around wildly until I find the metal links again. The weight of it pulls at me, and water fills my mouth as I struggle against the muddy surge, my lungs seizing from the cold.

My rational mind tells me to go back, that Bea cannot die and *I* can, but my body refuses to listen, fighting and pulling until finally, my fingers brush skin. Relief slams into me, more violent than the current dragging me under. Gritting my teeth, I wrap my arms around Bea and pull her to the surface. She's limp in my arms—dead weight. If not for my dàn of strength and endurance, I'm certain I would fail in making it back to shore.

I'm coughing up water by the time we make it to dry land, Bea’s chain barely long enough to reach outside the flooded valley, and I wonder how many times this has happened before. I lay her down, searching for signs of life. Her face is pale as un-dyed cotton, her lips blue. Her chest does not rise and fall with breaths.

Unwanted panic rises in my chest. This should feel like a victory. It is, after all, what I came here for. But it doesnae.

It feels *wrong*.

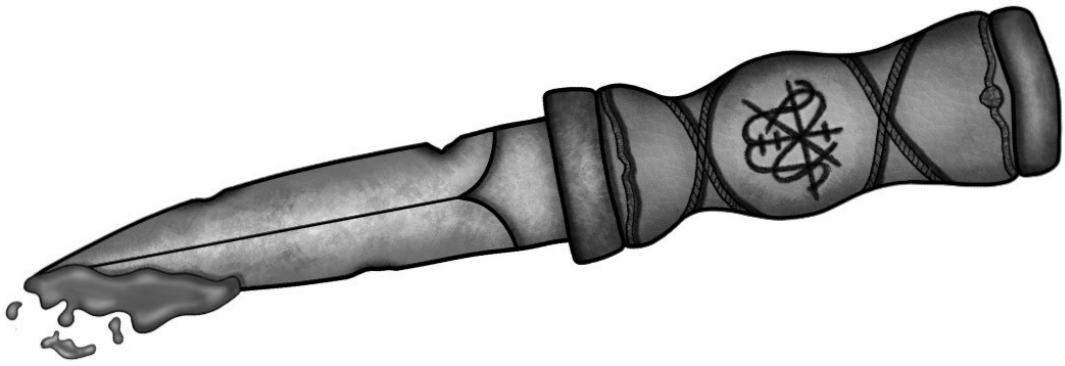
“Washwoman,” I say, shaking her. “Bea!” She doesn't answer, and I press two fingers against the side of her neck, feeling for a heartbeat, but there is none.

It isn’t possible. The Washwoman cannae be killed.

And yet, she is dead.

29

BRENNEN



I wait for relief. For the knot in my throat to loosen and the storm inside me to settle.

It doesnae come.

But before I can process any of it, the Washwoman stutters, water bubbling from her mouth. Her eyes open unnaturally wide as she rolls to her side and retches, violent heaves of muddy river water pouring from her mouth, just like Harold's granda described it in the journal.

It's then that relief crashes over me. The self-loathing that follows directly behind it is immediate and so intense, I nearly vomit. My palm burns, white-hot, and guilt eats away at my insides like I swallowed acid. The last thing I should feel is relief when the oath sworn in my blood hasnae been completed.

I look away, unable to bear the way her ashen skin and bloodshot eyes make my heart stutter. The need to check her for injuries overwhelms me, and my gaze trails along her exposed skin, searching for blood or bruises. She seems uninjured, and I relax a fraction—until I see it.

My stomach drops. There, located on Bea's leg, is my dàn of memory.

"Bloody hell," I say, standing up to look at my arms. "Mallachd ort!" My dàn for truth is gone, too.

A flash of fury works its way through me, but this time it's not aimed at Bea. She'd been unconscious, drowning in the river. It's impossible she did this intentionally.

It’s myself I’m angry with.

Not even angry. I’m *enraged*.

Because this wasn’t deceit or treason on Bea’s behalf. It was *my* mistake. One that caused me to lose one of the most important dàn I possessed.

“What happened?” she croaks as her vomiting ceases, rolling to her back and squinting against the fat raindrops landing on her face. Her breaths are still shallow, but some color has returned to her face, though she continues to shiver, and bubbles of froth cling to her lips.

“The glen flooded. It swept you out.” She looks at me blankly, as if she doesnae understand. “You drowned…” I say, gesturing to the river.

“Drowned… The water—”

Her eyes go wide, and she stands abruptly, scrambling back into the water, hands plunged in the river.

“What are you doing?” I shout, but she continues forward, two steps, three, then stills.

A sob bursts from her throat, and she collapses, the water coming up to just below her breasts.

“Thank the goddess,” she whispers under her breath. “Thank you. Thank you.”

Shock ripples through me, followed by disbelief. “You're thanking the goddess for drowning you?”

“I’m not thanking her for drowning me. I’m thanking her for saving my bed. It’s all I have. The only thing that’s mine,.”

“Are you daft?” I ask. “Get out of the water, Bea.”

“I won’t let it wash away. I’ll be fine here,” she says, pulling her knees to her chest.

I shake my head, taking a single step forward. “Come back to dry land before you’re pulled out again,” I order, eyes scanning the water. It’s calmed significantly, but it’s still much higher than usual, and muddy from the flood.

Her teeth begin to chatter, and she winces, her hand flying to her shoulder.

I freeze, the realization of what touching her cost me washing through me all at once. A hint of black peeks out from the neckline of her dress. It wasn’t just my dàn of memory and truth she took, but warmth.

Her shivers ease in seconds, and her breath catches, her eyes filling with wonder. “What’s happening? Why am I….” She looks up, her eyes going wide. “Why am I warm?”

I touch my shoulder where my dàn for warmth sat only minutes ago. Already, the chill is pushing through my wet clothes, goosebumps rising along my arms. “I touched your skin when I pulled you out.” My self-hatred grows.

“You…pulled me out? You dove in after me?” she asks. I dinnae answer, and the silence sits heavy between us. “Thank you,” she whispers, her fingers never leaving the dàn on her shoulder, and I know why. She's feeling heat beneath those fingertips for the first time in a century.

A fraction of my fury eases at the awe on her face, but shame instantly replaces it. I shouldnae care if she is warm. Shouldnae care that she is experiencing a rare moment of relief from her torment.

“If the river comes again,” I say, lowering my voice. “I willnae save you.” It comes out as a threat, but that’s not what it is. It’s a promise to myself, but the words leave a bitter taste in my mouth.

She nods.

“I understand,” she says with a small smile. She pulls her knees to her chest and looks up at the sky, rain glistening on her freckled skin.

I want to ask if she's going mad. If the lack of oxygen damaged her brain, because I dinnae understand why she would risk the pain of drowning for a stone pillow and the thread she hides beneath it. I curse under my breath, rubbing my arms, suddenly freezing.

“You've been warned,” I say, disappearing into my tent. I strip off my wet clothes, changing into something dry and rushing to crawl beneath the blankets. I close my eyes and try to sleep, but her face flashes in my mind. Grey skin and blue lips.

It should be a comforting sight, but it makes me feel ill.

Wind blows through the tent, and I shiver. It took me *years* to earn those dàn. Anger once again works its way through my blood, but it doesnae warm me, nor does it burn away the nausea churning in my gut.

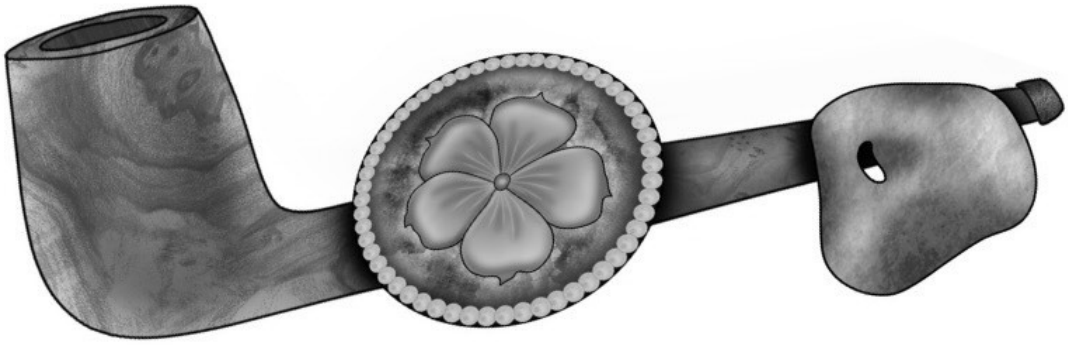
I’m wholly unused to feeling so off-kilter, and I cannae stand it. My teeth begin to chatter, and I grab several more blankets. The ones Soairse insisted I pack. I picture my littlest sister rolling them up with care, worried I would be cold. I’d told her it was a waste of space, but she’d stuffed them into a sack with her little hands anyway. “Don’t you want to be cozy?”

she’d asked. I hadn’t been able to argue with that, and now, I’m grateful to her.

It’s going to be a verra cold night.

30

BEA



Jlean back, the water now receding, and rest my cheek on the muddy riverbank. It's too dark to check on the items beneath my pillow. The moon is blocked by thick, dark clouds. Instead, I trace my fingers along the patch of skin where the dàn for warmth now sits, tingling with heat. It's a contentment I'm unfamiliar with, and it settles over me like a heavy cloak. I forget that I'm wet, forget the pain in my ankle, and close my eyes, fatigue pulling at my body.

But along with that pleasant warmth, there's a horrible guilt incessantly gnawing in my belly. I have no right to enjoy the lack of chill. Not when Brennen risked so much to pull me out. Once again, I stole from him, even if it wasn't intentional. Is he freezing in the tent? He must be, seeing as he's so unused to the cold.

With a sigh, I shove the guilt as deep down as possible. I cannot change that I now have his dàn any more than I can change the rest of my past, and suffering over misplaced shame will get me nowhere.

I close my eyes, and am only barely asleep when the prickling of hair rising along my arms wakes me. There's a groan. A shudder from the *After*. It vibrates through the ground, traveling through my body until I'm not sure if it is the earth trembling, or me. I pull myself to sit, leaning forward to peer into the black mist.

The groan settles, but the eerie feeling doesn't dissipate. The *After* pulses, twisting as if unsettled, it's long black tendrils reaching out further

than normal. The mist thins as it stretches, and something appears. A shape, tall and thin.

Even the dàn of warmth can’t stop my blood from running cold.

In the *After*, a figure stands stone-still, watching me. Their gaze needles into my skin, pointed and intentional.

Is it An Glèidheadair come to take me? To allow me passage through his gates? Or has the goddess of love and madness returned with stolen songs and nonsensical warnings?

I glance toward Brennen’s tent, wishing he would appear. Did he not hear the groan or feel the realm tremble? I could scream for him, but what would the figure do?

When I look back, scraping my insides for the courage to demand it reveal itself, the figure is gone.

I blink, rubbing my eyes and squinting into the darkness, but all is as it should be. I am very much alone. There is no person standing in the mist. No pulsing, writhing shadows.

I lie back down, still watching the *After*. Was it just my imagination getting away from me? It wouldn’t be the first time I thought someone was approaching only for a rabbit or fox to scramble from the trees.

With a shake of my head, I try to clear the image from my mind, scrub the feeling of being watched from my skin, but sleep refuses to find me. My body is too alert, waiting for any indication that something is wrong.

I stare into the night, searching for shapes until the first hints of light peek over the ridge. It’s not until the sky turns a soft, soothing pink that I’m able to relax. In the light of day, I feel foolish. Not once in a century have I seen someone in the *After*, nor do I think a human could survive touching the black mist. I’m just tired from the flood. From drowning, and I haven’t eaten enough. Not to mention, I’ve been on edge since Brennen arrived. That’s why I’m seeing things. Nothing more.

It’s easy to find monsters in the dark when you are one yourself.

I peek over my shoulder. Brennen hasn't emerged from his tent since he went inside last night to escape the storm, but I can feel his frustration pulsing from behind the canvas. The rain only stopped an hour ago. And while he’s probably dry, and I’m still drenched, I’m likely the only one of us who is not cold.

I stretch out my arms as dawn continues to fill the glen, and with just enough light to see, I finally move from my stone pillow. Brennen must've

thought me mad for remaining in the water, but the relief I felt when I'd found the rock still in place had been the sweetest thing I'd experienced in a long while.

I would rather drown a hundred times than lose the pieces of my spell. Even if I'm not sure how or when I will use them, I have spent so long gathering each item, and the thought of beginning again is unfathomable. I move the stone out of the way, digging down into the dirt, my relief only growing when I find my belongings exactly where they should be. A reed pipe, a mourning brooch, and an adder stone. Wet and caked with mud, but still, there.

A shuffling noise sounds from the tent, and I quickly pack the earth back over my treasures and return the pillow. A flash of black peaks from under my sleeve at my wrist, and my heart stutters. I pull it back to get a better view. Seven arching waves stare back at me, roughly the size of my thumb. Another dàn.

Brennen's dàn of truth.

My heart sinks. He'll trust me even less now, without the reassurance of his magic. Just when I thought maybe we were getting to a place of understanding.

I quickly roll up my sleeves, examining every inch of my arms for more, then my legs. I freeze. There's a dàn on my calf. Memory.

I search my torso. Two more dàn rest there—one on my ribs, blocky and sharp—weapon accuracy. The other on my shoulder, creeping across my collarbone—warmth—fluid and soft. Dread pools in my stomach. The dàn for warmth I cannot help but feel grateful for, but to take so many…

Guilt rears its ugly head again, hot and thick. The rational part of my mind knows it's not my fault, but my body doesn't care. I stole from Brennen as he was risking his life to save me.

If not my life, then at least from hours of agony. It's not the first time I've drowned, but it is one of the least pleasant ways I have not died, my body fighting for oxygen, my lungs burning until I'm unconscious.

I pull my sleeve back down as Brennen appears in the opening of the tent.

His hair is still wet, wavy and messy, tumbling in front of his eyes. The thick blanket wrapped around his shoulders makes him look even larger than normal, demanding attention. Even covered, his muscular build is obvious, but instead of it causing me to feel afraid, I find myself aware of

him in a way I don’t think I should be. The tension in his jaw. His fingers clutching the edges of his blanket. The rise and fall of his chest as he breathes.

Frustration rolls off him in waves, but there’s no anger mixed with it.

“Are you okay?” I ask tentatively. It's all I can think of to say. I expect an angry retort. Accusations. I brace myself for sharp words.

“I'll be fine,” he grumbles, “though I'll need to go into the village to get more blankets. Warmer clothes.” He stares at the place the fire had sat, doused by last night's rain. “I wish you'd taken a different one," he says with a shiver.

“I didn't mean to—”

“I know,” he says, meeting my eyes, and shock rattles through me. “Looks like it was four dàn this time.”

“I'll try to give them back, if you want. I mean, I don't know how but—”

He lifts his hands, interrupting my rambling. “I dinnae think you can, and I willnae risk losing more. Let’s leave it at that,” he says, marching to Sable where she munches on heather near the treeline. My shock grows into disbelief. He’s truly not angry with me about taking his magic.

He doesn't say a word as he mounts her, then disappears toward the village, I assume to find those warmer clothes.

I'm grateful he has that option. One I never did, because I know what happens next.

After the first rain comes the cold. A cold that will chill you to the bone. A cold that, if you can die, is likely to kill you.

He owns half the city; she wants nothing from him.

That usually lasts a chapter or two. Find more billionaire drama at **Lokepub**.

I'm grateful for the storm as I wander along the river. The flood washed all sorts of debris through the glen, and I find more mature moss than I've seen

in quite some time within reach of my chain.

Even though the temperature continues to plummet throughout the day, the sun remains overhead, and it feels like Hogmanay, a celebration ripe with gifts and good fortune. I collect every bit I can find, along with kindling for a fire. The one Brennen kept stoked went out in the rain, but with my dàn of warmth, I should be able to focus the heat enough to spark a flame.

Lolly soars overhead as I work, her roar a melody that calms my soul.

“I can’t believe it either,” I tell her, picking up stick after stick.

By the time I'm done, body aching from exhaustion, a stack of wood two feet high sits near my bed. Enough to last a few days, if not more. I pick up a few twigs, still somewhat damp from the rain.

My dàn for warmth flares to life, knowing my intention, and my hands grow hot.

The stick I’m holding steams, the moisture in it evaporating until it becomes almost brittle. I laugh, joy popping in my chest like bubbles in the river. I do the same to several more sticks, then make a pile. Focusing on them, I will them to ignite, but nothing happens.

I bite my lip, placing my hands on the bundle, but still, nothing. I sit back on my heels, frustrated. Dàn are supposed to become a part of you—intuitive. That's the magic. You don't have to be taught how to use them. But maybe because they *weren't* given to me, because they were stolen from their rightful owner, it’s different.

A gust of wind blows my hair around my face, but I don't shiver. Instead, I listen to it, allowing it to guide my body forward as if I’m bowing to pray. My skin prickles as an idea comes to me, dropped into my mind like a pebble in the river.

I lift my chin, take a deep inhale, and then, focusing at the base of the sticks, I blow. Softly. Tentatively.

A spark ignites, and the twigs catch. The fire grows warm in an instant, the orange glow lighting up my smile. It is not dark quite yet, but it will be soon. Brennen will return before night comes, and when he does, I can at least offer him this. Some sort of warmth as an apology for stealing what was his.

It’s not long before the sound of hooves echoes through the glen, and Brennen emerges, saddle bags full. He’s wearing a thick cloak, but even

with it covering his body, I can see the outline of his broad shoulders and corded arms.

My belly flutters, my cheeks heating, and I look away. What is wrong with me? A few days with a man in my glen and suddenly I've lost all sense?

He removes the bags and saddle, feeding Sable a few sugar cubes. My mouth waters as she crunches on them, Brennen stroking her nose. Shame and embarrassment heat in my gut.

I'm envious of a horse.

"Wasted no time using my dàn, I see," Brennen rumbles, clearly cranky from the cold. "Though really, you don't need it. The magic will keep you warm with or without it."

"I um…" I stutter, inexplicably uncomfortable. "Well. It feels nice. I've been cold for quite some time. But actually, I built it for you." My blush spreads down my neck, and I twist, trying to hide it from him. "The weather is turning, and it will get colder through the night."

"I'll be fine," he says, stubborn as ever, as he grabs another blanket from his satchel.

I sigh. "It seems a bit bullheaded to be cold for no reason, doesn't it?" I ask, but he pointedly ignores me.

I study him as he unpacks, his movements stiff and tight. His frustration feels like a ball of snakes in my chest, and I rub at my sternum to try to soothe it. He won't look at me and is making a point to stay outside of my chain's reach.

"What's wrong? Afraid I'm going to light you on fire?" I tease, and Brennen freezes, his grip tightening on the blanket he's holding.

"More like you'll steal more dàn if I get close enough."

I lift my hands toward the fire, relishing the heat. "Och, hush. I've been close enough to touch you many times now, and I haven't. It's *you* who seems to be unable to resist touching me," I say with a teasing smirk. Brennen's jaw ticks.

"Why do you think it is that it's only my touch that transfers magic to you?" he asks, surprising me.

I smile, relishing the fact that he's having a conversation with me without accusing me of something horrid. "Now that is an excellent question. Maybe you subconsciously wanted to give them to me," I say.

He huffs. “The last thing I want is to have less magic, or for you to have any at all.”

I roll my eyes. “I’ve told you many times, you’re welcome to try to take them back.”

He crosses his arms, finally looking at me. “You’d really give up your first taste of warmth in a century for me?”

My lips twist into a small smile. “Well, I made a fire for you. I’d *hope* if I returned the dàn, you’d offer to do the same.” The flames rise and crackle as if in agreement.

Clouds drift over the sun, and the temperature drops further. Brennen shivers, unfolding the blanket and wrapping it around his shoulders.

“Fates, you’re stubborn as a ram. You can get closer. I’m not going to murder you. And I won’t take your dàn. I’ll stay on my side of the fire like a good wee lass and keep my hands to myself. I promise.”

Brennen studies me for a long time, statue still, his eyebrows drawn together.

The wind calls, and I rise with a sigh, washing the clothes of a man who will die in a brawl. I place my hands into the icy water, but I do not feel its chill. The feeling is indescribable. A gift from the goddess, and I almost yearn to dive into the river’s depths. To see how far I can push the dàn’s power, but I still haven’t eaten and am low on energy.

Tomorrow, I tell myself. Tomorrow I will bathe. I will take my time, not be rushed by the cold. I will catch a fish and cook it over the fire. My heart leaps at the thought. The river calms, and I say the prayer of the Three of the path, the clothes drifting away.

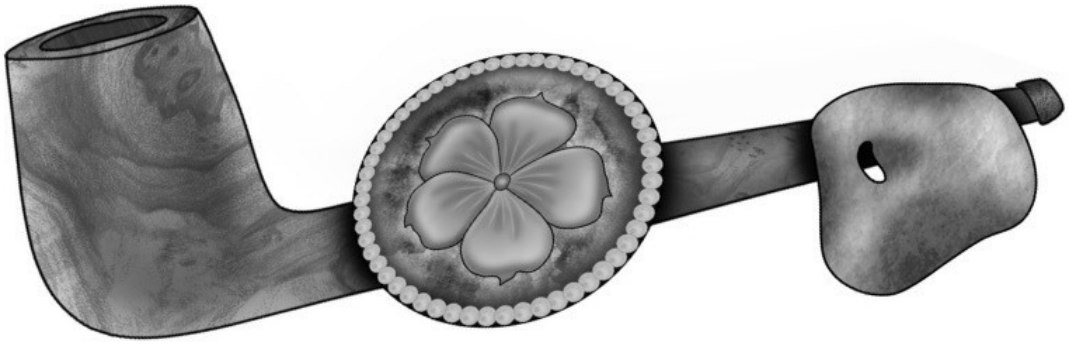
When I turn back, Brennen is sitting by the fire, his stern features illuminated by the flames. He watches me intently as I return to my side. I raise my hands in the air, exaggerating my intentions to stay far away, and his lips twitch up into an almost smile.

Only for a second, but it was there.

My heart leaps.

Maybe my dàn isn’t the only thing warming to me.

BEA



I've just let a sturdy brown shirt trail from my fingers when the river turns angry, and I brace myself for what I know is coming. In a blink, the world shifts, my head swimming and my vision going fuzzy as the ground disappears from beneath my feet. When the haze clears, I'm no longer at the river. I'm standing outside the window of a small stone cottage, watching as a woman removes what looks to be a pie from the hearth. I take an involuntary step forward, my mouth watering. My stomach grumbles, cramping. This time, I almost don't care that I'm in a vision.

The temptation of food is too great. Even just the scent of it fills something inside me. I lean forward, peering into the cottage.

The woman inside is beautiful, with tawny skin and warm brown eyes. She opens the window, setting the pie to cool, and the song she's singing floats outside.

There's bread in the oven, a pie on the sill.
A fire in the hearth that will fight off your chill.
Best to believe nothin's happenin' at all.
Cause the higher you climb, then the harder the fall.

It's the same melody I've heard in all the visions, and I step closer, trying to hear more. There has to be a reason for this song. Something that

connects the visions, but it sounds like a simple pub song. Something I would have once sung in another life, gathered with friends enjoying a dram. Frustration churns beneath my sternum, and I rub it away.

My movement catches the woman’s attention through the window. Her eyes meet mine, and I stiffen.

I wait to be pulled back to the river, the same way I always am soon after whoever I’m watching notices me. But it doesn’t happen.

My breath catches in my throat. Could this be different, somehow? My eyes dart toward the trees, and for a moment, I think about running. Maybe this time, I won’t be pulled back. I take a single step.

“Well, hello there,” the woman says, and I stop, looking back at her. Her eyes fill with concern, and I look down at my dress, still damp around the hem and dirt staining the thin wool. She tilts her head to the side, considering me for a moment, and an embarrassed flush spreads up my neck.

“Are you hungry?” she asks.

Just the mention of food makes my stomach grumble, and I press my hand against it, my shame and embarrassment only growing. “I couldn't—”

“Och.” She waves me off. “Come in then. Let's get you a bite. I’ve been on a bit of a tear with my baking, and I have so much I’m afraid I couldn't eat all of it if I tried.” She disappears from the window, and a second later, the front door swings open wide. “Come, come. Dinnae want to let the cold in.”

My feet move, the friendliness in her tone too alluring to back away from. I hide my stained hands behind my back as I step across the threshold. The woman’s home is warm. Not just in temperature, but in appearance, and there are touches of love everywhere. A hand-fasting tie on the mantle and what appears to be hand-painted vases and candle holders on the table.

I peer around for anything that might be dangerous. Anything that could cause her harm. I do not want to wash this woman’s clothes.

“Is anyone else here?” I ask, tentatively.

“Och, no.” She waves a hand, walking to her table. “Just me.”

My stomach plummets, and I close my eyes for a moment against the pain of the realization that hers is the death I will cleanse once this vision inevitably ends. I wring my hands together behind my back. Should I tell her? Warn her?

No, I quickly decide. It would be torture, knowing you were about to die. But maybe if I can figure out what's going to kill her, I can stop it somehow.

"Hungry?" she asks, pushing a large chunk of warm bread with salt and freshly churned butter toward me.

I reach out on instinct, my hunger overtaking my common sense and the plan forming in my mind. Her eyes flick to my hands.

I freeze.

"Are you injured?" she asks, brow furrowing. She takes a step closer, peering at my fingers.

My heart pounds. "I'm not. I—" My mind races, searching for some sort of explanation. "I was dying thread a few days ago. A bright red, with rowan berries. Seems it stained my hands."

She smiles knowingly, and the edges of her eyes crinkle.

"Happens to the best of us. Though," she furrows her brow, leaning closer, "I've never seen it stain quite like that before."

I laugh uncomfortably, taking a bite. The second the bread hits my tongue, buttery and fresh, I moan.

I try to take my time, to be polite, but my hunger doesn't allow it. I rip off a huge chunk with my teeth, then another.

"Are you in trouble?" she asks, eyes narrowed as she hands me a second piece.

I can't speak through the food in my mouth, so I shake my head.

"Just hungry then? Well, I can help you with that. More, maybe. If you'd like," she says. "I know times are hard for people, especially with the Epoch coming. Maybe the Fates sent you here for a reason," she says.

She has no idea.

I swallow. "I'm um… I'm just passing through. I won't be here long," I say, my eyes flitting through her kitchen. Nothing seems abnormal, except — There's a large knife on the table, the tip hanging over the edge. "Um… Thank you for this kindness, but is it alright if I move that knife into the wash basin? I'm rather clumsy. Wouldn't want to fall on it."

She tilts her head, assessing me, and I wait for her to ask me to leave. To realize it is not thread dye at all that stains my hands, and that I am oddly focused on the large knife in the room. "The knife?" she asks, turning toward it. Her face relaxes. "You're right. It's a bit precarious, isnae it?" She moves it just as I ask, and I force my shoulders to lower. "And, at least

consider staying a while," she continues. "My sister just got married. My parents are gone, and if I'm being honest, I'm rather lonely. I wouldn't mind having some company for a bit."

I give her a soft smile, nodding. I know I won't be able to stay, but if I could, I think this would be a nice place to hide away.

"Well." She claps her hands together. "Let's get you out of those wet clothes," she says, walking to a wardrobe. "Can't have you freezing in a wet dress, can we?"

Shame burns my cheeks. "I don't have anything else," I say, though I follow her, eyes still scanning the small cottage for danger.

She waves a hand. "I've just come into a bit of coin," she says, raising her eyebrows as if sharing a secret. "One of our own has been promoted, and his family is sharing his good fortune with everyone in the village. I used it to buy some new dresses." She pulls out the skirt of her soft blue gown. "Do you like it?"

"It's beautiful," I say, taking in the richness of the fabric. It's my favorite color, almost purple, the hue bright and cheery.

"I had three made last week." She goes to a hutch and grabs a thick green wool dress with gold embroidery stitched along the neckline and sleeves. "You can take this one, if you like. It never quite suited me."

She hands it to me, and I take it. I'm not sure why I'm shocked when the cloth lands heavily in my hands. I'd knocked into the table in the vision with the dog. Had touched the man at the pub, but still, I'm once again surprised when I'm not pulled back to the river immediately.

"Washroom's in the back," she says, nodding toward a hallway. I head toward it, stopping to push back a heavy paperweight too close to the edge of the mantle. A picture sits next to it, a man and woman with pure joy on their faces. It makes my heart ache. I lay the dress over the back of the couch, picking up the photograph to look at it closer.

"You said your parents are gone. Is this them?" I ask, picking up the small oval picture. The couple looks so in love, their smiles bright and fingers interlaced. A lump forms in my throat. I sort through the clothes I washed in my mind, searching my memory for their faces.

"Aye. Better parents you couldn't find," she says sadly. "They died a few years ago. A bad fever."

"I'm sorr—" the world tilts, my head swimming as I'm suddenly pulled back to the river.

I jump back as my glen comes into view. Brennen's face is startlingly close, his eyes burning into mine. With only a breath between us, his stubble is more prominent, and I can see that the faint scar above his eyebrow goes taut when his brow is furrowed. His jaw is even stronger, his forest green eyes brighter, and his lips firm and unyielding.

I forget how to breathe for a moment.

He’s shaking my shoulders, my skin burning where his fingers touch above the fabric covering my arms.

Dirty, white fabric.

Reality settles in my chest, my heart falling. I’d known I would be pulled back here, but it had been so nice talking to someone who didn’t hate me. Sharing a meal.

“It happened again, didn’t it?” Brennen asks, and I nod my head, my throat thick with emotion.

“You went rigid, and then your eyes glazed over. Like before. You were seeing something, weren't you?”

Nerves flutter in my stomach, but I nod. There’s no reason to hide it.

“I was in someone's house, and she fed me bread. Gave me clean clothes.” My voice cracks on the word. Not because I'm sad I lost the dress, but because I lost the dignity it would have given me. The girl had seen me as a human. Not a monster. Not the Washwoman. Just a lost soul in need of kindness.

“You can interact in the visions? Why didn’t you tell— Wait. What are you holding?” he asks, and I look down. I suck in a sharp breath, scooting closer to the fire to examine the portrait in the flickering light.

Shock ripples through my chest. How is this possible? “I was holding this when I was pulled back here. The girl I saw. This is her parents.” I rub my forehead. “I don't understand. Was I gone? Did I actually leave?”

His eyebrows draw together. “No. You were here the whole time. At least, your body was. But your mind? Your mind was somewhere else entirely.” He holds out a hand. “May I?”

A wave of shock passes through me at the way he asked instead of ordering me to comply. It wasn't a demand, and while I'm sure he'd make me hand it over eventually were I to refuse, the illusion of having a say over my actions is intoxicating.

Carefully, so as to not touch his skin, I hand it over.

“She mentioned a sister.” The words make my heart ache, and my eyes flick upstream. What if it hadn’t been the knife at all? Or the paperweight.

But what if it was, and I saved her?

Brennen’s fingers trail along the glass, and I realize his demeanor has changed. His eyes are narrowed, and his posture stiff. “The woman you saw. Describe her for me.” This time, his words *are* demanding.

I study his face. “She had a kind smile. Brown eyes and hair. She gave me a green dress, said her parents died a few years ago.”

“A green dress… Was it stitched with golden thread?”

I freeze. “How could you possibly know that?”

Brennen closes his eyes. “Betty. Her name is Betty, and her sister is Lillian. They’re from my village. Those are her parents. She always wore that dress. She’s to die?” he asks, and I hate the sorrow I see in his eyes.

But hope flickers somewhere inside me. My eyes dart back upstream. Her clothes haven’t appeared yet. Is it possible I succeeded? That I removed whatever it was that would end her life? I know better than anyone that a fate-sealed death cannot be stopped, but one like this? Maybe.

As if the river is laughing at me, the garments appear. A soft blue dress, brand new. I close my eyes, dropping to my knees. Sorrow wraps around my heart, squeezing tight enough to bruise. “I’m so sorry, Betty,” I say, accepting the clothes. I have no other choice, and her kind soul deserves cleansing.

Though, how will she die? What else could it have been if not the knife or the paperweight? She couldn’t get a sickness so quickly, and I didn’t see anything else hazardous. She was overly trusting, perhaps. Could someone have come to her after I left? I hope not.

I shake my head, guilt threading between my ribs. Maybe it was the fire. I hadn’t thought to check if the flames were controlled. If anything was too close to the hearth.

My voice is tight with emotion as I sing my song. Tighter, even, when I let the dress go, dipping my fingers in the river and tapping my chest, lips, and forehead. “An Glèidheadair welcome her, An Treòraiche guide her, and Am Breitheamh have mercy on her,” I whisper.

I hang my head for a moment, collecting myself, fighting back against the tears and panic that accompanied my last vision. Will I ever grow used to seeing the lives of those I cleanse, just as I got used to seeing their deaths?

When I turn back to Brennen, there's distrust in his eyes. "Betty was a nice lass. Kind. Why her?"

I shake my head. "I wish I knew."

"Tell me the truth. Do you ken what's doing this? Do you ken more than you're letting on?" he asks.

"Doing what?" I say, confused. He was there for my last vision, when I could hardly breathe from my sorrow at seeing the mother kissing her child.

He lifts his hands in the air. "I dinnae ken. Doing something to change the threads. Threads other than your own. Why are these deaths different? Is it something you did?"

I cross my arms. "What are you talking about? I've done nothing to any threads. Mine or anyone else's." I say, squaring my shoulders. I will not cower before his anger. Not again. And not when I haven't done anything wrong.

He runs a hand through his hair, shaking his head. "Every time I start to think—" He cuts off abruptly and scoffs, leaning down to stare into my eyes. "If you've done nothing to alter the threads, then why can *your* thread not be cut?"

I freeze, my heart stuttering. The air is ripped from my lungs, and I suck in a shallow breath. "My— What?" He's toying with me, giving me some sort of hope that I'm safe from the Fates' wrath.

"Your thread couldnae be severed."

"How is that possible?" I ask, my voice catching. I clutch my hand over my immortality dàn. If the Fates didn't give it to me as part of my punishment, then who did?

Shock spreads through his face, his wide eyes and open mouth matching my own. "You really didnae ken," he says, almost breathless.

"No," I say, my voice barely a whisper. "Are you saying the Cutter tried? That she tried to kill me, and couldn't?"

He studies me, his eyes exploring every inch of my face as if looking for the tiniest implication I'm lying. "Aye," he finally says, his jaw tightening.

My lungs constrict, my breaths going shallow. It feels as if I'm being buried alive, the realization that I was cursed here, not because the Fates wanted my punishment to be eternal, but because they *couldn't* kill me.

"It's why I'm here," he continues. "To learn why you cannae be killed. Fix it—"

“And kill me,” I finish for him. The words send an unexpected jolt of unease through my blood. I want a peaceful end. The opposite of a death at the end of his sword.

I shake away the thought. “I don’t know anything about the threads. I told you, I think the Cutter is tormenting me with the visions.”

His eyebrows draw together. “No, I dinnae think that’s it. If she knew you were leaving this valley, even just in your mind…” he stands, his anger morphing into a need to catalog the information. To tuck each piece into its appropriate box. “How *are* you leaving this valley? How were you able to be in Betty’s home, but still here? And how did you bring the picture back with you?”

I look at the picture in his hands. I wish I hadn’t picked it up at all. Not when it’s caused him to once again doubt me. Though he’s right about one thing. The Cutter wouldn’t like that I am escaping this chain, even for a few minutes. That I was given bread. Kindness.

Am I to save these people before their deaths, then? Is that the purpose of the visions? It must be. A way to show my heart truly has changed.

“I don’t know. I don’t know how I’m here and elsewhere, or how they can see me, or how I can interact with their world, but the visions have been happening more and more. The water gets muddy, the river surges, and I get pulled away. But I've never been able to interact with the people I see. At least, not like this. Not for more than a few seconds. Normally, I'm back here so quickly, there’s no time to do anything to help them.”

Brennen rubs his forehead, looking down at the portrait. “Are you certain she’ll die?”

I nod, guilt once again slicing deep. If I am meant to save them, then once again, I have failed. “If her soul isn’t already below, it will be soon. It doesn’t take long, once the clothes appear.”

Brennen’s shoulders straighten, his mask of control slipping back into place. “I’ll make sure this gets back to her sister.” He starts toward his tent, then stops. His throat bobs, betraying his facade. “How will it happen?”

“I don’t know,” I say, shaking my head. “I don’t see these deaths, but I think it might be a fire. I didn’t see anything else that could have killed her.”

To my surprise, he doesn’t continue on to his tent, but turns back and joins me, sitting a fraction closer this time. His eyes skate along my skin,

and my heart picks up in rhythm. He's looking at my face intently, almost as if he's counting my freckles.

"Can you tell me more? About the visions?" he asks, and once again, I'm shocked he's requesting information rather than demanding it.

I take a deep breath, my thoughts a jumbled mess. "The visions are… They're different. Typically, when I wash the clothes of the dying, I see a face in my mind, and I know how the person will die. But when the river gets angry, and I'm taken away, I'm no longer here. I'm in someone's home, or in a tavern. On a hill. I never see the person's death. I don't see sorrow. I see life, and happiness."

He stares into the fire, sifting through my words. "Was Betty happy at the end?"

I raise my eyebrows, surprised he's not focusing solely on the logistics of the visions, trying to puzzle through if they could help him on his mission. "Aye. Very."

Brennen nods absently, but his mind is clearly elsewhere.

"She was baking a pie."

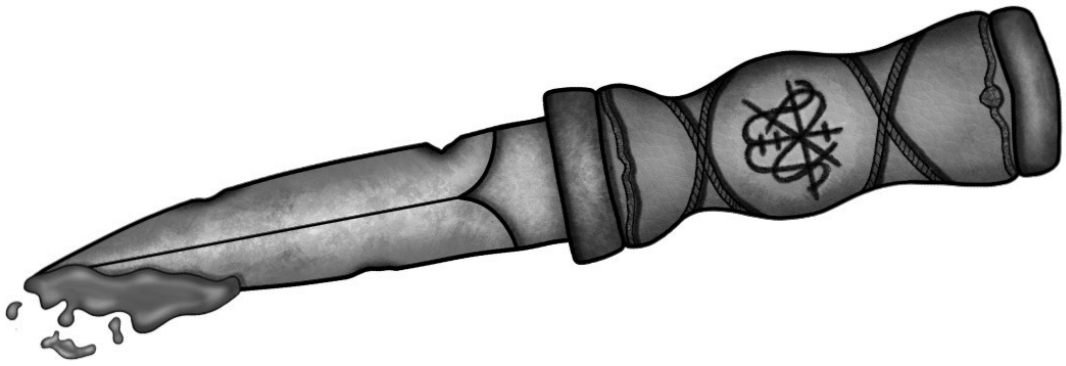
Brennen laughs. "That sounds like her." He meets my eyes. "May An Glèidheadair welcome her," he says.

I look toward the *After*, squinting into the inky black. The mist is moving more than usual. Unsettled once again. "May An Glèidheadair welcome her," I echo, dipping my fingers in the water and tapping my chest.

I shiver, but with my dàn for warmth, it's not from the cold.

32

BRENNEN



The temperature continues to plummet, the air growing colder by the hour. I add more wood to the fire, holding my hands so close they verra well may be burning. I wouldnae know if they were. They went numb hours ago.

Bea's spent the day studying me. Every few minutes, her eyes press against my skin, needling.

"You should move your tent closer," she finally says, tilting her head.

I clench my teeth, though it's not because I believe she's suggesting it because she has a nefarious plan to kill me and escape. It's because *I* am meant to be in control in this situation. In all situations. But here I am, without my dàn of warmth and no way to remedy it.

"The wind will come from that way." She points upstream. "You could build it right here." She pats the moss beneath her. "Put your bedroll next to the fire and leave the flaps open. The tent will block the wind, and you'll feel the fire at your front. It's your best chance at staying warm." She holds her hands up to the flames even though she doesn't really need to, a mirror image of me.

"The dàn will keep you from freezing, but if it gets much colder, you'll still feel the chill," I say. She looks up, a soft smile spreading across her face, and my chest tightens uncomfortably.

"I'm the warmest I've been in a very long time," she says, her cheeks flushed and eyes bright.

My lips begin to tip up, her happiness over not being cold contagious, but I school my expression back into neutrality. She stands. “Come on. Move your tent, then.” She claps her hands together, her expression turning stern.

I bristle outwardly at her order, scowling, but inside, I know she’s right. I may verra well freeze without a fire, and my tent is much too far away from it, and Bea, to do me any good. “Where would you sleep?”

“If you set up here,” she points to the top boundary of her bed, “I’ll still have room there at the bottom. I'll be fine. I can gather more moss tomorrow to make it bigger. I’ll even let you help me.”

The thought of her sleeping on a three-foot sliver of ground in the cold while I have a soft bed only feet away makes me uneasy. Prisoner or not, it feels wrong. Like I’m taunting her with something she cannae have.

“I'll be *fine*,” she says again, as if reading my mind. “But you,” she gives me a pointed stare, “do not have an immortality dàn. Nor a dàn of warmth. This cold will kill you. And it'll only get worse as the night goes on. Even colder over the coming weeks.”

I shiver at the thought. The valley seems to hold the chill in an unnatural way. It’s so much colder here than back home or even just through the forest in Dalbàsail. My breaths come out in white puffs, and despite having several blankets on my shoulders, my teeth chatter.

She stands, moving out of the way and gesturing to her patch of moss. “Come on,” she orders. “Do it before I'm forced to wash your clothes before your time.”

“Would you really care if you did?” I grumble, standing. I’ve told her I’m here to kill her, after all.

She sighs, meeting my eyes. There’s a sadness in them, and an honesty that makes my skin prickle. The bright grey-blue sparkles in the light of the fire, piercing my skin.

“Yes. I would. I've caused enough suffering. I have no interest in allowing others to experience more, especially if I have the ability to stop it. Get up. Let’s go,” she says, as if she hadn’t just offered to give up her comfort for mine, waving a hand toward the tent. Once again, I bristle at her commanding tone, but begrudgingly, I obey. I dinnae have a good argument for why I won’t move it.

Nor do I have a good argument for why her offer makes me want to find enough wood to build a shelter for her, too—a feeling I dinnae want to

examine too closely. She took my dàn, so why should I freeze to death for her comfort?

It doesn't take long to move the tent. I position it where she suggested, blocking the wind from the top of the river, covering a little more than half of her bed of moss. Bea helps me arrange my things inside, her chain clanking as it hits the metal poles. The skin around her ankle is red and angry from all the movement, and unease slips across my shoulders. Should I get her more willow bark to help with the pain?

My satchel falling off the desk interrupts my thoughts, the items inside scattering across the floor. Bea rushes to clean up the mess, nothing more than fishing hooks, some leather straps, dried meat, and a few coins. She’s quiet as she turns each item over, examining them before placing them back in the bag.

It must have been a long time since she's seen such things, and for a moment, I consider offering them to her as thanks for her help moving the tent.

“Much better,” she says, clapping her hands together, her face glowing with satisfaction.

She's right. The temperature difference is staggering. The heat from the flames fills the tent almost instantly, and its thick canvas blocks the frigid wind. I position my bedroll close to the fire, then grab a few blankets.

Bea gives me a timid smile as I set up my things inside, tucking her hair behind her ears, and I clear my throat, my chest tightening uncomfortably. She looks so proud of herself for the idea, genuinely happy that I will be warm now, and once again, I’m unable to reconcile that this is the same woman who killed all those people. It may have been her hands, but… All I have seen from her is kindness and selflessness. The two women can’t be the same.

And yet, they are.

I need to remember that.

“Sleep well, then,” she says, suddenly timid as she steps over my bedroll. She lies down on what remains of her makeshift bed, putting her head on the rock she calls her pillow and curling into a ball.

A strong gust causes my tent to lean, the wind howling outside it, and I tense.

It doesn’t let up, and despite myself, I glance back at her.

She’s hugging her knees, shoulders hunched and head down, as if she can hold on to her body heat by sheer will. She looks small in the flickering fire. Vulnerable.

I grit my teeth and roll onto my back, pulling the blanket higher over my shoulders. Trying to ignore my conscience. The Washwoman has endured this before, and without the dàn. She’ll be fine. She might find herself chilled if the temperature continues to drop and the wind doesnae let up, but she cannae die, *and* she has a fire. Something she’s never had before.

Another gust rattles the tent poles.

I somehow sense her shiver this time, even without looking at her.

“Damn it,” I say, rolling to face the opposite direction. Her warmth, or lack thereof, isnae my problem. Nowhere in the Cutter’s instructions did she say, ‘Find a way to kill the Washwoman, and make sure the murderess stays comfortable in the meantime.”

Another gust nearly extinguishes the fire, carrying its embers off into the dark of night. I feel its warmth leave me, and I stiffen.

No. I will no get up. I will no lose the little body heat I have left beneath these blankets.

The wind howls again, even stronger.

“Goddess below,” I hiss, throwing my blanket off and grabbing another before I can stop myself. Bea startles when I throw it on top of her, her eyes filling with surprise and her lips parting, but I dinnae give her the chance to speak. I don’t want to hear her thanks or appreciation.

Because I shouldnae be doing this. Shouldnae care if she's cold or comfortable.

“Just take it,” I snap. “In fact, keep it this time,” I push as much dominance into my voice as possible, forcing it to come out like an order and lacing each word with enough bite to make sure she hears the warning beneath it. I dinnae want her to argue with me or thank me. Dinnae wish to prolong this moment of weakness for even another second. I seem to be making a habit of giving her blankets, and I don’t want to linger on the reason why.

“Alright. Tha—”

“Goodnight,” I say sharply, ending the conversation. A flicker of hurt flashes in her eyes as I turn away, but I dinnae care. I *cannae* care. I have

done what my honor called me to do. What any decent man would do, and nothing more.

I yank my blankets back over my shoulders, pulling them tight enough to smother any other possibilities of why I care if the woman is cold, and try to sleep.

Except I cannae rest. I toss and turn, a different kind of guilt settling in my stomach. One even worse than the guilt of watching Bea freeze, because, though it pains me to admit, I cannae deny that I feel for the Washwoman. Not only the anger I arrived here with, though it's still there, simmering beneath the surface.

But also sympathy. Pity. Emotions the person who murdered Marsaili, or anyone else, doesnae deserve.

And yet no matter how I try, I cannae squash them.

The pity mixes with fury. Disgust at myself festering in my gut. Marsaili's memory deserves better.

I close my eyes, silently begging the vow on my palm to burn. To give me that bite of pain so I can feel my need for vengeance burn hot again, but it doesnae come. The absence of it taunts me, and before I even realize it, I'm reaching for my dagger. I sit, staring at the Washwoman's sleeping form in the firelight. I can no longer see her. Even her head is covered by the blanket, but it doesnae matter. She is right there—the target of my vengeance.

I dinnae owe her anything, and I *need* to remember that.

I slice the dagger along the scar that marks my unbreakable vow, whispering a silent apology to Marsaili as the sharp bite of pain spreads through my palm. The sting of it calms my racing heart, grounding me. There's a reason I made this vow in the first place. One I knew the consequences of not fulfilling.

I may feel sympathy for the woman outside my tent, but how could I not? I'm an honorable man, and she is a broken woman. Beautiful, but broken.

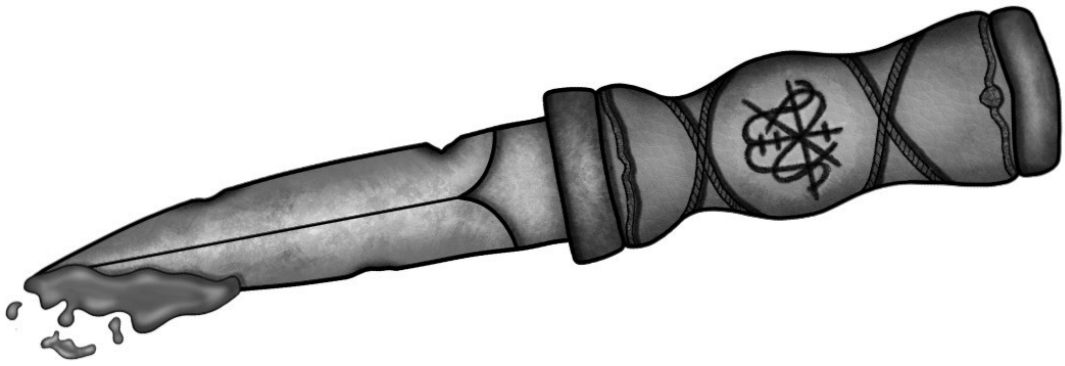
Maybe she's changed in her century of punishment, but that doesnae change what I must do.

I willnae break my vow.

I *cannae* break my vow.

33

BRENNEN



I emerge from the tent in the morning with my resolve strengthened. I've been failing in my duty of gathering information. Let the pain and suffering I've witnessed distract me from my mission. My vow, and it has to change.

If I'm going to kill the Washwoman, and I *am* going to kill her, I need to know how she changed her thread. Why she killed Marsaili and her family. I'll no allow her to continue to hide the reasons for her punishment from me.

It's what brought me here, after all. The reason I spent the last six years hunting her, and I owe it to myself, and Marsaili, to get her to admit what she did and why.

The fresh scar on my palm burns as I grip my canteen and take a swig from it, and I relish the feeling, grabbing the bite of pain and tucking it into my chest. This is exactly what I needed. A physical reminder of why I am here, and what I must do. Of the agony the Washwoman has caused me.

I turn, ready to demand answers, but stiffen when I see her. The burn in my scar turns into an ache, spreading through my entire palm, the sight of her like pressing against a bone-deep bruise. She's sitting by the fire, drawing in the mud. Little speckles of dirt dust her cheeks, nestled in among her freckles, like she was so engrossed in her drawing she didn't notice mud spattering about. She looks beautiful in the morning light, her

wild red hair braided loosely down her back, escaped tendrils framing her face.

I hate myself for thinking it, but the thought comes unbidden, crashing into me like a violent, unexpected gust of wind. A vibrant purple marsh violet is tucked behind her ear, and when she looks up at me, her eyes brighten, crinkling at the edges. She smiles, but it quickly drops when she sees my bloody hand.

“What happened?” Bea asks, standing and reaching out to look at the fresh cut. I stiffen, and she stops, but her eyes are full of concern, almost as if she can feel the pain of the wound herself.

“Nothing.”

Her forehead creases. “I still have some willow bark,” she offers.

“No.” I grit my teeth. I *want* the pain. Need it to distract me from her bloody kindness. From her beauty.

The word hits me out of nowhere once again, and I widen my fingers, purposefully stretching the scar. The scab cracks, and blood trickles through my fingers, dripping onto the riverbank as pain spreads along the puckered line.

Her brow furrows with concern. “I have bandages, too,” she continues. Her words knock me off balance, chipping away at the resolve I’d only just hardened, threatening to crack it. She’s being thoughtful again. “The wolves—”

“I’m no afraid of the wolves,” I almost growl, lowering my chin. She swallows, her brows drawing in. Guilt threatens to claw its way up from where I buried it last night, but I stomp it back down. I willnae allow myself to feel sorry for my rage. It is righteous. But more importantly, it is justified.

“Why are you so angry today?” she asks, her voice hesitant. “If I’ve done something—”

I grit my teeth. *If she’s done something…* She *killed* my geallta. That’s what she did.

But she doesnae know that, a small voice says in my mind. Or does she? It kills me that I dinnae truly ken what knowledge she possesses. What she is purposefully hiding from me.

But I’m going to find out.

“You know what you’ve done. And you refuse to talk about it.” I meet her gaze. “I cannae keep doing this. Speaking to you as if you’re not a

murderer. Sharing a fire with you like your hands aren’t stained with blood *you* spilled. I need you to tell me why you murdered those people.” My voice is firm, and my question strategic. Asking her to think about *why* she killed seems to cause her discomfort.

Maybe, with enough of it, she’ll bend.

She proves me right, closing her eyes as her lips twist into a grimace. “How many times must I tell you?”

“That's the problem,” I say, stepping forward. My voice drops to a harsh rumble. “I dinnae ken any more now than I did when I arrived here at this Fates-damned river. You've told me *nothing*.”

She meets my eyes, not backing down. “Neither have you. Why should I tell you why I did it, when you refuse to tell me why it matters so much to you?”

I shake my head. I am not the one being questioned. I am not the one who owes the other answers. “I was sent here to gather information. Tell me why you did it.”

“I can’t!” she shouts, putting her hands over her ears and beginning to rock.

“Aye. You’ve said as much. But *why*? *Why* can't you?” I ask, pressing harder. I willnae back down. Not this time.

She shakes her head, and a tear streaks down her cheek. “You wouldn't understand.”

I ignore the way her tears twist knots in my stomach, hope sparking deep in my chest. There *is* a reason, then. “Then make me!” I throw my canteen down, and pebbles fly through the air from the impact. The glen seems to hold its breath, as does Bea.

I lower my voice. “Tell me why you killed them,” I repeat, determined.

She grits through the obvious pain. “Please stop,” she begs, her hands fumbling along the ground as if she's searching for something to hold onto. Something to ground herself. “Stop asking me. Please. I cannot rip myself apart for you. Can’t you see that?” She opens her arms wide, her expression morphing into desperation. “I can’t dig into the worst parts of myself, through my deepest pain, to help you find comfort or answers or to fulfill your duty. That is what you do when you ask me this. You *hurt* me.” A trickle of red drips from her nose, and I pause. Not just from the blood, but her words.

“Bea,” I say, her name a shard of glass against my throat. Her pain seeps into me, because this isn’t who I am. Someone who causes suffering. And yet, does she not deserve my questioning? She’s withholding answers. Things I *need* to know.

The roughness in my tone seems to break through her pain, enough for her to meet my eyes. “What happens when you think about that day?” I ask.

She swallows, and I hold her stare, taking a step closer.

“Please. What happens when you think of it?” I ask again, even more gently this time.

She wipes her nose with her knuckles, then stares down at the blood for what feels like an eternity.

“I hear their screams in my mind.” she whispers, refusing to look at me. Her hand begins to shake. “Their cries for help. They scrape against the inside of my skull, pressing outward until it feels as if my head may crack open.” She looks up at me. “I *feel* their pain, their blood—hot and sticky on my hands, dripping up my arms.”

My fingers curl into fists at the mention of Marsaili’s blood, and I stare down at her hands. The way the stain coats the entirety of her palms, trailing up her forearms in little rivulets. “You act as if it’s the fact they died that pains you.”

“It *is*,” she snaps, and there’s fire in her voice. Fire I dinnae think she is faking.

I run a hand across my face in frustration. Does a murderer regret their actions like this? Their own body revolting against what they did? “But you killed them. Didnae you?”

The air is heavy as I wait for her answer, and part of me hopes she'll deny it. Hopes this is all a wild misunderstanding, and that my gut instincts are right. That she truly isn’t capable of such violence. That something else occurred that can explain away the horror of what happened that night.

And yet, had she not killed before? A century ago, when she ended her friend and her lover’s life?

“Yes,” she says, her eyes welling with tears. “I did.”

My hope falls like a drip of molten iron dropped into water, instantly hardening into a ball of anger. “Then tell me *why*,” I order, my voice sharp. “Tell me why, and maybe I can understand. Maybe I can help you.”

“I can’t—” Her voice breaks.

“Tell me *something*. Tell me what you wanted out of it. Tell me how you chose your victims. Tell me how you escaped this valley.”

Her eyes flick to mine, and she sucks in a sharp breath. “If I tell you something. *One* thing, will you stop tormenting me?”

I pretend to consider, but really, this was my plan all along. One I’d formed in the long hours last night when sleep had refused to find me, the cut on my palm throbbing. If I cannae get her to tell me why she did it, maybe I can wear her down in hopes she’ll give me another piece of information that might fill in one of the holes in her story.

“For now,” I say, crossing my arms.

She nods, her jaw clenching as she picks up a rock. She twists it between her fingers, glancing up at me.

“Well?” I ask.

She opens her mouth, then pauses. “Will you please sit down? I can't think with you standing over me like that. You're so…” she waves a hand at me, but doesn't continue.

So what, I wonder. Angry? Wrathful? I didnae even activate my dàn of dread. She has no idea how *so* I could be if I wanted.

“Fine,” I say, leaning back against a log as she places the rock down and begins to search for another. She grabs several, beginning to build a cairn. It takes a few moments before she speaks, the stack of rocks seven high by the time she opens her mouth again.

“Before I killed those people, I had no chain.”

Anticipation prickles along my shoulders. This one sentence is more than I've learned in the entire time I've been here.

“I had boundaries within the glen, of course, but they were much further away. I couldn’t get any closer to the *After* than I can now, but I could go up around the bend,” she points upstream. “I could go into the woods, all the way to where the rocky part of the ridge begins.”

I tuck every word away. “You never went past the boundaries?”

She scoffs. “I tried, but I couldn’t. They’re warded by the Fates with dàn carved into trees with knives dipped in my own blood. I think it connects my life force to the valley, my blood soaking the trees, traveling into their roots and the land itself. I could feel it, that connection, when I’d get too close to the boundary. Still, it was wonderful,” she says, wistful. “Compared to this, at least. My bed was so soft and plush with all the moss

I could gather. I was able to hunt. I could follow the fish and watch the birds fly through the forest."

She pauses, her eyes darting to the opposite side of the river.

"One day there was a storm. The wind was unlike anything I've ever seen. Trees were uprooted, thrown clear across the river. One of them held a ward. I felt it, when the boundary broke. Something snapped in my chest, and in a blink, I was free. I didn't think. I didn't consider that leaving the valley would cost me so much. That would lead to all this." Her eyes go glassy as she gestures to her shoreline and chain.

"The wards blocking the *After* still stood, so I found the fallen tree, and I ran through the gap. Stole a horse and kept going until I was too exhausted to continue. I was so hungry, and I was afraid I wouldn't find a place to hide. I think I knew deep down I could never escape the Fates. Not forever." She pauses, trailing off.

"What happened next?" I say, my voice quiet so as to not break through her trance.

She closes her eyes, and I wonder if she's hearing the screams. "I remember falling asleep against a tree. And then, nothing. Not until there's a knife in my hand, and blood coating my fingers as I pull it across a neck."

My pulse stutters, my mouth going dry. "You didn't leave intending to kill anyone?" I ask.

She winces. "No. I would never, ever want to end a life. But it doesn't change the fact that I did. That I ended so many. I can still feel the woman's back against my chest. How cold the hilt of the dagger was in my hand." She shudders, her face going pale. "It doesn't feel like you think, cutting through a throat. It's not smooth, and it requires a surprising amount of force. It haunts me, that feeling. I dropped the dagger as soon as I realized what I'd done, and I tried to help her, but it was too late."

Nausea roils through me at Bea's words. At her description of the feeling of ending not just any life, but Marsaili's. My vision goes fuzzy at the edges, and I shake my head, my mind swimming as if I'm wading through the thick fog that hangs over the glen. "You cannae tell me why you killed them because you dinnae ken. You dinnae remember." It comes out as a statement rather than a question, a rough whisper, almost to myself.

Could what she's saying really be true? That she didn't choose to kill anyone at all?

My heart thunders, an emotion I can't name coiling around it. Not confusion. Not regret or shame, but a jumbled mix of them all, growing stronger by the second. And not for the first time since she took it, I wish I still had my dàn of truth.

“But there *is* a reason,” she says, wrapping her arms around her waist as if she is about to shatter, and is trying to hold herself together. “Something’s wrong with me, Brennen. I just don't know what. I *never* wanted to hurt anyone. Never. And yet, when I wasn’t chained to this river, that’s exactly what happened. Maybe the curse binding me here corrupted my soul. Or maybe it was corrupted long ago. Maybe there are bigger consequences to leaving this shore than the Fates told me.”

“It's why you wish for death,” I say, breathless, and she finally meets my eyes, giving me a sad smile.

“Aye. It is. I told you, I don’t *want* to hurt anyone, and I meant it. But I don't want to be here, either, living in constant shame, guilt eating away at me. No one is meant to live forever. To *suffer* forever. I’d like to think before I go, I’ll find a way to pay my debt to Ban-dia a’ Bhàis. That maybe in the *After*, I’ll be able to find the peace I will never find here.”

My mind whirls, tiny cracks forming in my protective shield of anger.

When she looks away again, her eyes are brimming with tears. “Does that satisfy your question? Will you stop asking me about that night, now?” she asks, swallowing. She’s trying not to cry. To keep those tears within the boundaries of her long eyelashes. Her lips tremble, and she presses them together.

I nod, sensing that if I were to press her, I wouldn't get any more information. Not now, when she seems so raw and vulnerable. When she truly doesnae seem to remember. What would I even ask? If she regrets it? It’s clear as the river that she does. That she would take it back if she could.

The cracks in my resolve spread, tiny fissures branching outward.

I stand. “I’m going to hunt.” I clear my throat, an uncomfortable pressure settling on my shoulders. “Do you want me to catch you something?” I ask. She doesn’t eat often. Though maybe she simply doesn’t need to. Not like the rest of us mortals. She said her body doesnae change.

She sniffles, clearing her throat as she discreetly wipes her eyes with the palm of her hand. “No. I’m not hungry.”

“Alright,” I say, even though I’m not, either. I cannae imagine eating anything right now, but I need to move. To work off some of the discomfort

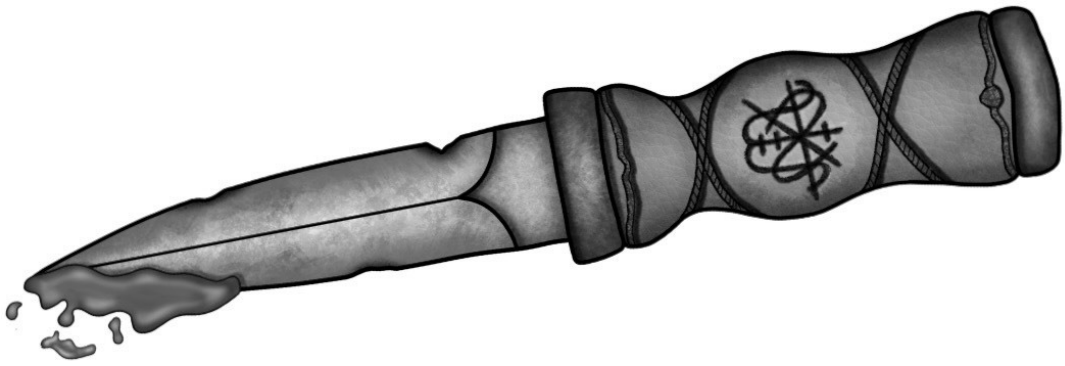
building inside me, because suddenly everything seems so much more complicated. Because Bea isn't a monster at all. Mad from her curse, perhaps. Dangerous, certainly, but every part of my body believes she never intended to kill anyone, and I now have proof that she isn’t the vile, cold-blooded killer I was warned she would be.

She is simply a victim of her mind, and it changes everything.

But even worse, it changes nothing.

34

BRENNEN



I abandon hunting after an hour of wandering the glen, my mind too preoccupied to focus on tracking, or anything really, for that matter.

Sitting down at my writing desk, I pull out a quill and parchment. And yet, as I stare at the paper, I'm unable to write a single word. It remains blank, completely unblemished. Because what is there to say?

It feels as if I'm playing a game I have no chance of winning. I have to update Cailleach with something, but what? Should I tell her the Washwoman now has several of my dàn? That she begged me to ask her to stop torturing her with visions of joy and life?

I sigh, rubbing the scruff along my jaw, then pick up my quill.

Cailleach,

I hope this letter finds you well. I write to make you aware that something has changed with the Washwoman. She is seeing visions of life before deaths that dinnae follow the typical pattern.

I pause, unsure how to continue. I dinnae want to accuse the Cutter of not having control of her power, and yet, what if the change Bea is

describing is unknown to her? If so, it's my duty to inform her. Even if Bea seems to think she's doing it to torture her, it doesnae feel right in my mind. Something else is happening.

I'm sure you are aware of these deaths and that the change is intentional, so it is only with the most cautious intent I write to inform you, on the nearly impossible chance that these deaths are somehow occurring outside of your all-powerful will. I will continue to work on our mission.

Your humble, loyal servant,
Brennen.

I quickly fold up the letter and seal it with wax before I can second-guess anything I wrote. I could spend hours dissecting my words, making sure nothing could be twisted, but it will do no good.

I pull out a second piece of parchment. One I dread almost with equal intensity.

Lillian,

I start, but no other words come. Not this time. I stare at her name, waiting for something, anything, to come to me to write. I'm sorry for your loss? It feels trite. Doesn't express that I understand the gravity of what happened to her sister.

I set the quill down, frustrated.

The sound of Bea's chain against the rocks reaches my ears, and she pops her head into my tent, red curls tumbling into her face. My pulse trips, the air thickening until the tent seems less than half its size. I force my lungs to expand with a deep inhale, pressing down whatever emotion her sudden appearance caused before it can further take shape.

Her cheeks redden when her eyes meet mine, our conversation likely still circling through her mind as well. “Um… It’s getting colder. And I’ve gathered all the firewood I can reach,” she says, jangling her chain. “But it won't be enough to last us much longer.”

“I'll gather more in a moment.” My voice comes out tight. She must notice, because she doesn’t say anything else, nodding and backing out of the tent. “Wait,” I say, the word slipping out without my permission.

She pauses, chewing on the inside of her cheek.

I stare at her for a moment as she tucks that wild red hair behind her ears, emphasizing her freckled nose and wide eyes. My lungs constrict again. I dinnae want to ask her for help, not when I still cannae rectify the woman before me with the crimes she committed, but it’s undeniable that she’s seen more death than anyone, aside from the Cutter herself.

I straighten. “I'm writing a letter to Betty's sister, Lillian. I wish to send her my condolences. We weren’t particularly close, but I’ve known their family for a verra long time.”

Bea’s blue-grey eyes turn sad.

“You know a lot about death, and you were with Betty in her final moments,” I continue. “What should— What would you say?”

She takes a tentative step forward, raising her eyebrows in question, and I gesture for her to come in. The tent seems to shrink even further as she enters, giving me a soft smile that travels straight through my ribs, and I clear my throat, looking back to my parchment.

“I've seen a lot of death, but I've also experienced a lot of grief. My own, and that of the family members of those passing or passed who come to me. They want to stop the death or find a way to reverse it, yes, but I also get the feeling that what they really want is to know their loved one won’t disappear. They don't want them to be forgotten.” She pauses, pressing her lips together in thought. “Losing someone, it's a wound that never heals, and yet the sun continues to rise over the ridge, and the larks carry on singing their songs.”

My throat goes dry at her words, because I’ve felt that exact way. Still do. How can the world continue on when a life ends so suddenly? Shouldn’t it change the verra fabric of the realm?

“Have you ever lost anyone?” I ask. Her eyes go glassy, but no tears fall.

“I've lost many people.” She clears her throat. “Have you?" she asks, and I stiffen.

“Hasn't everyone?” I ask. The words come out with a bite I didn’t intend, and she flinches.

“I’m sorry. It’s none of my business,” she says softly, and I wonder if it’s because she feels for me, or because she knows she had a part in the death of whoever I lost by washing their clothes.

If only she knew really how big of a role she played. How sorry she should be.

“Losing someone changes you forever. Is there anything anyone could've said to you to make it better?” she asks.

I don't even have to consider her question. “No.”

She nods. “Exactly. You seem to spend a lot of time making sure you're doing the right thing, but there's not *always* a right thing to do.” She wrings her hands together, nervous. “There’s no way to make this better for Lillian. Some things simply cannot *be* made better. So you do the best you can, and you let go. You let that be enough.” She nods sadly, brushing off her dress.

“I'm sorry for your loss. For Betty. Even if you weren't close. I didn’t know her for long, but I'd like to say she'd be happy to know her life touched yours enough that you care to write at all. I think her sister will feel that way, too.”

I nod, taking in her words, the discomfort in my chest easing a bit. Despite everything, she's right about this, so I put my quill to the paper and begin to write.

Lillian,

I’m so verra sorry to hear about Betty’s death. I was always fond of her. May she be safe and warm with your parents in the After. While I may be away at my post, my family will be more than willing to help you with anything, should you need them.

May An Glèidheadair welcome her, An Treòraiche guide her, and Am Breitheamh have mercy on her.

Brennen

Bea is gone when I finish the letter. I wrap the picture of Betty and Lillian's parents in parchment, then bind it alongside the note with a length of twine.

It doesnae feel like nearly enough.

I hang my head in my hands. None of this feels right. With a sigh, I pull out a third piece of parchment.

Saoirse,

Just writing my littlest sister's name allows me to breathe easier. I picture her chubby little cheeks. The smile that has always been able to thaw my icy exterior. I remember holding her as just a bairn after Marsaili's death, her little fingers gripping mine, restarting a heart I thought had completely died.

Happiest birthday, little one. I cannae believe you're six years old. How did time pass so quickly? I will be home as soon as I can, and cannae wait to celebrate with you. In the meantime, I made you something. I hope you love it. Tell Isla and Mairi to spoil you with extra sweets. You deserve it.

I love you, and am so verra proud of you.

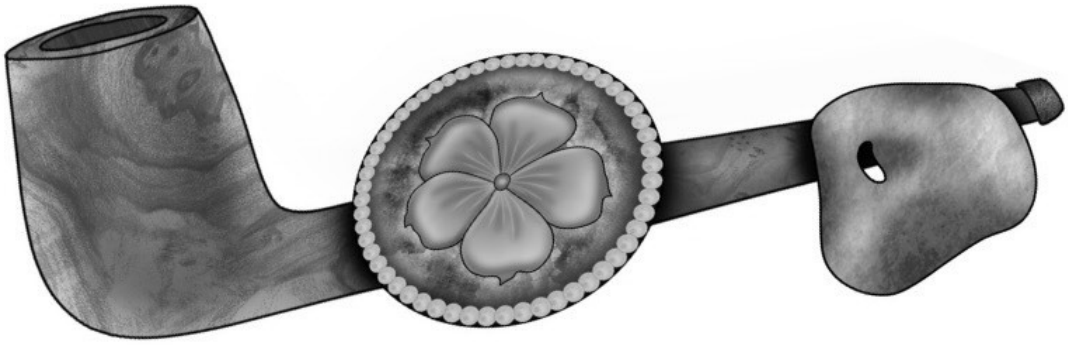
Brennen.

I enclose a small lamb carving I made for her, sealing it with wax, and as I add the letter to the stack, a fraction of my unrest disappears. Saoirse would tell me not to fret. That as long as we have our family, everything will work out in the end.

I have to believe she's right.

35

BEA



The fire crackles as we sit beside it, Brennen on one side, me on the other. It’s a physical divide, yet it still feels like something has shifted between us today. His anger has changed. Not disappeared, necessarily, but morphed into something a bit less sharp. He doesn't seem to hate me with every beat of his heart now, though I can still sense the anger bubbling beneath the surface of his calm exterior.

I try to ignore it. To ignore *him*, but my body won’t listen. Every few seconds, it seems, my eyes flick to where he sits reading a book, a leather-bound journal of sorts, his eyebrows drawn together as if he’s thoroughly studying the contents inside. But it’s not just me who seems to be unable to keep my eyes to myself.

Every so often, his gaze sears my skin as well. What is he searching for?

The sensation of him watching me prickles again, and I look up, but he quickly turns away. His strong jaw clenches, and he rubs a hand across his scruff, his forearms flexing as he turns the page. Heat flares deep within me, my skin suddenly overly sensitive. The fire is too warm, and my dress scratchy.

This is foolish. Embarrassing even, the way my body has begun responding to his proximity. Maybe it's just spending so much time with someone after being alone for so long. Maybe I would feel an attraction to anyone of his age and physicality. Or, if not an attraction, an appreciation at least.

Brennen is a soldier through and through. Strong in a way that speaks of hard work, his muscles defined and corded, honed by years of training and self-control. It takes perseverance to become a warrior like that, and I wonder, if I'd possessed some of his fortitude, would my life have turned out differently? Maybe my mind wouldn't have broken and caused me to do the horrible things I've done.

I think back to that night six years ago. What could've caused me to snap so severely? Was I afraid of something? Did I see a threat that wasn't there? Or is it really as I suspect? That the curse binding me here fractured my mind when I escaped?

The screams begin to echo as I prod my memory, and I wince, pushing the thoughts away. Every time I try to come up with answers, my mind betrays me once again. But *is* there an answer, hidden somewhere in the depths of my mind?

Even thinking about the memories causes the screams to grow to a roar, and I bite my lip, pushing the thoughts away before the pain of it can get any worse. I grab some stones and begin to stack them, but only make it to four before they tumble to the ground. They're too round, and I search for more suitable ones, desperate for a distraction.

But Brennen's gaze once again heats my face, and I abandon the search, fighting the flush creeping up my neck. His lips tip down in what seems to be concern, and not for the first time, it knocks me off kilter. This man, who's sole purpose of being here is to kill me, seems to genuinely care if I'm hurt. If I suffer.

"Are you in pain?" he asks, his voice low and rough. His eyes flick to my ankle. "I can get you more willow bark if the cuff has been bothering you."

I rub my temples. "No. It's not that. It's—" I pause, taking a deep breath. Part of me wants to be vulnerable with him. It'd felt good, earlier, to confess how I'd escaped the river. To confide in someone, and I want to tell him how much the bits of memory I do have haunt me.

"The screams returned," I shake my head. "I was thinking of them. Of the people I killed."

He leans back, studying me, as if surprised by my willing admission. "Do you think of them often?"

"Every day," I say, picking up my hem and running my fingers along it so I don't have to look at him. There's a hole I haven't gotten around to

mending, avoiding having to ask Brennen to return my needle to me. It's so big now, I can fit four fingers through it, and I need to fix it desperately.

"I, um… May I have my needle?" I ask, lifting the hole. "You said to ask if I needed it again. And I guess now's the time," I say, rambling. I don't know why his presence makes me feel so nervous. Like everything I do or say is awkward and strange.

He stares at the hole intently, his only movement the rise and fall of his chest. Nerves bubble in my stomach at his silence, and I hurry to fill it. "You see, when you only have one garment, you must take care of it. I know what I'm doing, though. I can fix it easily. But I should do it now, before it gets any larger and—"

"You've really worn that garment for a hundred years?" he asks.

I brush my fingers against the worn fabric. "Aye. I think there must be some sort of magic that keeps it from falling apart completely. But I still must mend it."

He looks at the multicolored patches of thread all along the skirt, fixed with whatever I could find. His gaze shifts away from me for a long moment as he stares at the cut on his hand. The one I haven't had the courage to ask about again. It looks intentional, even more so with the fresh wound overtop the scar. One that hadn't been present when he'd gone to his tent last night.

He closes his eyes for a moment, his jaw going tight, then reaches into his boot and pulls out a piece of folded fabric, and a laugh slips through my lips.

His eyes pop wide, then narrow.

"What?"

"You really hid the needle on your body?" I ask, turning fully to face him, pretending to pinch a needle between my fingers and throw it at him like a dart. "Were you afraid I would stab you with it? Aren't you An Àrd?"

He pins me with a stare. "I thought you might try," he grumbles, tossing the bundle over the fire. I don't miss his word choice. Not think. *Thought*. The word wraps warmth around me like a cocoon.

I stand and wander to my pillow, lifting it and grabbing a bobbin of thread from the top. Brennen is watching me again, and I hold it up.

"Afraid I'll garrot you with this?" I ask, and a smile flirts at the corners of his lips. My heart stutters, and my neck flushes with heat. I silently curse myself, embarrassed. You'd think a man had never smiled at me before, the

way my body’s reacting to a half smile. Not even a half smile. It’s the barest hint, so fleeting, I may have imagined it.

But in truth, I don’t think it’s that a man is smiling at me at all.

It’s *this* man. My flush deepens.

“I think I can survive a bit of thread,” he says, turning the page, and I’m grateful he’s no longer looking at me.

I try to ignore him as I patch the hole with the deep purple thread, a stark contrast to the off-white of my dress.

“How long *exactly* have you been here?” Brennen asks, resting the book in his lap. When I look up, he's studying me again, and I wonder what he’s looking for. He’s spent hours since he’s been here staring at me, like I’m a puzzle begging to be solved. I look back down to my hem, unable to bear his scrutiny. It makes me feel naked, looking at him. Like he can see through my clothes and skin down to my very marrow.

I pause my mending to lift the bottom of my skirt. “See these?” I ask, showing him the line of tiny stitches around the hem. “I make a mark every winter. I’ve seen a hundred and three of them from this shore.”

Brennen stares at the stitches. “And how old were you when you were sent here?”

Young. The word comes unexpectedly, as do the emotions that accompany it. I had so much life ahead of me, and yet I’ve done so little.

“Twenty-three,” I make several straight stitches through the hole. “But I stopped aging when the curse began.”

His brow furrows, and he nods, leaning forward. “You've lived through an Epoch, then.” My hands still, a shiver skating down my spine. It wasn’t where I’d expected his mind to go, and yet, it’s a fair question.

“I have,” I say. The words come out as a whisper. “Is that what you're reading about?” He closes the book.

“In part. What can you remember of it?”

I hesitate for a moment. It's not something I like to relive, yet it’s another answer I can give him. “It started in the night. I saw creatures flying through the sky. First, just a few. Then, hundreds. Brollacham dug up from the ground, and Cu Sìth raced through the forest in packs, howling endlessly.

“Did they harm you?” He asks. His knuckles go white on the book.

“No,” I say. “I don't know why, but they left me alone. I could see them, but I'm not sure they could see me. It felt like it does with Lolly. They never

came within my boundaries. Maybe the wards kept them out. But there was one day, when I saw a bodack. Wrinkled and old, with stringy white hair and onyx eyes and gnarled claws for hands. He stared at me. *Right* at me. I ran upstream to hide, and when I looked back, he was gone."

Brennen seems unfazed by the horrors I witnessed. He's in soldier mode, assessing. Planning. "How long did it last?" he asks.

"Near ten years. There were so many clothes to wash, and I saw each death in my mind. People were torn apart limb from limb. Eaten alive. I could hear the screams from Dalbàsail. I lost count of how many people died. Thousands." I shiver, the memory making me nauseous. "You know, the Epoch is the only time I've ever been grateful to the Fates. The wards kept me safe. But I've always wondered, why not ward the villages throughout the kingdom completely? I'm sure the Fates were safe in their impenetrable castles. But what of their people?"

Brennen's shoulders go tight, his eyes narrowing, as if he's angry I'm questioning his queen. But he doesn't accost me for it, and I wonder if maybe he's considering what I said.

"Will you be safe when it comes?" I ask him.

"As you said. I am An Àrd. This is what I've trained for."

"And yet I have seen monsters you have not. It would take twenty men to fight off a Beithir."

He considers this for a moment. "Aye. Without the dàn I have, sure. But it's no myself I'm worried about. I'm worried about my family," he says. His mouth snaps shut, as if he hadn't wished to share his fear with me. I don't press him on it, returning to my mending. My thread runs out an inch shy of completely fixing the tear, and I sigh, knotting the end and throwing the spool into the fire.

The flames consume it, the fire flaring and spitting sparks into the night, and in the orange glow, Brennen becomes more clear. He's staring into the distance, deep in thought, his eyes haunted.

"You can bring them here," I say gently. "Your family. The new wards still hold. I swear I will not harm them." He looks up to me, his strong jaw tight. He considers me, but doesn't answer. Disappointment settles low in my belly.

He doesn't know if he believes me.

"Here," I say, reaching over the fire and holding out the needle. He stares at my hand, but doesn't take it.

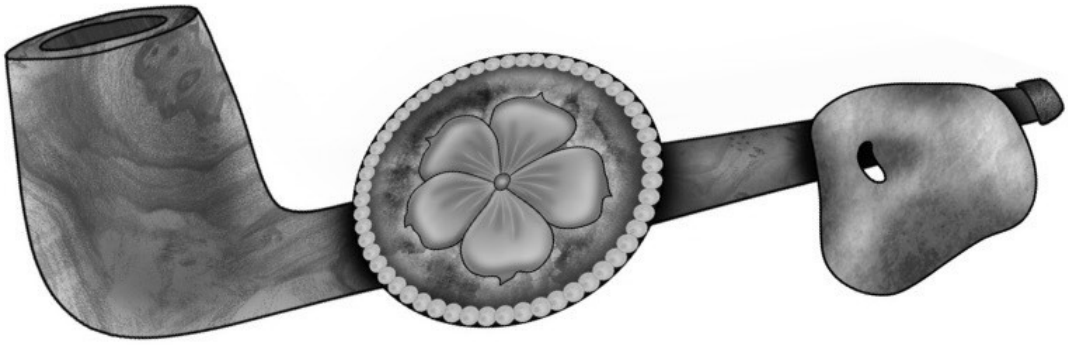
“Keep it,” he says, nodding to my hiding spot. Unease twits between my ribs from his knowledge of where it is, but even if he looked beneath the rock, all he would find are my trinkets. The pieces of the spell, the things that *really* matter, he'd have to dig much deeper to find. And why would he, if he thinks he knows all that’s in my trove?

I drop the needle in my apron pocket. “Not afraid of me anymore, then?” I ask, my voice teasing. He looks up, his eyes traveling across every inch of my face. The weight of his gaze pushes against my skin, so intense it feels as if he’s actually touching me, but I do not look away.

“That’s where you’re wrong. I think I'm more afraid of you now than I ever was,” he says, opening the book once again and returning to his reading without another word.

36

BEA



I wake to the earth groaning and the hair on my arms standing on end. There's a cry—a wail—and a feeling that someone is calling out to me.

I rise to my elbows, blinking the sleep from my eyes. There's another moan coming from downstream.

"Hello?" I call out, scrambling to my feet. I peer into the darkness, my eyes struggling to adjust now that the light of the fire is behind me. "Is someone there?"

The *After* pulses, its rhythm in beat with my pounding heart. Through the mist, a sliver of black, darker than the rest, appears.

"Helllppp meeee," The voice is human, but not. Raspy and pained, as if the person is uttering the words with their dying breath, and it hits me like a knife straight into my chest. I do not have a single rational thought. I only react; I'm in the water, in less than a second, fighting to get to the voice.

"Helllpppp meeee," they beg again.

"I'm coming!" I surge forward, but I do not make it far before my chain catches, and I fall, cursing under my breath. "Brennen!" I shout, scrambling to my feet. He emerges less than a second later, his eyes wide and hair messy.

"There's someone down there. They were crying for help, but I can't reach them!" My voice is panicked, on the edge of hysteria, because I can't hear them anymore. Are we already too late?

Brennen runs into the water without hesitation. “Where are they?”

“In the mist!”

Brennen pulls his shirt off, muscles rippling as he throws it onto dry land and dives into the deep part of the river.

He stands as he nears the *After*, moving to the side and peering into the black.

“Hello?” he shouts, but the smear of dark is gone. The *After* calms, receding. He looks back at me.

“I swear I heard someone. They were right there!”

He takes another minute to search, creeping closer to the drop hidden by the black shadows, avoiding touching their long, trailing fingers as he peers into the darkness.

“There’s no one here,” he repeats, taking his time to wade back to shore.

“Could they have fallen down?” I ask, my heart skipping a beat. What would An Glèidheadair do if a living soul fell in front of his gate?

“I dinnae think so. The water level is low today. It’s too shallow before the drop.”

I shake my head, my mouth going dry. “But I heard them. Someone was there.”

Brennen grabs his shirt, returning to the tent. I follow behind, but he closes the flaps, blocking me out. The sound of wet clothes falling to the ground meets my ears, and my breath hitches, the realization that he’s—

I lock my gaze onto the fire, trying not to picture his bare corded arms or the way his waist dips into a V at his hips. How taut and toned his stomach is.

My heart rate picks up as the flaps open again.

“If there was, they’re dead,” he says, completely unaware of where my mind has just gone. “No one survives the transition into the *After*. An Glèidheadair would kill them on the spot,” he says, answering my unspoken question. He holds an arm out to indicate I should come in. He’s wearing dry clothes, but his lips are tinged blue. I grab several more sticks and throw them onto the fire, but I don’t enter the tent.

He quirks an eyebrow. “Prefer to stay soaked?”

I press my lips together and take a tentative step inside, eyes flicking toward the *After*. There was someone there. I can still feel them. But even more, I’m suddenly aware of the space between Brennen and me. Or lack thereof. My body refuses to move deeper into the tent. For some reason,

even with whatever is lurking in the dark, being in the small space with him feels terrifying. Too much. Too close.

“I don’t want to get your bedding all wet.”

His eyes fall to my soaked dress and stop. My skin burns with awareness, his gaze locked onto the fabric clinging to my breasts, outlining more than I would like. My breaths tighten, the movement of my chest beneath my dress causing a rush of shivers through my sensitive skin. His throat bobs, and he looks away abruptly, as if severing a thought mid-sentence. He rubs the cut on his palm, moving to a stack of clothing and shuffling through it. He hardly seems to notice what he’s chosen, handing me a long-sleeved green tunic and stepping out of the tent, all the while avoiding my gaze.

I stand there in shock. He’d given me his shirt. A new, thick shirt *not* covered in stains and mud. I lift it to my nose, taking a deep breath, and the scent of juniper, smoke, and metal wraps around me—the smell of Brennen. I’ve caught hints of it on the wind when he’s standing upstream, but smelling it like this makes my head swim. The cloth is extraordinarily soft, and I rub it against my cheek.

For just a moment, an image of Brennen wearing the shirt flashes through my mind. The scent enveloping me because his arms are wrapping around me. Because he’s—

No. I shake my head, forcing the thought from my mind. Why am I thinking this way? Picturing him touching me. Actually viewing me as more than his duty. Why now, when I haven’t even thought of a man in more years than many people live?

Is it just his proximity? The fact that there has been a strong man, a warrior, so close for weeks now? Or is it that he’s not just a warrior, but a man of honor? Someone with more depth than I could have imagined behind the wall of anger he arrived with. A wall I’m beginning to see the cracks in.

I swallow, nodding to myself. That has to be it. Brennen is a good man, and I have been starved of male attention for a century. It’s natural to react this way. Or at least, I tell myself it is.

Pretending the clothing isn’t even his, I step out of my wet dress and pull the tunic on, adding my clothes to Brennen’s pile. The tunic is far too large, comically loose and hanging to my knees, and I try not to think about how muscular his arms and chest must be to fill it out so nicely.

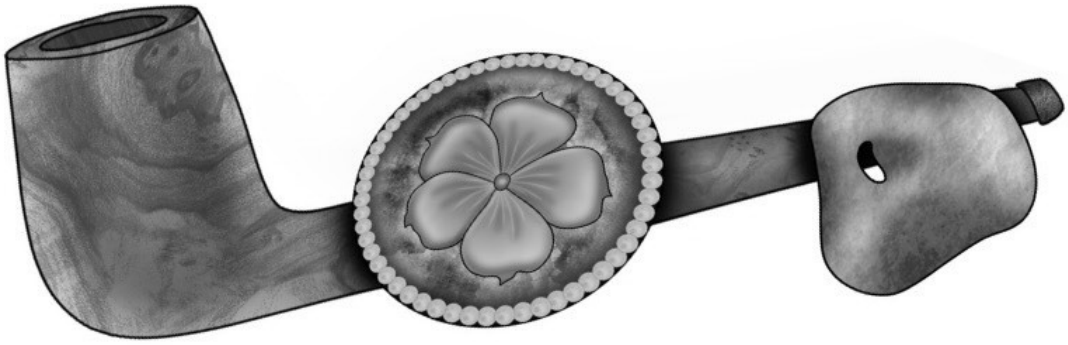
I try to push the thought away, but I cannot pretend the clothes aren't his.

My breaths go shallow. It's too intimate. Undeniably so, and my cheeks flush as I open the tent flaps and move back to my bed, sliding beneath my blanket as quickly as I can. I do not look at Brennen, but I *feel* his eyes on me as he returns to his tent. My stomach twists, but I ignore it, pulling the blanket over my head and staring into the *After*, searching for the blot of black I'm certain was there.

For anything to prove I'm not going mad once again.

37

BEA



Brennen’s gone to get supplies, so just as I have every other time he’s left the valley since moving his tent closer, I pass the time shuffling through his belongings. While he still keeps his weapons past the hollow log and firmly out of my reach, the rest of his things remain scattered about as if he’s still here. A half-finished carving sits on his desk, along with a haphazard stack of parchment and a pot of ink.

Curious, I flip through the pages. They’re notes on me. Things I’ve said and done, a catalogue of meaningless actions.

I toss them back on the wood, rolling my eyes as I slide my hands between the blankets stacked neatly in the corner, finding nothing. I search beneath his bedroll. In his spare clothing. If he has a naming pendant, it’s either on him at all times or, more likely, back wherever he calls home. Nor can I seem to find anything I could even hope is a promise broken.

Lolly roars, and I peek out of the tent, lying down by the fire. She's less active today. Lazy, almost. Flying in long, swooping arcs as she circles the glen. Her presence has become a comfort, and even Brennen seems to have gotten used to her.

An image of him flashes in my mind, the pain on his face as he tried to find the words to write in the letter to Betty’s sister. I still don’t particularly enjoy his rough exterior or his frequent anger, but I'm finding it difficult to hate *him*. It's undeniable he’s a good, respectable man. That he tries to do the right thing, always. I know better than to think anything he wrote will

ease Lillian’s pain, but maybe it helped soothe whatever seems to cause *him* so much of it, instead. I think of the picture of Betty’s parents, hoping An Treòraiche led her straight to them to be reunited.

I bolt upright. The picture. How had I forgotten about the picture?

A picture I’d brought back with me.

Anticipation burns along my skin, dangerous flickers of hope.

We hadn’t been able to come up with an explanation. I hadn’t really been there. My body had been *here* the entire time. Brennen confirmed it, but the picture had still come back clutched in my hands.

Can I bring anything I’m holding in the visions back with me?

My heart thunders against my ribs. This could be it. My chance to break the curse. How had I not thought about it before?

The visions seem to be getting longer. If I can find the last two pieces, hold on to them and bring them home, maybe after I complete my penance, I can finally do it. Maybe that’s *part* of my penance. The goddess of death offering me a way to atone. Find a way to stop these deaths, secure the pieces of the spell, and maybe, break this curse and go to my rest.

Maybe I can finally be free. On *my* terms, and no one else's.

I tilt my head up to the sky, throwing my arms out.

“This is it, Lolly!” I shout, spinning in a circle. My chain catches, and I stumble, but even through the pain in my ankle, I laugh—a real, joy-filled giggle. “It's finally going to happen.” Tears burn my eyes. I'm not foolish enough to think it will be instant, but this changes everything.

It gives me hope.

“What's finally going to happen?” Brennen’s rumble brushes against my skin.

I stiffen, turning around slowly, my heart rate picking up. “I— I was going to try to muster up the courage to ask you to bring me more thread to finish patching the hole in my skirt. I was going to be brave and ask for what I need.” He stares at me blankly, his scarred eyebrow raised.

“Um… Finally.” I force a smile, grateful Brennen no longer has his dàn of truth. It’s a weak excuse, but at least he doesn’t have proof I’m lying to him.

Brennen narrows his eyes, clearly not believing a word I said as his gaze flicks to my chain, but he doesn’t press me on it.

Interesting.

Why is he not suspicious, questioning me further? I don’t have time to examine why he let my blatant lie go so easily as he shakes his head and pulls a bundle from his satchel. It's yards worth of cloth, a sturdy, thick wool in a warm brown.

“You dinnae need thread.” He doesn’t shy away from looking at me as he holds the bundle out. “For you,” he says.

My mouth pops open in surprise. “That's enough cloth to make a whole new dress,” I say, breathless.

“No. It *is* a dress.” His voice is stiff. Overly formal. “And a new apron and shift.” He hands them both over to me, and the weight of the fabric brings tears to my eyes. I unroll it, taking in the details. The sturdy threads at the chest and thistles embroidered along the hem in soft tan thread. “Why — I don't understand why you would do this for me.”

“I think a century in that one is plenty,” he says, flexing his fingers around the fabric. “I know you think there’s magic holding it together, but it doesnae— Well it doesnae look to me like it’ll last you much longer,” he says, stumbling over his words, his nerves so at odds with his always-confident exterior.

“Surely the Fates aren’t so cruel they’d make me wash the dead’s clothes without wearing any myself,” I say, keeping my tone light. For some reason, I don’t want him to know how much this truly means to me. Part of me thinks he’ll pull back or shy away. But part of me thinks, if I show him how deep my gratitude runs, he’ll see me even more clearly than he already seems to.

Brennen’s green eyes drop, gliding down my body as if he’s imagining my clothes disintegrating into nothing, but he clears his throat and quickly looks away, his jaw going tight.

Is it possible it’s not just me who has imagined what the other’s body looks like beneath their clothing? Just the thought makes my knees weak.

I shuffle my feet as a strained silence stretches between us, growing more taut by the moment. He shifts, his hands fisting at his sides as he clears his throat.

“You should go change,” he says, nodding toward his tent.

“Right.” The warmth in my cheeks spreads into my chest, thankfulness thick in my throat. I turn toward the tent, but stop myself. “You didn’t have to do this, you know,” I say. “Not for me.”

Brennen shakes his head. “You may be my prisoner, but even prisoners have basic rights. I want to apologize on behalf of the Fates that your needs have not been recognized until now.” He meets my eyes. “I— It wasnae right.”

A lump forms in my throat, expanding until I can hardly speak past it. This is a man who doesn’t speak without knowing precisely what he’s going to say, stumbling over his words. Apologizing for something he didn’t do.

My stomach twists. “I appreciate that. Thank you,” I whisper, and he gives me a sharp nod.

“I’ll give you some privacy,” he says, not sparing me another look as he walks upstream out of the reach of my chain.

I walk toward the tent, unfolding the dress in my hands and holding it against my front. It seems to be exactly my size, as if it was made just for me. So does the apron, and my cheeks heat at the knowledge that Brennen is aware enough of my body to choose something that would fit so perfectly.

I run my fingers across the bodice, stilling when I find something in the pocket. Several needles and a spool of thread the same color as the thistle embroidery.

The lump in my throat thickens. *You may be my prisoner, but even prisoners have basic rights*, he’d said, but I don't think it was his duty to me as his prisoner that caused him to buy me this dress at all. He may have explained it away to himself as the noble thing to do, but I think it’s because, even if he cannot admit it to himself, he sees me now as more of a person than a monster. He’s given me blankets. Called me by my real name. Brought me something for my pain and wounds.

The dignity those acts of kindness have given me means more than the material possession of a new dress ever could.

I’m closing the tent flaps when Brennen leans down, and I pause, waiting to see what he’s found.

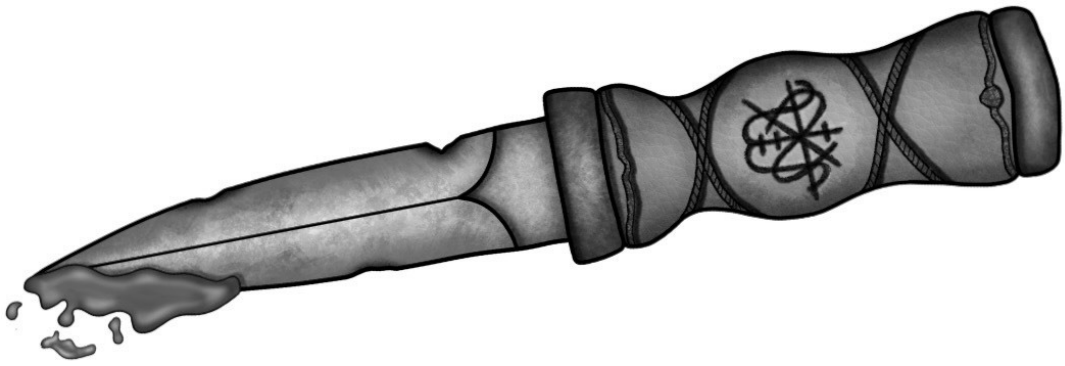
Tears sting the back of my eyes, my vision going blurry as they gather between my lashes.

Moss.

In his large, calloused hands is a thick sheet of moss. He bends down again, grabbing another, and that is when the tears finally fall.

38

BRENNEN



Bea stands in the middle of the river, her new dress soaked from the knees down. She's bent in half, her hands in the water, face scrunched in concentration. Her hair is pulled over one shoulder, the ends of her wild curls floating in the current. She looks ridiculous, but also—beautiful.

I *hate* myself for thinking it. For noticing how the sun makes her red hair shine and her freckles more prominent. How the reflection of the water makes her blue-grey eyes look deeper than the river itself.

"You'll never catch a fish with yer bare hands," I call, trying not to notice the way her breasts swell with her slow, steady breaths.

She scoffs, but the only thing that moves is her face. Her body remains perfectly still, ready to strike. "Hush. You'll frighten them," she hisses, eyes following a long, speckled blob in the water. It creeps forward to swim past her ankle, and she lunges. Water splashes outward as she careens sideways, and I push myself upright to see better.

She jumps up, triumphantly holding a wiggling brown trout overhead with both hands.

"You were saying?" she asks, a huge smile on her lips and delight in her eyes as she grabs a river rock and strikes the fish with a firm jab just behind its head. It stops fighting instantly—a quick, painless end.

My eyebrows raise in approval. "Who taught you that?"

“I taught myself. I’ve had quite a long time to learn, you know. You’d be surprised how much effort you’ll put into catching a fish when the only other thing you have to eat is bramble berries,” she says matter-of-factly, picking up several rocks to examine.

“Not how to catch them. How to kill them.”

Her hands still. “I didn’t enjoy killing it. If that’s what you’re saying.”

Shame burns the back of my neck. “No. I didnae say yeh did. But most people wouldn’t know to strike it behind the eyes like that. They’d just let it suffocate.”

Bea shakes her head, plucking up a rock with a sharp edge. “I didn’t like watching them fight for air. It looked painful. It took some time to figure it out, but a single firm strike seemed to be the quickest, most painless way.”

“Aye. It is.” She trudges to shore, lifting her skirt with one hand and holding the fish with the other. “You must have caught a lot of fish, then. Do you have to eat?” I ask, curious.

She shrugs. “Not technically. My body doesn’t change, remember?”

I force my eyes not to drop to the wet cloth clinging to the curves of her slim figure.

Bea bites her lip, dragging the sharp stone across the fish’s belly. Blood slips through her fingers as she pulls the insides out, and my stomach roils.

“Here,” I stalk forward, holding out my hand.

“I can gut a fish.” She looks at me with narrowed eyes as if I’m insulting her, but I cannae bear to see her already stained hands coated with fresh, hot blood. My stomach twists, and I clear my throat.

“As can I,” I say matter-of-factly.

Bea sighs, handing it over with a shrug. “Suit yourself.” She stands, cleaning her hands off in the water, and my pulse slows. Turning her back to me, she adds more wood to the fire.

I finish gutting the fish, then spear it on a stick. Bea holds her hand out as I move back to the fire, but I walk past her, settling down on my side of the flames and holding the fish over them to cook.

She leans back, studying me as I slowly rotate it.

“I didn’t realize you were such a gentleman,” she says with a playful smirk, and I suck on my teeth. She’s teasing me. She knows I’m not a gentleman, for the goddesses’ sake. I’m here to kill her.

So why did you buy her a dress and gather her moss for her bed? Why are you cooking her fish?

I bristle at my own thoughts. I'm behaving how a man should, prisoner or not.

For the first time, I'm glad my dàn of truth is gone. Because without it, I can pretend I'm not lying to myself.

"It's no about being a gentleman." I slowly twist the fish, trying to ignore her, but she leans forward, eyes boring into me. I swallow. "I'm used to taking care of people, is all."

She crosses her arms over her knees, laying her chin atop them. "That so?" she asks, her interest clearly piqued.

I make a noncommittal noise, not wanting to tell her more about myself than I have to.

"Well? Who is it you take care of, then?" she presses, but she seems nervous. Her feet tap against the ground, and she presses her lips together. I think she's afraid to push me. To have me pull back from the tentative understanding that has grown between us since I learned she didnae mean to kill anyone. It must be tempting, filling the silence with conversation after so long alone.

I allow my eyes to meet hers and instantly wish I hadn't. She stops tapping her feet, and her face turns shy. She looks away, pretending to examine her hem and allowing her hair to fall in front of her eyes to block her blush.

I dinnae like the way the flush of her cheeks warms my chest. Makes my cock twitch.

Marsaili.

Her name hits me with a sudden intensity, the guilt squashing any trace of desire in my blood.

"I'm the oldest of eight," I say, needing to focus on something else.

Her eyes light up, and I sigh. "My parents passed several years ago, just after my baby sister was born. I took care of my siblings after that, until my aunt and uncle moved closer to help. I practically raised Saoirse."

Bea smiles at me, so bright, I have to look away.

"I bet you're a wonderful brother. I'd imagine your siblings miss you very much."

My throat constricts at the compliment. I picture Saoirse's face. Her full cheeks and little dimples. "I'm not so sure about that. I think most of them think I'm too inflexible. I made them all finish their schooling. Didnae allow them to make any mischief."

She laughs, and the sound shoots straight between my ribs.

“That’s not so awful, is it? A brother who cares about you enough to make sure you stay safe and get an education. You could be like that husband you sent away, Hamish. Or you could’ve not cared at all.”

“Aye, perhaps. But my siblings are different from me. They always said I saw the world too rigidly. Right and wrong, with nothing in between.”

She feigns shock, popping her eyes wide open and placing a hand over her heart. “No. You don’t say.”

I suppress a laugh. “Aye. They'd grumble when I would give them consequences for their actions. Said what did it matter if the cows were milked before breakfast or after, or if the garden was tended to.” Bea nods as I speak, watching me raptly, as if trying to see beneath my skin.

“But I told them, there *is* right and wrong. If there are rules, they must be followed, or we’re no better than animals,” I say, and a bit of the tension I always carry in my chest eases. Like maybe if she understands my motivations, not just regarding her, but everything in my life, it will be easier to do what must be done.

She leans back, crossing her arms. “Sounds like you were woven to be a Dìdeanair. Were they angry at you for it? The rigidity you speak of?”

“No.” I can't help but smile as I picture Saoirse sticking out her tongue at me when I made her do extra cleaning after ignoring her chores for the day. She'd thrown a handful of bubbles from the washbasin at me. Always playful, even when I was cross.

“I think I would have liked for someone to have cared enough about me to make sure I grew up to become a good person. Maybe if I'd had that…” Her eyes go hazy.

“Did your parents not?”

She swallows, and her answering smile is sad. “My parents died when I was eight. I didn’t have anyone to take me, so I was dropped at the Weaver's Temple.”

“Were you dedicated to her?” I ask.

Bea shakes her head. “No. I used to bear the Cutter’s sigil. Though I've wondered why I would be dedicated to one Fate, but left with another. I don’t have an answer.”

“Who raised you?" I ask, confused. I’d never thought of the Washwoman as a child. Someone with a past I dinnae ken anything about.

“It wasn't the Weaver, if that's what you're thinking. I was sent to a home where many other children without parents lived. Most days, there was hardly enough to eat. But I guess, in a way, it gave me siblings. I had a family, of sorts, if not parents. When we turned fifteen, we were left to fend for ourselves.” My mind reels with this new information. She hadn’t only suffered this last century, but practically her entire life.

“Have you no memories of happiness?” I ask, my chest tightening.

She waves me off. “Of course I do. I made a friend, Molly, and together, we made our way here, to Dalbàsail. We were welcomed. I had a home.”

“You lived in the village?” I ask, wondering why no one in town told me this. The fish starts to smoke, and I realize I've stopped turning it. I flip it over, making sure not to let it burn.

“Aye.”

“No one in town told me that.”

Her eyes flash with sadness. “Part of the curse. When I was sentenced here, I was wiped from everyone’s memory. The people who hurt me… They were friends. People I’d cared about. People who’d cared about me.”

I recoil at the thought. To be hurt so severely is one thing, but for it to be done by someone who once knew you? It’s another level of torment altogether.

“I was happy, though. In Dalbàsail. Molly and I were inseparable.” She smiles. “She loved to read and was smart as a whip. She could tell you the name of any flower or plant and how to use them for medicine. And there was a man I thought loved me. Liam. He was kind, and as handsome as I’d ever seen. His family didn't have much more than I did, but it didn’t matter.”

“You loved him?” I ask. I dinnae ken where the words come from, but they fly out of me, gruff and jagged.

“Och,” she laughs, “I thought I did. But I was young and poor. I had nothing to offer him. He moved on after a while. To Molly, actually.” She doesn’t seem angry as she says the words.

“Aye. I know this story. The one of how you came to be cursed here. Liam moved on to your friend, and you wanted to kill them for it.”

Her eyes go wide with shock. “What?”

I sigh. “Dinnae act confused. It’s why the Fates sentenced you here, is it not? You were slighted by your friend. You wanted revenge. The man you

loved moved on, so when you saw your friend's clothes in the river, you stole them so you could kill her yourself, and her lover."

She's shaking her head as if at a loss for words, her fingers pinching at the skin of her arms. "That's not what happened at all. I was washing not far from here. My *own* clothes. We all did, back then. We were used to seeing clothing appear upstream. The river washed the clothes on its own, before I was cursed here. We knew better than to touch it. But I recognized Molly's burgundy dress, and lost all reason. I grabbed her clothes before I even knew what I was doing, because I *didn't* want her to die. And I certainly didn't kill Liam. "

My hand stills, the speared fish nearly falling from my fingers. I frown, confused. This isn't what the Cutter told me. Isn't part of her legend at all. But is anything I've learned of her in my time here accurate to her tale?

Very little seems to be, if I'm being honest.

"You didn't?" I ask, watching her face closely for any sign of deceit or discomfort.

"Of course not," she shakes her head vehemently, clearly appalled by my question. "Molly was my best friend. I didn't care that she and Liam had fallen in love. *Actual* love. Not whatever silly infatuation I'd had for him. I was happy for them."

Her words clash with the Cutter's telling of the story, as well as her own confessions. "You admitted you did it." I say, my chest tight and mouth dry.

She shakes her head. "No. I said I killed the people of Vengach. But Molly and Liam? No." She shakes her head. "Is that what the Cutter said? That I took the clothes so I could kill her myself? That I killed them both?"

I stare into the fire, my silence answer enough. Bea's face falls. "I don't understand. Why would she think that?" she asks. "All this time, I thought I was sent here for interfering with her magic."

I dinnae have an answer for her. "Did Molly live?" I ask instead.

Bea looks at the river, her eyes glazing over. "No. I was a fool to think I could save her. She died the next day. I don't know how her soul was cleansed. If An Glèidheadair accepted her." Her lips turn down, her eyes flashing with sorrow. "Liam followed close behind. I blame myself for his death. Wept as I washed his clothes. Cailleach thought I still loved him, I think. She wanted to take even that away from me."

There's a tug at my heart as a piece of her tale unfurls like blood in the river. How has her tale been so twisted over time? And how did the Cutter

get it so wrong?

“Have you ever loved anyone?" she asks, surprising me. The muscles in my shoulders tense, and my palm burns. Once again, I study her, searching for any hint that she already knows my answer. That I loved someone fiercely, and that *she* was the one who took her away from me. But it's not there. All I see is a gentle curiosity. A woman searching for connection.

“I was in love once,” I say, the words as painful as shards of glass scraping against my throat as I speak them.

She smiles at me, and I loathe how it makes my heart leap.

“Was it wonderful?" she asks, her voice soft. I picture Marsaili’s smile. The slight gap between her front teeth. The way her eyes crinkled when she looked at me with more love than I could have ever deserved. My throat closes, and when I speak again, my words come out choked.

“Aye. It was.”

I pull the fish from the fire, turning it around to make sure it's done.

“Well. What happened?” she asks.

I'm frozen for a moment. Unsure what to say. Part of me wants to shout at her, to shake her and tell her exactly what happened. That the woman I’m speaking of is gone because of *her* blood-stained hands. I want to demand she remember why she killed them. That she forces her mind to fill in the blanks in her memory.

Instead, I stand and hand her the fish.

“It ended,” I say, pulling the bird carving from my pocket as I stalk toward my tent, my chest so tight, I can hardly breathe. Too many emotions swirl inside it. Pity for this woman. Even more anger at her. Fury that I’m even able to feel both.

“Wait!” Bea calls as I'm ducking inside, and despite myself, I pause.

“Would you—” she hesitates, tucking a curl behind her ear. “Would you like some? It's been a long time since I've shared a meal with someone.” There's a vulnerability in her expression that makes my heart ache, and once again, I'm hit with the sensation that all of this is wrong.

But the grief settled in my chest burns hotter than that ache.

It has to.

My scar throbs, reminding me that even if I were to find a way to forget, to justify what she did, I would still have to kill her. I made a vow in my own blood, one my verra soul rests upon, and I cannae break it. Not just

because it’s what Marsaili deserves, but because I made that vow with the goddess of life and death herself.

“Not tonight,” I say.

Her face falls, and I almost turn back.

Almost, but I dinnae allow myself.

I keep my eyes forward as I step inside and pull out a piece of parchment and ink. This time, I write down memories of the night Marsaili died. The night my life changed forever. I write every last detail.

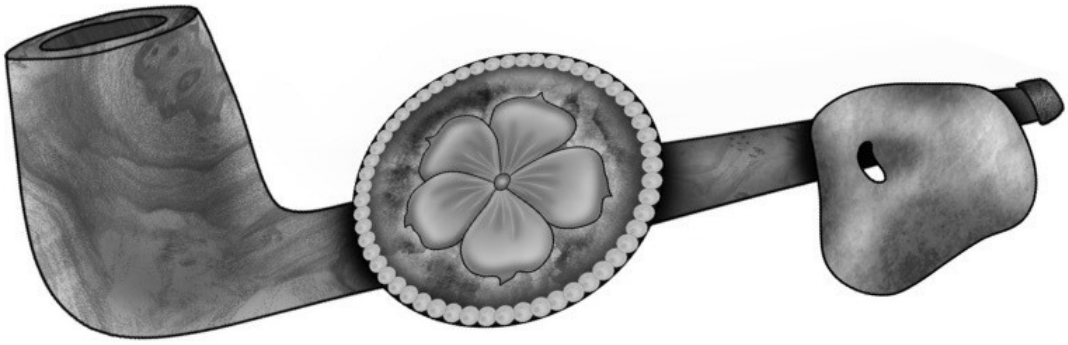
The blood.

The blank stare in Marsaili’s eyes.

And by the time I finish, I almost believe that I still want to kill the Washwoman.

39

BEA



Several days have passed since I asked Brennen to share a meal with me, and since then, he’s hardly looked my way. I try not to let it bother me when he stays by the fire, completely ignoring me as he either reads his journal or works on his bird carving. A bird I've seen him dismember, mutilate, and decapitate at least a dozen times.

It always starts out fine, his hands working the wood in an expert manner, but for some reason, he doesn’t maintain that temperament. He grows frustrated as he carves, and always, without fail, he ruins it. And each time, I wonder why.

I almost ask him, but something in his posture stops me, even though I can hardly stand the silence. It's worse than the quiet of being alone. Different, and filled with tension. Filled with meaning, although I don't know what it is.

I’d thought it’d been kind of me to offer to share the fish. He'd cooked it after all. And I’d hoped maybe we were developing more than just a tolerance to one another. A sort of friendship, even. He'd opened up to me more than I ever expected upon our first meeting, telling me about his siblings, and he’d really listened when I’d told him about my own childhood.

He slices into his carving again, and the bird’s wing snaps in half.

“*Mallachd*!” he says, throwing the block of wood into the fire.

“Is everything alright?” I finally ask, breaking the silence. His head snaps up, almost as if he'd forgotten I was chained here. He stares at me for a moment too long, but I don’t allow myself to shy away.

“Fine,” he says, picking up another piece of wood in his calloused hands.

Frustration buzzes inside my chest, but I’m not sure if it’s his or mine.

“Then why do you keep snapping the wings off your birds?” I ask pointedly, unable to handle his avoidance any longer.

His jaw clenches, and he picks up another block. “Because I can't get the bloody thing right.”

My dàn of truth flares, but I don’t call him out on it. “Are you sure it’s not because you're angry?” I ask.

He makes a deep, harsh slice. Then another. “Who said I'm angry?”

I let my silence be his answer.

He glares at me, and I sit up taller. This has gone on for too long; his inability to look at me. To move without fury and frustration.

“Well, aren’t you? You’re angry I asked you to eat with me. You’ve hardly said a word to me since. I didn't mean anything by it. Only that I had food and was willing to share. I know I'm your prisoner, and that you're going to kill me when the time comes. But, can't we at least be pleasant with one another in the meantime?”

He freezes. “Have I no been pleasant?" he asks, eyes flashing with darkness. “Did I no bring you a new dress? Give you a blanket? *Twice*?” He presses the edge of his blade against the block of wood, about to slice, but stops himself, his nostrils flaring. “Did I no save your life?” he asks, his voice rough, as if doing those things for me wasn’t pleasant for him at all.

I shrug, equally frustrated with him. “Well, not really the last one, seeing as I cannot die.”

I see it then, the moment his shroud of anger cracks. He's not smiling exactly, but his lips tilt up the slightest bit, and the darkness in his eyes shifts to something akin to mischief.

“You were close enough to it,” he grumbles, leaning back with a sigh.

I exhale, my shoulders lowering as the layer of ice between us thaws a bit. He makes a few far gentler slices.

“I'm no angry with you. Or,” he rubs the back of his neck. “I dinnae ken. Maybe I am.” He corrects himself before my dàn can alert me of his

lie. He stares into the fire, his jaw working as if he’s considering what to say. How much more to tell me.

Just say it. My heart begs. *Say anything*.

“It's alright if you're angry at me, you know. I can handle it,” I say softly, and he closes his eyes, almost like the words hurt him. But they’re the truth. I’m not naive enough to believe he’ll disregard his duty for me. Not this man, to whom justice matters more than anything else, and who follows simple rules as if they’re law.

I do not need him to betray himself for me, but it would be nice if we could be something at least akin to friendly until the time comes when he must do what’s required of him.

Hopefully I can complete the spell before then, and that day will never have to come at all.

A rustling sounds in the woods, and Brennen jumps to his feet, hand on his sword.

“Announce yourself!” he says, and I wonder how he knows it's a person. All I can hear is a vague shuffling, easily explained by an animal, but Brennen is tense. Does he have a dàn for sensing danger, perhaps? Maybe enhanced hearing?

“It’s only me,” a deep voice says, and Brennen visibly relaxes. A man walks into the glen. He's handsome. Strong, with short hair and bright brown eyes. He looks familiar, and I try to place him. There’s a kindness about him, and I warm to him immediately, even as a sharp pinch of pain flashes through the dàn on my leg.

“Theo,” Brennen says, his brows drawing together as he stands. “Is everything okay? Has something happened?”

The man Brennen called Theo raises his hands. “No. Everything's fine. I received a letter for you a few days ago, but you havenae been back to restock on supplies. I thought I should bring it to you, in case it was important.”

He steps forward, handing one of the two satchels in his hands to Brennen.

The feeling that I’ve met this man before gets stronger, but I can’t place him. “I know you,” I say, tilting my head. He turns to me and smiles.

“Aye. We’ve met before. I was just a wee lad then.” He holds a hand out to about hip height. “Though I dinnae ken how you could remember me from so long ago.”

“She has a dàn of memory. Stole it from me, you know,” Brennen says, opening the satchel.

“Stole it from you?” Theo raises his eyebrows.

“Dinnae ask,” Brennen says. “She—”

“I remember,” I interrupt them, unable to hide my smile as the memory of a young boy with curly hair and dimples flashes through my mind.

“You came here because your parents hid your sweets. You wanted to know where they were. Did you find them, then?”

His answering smile is as bright as my own.

“Aye.” He leans forward conspiratorially. “I found them, alright.”

I clap my hands together in delight. “I'm glad. Though I hope they were worth risking coming to see the Washwoman for. You got quite a fright, didn’t you?”

He laughs. “Aye, I did. And I suppose it was a risk, but I'm a good judge of character. The village may be afraid of you, but even when I caught you and asked my question, I didnae fear you. I never have.”

My eyes flick to Brennen, but he’s shuffling through his bag, seemingly distracted by its contents, and I relax.

“I think I like you, Theo,” I say with a broad smile.

He gives me a half-bow. “It's an honor to meet you again.” He holds out the satchel. “I brought you something, too.”

Surprise flits through my belly as he hands over the bag.

“For me?” I ask, opening it. There's a container inside, and it's warm in my hands.

“Food?” My mouth waters, but I force myself not to rip it open and devour it. If I’m going to be treated like a lady, I’d like to behave like one. I crack it open, the delicious scent of thyme and rosemary wafting through the air, and wonder how my fortune seems to have changed so drastically since Brennen arrived. I now have a sturdy dress. A dàn of warmth, and a fire to sleep beside. A blanket and food. Company, even if it's begrudging. All of those things, I have because of Brennen.

Was he a gift from the goddess, or is it just luck? Either way, I am grateful.

“It’s just stew,” Theo says, “but with it being so cold, I thought the two of you might do well with something hot in your belly.” He runs a hand through his hair. “I’m sorry I haven’t brought you something before.”

I shake my head. “No, that’s okay. It smells delicious.”

“Aye, it does,” Brennen says, his container already open. “Would you like to join us?”

“No.” Theo raises his hands. “I’ll need to get back to the tavern. I’m teaching Anna the ropes. She’s a natural, but she’s not quite ready to be on her own for long.”

“I’m glad to hear that. So she willnae need new lodging, then?” Brennen asks.

I tilt my head. Who is Anna, and why was he finding her lodging?

“No. She’d like to stay. Billy’s friends are here, after all. I’ll exchange lodging for help at the tavern.”

Brennen shakes Theo’s hand, and something passes between them, but I can’t place the emotion. Camaraderie, perhaps? If they’re speaking of Billy’s mother staying at the tavern, it must mean Brennen helped them with whatever was causing their predicament.

Theo starts to turn, then pauses. “By the way. Harold's been asking after you. I told him I’d pass along his message to find him next time you come to the village.” He nods. “Washwoman.”

“Bea,” Brennen says, and I whip my head toward him in shock, but he's too busy inspecting his stew to notice. A lump forms in my throat, surprise rippling out of me until I feel like I’m glowing as bright as the moon, but somehow, Brennen doesn’t seem to sense how much that correction means to me. Doesn’t realize he’s only giving me more evidence to believe he no longer views me as a monster.

Theo looks at Brennen, raising his eyebrows. “Bea, then,” Theo says with a kind smile.

“Thank you!” I call after him as he disappears, my heart lighter than it’s been since before I was sentenced here.

Brennen settles by the fire.

“Let's eat then, before it gets cold.” He pulls out a spoon, crossing his legs. I try to hide my smile at the invitation as I do the same.

We eat in comfortable silence, and it’s nice, this piece of normalcy. Even if it won’t last forever.

“Guess you're not afraid to share a meal with me after all,” I say before I consider what those words could do.

He stops his spoon halfway to his mouth, and I hold my breath, afraid he will put it back down. Afraid he will make an excuse and leave. But slowly, never breaking eye contact, he takes a bite.

“No. I guess I’m not,” he says. The words scrape across my skin, a pleasant warmth following behind them.

He clears his throat, then looks away, poking his spoon around in his food. He finds a piece of carrot, scooping it up, and I do the same.

“What are you always carving?” I ask, testing whether this meal might not include just company, but conversation as well. “I know it's a bird, but—”

“A robin,” he says, short and to the point as always. I sit up straighter, excited he actually answered me this time.

I peer closer, and the fact that it’s a robin becomes more obvious. It’s small and round, with a short, delicate beak. How did I not see it before?

“Robins are beautiful birds. Are they your favorite?” I ask, prodding gently.

“Something like that,” he answers tightly, taking a chunk of wood off near the foot.

I sigh wistfully, ignoring his obvious continued tension. “I should think, if I were a bird, I'd like to be a skylark. Robins are beautiful, but I love the way larks sing as they take flight. How high in the air they’re able to soar.”

He pauses his carving to take another bite, but doesn’t look up at me, and something pinches in my chest.

Talk to me, I silently beg.

“If I were a bird,” I continue softly, “I would fly far away from here and never look back. See what's beyond the mist.” I picture myself soaring over the black fog to another kingdom. Another realm, where there are no Fates to curse me. Where I could begin again.

“I’d still have to catch you,” he says, and my lips quirk into a smile.

“You could try. But I’m very quick when I’m not chained,” I tease, and he looks at me. His eyes are dark, swirling with emotions I can’t decipher. He stares at me intently for a long moment, and my heart sinks. There’s a war waging somewhere deep within him, spilling into his expression.

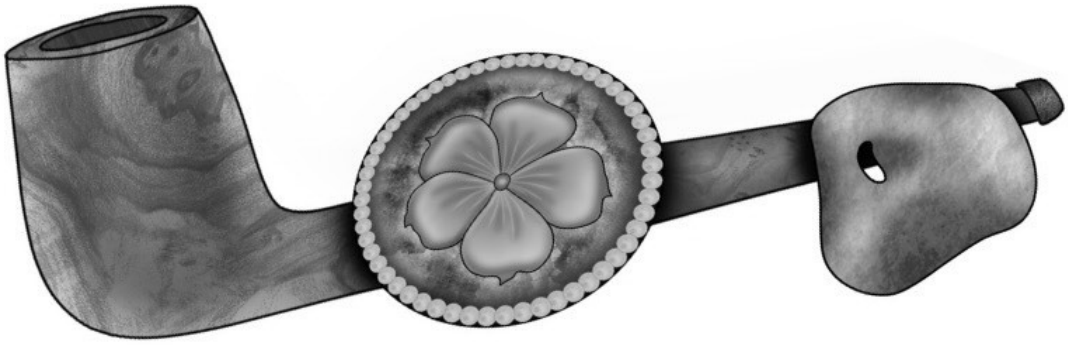
“Don’t worry,” I say, rubbing my sternum as an ache forms there—a need to eradicate whatever it is threatening to pull him back into his mind. “Lucky for you, I am not, and will never be a bird,” I say, sorrow swelling in my heart for this man.

He meets my eyes, his expression tight, but for just a second, his mask of control slips. His shoulders fall, just a fraction, and he squeezes his knife

tighter in his hand. “I wish you could be,” he says, so quietly, I almost wonder if I imagined it.

40

BEA



My mouth waters as I lift another spoonful of stew and watch my dragon land on her ridge. Brennen doesn't even flinch this time, and I smile, content. The scent of beef and carrots and potatoes wafts through the air, the most delicious thing I've smelled in years, and I take a bite, moaning as the warm broth coats my tongue.

"It's no that good," Brennen says, even though his bowl is already halfway finished.

"It's the best thing I've ever tasted," I say, taking another bite. I try to slow down and savor it, but it's too delicious. "I'm getting spoiled as a prisoner, I think," I say, and Brennen laughs. *Actually* laughs. The sound shoots straight to my core, a deep, husky noise, like a stubbly beard scraping across delicate skin, and my stomach clenches.

What is happening to me? Is all it takes a singular laugh to turn me into a blushing young lass?

Brennen takes another bite, then sets his bowl down and opens the letter. His somewhat jovial mood seems to burn away instantly, and he leans forward, his knuckles white from his grip on the parchment.

I freeze. "What is it? Was the Cutter not happy with your letter? Is it because I asked you to tell her to stop—"

"No. It's not from the Cutter. It's from Lillian." He looks up, and the horror in his eyes causes my blood to turn to ice.

"What did she say?" I ask.

Brennen,

I dinnae understand the meaning of your letter, nor how you have a portrait of my parents. Betty disappeared several days ago and has not been seen since. How did you learn of her disappearance? Has she been found?

Surely my sister is not dead. Wouldnae I know if she were? Wouldnae I feel it? Please, tell me what you meant by your letter. I cannot live only wondering.

Lillian

The stew turns sour in my stomach, and my hands shake so severely I'm forced to put the bowl down completely.

“Disappeared, like the others you mentioned?” I ask.

Brennen nods as he reads the letter again in full, his eyes flying across the lines of the page as he mumbles the words.

I shake my head. “But I washed her clothes.” I hold up my stained hands. “That’s what happens. The way of things. I wash the clothes, and the souls pass on.”

Brennen stands and begins to pace, stew forgotten, his hands clenched into fists. “But before you washed her clothes, it was different. You were singing, but it wasn’t the same song you normally sing. And you weren't *here*. Your eyes were blank and glassy.”

“The visions. The ones of people living their usual lives.” I say. “What if the Cutter knows nothing of these deaths at all? What if she truly doesn’t know the women who’ve disappeared have died?”

“Have you had many of these visions?” Brennen asks, morphing into a soldier in front of my eyes.

I nod, my mind reeling, my stomach churning. “More than I can count.”

“Is it always women?”

“I don't know. Sometimes it's just a woman in the vision, but sometimes there are several people. I— I don't look to see if it’s men’s or women’s clothes when I wash them anymore. I don’t like knowing who's going to die. Not after witnessing their happiness.”

Brennen rubs the back of his neck. “But is there always a woman present? A young one?”

I close my eyes and shuffle through my memory.

The pub. The hilltop. The cottage. “Yes, I think so. There's always at least one.”

He nods, his eyes far away as he shifts through his thoughts. “Is there anything else that's similar about them?”

“The people in the visions. They can see me. At least, for a moment. I can interact with them. And the visions seem to be getting longer.” Pebbles crunch under his feet as he continues to pace. “And there's always music. The same melody. Humming or singing or bagpipes. Sometimes a violin or whistling. But it's always there.”

“And do clothes always come downstream after these visions?”

“Every single time. I wash them just like I wash any others and send them into the *After*.”

He stops pacing, his gaze settling on my hands. He stares at them for a long moment, then meets my eyes. “And when you get the clothes, is there blood on them?”

A chill works its way down my spine, and I close my eyes, trying to remember. I do not look at the clothes as I wash, but had blood floated downstream as I’d cleansed them? I don’t think it did. I shake my head. “No,” I whisper, my voice shaking. “How did I not see it? It shouldn’t be possible for so many to die without a single drop of blood.”

Brennen’s jaw tightens. “Could it be poison?”

It’s hard to speak through the bile rising up my throat. “There are several ways the dead pass without bleeding. Certain poisons, but not most. Drowning. Suffocation. But what if they’re not actually dead? What if someone is taking them? Hiding them away?”

Brennen rubs his forehead. “It’s ancient magic that sends souls to the *After*. Their souls are bound to the garments you cleanse. If the *After* has them, they’re gone.”

“I didn't know,” I say, twisting my hands together. I don’t want him to believe I was hiding things from him. Not when his dedication to the Cutter

is so absolute. Not now that we've found some common ground. "I need you to know that. I didn't know I was washing clothes the Cutter didn't send to me. I tried to fight against it. I thought maybe she was testing me. Sending me into the visions to see if I'd try to save them, or I thought maybe she or the goddess were giving me the chance to atone. I thought if I could save them—"

He holds up a hand. "I ken you didnae know. I saw the pain in your eyes after that vision. How badly you wanted them to stop." He stands. "I have to go to Cailleach. Warn her of what's happening. If all these women are dead, then someone is working against her will. Someone is actively defying the Fates and their rule."

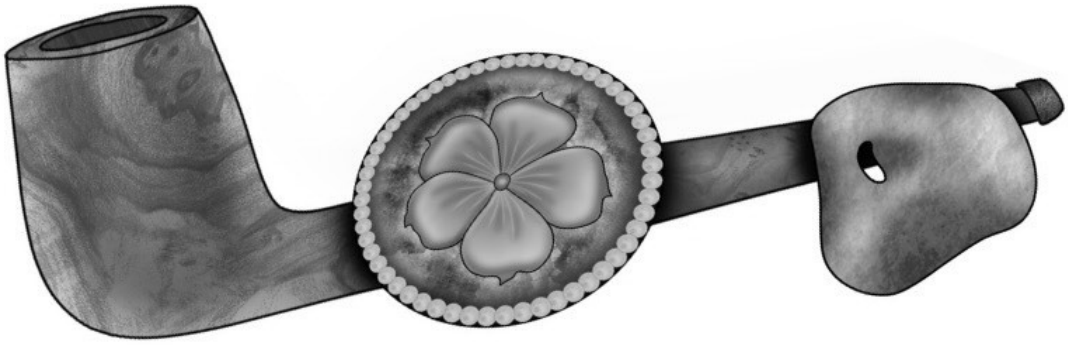
My mind spins. It shouldn't even be possible. "But who? Who could possibly have enough magic to go against them?"

Brennen grabs his satchel and whistles for Sable, wasting no time. He doesn't pack up his tent or bother grabbing his other items, simply running to mount the mare.

He meets my eyes. "Ceatharnaich? I dinnae ken. But I'm going to find out.

41

BEA



"Guess it's just you and me again, Lolly," I say, stretching out in front of the fire to watch the giant dragon swoop across the sunset. She doesn't answer of course, and a pang of sadness settles deep in my belly.

The quiet feels different than before. Even during the days Brennen had ignored me, I'd heard him shuffling through his tent or walking along the rocks. Now that he's gone, the glen feels too big and empty. So much lonelier than before.

The wind shifts, and I roll over, preparing to wash, but the river is brown. Bog myrtle permeates the air, and my stomach fills with equal parts dread and anticipation.

I brace myself for the vision, the world tilting and my head swimming, and then I'm inside a tailor's shop. Bolts of multicolored fabric sit stacked on floor-to-ceiling wooden shelves, mostly wool and linen, in every shade imaginable. Spools of thread are scattered at a workstation, along with shears and some chalk. There are three mannequins, eerily bare. The shop is empty except for a man sitting at a counter.

He's singing under his breath, a melody that brings gooseflesh to my arms.

There's friendship in bushels and tales long been said.

Let's tell each other's before we fall dead.
Can happen in moments, the blink of an eye.
The river will take you when it's time to die.

A song cannae tell you the time it will end.
As long as you live, a new one can begin.
A thread cannae cut if it cannae be seen.
If I ask it of you, will you hide mine for me?

So sing till— "Oh, hello. I didnae hear you enter," the man says, leaning back to look at me with wary eyes. He's clearly unsure of how I suddenly appeared, no ding of a bell or shuffle of footsteps, but he is not the only one confused.

It isn't men who are disappearing. And yet, he's the only person I see.

"Are there any women here?" I ask, my voice urgent. I don't know how much time I will have here.

"Aye. My daughter. Why do you ask?"

"Well—" I clear my throat, trying to think of a suitable excuse. "I'd like to take in my gown, but I'd feel more comfortable with a woman doing it.

His eyes narrow, but he stands, relief crossing his face. "Suit yerself."

The moment he leaves, I dash behind the counter, scrambling to find something, *anything*, that could help complete my spell, but there's nothing of use. A thimble. Thread and needles. Some money.

"Can I help you?" The woman's sharp voice stops me in my tracks, and I turn. "Or would you prefer to keep digging in my da's belongings?"

"I'm sorry. I was looking for a handkerchief. I had a coughing fit, and—I apologize."

"Right," the young woman says, her narrowed eyes telling me she doesn't believe a word I said as I close the drawer and step away. Her gaze flicks down my body. "Da said you want your dress taken in? It looks perfectly fine to me."

I rush forward, grabbing her hands. "I need you to listen to me, you're in danger," I say, looking around the shop for whatever it might be that will cause her death, but I don't see anything amiss or dangerous.

The woman stumbles back, her eyes widening with fear. She yanks her hands away, bringing them to her chest. "What are you talking about? Who

are you?”

“Never mind who I am. You're in danger. You need to run. Now, and don't look back.”

“You’re frightening me," she says, her lips trembling.

I want to shake her. *Run!* My mind screams. “I’m sorry, but you should be frightened. Listen to me. I know this is terrifying, that I sound insane—”

“Your hands…” she says, her eyes filling with fear. “They're covered in blood. Who are you? Da!” she shouts.

I hold them up, reaching toward her. “I am the Washwoman of the River of Death. The Bean-Nighe.” I try to make my voice as menacing as possible. Let her fear me. Maybe fear will spur her to listen. I stalk forward. “And if you do not wish for me to wash your death-clothes,” I lean forward, baring my teeth. “Run.” I barely get the word out before I’m thrown back to the river.

My heart pounds as I look around, getting my bearings. My hands shake, and my breaths come in short pants as I look upstream, praying.

Please, let her listen to me.

Please, let her run.

The river holds its breath, and so do I. Five seconds. Then ten.

Shouldn’t the dress have appeared by now, if the woman was going to die? How long did it take the other times?

The river pauses, slowing, and hope bubbles in my chest.

But a gust of wind comes, and upstream, the woman’s yellow dress appears. I scream in frustration, but the magic of the curse turns the sound into my song. It’s ripped violently from my throat as I’m thrown to the ground, the riverbed slicing into the skin of my knees. It's agonizing, but the magic holding me in place doesn’t even allow me to shift off my wounds.

“Why?” I scream at the river, even as my fingers work. I inspect the dress.

There’s no blood.

“Please, don’t take her!” I picture the woman's face. Did she not listen to me? Did she not flee? Or had it simply been impossible to outrun whatever was coming for her?

Lolly roars, and I feel her rage in my chest. Like all the others, this death isn’t right.

The curse releases me, and I collapse, my heart cracking in two. Another vision, and I neither found what I needed to complete the spell nor

saved the girl. It’s not simple sadness I feel, but utter defeat. Failure, hot as a brand on my skin.

I wash my bloody knees off in the water, then move to the tent where my bandages remain, sitting on Brennen's bedroll as I dress the scrapes. His scent wraps around me, juniper and smoke and metal, and it calms my racing heart a fraction. Brennen is out there, possibly telling the Cutter what's happening as we speak. This will all end soon.

The thought brings me comfort, but also terror.

There will be a limit now to how long these visions will continue, for surely the Cutter won’t allow these deaths outside of her control to go on. I have no choice but to find the last two pieces of the spell before she finds whoever is killing these women. It’s my only chance to be free of this prison without spending another century searching pockets or dying at the edge of Brennen’s sword.

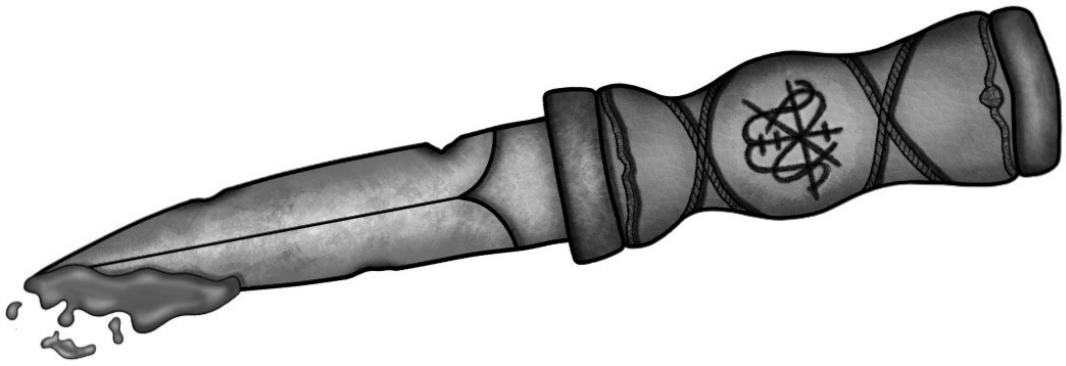
I steady my resolve, wrapping it around myself like armor. In my next vision, I *will* find what I need to break this curse, and I *will* find a way to help these women as I do it. I will end my part in whatever is happening to them so I can go to my rest knowing I’ve done all I can to atone. That, even despite the things I’ve done, I’m still a good person.

The thought is as comforting as a heavy cloak, and suddenly, I am so very tired. I lie down, wrapping myself in Brennen’s blankets. It feels as if his heat remains in the fabric, and it’s comforting in a way. My eyes grow heavy, and I roll over to sleep. This will all be over soon.

Brennen will make sure of it.

42

BRENNEN



Doimhneachd nan Dà looms in the distance as I approach the Cutter’s castle. The loch shared by the three Fates glistens in the moonlight, calm and peaceful, a striking contrast to the stormy unease raging through my body. The island in the middle is barely visible through the smir, the enormous cairn of stones built upon it as prominent as ever, and not for the first time, I wish I could go there.

The architecture of it is beautiful, and I'm certain the view from atop would be stunning. I think I would brave the long swim, especially on a night like this, when the cold water might steady me before I meet with the Cutter. I'm certain I would, in fact, if not for the Fates’ pets—the enormous black serpents that call the loch home, guarding the Fates’ castles from behind.

I scan the water for glimpses of their razor-sharp scales breaking the surface, but the water remains completely still. It’s almost more eerie, not seeing them, knowing the monstrous beasts lurk somewhere beneath the surface, completely hidden. It's rumored they remain from an Epoch hundreds of years ago and were allowed to survive the Fates’ wrath in exchange for their protection.

I've always found that curious. Why fortify the only area protected by their other sisters? Why not create a moat in front, where they are the most vulnerable? Is it possible it’s because the Fates do not trust their sisters as much as they say?

I shake the thought away as I arrive at the portcullis. No one is guarding the door, but I'm not surprised. The kingdom is asleep. Only a fool would try to enter at this hour.

Let me be a fool.

It would be a bigger mistake to wait. If Cailleach learned I had information about the missing women and did not share it immediately, I fear there would be no forgiveness.

I bang my fist against the thick wood, then step back to wait. It takes a few minutes, but eventually, the enormous gate lifts. Garrick strides forward, his usually jolly eyes widening in concern when he sees me. He looks well, his hair cropped shorter than the last time I saw him, beard trimmed and well-groomed.

"What's happened? What are you doing here?" he asks, clasping my forearm and pulling me into a tight hug.

"I need to see Cailleach as soon as possible," I say, returning the hug before striding toward the front of the castle. Garrick nods to the guards outside, and they open the doors without hesitation. There's a sense of deja vu as I enter between the enormous black monstrosities. Has it really only been a month since I last walked through them? How could so much have changed in such a short time?

"Wait here," Garrick says, disappearing toward Cailleach's quarters.

I push down the dread and anticipation coiling in my stomach, studying the portraits in the hall to distract me as I wait. The largest sits in the middle of the wall—a quarter-dragon-tall image of the Cutter reclined on her throne of bones, her skin so pale, it's nearly translucent, a thread turning to dust in her jewel-covered fingers. There's a hint of a smile on her lips, and her eyes are bright. It's chilling, and I can't help but wonder whose life she ended while sitting for this portrait.

On her right sits the Measurer. Warm brown skin and black hair woven into an elaborate plait that trails down her back. Her eyes are closed, her serious expression emphasizing her high cheekbones, and she holds both hands out, a length of thread draped across them.

And then, on her right, the Weaver. She sits at a loom, red hair loose, her hands raised as she spins the threads with her magic. The window is open, and light shines through, highlighting the softness of her features and rosy skin. Of the three of them, she seems the kindest, a soft smile pulling at her lips.

There's little resemblance between them, except for their eyes. Unnaturally blue, all-knowing, and as endless as the sea. I step forward, and they seem to follow me. It’s eerie, and I shift to my left. Three large strides. Their eyes remain fixed on me, and I fight the shiver running down my spine, forcing my eyes away from theirs. Magic, surely.

My gaze slips from the gilded frames to the ornate wallpaper. Black with gold embellishments—the shapes of bones and thistles intertwining with Cailleach’s dàn. But where the wall meets the corner, there’s a sliver of blue. With a quick look over my shoulder, I hurry to examine it. I listen for the sound of footsteps as I peel away a strip roughly the size of my palm.

Beneath the black and gold, the wallpaper bears a different pattern. The thistles remain, but there are no bones, and the dàn is different. The difference is slight, but I notice it immediately.

Extra lines cross through the center, and the curves are deeper. I lean closer, trying to discover each change. Looking for clues as to why it was ever changed at all.

My dàn of danger flares, and I jump back, pressing the wallpaper back into place the best I’m able. Only a moment later, Garrick appears. I wait for him to crack a joke, but his expression remains stern.

“She’s ready for you.” He leans closer so that only I can hear him. “Be warned. She isnae happy about being woken.” I nod, steeling myself for her ire, quickly rolling down my sleeves before my missing dàn can be noticed. With a deep breath, I push open the doors.

At the end of the long aisle, Cailleach rests on her throne. She's wearing a dressing gown, and her long hair is braided down her back. Her lips are red, as if she’s been drinking wine, and even in the night, her fingers are covered in rings. Blood-red rubies and sparkling diamonds and brilliant blue sapphires. *Does she ever take them off?*

“Leave us,” she tells Garrick, her voice icy. He exits the room quickly, closing the door firmly behind him.

There’s a flash of relief when I realize Athair isn’t present, but it’s short-lived. Cailleach’s eyes bore into mine, anger radiating off her in waves.

I drop to a knee. “My queen—”

“Why are you not at your post?” she asks, skipping all pretense. I dinnae dare to look up.

“Something has happened. Something I thought you would want to know about as quickly as possible. I rode through the night to get here.”

“So you left the Washwoman alone?”

“I’ve assigned someone to check on her. Someone I think you should consider recruiting as a Dìdeanair. They will see she doesnae disappear.”

Cailleach’s eyes narrow, and the room grows cold. “You left her with a civilian?”

I stiffen at her sharp, disapproving tone, and I’m suddenly glad I did not name Theo as the one I asked for help. “Aye. But I can assure you, The Washwoman is secure. Her chain holds, and I checked her wards myself just before leaving. Escape is impossible.”

There's a long stretch of silence, the weight of her judgment so heavy on my shoulders, it’s a fight to remain upright. Her fingernails click on her armrest as she taps her fingers in a rolling metronome.

Click, click, click, click.

Click, click, click, click.

She sighs. “Rise and speak, then. But I will warn you, should your message not warrant waking me in the night, I will not be pleased.”

I shiver, but rise. “It’s about the disappearances. I’ve learned something about the women who are going missing.” Her head snaps up, her eyes narrowing.

“What have you learned?”

I swallow, squeezing my hands into fists to keep them from shaking. “I —I do not think the women are alive.”

She leans forward, and for a moment, I wonder if *she* can breathe fire, just like Athair. “And why would you think that?” she asks, her voice ice.

I do not cower. “The Washwoman has been having visions. Instead of death, she’s seeing life. Happy moments. She thought maybe you had changed her punishment. But— I witnessed one of her visions. Forced her to describe it. It was a woman from my village. Betty. I sent a letter of sympathy about her death to her sister, and she responded. She is one of the disappeared, and yet, she is dead.”

Cailleach’s fingers still as she grips the arm of her chair.

“Dead?” She hurls the word at me like an accusation, and the anger in her voice makes the hair on my neck stand on end. I scramble to find the words that will make her understand.

“I know we believed they disappeared and were alive somewhere. That you hadn’t seen their deaths or cut their threads, but these women who are missing… Their clothes have been washed. Every one of them.”

She slams her hands on her chair, rising to her feet. Her expression darkens, her lips twisting into a sneer.

“How dare you?” She lowers her chin. “You actually believe there are deaths occurring within *my* kingdom I do not know about?”

I have to fight not to step back from her fury. “I beg your forgiveness, but that is exactly what I think. Someone is committing treason. Someone is killing outside of your power.”

She waves a hand as if dismissing me, but her eyes flash darker. “Impossible.”

But is it? There are thousands upon thousands of threads in this room. I’ve stood here and fought against the urge to look at them, only noticing the sheer number of them in my periphery as they float into her hands when it’s time for a life to end. How they crumble to dust and disappear when it does. If someone somehow accessed power that could sever the threads magically from afar, without needing her to do it, would she even notice?

I dinnae dare ask.

Cailleach narrows her eyes at me. “Did I not tell you the Washwoman would aim to fool you? Manipulate you? Are you really so weak,” she spits the word like it’s poison on her tongue, “that she was able to break you so easily?”

“I dinnae think she's lying,” I say softly, but firmly.

“Silence.” She doesn’t raise her voice this time, but the harsh softness of her tone is even more terrifying than obvious fury.

“It is not possible for deaths to occur outside of my will. The only way a life ends in this realm is between these fingers.” She holds her hand up, and several threads float into it.

Seven of them.

I nearly vomit, my breath ripping from my lungs in a violent whoosh. Why did I come here? I knew Cailleach wouldn’t take kindly to my concerns, that she would be defensive, but I truly thought her love of her kingdom—her duty to it—would be stronger than her pride. My hands shake as the threads settle on her fingers, and I clench them into fists.

“I— I apologize. ”I bow deeply. “Please, forgive me for my misguided concerns.”

She smiles at me, a cruel twist of her lips beneath dark, rage-filled eyes. “Are you not capable of the task I have given you?”

I shake my head, raising my hands. “I am. I was mistaken. I only thought—”

“I wouldn't blame you if it was too much.” Her voice is calculated as she lifts one of the threads, and I nearly leap forward and rip it from her hands. Whose is it? Cillian’s? Saoirse’s?

“Though I thought, with your history, with your Marsaili, you would be beyond her manipulation. I thought with your unbreakable vow and your vengeful heart, you would be blind to her deception.”

“I am capable. I thought I discovered information that would help, but even though my intent was pure, I was clearly wrong. I’m only a human, unable to fully grasp the immensity of your power.” I step forward, pushing resolve into my voice until it is as hard as steel. “My mission hasnae changed.” I lift up my hand to show my unbreakable vow. “I want vengeance. I want to do *your* bidding, and when the time comes, I want to kill the Washwoman,” I say, but the words feel wrong coming out of my mouth.

Cailleach sighs dramatically, but the anger in her eyes lessens a fraction at my groveling.

“I think some time away from the Washwoman would do you well. My dear sister is concerned about a village in Tìr an Tomhais. Iomallrùin. She believes a pocket of ceatharnaich could be forming there. You will go there and investigate. After you are certain none remain, you are to go home. Visit your Marsaili’s grave. See your family. I think it would do you well to lay eyes on them again. You never know how long you will have with them, you know.” She strokes the threads, and sheer panic explodes in my chest.

“I dinnae want time away. I want to help you stop whatever is happening to these women.”

“You said you wish to do my bidding. You will go where I say. You will remind yourself of what happens to those who think they know better than the Fates. You will see your siblings, and you will remember why you will not fail me again.” She meets my gaze. “Now go.” She dismisses me with a flick of her wrist. “Do not return to the river until a fortnight has passed. Should the Washwoman disappear in that time…” she trails off, but her meaning is clear.

I fight against the urge to stare at the threads. My siblings. The people I love most in this world.

“I understand.”

A cruel smile spreads on her lips. “Garrick?” she calls. The heavy doors open again, and he enters.

“You are to escort Brennen to Iomallrùin to assess for ceatharnaich, and then home. Ensure he does not return to the river until a full fortnight has passed.”

“Of course, Cailleach,” he says with a bow, his eyes finding mine and narrowing with concern.

I bow, then turn to leave, and Garrick follows close behind.

“I do so hope the Washwoman doesn't disappear while you’re gone,” Cailleach calls after me, her voice light with mock sincerity.

But as I walk into the night, her cackle following me into the crisp air, I am certain that both my family and the Washwoman have never been in more danger.

43

BEA



It begins with a groan, guttural and deep. I shoot up in Brennen's bed, my heart racing as I blink the sleep away.

"Hello?" I call out, my voice shaking.

"Hellllllppppp meeeeee," a pain-filled moan slithers through the tent, and I freeze. The hair on my arms stands on end, a shiver running down my spine. There's a long moment of silence, and I rise to peek out of the tent, grabbing a branch from the pile of wood next to the fire. "Who's out there?" I ask, lighting the end of the stick and holding it out in front of me to search the darkness.

The *After* shudders, the ground beneath my feet rumbling. "Hellllllppppp meeeeee," the voice calls again, and I stiffen. I squint into the night, where a dark shape floats within the *After*. The moaning grows louder, the air suddenly crackling with energy.

"Who are you?" I call, but my voice comes out small.

The figure pauses their movement, and I take a tentative step forward. In an instant, several more shadows appear, as if my presence called them into existence.

"Who are you?" I say again, wading into the water. I don't want to get near them, but my feet refuse to stop moving, a tug in my chest urging me forward, closer and closer until I'm less than half a dragon's length away from where they hide in the black mist.

“It hurts,” one of the shadows says. A different voice, this time, and my stomach twists. I should turn around. Should hide in Brennen's tent and not emerge until morning comes, but the voice is familiar. My dàn of memory burns, and something tickles my mind, but still, I can't quite place it.

“Please, goddess, help me.” A sob of agony. Another voice. Then another and another.

My chain catches, and I stumble, even my dàn of steadiness no match for the abrupt stop. Pain shoots through my ankle, and I fall forward into the water. My torch submerges, extinguishing in a second, and only darkness remains.

“No,” I whisper, my blood running cold. I struggle to see in the abrupt shift to pitch-black night, and as my eyes adjust, a figure draped in shadow emerges from deep in the *After*. She’s on her hands and knees in the shallow water, crawling towards me, her elbows bent at unnatural angles. She looks more animal than woman, her hair stringy around her face, and her skin is grey and mottled. She collapses as if in pain, and I reach out to try to help her.

She meets my eyes, but her face is cloaked in darkness. “It hurts,” she says.

“What hurts? How can I help you?” I ask, my voice coming out as strained as the others.

“They won't let me in. They won't let any of us in,” the woman wails. “You have to help us.” Her hands claw at the riverbed as she fights her way toward me, and my heart pounds against my ribs as I scramble back. She stops abruptly, as if she, too, is chained. Something's holding her back. To her left, another hand appears, then a head. A second crawling figure, cloaked in darkness. I gasp, standing and turning away in horror.

“What’s happening? Who are you?” I ask, my voice shaking with panic.

“They won't let us in!” she screams again.

I cover my ears, unable to bear the agony in her voice. “Who? Who won’t let you in?”

“Help us!”

“I don’t know who you are! I don’t know how to help you!”

The woman shrieks as she’s yanked back with a sudden ferocity. There’s a crack, the darkness vibrating as she’s pulled with such violent force, water sprays several feet outward. I gasp as she disappears into the *After* in less than a breath.

The others try to flee. “Wait!” I cry. I need answers. I cannot help these souls if I don’t know who they are or why they’re here, but within seconds, they, too, are ripped down into the depths of darkness.

I close my eyes, listening for them. For their groans, but there’s nothing. The glen is completely silent other than the rushing of the river. I scramble back to the tent, my heart pounding against my ribs. What in the goddesses’ name had I just witnessed? Ghosts? Souls trapped by the *After*?

My heart stops, skipping a beat.

Are these the missing women?

They won’t let us in, she said. What if she’s talking about An Glèidheadair? Except, if that were the case, why did she say *they?* Am Breitheamh and An Treòraiche have no part in guarding the gates, too busy with their own duties along the path.

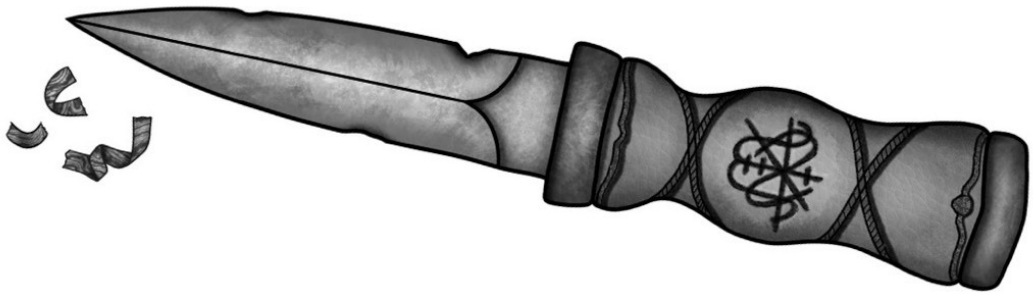
I take deep breaths, trying to calm the panic gripping my entire being.

What do these souls want from me?

And must I face them only now, when Brennen isn’t here?

44

BRENNEN



Garrick and I have hardly spoken the past day and a half as we rode. Not that we could, really. We've kept a breakneck speed. It had been clear Cailleach intended our arrival at Iomallrùin to be sooner rather than later, and by the time we hopped off our horses to sleep beneath the stars, we'd both been too exhausted to carry on much of a conversation. Though I can't help but wonder if Garrick's lack of talking is because he's as exhausted as I am or because he doesn't want to know anything he might have to report back to the Cutter.

Dome-shaped cottages appear in the distance, their fat roofs so different from the angular ones generally found in the Cutter's domain. The town is rather small, fourteen or so houses at most.

"A village of thirty people. How threatening." He sighs. "At least it won't take us long to find if there are any ceatharnaich," Garrick jokes, taking in the village.

"Do you think there are?" I ask, wondering if Garrick is thinking the same thing I am.

"I'd be surprised," he says, and I nod. Normally, we find rebel groups in larger towns where there are more voices to stoke the flames of anger against the Fates. The smaller villages are generally too busy trying to survive to focus on anything else.

I hope we're right. The last thing I want is to have to dispatch of ceatharnaich at the moment, especially when I'm fairly certain the Cutter is

wondering if I'm one myself.

The horses’ hooves clop as they transition from walking on grass to stone. A woman pops her head out the window at the noise, the color leaching from her cheeks. My stomach drops. It’s not a good sign; though, it's not out of the ordinary for those who don't often see soldiers to be afraid of us. At least, I hope that's all it is.

“This looks like as good a place as any to start,” he says, and I nod.

“May as well.”

We hop off our horses, tying them to a post, and knock on the door. A young boy answers, no older than six. His eyes sparkle with excitement.

“Thomas!” he yells over his shoulder. “See! I wasn't lying, there really are Dìdeanair here!” An older boy, maybe ten, runs up behind him, eyes wide.

“Aye, there are,” Garrick says, ducking his head in a bow. The boy kicks his heels together, doing the same. The woman I assumed to be their mother rushes up behind them, using a hand towel to usher them away from the door.

“All right, give them space,” she says. The boys scramble away, and she lets out a huff. “Children, eh? Now, how can I help you two fine men?” she asks. “Are you hungry?”

“Well, since you mentioned it—” I interrupt Garrick’s sentence with a jab to the ribs.

The woman seems nervous, but no more so than would be reasonable when a soldier unexpectedly shows up at your door, let alone two.

“We've been sent by the Cutter," I say, skipping straight to the point. I want to get this over with and get back to my family. “It seems her sister believes there may be some who reside here who are part of ceatharnaich groups.”

The woman’s eyes open wide, and she stiffens. “Here? Why, that's absurd,” she says, placing a trembling hand over her heart. Her fear seems real, and not because she's hiding something. There’s truth to her words, and she’s afraid of being falsely accused. Or at least, I hope.

Garrick nods to me in agreement, and I let out a breath.

“Thank you for your time," I say, bowing. We continue on in the same fashion, going door to door, and the woman’s shock and worry ring true. At every house, I breathe a little easier. These people seem truly shocked by

the accusation, and my intuition tells me to believe them. Maybe we'll escape this day unscathed, without having to dispatch of any traitors.

I knock on the final door, and it opens immediately, as if the residents inside have been waiting. A man and his wife stand together, holding hands.

"How can we help you?" the man asks.

"We've been sent by the Cutter to discern if there are any rebel groups residing here," Garrick says, meeting his eyes. "Do you know of any?" Both the man and woman shake their heads.

"No. I've not even heard of rumblings. Not a single word." I hold my breath for a long moment, wishing I still had my dàn of truth, and Garrick smiles.

"Thank you for your time," Garrick says, and my shoulders fall in relief. Just as we turn, a young man steps out from the back, stiffening when he sees us. His eyes go wide, but that's not what catches my attention. It's the anger that floods his face the moment he sees us. The hatred in his eyes as he takes in our uniforms. He grits his teeth, his hands clenching into fists.

Garrick doesn't seem to miss it, either, his hand subtly shifting toward his sword, and I hold my breath. The boy is young, maybe sixteen. Likely too wee to be formally involved with any ceatharnaich, and despite my duty, I find I dinnae want to question him. Not when dread is coiling like a snake in my stomach. Have I not committed treason myself by questioning the Cutter? By not reporting Harold's journal?

Why should this boy be punished for his thoughts, if I havenae been? My heart rate picks up.

I study my friend out of the corner of my eye, watching as he appraises the boy from head to toe, and I hold my breath.

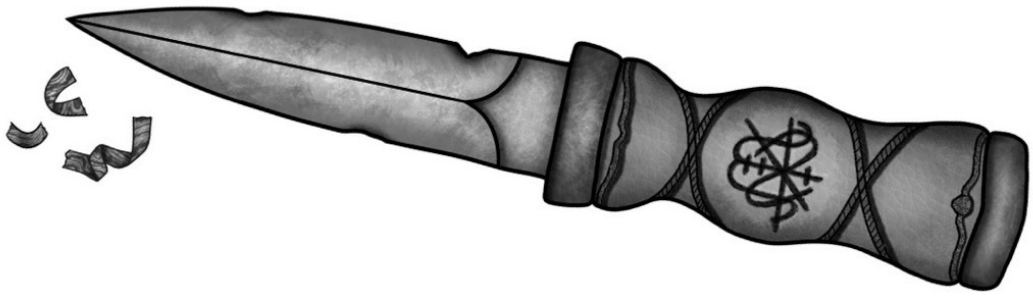
"Right then," Garrick says, lowering his hand. "Thank you for your time."

His shoulders are stiff as he turns, leading us back to our horses. My head spins as I follow behind him, remaining silent. What just happened? Had he, like me, been unable to fathom questioning the young man and finding him guilty? He's only begun to experience life.

At least for today, the boy will live. I just have to hope he's not the match that will one day ignite a rebellion that will burn this kingdom to the ground.

45

BRENNEN



"Och, I'm glad that's over with," Garrick says, rolling the tension from his shoulders as we leave Iomallrùin. "Though someone could have invited us in for a dram after our long journey to protect their village, don't you think? And why didnae you let them feed us? We've eaten nothing but cheese and apples since we left the castle."

"You think anyone actually wanted us in their homes? Wearing these?" I ask, gesturing to our uniforms.

Garrick puffs out his chest. "Aye. Have you seen my muscles?" he asks, flexing his biceps. "The lasses love a man in uniform."

I laugh. "Not when the man in said uniform is there to figure out if they're a traitor or not."

He waves me off. "I knew we wouldn't find any," he says, and I once again wonder if he missed the young man or turned a blind eye. I almost ask him, but stop myself. He's here to act as Cailleach's ears.

Though, is it possible I can trust him? I've known Garrick for a verra long time, and he is a good man. An honorable soldier, even if he likes to pretend he doesnae care about anything other than booze and women. If he chose not to question the boy, I could confide in him. I consider it for a long moment, deciding I cannae risk it, but I find that even though I cannae speak freely, I'm glad he is the soldier riding alongside me.

It's the only reason I do not break completely from my fear of Cailleach's threat. Fear for my family.

For Bea.

It’s an unwanted emotion, caring about what happens to her, but it’s there, undeniably tucked next to my heart. I picture her blue-grey eyes. The way they crinkle at the edges when she smiles. How impossibly wide they become when she is afraid.

What will Cailleach do to her now that she believes Bea was questioning her power? Is her pride so strong that she would ignore my warning that the women who have disappeared are actually dead, and then punish me, my family, and Bea?

Garrick finally speaks as we pass the loch, the wind off it damp and cold.

“Are you ever going to tell me what's happened with the Cutter? Or am I going to have to pull the reason out of those constantly scowling lips of yours? I mean, really, Brennen. Would it kill you to not look as if you’ve been sucking on lemons?”

I roll my eyes. “I dinnae scowl.”

“He says with a scowl. Now go on. Why did she really send us here?” he asks, and my jaw clenches tight. I dinnae ken where to begin.

“The Washwoman. She's no what I thought she’d be,” I admit, testing the waters.

Garrick bursts out in a belly laugh, and I pin him with a glare. He straightens. “Oh. You’re being serious?”

I raise my eyebrows.

“Of course, she’s not the creature from the legend,” he says, raising his eyebrows. “Have you heard the version where she has the body of a serpent?” He laughs again, but it dies off as my expression darkens.

He clears his throat. “Right. Okay, then. How is the monster different?”

I meet his eyes, holding his gaze for a long moment as I try to decide exactly how much to tell him. He knows my family, and I’m certain he cares for them. I grew up with him, after all. Joined the Dìdeanair together, and we trained side by side for years. If pressed, I would probably say he is my closest friend. But is that enough for him to keep my secrets from The Cutter?

It has to be.

“I dinnae think she’s a monster at all. Not anymore,” I say, unable to hold it in any longer—the feeling that has been steadily growing with each of Bea’s acts of kindness and compassion. But it’s not the only reason I tell

him. If I’m going to convince Cailleach about the disappearing women, I’m going to need help from someone who has her favor.

Garrick stops his horse, his expression shifting from good-natured teasing to pure shock. “You're speaking of the Washwoman, right? The same woman who killed Marsaili?”

I stiffen at the name, a surge of protectiveness washing through me, but not for Marsaili. Garrick had loved her like a sister. Her name on his lips is a comfort. It’s Bea I feel defensive of. “I ken how it sounds, but she's no what we’ve been made to believe.”

He shakes his head. “I dinnae understand. What are you saying? That you don't think she killed Marsaili? Killed her family?”

“No.” My hands clench into fists, and I shake my head. How am I to explain my feelings to Garrick when I can hardly understand them myself? “She did. She’s said as much. But it wasnae really *her*. Her mind broke that day. She doesn’t remember any of it. Thinks maybe the curse caused her to go mad when she escaped.” I nudge Sable forward again. Garrick follows suit, but remains silent. “You know of the women who have been disappearing?” I ask.

“Of course. What of them?” he asks, his voice wary.

“I dinnae think they're disappearing at all. I think they're dead. *That* is what I told Cailleach.”

Garrick pulls his horse next to mine. There's disbelief in his eyes, but I can tell he's listening. “Something’s been happening with the Washwoman. She's having visions of the women who are going missing. One of them, Betty—”

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“From home?”

I nod. “She disappeared over a week ago. Bea had a vision of her. I saw it with my own eyes. Her gaze went glassy, and she was singing this strange song. It made no sense. I shook her. Shouted her name, but she didn't flinch, didnae react at all. And then when she came to, she was holding something

from Betty's house in her hands—a portrait of her parents. I recognized them immediately."

Garrick grips the reins tighter. "You're certain she didn't have it before?"

"She couldnae have. I searched her myself when I arrived. She has no possessions, and she's chained to the shore. How would she get a picture of Betty's parents without something magical happening?"

Garrick sits up taller. "The Fates control all magic."

"Do they, though?" I ask.

He stiffens, lifting his chin to assess me, but I dinnae back down from his stare. "What are you saying?" he asks.

My shoulders inch toward my ears at his reaction, and I choose my next words carefully. "All I'm saying is Bea washed Betty's clothes. She has to be dead."

"Then the Cutter would know," he says, and part of me wonders if I've made a mistake. Maybe I cannae tell him my fears. My doubts. Garrick is always at the Cutter's castle. Is it possible he's closer to her than I thought?

I rub my forehead. "One would think. Would *hope*. But would it truly be so impossible for someone to work outside the Fates' rule? These ceatharnaich groups we find and fight. The written magic that was destroyed. What if more remains than we think? What if there is someone with more power than we're aware of, and that's why the Fates are so obsessed with us finding and eliminating them?"

A scream of pure agony pierces the air. Sable's ears perk, and Garrick and I meet each other's eyes. Without a word, we dig our heels into our horses' sides, their hooves kicking up peat as we steer them toward the noise. The scream rings out again—the rawness of it piercing through the air. We race forward, the Faerie Mounds coming into view. Hollow Hill rises in the distance, the standing stones on top looming over the braes.

The scream stops, echoing away into silence.

"Hello?" Garrick calls. "We are guardians of Cailleach! Are you in need of help?"

I strain to listen for an answer, but there's nothing but the sound of the wind rustling the heather. I hop off Sable, trekking to the top of Hollow Hill. I peek around the standing stones, but there's no one here. No one hiding.

"What was that?" Garrick asks, breathless as he joins me. "An animal?"

"No. That was human. A woman." I say, certain of it.

“Then where is she?”

I can only shake my head.

We search for an hour, then two, walking every inch of the rolling mounds, but find nothing.

“Maybe she fled,” Garrick says, and I nod.

“Aye. She’d have gone that way,” I say, nodding toward a deer-worn path through the birch trees.

“Then that way we'll go,” he says. My heart pounds with nerves as we travel, but we do not see anyone, and we do not hear any more screams.

“Is it possible we heard one of the women dying?” I ask.

Garrick’s eyes flick to mine. “Anything’s possible,” he says, pausing. He lowers his voice to a near whisper. “You need to be careful voicing your worries aloud, Brennen”

My brows lower. “Why’s that?” I ask.

“There are people you can question. The Cutter isnae one of them. I thought you’d know better. She’s executed higher-ranking members of her court than you for far less. I’ve watched her do it more times than I can count.”

I square my shoulders. “It's no death I'm afraid of. No my own.”

He appraises me, all traces of his usual humor gone from his features. “Then what *are* you scared of?”

I do not answer, because to give voice to my fears would be blatant treason, and while Garrick is warning me, he is still a guardian, and I cannae risk telling him more than what the Cutter already knows.

46

BEA



I do not fall asleep until the sun is peeking above the horizon, and even then, I’m not granted rest. The black of my restless sleep morphs, and suddenly, I’m in a cottage. Sunlight filters across old wooden planks, and a rhythmic tapping sounds from the corner of the room.

I’ve been here before.

The fragmented pieces of my sight grow sharper, the picture coming into focus. A woman sits at a loom, but her face is hidden behind the frame. She’s humming, and beneath the melody is the sound of rippling water. I crane my neck to look out the window, trying to see where we are, but there’s nothing but sky out the window. We must be on a hill. I try to move towards the woman, but my feet are stuck in place.

“Show your face,” I beg her, but she doesn’t hear me, remaining hidden behind the large loom she works at.

There's a knock at the door, and the tapping stops. She stands, and I get a flash of her wrist. Where her dedication dàn would sit, there is a long, puckered scar. Hints of black peek around the edges of it, but I'm not able to discern which Fate she was dedicated to. Whoever it was, the dàn is too disfigured to recognize.

The woman's back is turned to me as she opens the door. She doesn’t seem afraid, but still, my stomach tightens. I know what happens next. I’ve seen it.

“I didn't think I'd see you so soon,” she says. A shadow falls in the doorway, but I cannot see who’s causing it.

And then the dream shifts, the edges growing fuzzy. A blade slices across the woman's throat, and she falls, twitching on the floor. Blood pools around my feet, and I open my mouth to scream, but no sound comes out. It is horrifying, this helplessness. Even in my dreams, I cannot escape it.

The shadow moves forward, the outline of a body appearing, and then, I am awake.

I sit upright in a cold sweat, bile rising up my throat.

“Hello. Are you alright?”

I jump. Someone’s here, but that is not Brennen's voice.

“It's only me,” they say. The sound scratches at my mind, and I find that even though I cannot place it, I don’t feel afraid. I smooth my hair down and peek through the tent flaps.

Theo stands on the other side of the fire, his brows creased with concern.

“I thought I heard shouting. Is everything okay?” he asks.

I sag with relief. “Theo, hi. I was having a nightmare. That's all,” I clear my throat. “Is there something I can help you with? Brennen isn't here, if you're looking for him.”

“I ken. He asked me to check on you if he wasn't back by yesterday. I havenae seen him, so I thought I should come by.”

“He had urgent news for the Cutter.” I try to sound calm and confident, but if Brennen had warned Theo to come if he hadn't returned, did that mean he was anticipating danger?

“May I?” he asks, gesturing toward the almost extinct fire. His breath comes out in white puffs, and I hurry over to it, throwing on some kindling.

“Of course. Please, sit,” I say, leaning forward.

Slowly, I exhale, blowing onto the wood. It ignites instantly, and Theo's eyebrows arch in amusement.

“The Washwoman can breathe fire?” he asks. “That isnae a part of your tale.”

“Well, seeing as I wasn't able to do it until I took Brennen's dàn of warmth, I suppose that makes sense.”

He leans back, surprised. “You really took his dàn?”

“Well, I didn't mean to,” I say. My voice comes out defensive, and he raises his hands, laughing.

“Even if you did, why should I care? Looks to me like he has more dàn than the rest of the village combined. Seems fitting for him to share some of that power.”

His voice is light and jovial, teasing, and I relax, my defensiveness melting away.

“Well, when you put it that way.” I throw a few more logs on to keep the fire going.

“I brought you something.” He tosses me a bag.

There's a crinkling noise inside, a clacking, and I open it hesitantly. Inside are assorted sweets, licorice, and hard candies, along with other types I've never seen before.

A wide smile breaks out across my lips.

“Felt it was time I repay you for helping me all those years ago,” he says, his smile matching my own.

“I was happy to do it,” I say. I don’t wait, popping a glossy red piece into my mouth. The sweetness of the sugar almost makes me cry, and I press it between my tongue and cheek, savoring it. “Would you like one?” I ask.

“No. You keep them; I have plenty more. Do you know when Brennen will return?” he asks, and I shake my head.

“He left so quickly, he didn't tell me much at all. Why do you ask?”

Theo clears his throat, looking away.

“The Cutter's men arrived this morning. I have near a dozen of them seeking lodging in my tavern as we speak.”

My heart starts to thunder, my eyes darting around the tree line.

“They dinnae know where you are. At least I don't think so. I'll make sure you're safe.”

“Thank you,” I say, breathless.

He nods. “They're asking about Brennen.”

I go still. “What about him?”

“How often he comes to town. If he seems fond of you.”

Heat creeps up my neck. “That's ridiculous. He's here to find a way to kill me.”

Theo raises his eyebrows. “Are you so sure about that?”

“He hasn’t told me otherwise,” I say, even though those three words, *fond of you*, cause my breaths to go shallow and my heart to race.

Theo sighs, rubbing a hand across his scruff. “I dinnae like the way they're prodding and prying. Is Brennen in some sort of trouble?”

Dread fills my stomach. “I don’t know,” I answer honestly. “I hope not.”

Theo nods. He leans forward, taking a second to warm his hands by the flames. “As nice as this fire is, I should be getting back in case more come.” He stands, pausing. “I don't like having Cailleach’s Dìdeanair here.”

Defensiveness surges in my chest, hot as flames. “Brennen is a good man,” I say.

“I agree. I’m no speaking of him, but these other guards... I dinnae trust them.”

I hold his gaze, my stomach twisting. “You shouldn't.”

He gives me a sharp nod. “I won't. Be well, Bea.” He turns to leave, but I stop him.

“Wait. Aside from the soldiers arriving, have you heard any other news?”

He crosses his arms. “Like what?”

“The women who are disappearing. Have there been any more in the past few days?”

He tilts his head, crossing his arms. “Aye. There are rumors of one from Gloscan two days ago.”

My mouth goes dry, and it takes effort to ask my next question. “Was it a tailor's daughter?”

His eyes widen. “How could you possibly know that?”

“I don't,” I stutter, unsure if I can trust him, what's safe to tell him. “Something is happening. I can’t explain it, but you need to be careful with the Cutter’s men there. As do the women in the village. If you get news of any others, will you let me know?”

He nods his head, chewing on his cheek. I can tell he wants to ask more, but he restrains himself.

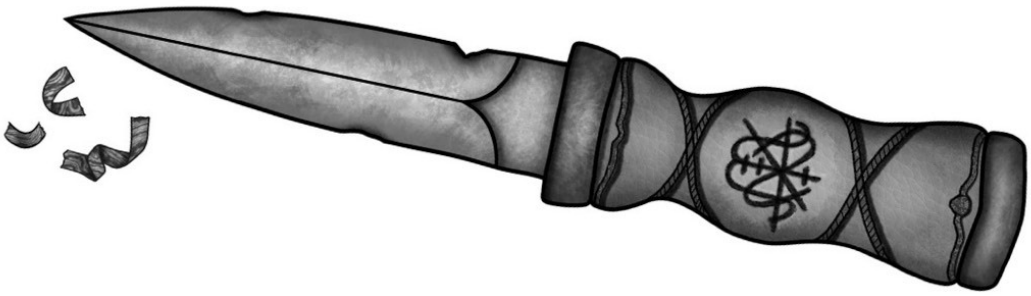
“I will,” he says. “You be careful, as well.”

But it is not my safety I worry about as he walks away. It is his. Brennen's. And every young woman in the kingdom, because none of them are safe.

Someone is killing them, and I fear that I may be the only one able to stop it.

47

BRENNEN



Saoirse sits curled in my lap, playing with the carving I made her for her birthday. It’s a miniature lamb, with fluffy hair and delicate ears. She giggles as she pretends it’s walking up my arm, and despite everything happening—the women, the Cutter, Bea—my heart warms.

I shift under her weight.

“When did you get so big?” I ask, wiggling back and forth, pretending to be uncomfortable.

“I'm six now, don't you remember?”

“Aye, you are. Not so wee anymore.”

Our siblings sit around the hearth, playing jacks on the floor or reading. It’s been nice being home the past three days, seeing them all healthy and happy.

“This is what I wished for on my birthday, you know. For you to come back,” Saoirse says.

“Is the lamb I sent you not enough?” I joke.

“No,” she says, tone turning serious. “Will you make me another? I think he needs a friend.”

I laugh at her blunt honesty. “Well, if he needs a friend, then, aye. Of course, I’ll make you another.”

Garrik comes from the kitchen, taking the armchair next to me. “Speaking of birthdays,” he says. Saoirse perks up at the package in his hand. “Didn’t you just have one?”

“I did!” Saoirse’s eyes light up.

“Well, I decided I couldn’t come for a visit without bringing you a gift of my own, could I?”

Saoirse squeals as he hands the parcel to her.

“Tell me, Saoirse. Do you still like scary stories?” Garrick leans in, his eyes bright with mischief.

“Of course I do.” She rips open the package, her eyes going wide as she looks at the leather-bound book in her hands.

“It’s a collection of stories,” he says. “Fairy tales. Some of my favorites.”

She turns to me. “Can I go read it?”

I’m about to tell her yes when Garrick stops her. “Why don’t we have your brother read the first story to us? My da used to read it to me, and it’s been a long time since I’ve heard it.” His eyes bore into mine, and I tense. I know this look. He’s up to something.

“Oh, please, Bren. Will you?” Saoirse asks, and her excitement curbs my suspicion enough to crack open the book.

“Of course,” I say, warmth filling my chest that she still wants me to.

In the beginning, the Three were One.

One heart. One mind. One pair of hands.

And yet, it was too much for One soul to carry alone.

With every thread she spun, she smiled. And every life she measured long. But along with endless lives came suffering. The One could not bear to cut the threads she had so tenderly woven. And yet, they begged her for death, their bodies withering away in agony, their minds slowly failing.

And because she loved her people so, she listened. With trembling, sorrowful fingers, she severed their threads, tears streaming from her eyes and flooding the realm.

And so, the river formed.

I pause, eyes flicking to Garrick, but he’s staring into the fire. Why give Saoirse a story about the river—the Fates—now? Clearing my throat, I

continue.

It flowed to the end of the land, her tears carrying the souls of the departed into the After where the goddesses dwelled.

“Why do you cry?” the goddess of death asked the One. “I gave you power. I gave you magic, and yet, you still weep.”

“What good is power if I have no one to share it with? When I’m forced to kill what I created?” she asked.

And the goddess took pity on her, fracturing her into three. From that soul, The Weaver, The Measurer, and The Cutter were formed.

Three hearts. Three minds. Three pairs of hands, created to work together to allow the passage of life to be gentler for all. The living would not suffer past their time. The Cutter would not have to end her own children’s lives.

And so the river born of her tears gently flowed, nourishing the After.

For a time, they worked together. There was balance.

Until the day a thread frayed. A thread belonging to a girl meant to be the youngest of three mortal sisters. Her life had been woven into theirs before her thread ever came to be, but somehow, it was incomplete.

The Weaver believed she should destroy the thread and begin again.

The Measurer insisted she must work within the length that had been woven.

The Cutter, uncomfortable with imperfection, yearned to cut away the damaged edge, regardless of her sister’s measurement.

And because they could not agree, they did not act. The thread sat ignored, and without magic to sustain it, it turned to dust.

Unease fills my gut at the image, and I falter.

“Keep going!” Saoirse says, impatient as ever.

Garrick finally looks at me. “Aye, Brennen. Keep going.”

I narrow my eyes at him, returning to the story.

For the first time since its creation, the river faltered. The water surged, and the deep black mist of the After crept up from below. At the river’s end, darkness rose, overtaking the earth. The earth rotted where it touched; anything alive unable to survive it.

And inside the deep black mist, the frayed soul was trapped, desperate for release. Afraid and alone.

As the soul haunted the river, anger and resentment hardened the Three. One by one, pride blinded them, and each believing they knew best, began to do as they wished.

The Weaver wove threads as long as she pleased.

The Measurer measured lives too young, only to spite her.

The Cutter cut without regard to the Measurer’s will. Magic faltered, and the earth grew dark. A rift formed in the sky, and monsters descended.

“The Epoch,” Saoirse says, her delicate features flickering in the firelight.

“Precisely,” says Garrick. “Is this scary enough for you?”

Saoirse gives a tight nod. And while I do see fear in her eyes, there’s excitement there as well. “Well, what happened?”

I tuck her closer. “Is it too scary? I can read you a different story.”

Her eyes open wide. “I’m not a baby, Bren, and I’m not afraid of the Epoch. You’ll protect me from it.”

I press a kiss to her blonde curls. “Aye, I will,” I say, picking back up where I stopped.

The two mortal sisters felt the pull of their missing piece, and so they followed the river, their hearts aching without her. But when they found the young girl haunting the shore, she could not be saved.

But if she could not leave, they decided, neither would they.

Hand in hand, they stepped into the darkness that destroyed all it touched, and the river held its breath.

But the goddess had been watching.

She had seen the Fates selfish ways. Witnessed their ploys for power. But in the mortal sisters, she saw something new—selfless, sacrificial love."

Saoirse squeezes me tighter.

She struck down the Three who ruled with so much pride, and their magic unraveled, flowing back into the earth, and with a kiss to each of the mortal sisters' brows, she blessed them.

Their bodies healed, and their lives extended past what had once been measured. But the goddess did not grant them endless reign, lest the temptation of unfettered power become, once again, irresistible. The sisters, knowing they would never succumb to such things, agreed to rule, and with the goddess's blessing, they clawed their way through the After *and back above, ready to govern as one.*

Until once again, they didn't.

And once again, the monsters came.

Garrick's stare grows sharper as I finish, and when I look up, he's leaning forward, arms braced on his knees, examining me.

"Why didn't they?" Saoirse asks.

Garrick doesn't take his eyes from mine as he answers her. "That's what makes the story so scary, isn't it? Even the sisters who had once loved each other wholly and truly fell victim to the temptation of power. If left to rule too long, everyone does. It's a tale as old as time."

She yawns. "I should think I'd like to be a Fate. I'd have all the magic I could want, and I would do good with it. I wouldn't go bad, like the sisters."

I ruffle her hair. “I have no doubt of that,” I say. She smiles softly, closing her eyes. “Alright. Time for bed,” I say, tickling her sides. She groans, but stands, as do my other siblings. When I’m finished saying goodnight, Garrick is still sitting in his chair, staring into the fire.

“A dram?” I ask.

“Aye,” he says, and I notice a letter in his hands. He breaks the tense silence as I hand him his glass. He takes a sip, raising the piece of paper. “I received word earlier of a ceatharnaich group discovered in Braemuir. Another in Dalrannoch.”

I shake my head, settling back into my chair to take a sip of whiskey. The liquid burns, warming my belly immediately.

“Why is it, you think, so many resistance groups form before the Epoch?” Garrick continues, but this time, the question is probing. He wants an answer.

“Why the sudden interest in the Epoch tonight?”

He lifts his chin, waiting for me to respond, and I sigh.

“Is it no enough that they wish to overthrow the Fates?” I ask.

“Have you ever stopped to think about *why* they want to overthrow them to begin with?”

I stiffen, still unsure if I can speak my true feelings aloud. “They fear the monsters that will come. Misplace their anger that the Fates are not able to protect everyone.”

He shakes his head, laughing darkly. “You really think the queens couldn’t protect every last subject, should they care to?” A dangerous ember of hope flickers in my chest. His words are just as close to treason as my thoughts about the disappearing women.

“Whatever your question is, Garrick, ask it,” I say.

The fire crackles in the hearth, a loaded silence pressing between us. “Am I wrong, that maybe I'm not the only one beginning to doubt our queens?”

The air is stolen from my lungs. I try not to react, because what if this is a trick? His way of learning if I’m a traitor myself.

I dinnae think it is, but how can I be sure? My eyes dart to my siblings' bedrooms.

“Brennen,” he stops my racing thoughts with a hand on my arm. “You've known me your whole life. Do you really think I would come into your home where your family is sleeping and try to trap you? That I would

turn you in or hope to see you punished? No.” He shakes his head emphatically. “I'm asking you this because it is how *I* feel. And based on the questions you've been asking, the things you’ve been saying, I'm wondering if maybe you are, too.”

I hesitate, and the disappointment in Garrick’s eyes is clear. He wishes I trusted him, but Garrick doubting the Cutter is beyond my wildest imaginings.

“Yer going to make me say it? Fine.” He sets down his whiskey. “I know you noticed the young man in Iomallrùin, just as I did. Why do you think I didnae question him? He was clearly ceatharnaich, or at the very least, will end up as one. I willnae kill one of my own.”

I freeze, his words piercing my chest like an arrow.

“You’re ceatharnaich?” I ask, my voice barely a whisper.

“Aye. It’s why I no longer patrol. Why I’ve embedded myself within the Cutter’s castle. I made myself useful to her, so I can gather information and wouldnae have to kill the ones I fight alongside.”

Unexpected discomfort settles in my stomach. I’ve killed ceatharnaich, too. More than I can count, fully believing I was doing the right thing. That I was protecting the kingdom from those who would wish to destroy it. But what if I was wrong all along? What if the ceatharnaich are trying to protect us from what the Fates are doing to us, leaving us vulnerable when the Epoch comes?

It’s not until Garrick answers that I realize I spoke the final question aloud.

“It’s more than that,” he says. “They don’t protect us, and they dinnae allow us to protect ourselves, either. It's not right that the Fates have taken the magic that once ran in our blood away. It was a gift from the goddess, and it’s rightfully ours. He pulls down his shirt collar. “This was my naming dàn. Protection. The Measurer made a mistake in giving it to me because the need I have to protect this kingdom is all-consuming. I’ve felt it since I was a boy, and I see the holes in their design. The earth itself was supposed to give us our magic.”

I shake my head. “You’re making no bloody sense. The Fates have always controlled magic.”

“No. The goddess did not design it for the Fates to bestow us our magic. She gave it to us *herself*. We once submerged in the river Bàsail, and as the

water cleaned our souls, we were blessed by her. It was the river that gave us our dàn. Not the Fates."

My heart picks up in rhythm. It would make sense for there to be another source of magic. How else would our people once have known the runes and spells in Harold's journal? "How do you know all this?"

"They may have destroyed our books, but they cannae destroy our voices. The story has been passed down through my family for generations, and I know we're not the only ones. We used to be blessed with all sorts of magic. Our lives were far longer. There was peace. But these Fates, they've taken that away."

"*These* Fates? What do you mean?"

"Hard-headed bastard," Garrick mumbles under his breath. "Did you not listen to the story? The Fates we know today are not the first. There were others before. There will be others after."

I place my dram down. "What happened to them?"

"No one knows, as far as I can tell. But it wasn't until these three Fates ascended that everything changed. So I'll ask you again, what is it that you think is happening at the river?"

I grip the arms of the chair, the wood creaking. "I think the Cutter is lying. I just don't know what she's lying about." I pause, mind spinning. "Choosing this story wasn't an accident, was it? You think the Cutter is hungry for power."

Garrick finally takes a sip of his whiskey, relaxing back into his chair. "I think there's more going on than meets the eye."

The story echoes in my mind, settling into my blood. When the queens acted outside of the goddess's will, the *After* rose. Everything it touched died.

"If what you're saying is true, and the Fates have stolen the goddess's magic. Do you think it could happen again? That the *After* could come for the living?"

"I do. And with the Epoch approaching, I fear it may be worse than we ever imagined."

My throat closes around my unspoken fears. Could the *After* spread and kill those surrounding the river? Theo and Harold. Billy and Anna.

Bea.

The thought turns my blood to ice, and my palm burns.

I stand. “I have to go back. Now. I have to warn them. I have to make sure it doesn’t take Bea.”

Garrick raises his eyes in surprise. “Bea?”

I ignore the way her name in his mouth makes me want to put my fist through a wall. It’s only my vow driving me back to her. Nothing more. Cailleach’s expectations of me. “If the *After* kills the Washwoman, and the Cutter won’t listen… If she thinks she disappeared… " I look toward the hall where my siblings sleep.

“Aye,” he says. “We’ll leave in the morning.”

Relief floods my chest. “You’re coming with me?”

He shakes his head. “No. But I willnae return to the Cutter just yet, either.”

“Where will you go?” I ask, walking around the living room to gather my things. I dinnae think I can wait till morning.

“I’ll need to warn my men in Dalrannoch and Braemuir to hide.”

I nod. “And then?”

“To Hollow Hill,” he says. “I can’t help but think what we heard wasn’t a coincidence at all. I’m going back.”

“But what if the woman we heard isn’t there?”

He rolls up his sleeve to reveal a second dàn. One I’ve only heard of.

Premonition.

He meets my eyes.

“She’s there. I just have to find her.”

48

BEA



My skin crawls as the sun begins to set, and as darkness spreads through the glen, so does my dread. I try not to think about them. The souls that cried out to me last night, begging for my help, but even so, my eyes keep flicking towards the *After*.

The darkness pouring from it pulses, inhaling and exhaling as if the shadows are alive, and I shiver.

I grab another piece of wood and throw it on the fire, kicking myself for not asking Theo to collect more for me while he was here. The stack has dwindled since Brennen left, and there's nothing to gather within the length of my chain. Soon, it will run out completely.

The thought of being trapped in the dark with the ghosts of the *After* makes my lungs constrict, and I crawl inside the tent and close the flaps. I do not want to know if the ghosts come again tonight. Not when there's nothing I can do to help them.

I close my eyes and try to sleep, but my body is too alert. The ground shudders, groaning as if the earth might crack open and swallow me whole, and I stiffen. Fear wraps around my heart so tight I worry it might stop beating altogether.

Even without hearing their cries yet, I know they’re coming. I *feel* their presence. Restless souls wandering the mouth of the *After*. But why? I squeeze my eyes shut, counting the beats of my heart, trying to think of anything other than the figures lurking outside my tent.

A soft noise floats through the night. Someone humming, and my hair stands on end. I know that melody.

It's the one from my visions. The humming turns to singing, but it's not a beautiful sound. The voice is cracked and pained.

There's friendship in bushels and tales long been said.
Let's tell each other's before we fall dead.
Can happen in moments, the blink of an eye
The river will take you when it’s time to die.

On shaking legs, I rise, holding my breath as I peek out of the tent. It's the song the tailor’s daughter was singing, and through my fear, I wonder why I didn't notice the part about the river before.

A song cannae tell you the time it will end.
As long as you live, a new one can begin.
She knows whose coming, she’s waited all night.
Held off on the last verse until you arrived.

Dark shapes drift through the *After*. Some crawling. Some standing. It’s horrifying, these figures who are somehow both human and *not*. They wander aimlessly, all except for one.

She stands in the middle of the river, closer than she was last night.

So sing till the song takes the life it was due,
Some hands hold the blade, and some hands hold the truth.
When the river runs red and the After draws near,
The darkness will come and bring all that you fear.

I move out of the tent, unable to stop myself. Needing to confirm what I already know in my gut. That *this* is the tailor's daughter. The woman I warned to run. I recognize her voice now, even though I can’t see her, still shrouded by shadows.

I feel her eyes on my face as she holds out a grey hand and tilts her head. Her voice changes suddenly, the tone dropping.

The Washwoman kneels with her palms stained with red,
She sings to each soul, knows each name of the dead.
When her mind breaks again, and the river runs dry.
She'll think of the poor souls who taught her to die.

The last note trails off, and the woman turns towards the others.

“She rises,” the woman says, but it comes out as almost a moan. Like a match ignited, the dark figures surge toward me all at once.

“Help us,” they beg.

“It hurts,” they cry.

I scream in terror, stumbling back. “I don't know how!”

“It's because of *you* we are here,” the tailor's daughter spits, throwing a finger toward me.

I shake my head, my heart racing. “No. I warned you to run. I said you were in danger!!”

“Only you can stop this,” she says. “Only *you* can get them to let us in.”

The figures get closer, and the darkness melts away from them. I can see them now clearly. Betty. The woman on the hill. *All* of the women I've seen in my visions. Their faces are pale, twisted in agony.

“Help us,” they beg, feral. Unlike the tailor’s daughter, they almost don't appear human at all.

“What's wrong with them?” I ask. “Why can you talk to me, but they can only cry out in pain?”

“Being trapped in between rots your mind. I havenae been here as long, but I will soon be like them, too, should you not help us.”

My ears ring as pressure builds in my chest. “Me? But I’m trapped here, too. What am *I* supposed to do?” I ask.

She shakes her head, her sad eyes pleading. “I cannae tell you more, but it’s there in your mind. Everything you need, you already know.”

“But I don’t know anything,” I say, raising my hands in front of me. Her eyes lock onto the bloodstains.

The woman lunges toward me, and I scream. “You do! You know the truth! Help us!” The sadness in her features shifts to anger, and I stumble

back. The movement must catch the other souls' eyes, because they surge forward, descending on me as one.

I back up, fear burning in my blood hotter than a brand. "I don't know what you're talking about. I'm sorry!" I say, but they do not stop.

"Help us!"

Something pulls at my skirt, and I scream when I see the woman from the pub clinging to the skirt of my dress. She cries out, pain etched into her saggy, grey skin. I rip my dress away, turning to run.

"I'm sorry!" I say, tears streaming down my face as I sprint as fast as I can onto the shore and dive into the tent. I stare through the flaps, waiting for them to follow, but they do not come after me. They remain just inside the river, arms reaching out as if straining to reach me, and I shiver.

It doesn't look as if they can leave the water.

For now, at least.

I close the flaps and hide beneath the covers, covering my ears. It's not that I don't want to help them. I do, desperately. Nothing would be worse than being a lost soul, but what can I do? If the Three of the path are not allowing them to enter, there *must* be a reason.

I search my mind for answers, but they do not come. I cannot focus with the cries of the dead seeping through the cracks of my fingers, begging me to set them free.

It's not until the sun peaks above the horizon that they stop, and when the moon once again returns, so do they.

49

BEA



I'm sewing what I can remember of my naming dàn into a stretch of fabric ripped from my old dress when a branch snaps in the distance, and I bolt upright. My first instinct is to look towards the *After*, to where the lost souls will emerge when night falls, but the sun still has hours until it will dip below the brae.

The ghosts won't visit for some time, which means someone else is coming.

I square my shoulders as I search the treeline. Theo had warned me about the guardians in the village. He said he would do his best to keep them from coming here, but they've come before, and I'm certain they'll come again.

Through the trees, there's a flash of gold, the hilt of a sword with skulls etched upon it.

It is a Dìdeanair, then. My breath hitches.

They step through the trees, and I leap to my feet.

"Brennen!" I cry, running toward him. I throw myself against his chest just after he passes the hollow log, ducking my head low to make sure my skin does not touch his as I wrap my arms around his waist. Sobs break free from my throat as I savor his solid body. His steady heartbeat and warmth.

Brennen goes stiff. He doesn't embrace me back, but I don't care. I am no longer alone, and when the souls cry out for me to save them tonight, I will not have to endure it by myself.

“Why are you crying? Did someone hurt you?” he asks, his voice rough, and I shake my head against his chest, sniffling.

“No. Nothing like that,” I say, my voice tight. Where do I even begin?

He wraps his fingers around my biceps, forcing me back so he can look at me. His eyes start at the crown of my head, examining every inch of my face before dropping down until he reaches my toes, as if he doesn't believe I’m uninjured. His gaze heats my skin, and I blush, the flush spreading down my neck.

“If it's no that you’re hurt, then what is it?”

My lip trembles as I consider how to tell him what’s happened since he left. I know how it will sound, especially when I told him there was someone in the *After* before. Will it just be another reason for him to think I’m mad? I wring my hands, gathering my resolve.

“The cry I heard in the night before you left. You said no one was there, but it was a soul. One of the women who disappeared.”

Brennen narrows his eyes. “A soul?”

I nod, relieved he’s not immediately dismissing me. “First, it was one. Now it’s all the women from my visions. They come at night, moaning and crying, saying *they* won't let them into the *After*.”

“An Glèidheadair isnae accepting them?”

“I don’t know. They can’t tell me more. All they said is they won’t let them enter.”

He dips his chin, and I can see the wheels turning in his mind. His eyebrows furrow in thought, his jaw going tight.

“You’ve learned something,” I say. He lets go of my arms.

“Let's sit,” Brennen says, swallowing. He doesn't lead me toward the fire pit where, without kindling, the flames have completely died out. Instead, he turns away from the *After*, sitting down almost at the end of my chain length.

He faces the darkness, his eyes never leaving the curling black mist.

“You don't seem surprised at what I said about the *After*.”

He shakes his head, leaning forward and bracing his forearms on his knees. He takes a moment to speak, like he doesn't know where to start.

“The Cutter didnae take kindly to my warning. She doesnae believe the women you’ve seen in your visions are dead.”

My mouth falls open, his words settling like a stone low in my stomach.

“But they have to be. You believe me, right?”

He holds up his hands. “I *do* believe you. I dinnae think Betty would just leave her family. Nor the others. And if you’re seeing their spirits, it only confirms what we suspected. They have to be dead.”

“Did you tell her that? That you were certain?”

“And make you wash my clothes? No.” He rubs his forehead. “I told her what you’d seen. About Betty. But she was angry for my doubting her.” He swallows. “She threatened my siblings. It wasna worth the risk of pushing her further. I'm not even supposed to be here yet. Not for another week. She sent me home, but I learned something there.” He pauses, finally meeting my eyes. Something in his expression falters, just for a moment, but he schools it back into neutrality before I can place it. “I had to return. It couldn't wait.”

A jolt of fear skates down my spine. “Tell me you didn't go to Dalbàsail,” I say.

He tilts his head, confused. “No. I came straight here.”

“If you’re not supposed to be here, you have to hide.” I grab his arm, eyes darting to the trees. “The Cutter sent Dìdeanair to the village. Theo came to warn me. He said they're asking questions about you.”

His gaze follows mine. “I dinnae think they’ll come here. Not unless they're ordered to. They’ll likely believe the villager’s stories that looking upon your face will lead to a loved one's death. Have you seen any soldiers?”

“No. Theo said he’d try to keep them away.” Relief flashes in his eyes.

“I trust he'll do just that, then,” he says.

I do not share his relief. “Why would Cailleach send them here at all?”

Brennen pulls out his bird carving, his knife hovering above it. He looks up. “Did you know the Fates we worship weren't the first?”

The air is stolen from my lungs. What is he talking about? Cailleach has always been the Cutter. Chosen by the goddess herself.

“What?” I ask, breathless.

He puts down the bird and knife, pulling out a stack of paper that appears to be pages ripped from a book. He hands them to me, and I read the first line.

In the beginning, the Three were one.

My mind can barely keep up with my eyes as they skitter across the pages. Three Fates who did not agree. A goddess who struck them down. Monsters clawing their way above ground.

“The Epoch comes because the Fates went against the goddess’s design?” I ask.

He nods, his expression serious. “I think so. I dinnae think—” His fingers tighten around the bird. “The Fates give us our magic, but I dinnae think it was meant to be that way, and I dinnae think it *has* to be that way.”

“What exactly are you saying?” I ask, pinching at the skin of my hand to get out my nervous energy. Brennen’s eyes follow the movement, and he reaches out to stop me. “What if this isn’t even true? It’s ripped from a storybook.”

“Aye, but it makes sense. We know someone is killing these women. What if there are others with magic that works outside the Fates? There used to be books of magic. Dàn we could use on our own without being gifted them. Ways to use the power found in the verra ground. The Fates had the books destroyed, but they couldn’t have found them all. They didn’t. Harold has one. The magic in it is harmless, but what if the ceatharnaich groups throughout the kingdom have spells that give them more power? The Fates are near obsessed with finding them all. Eliminating them. What if the queens fear them because they have magic they are not able to control?”

I close my eyes, trying to process it all, and fear ripples through me. “Does she think there are ceatharnaich in Dalbàsail? Is that why she sent her soldiers?”

“No. They’re here because of me. I questioned Cailleach, and she’s no happy about it. I think she sent them as a warning. That I am *her* guardian, here on a singular mission.”

He doesn’t say what that mission is—to kill me.

“So you think there are others with magic. And that’s why these women are dying?”

“It has to be. I cannae think of anyone else who would do such a thing.”

“But why?” I ask, shaking my head. “Why would the ceatharnaich kill these women?”

He rubs a hand across his scruff, and even through my fear, the sight of his muscular forearms flexing causes warmth to pool in my stomach. “Maybe they’re taunting the Fates. Maybe they know it will unsettle them.”

I shake away the feeling. “Could that be why An Glèidheadair isn’t allowing the women into the *After*?” I ask. “Because they died outside of the Fates’ design?”

He seems to consider this. “Aye. It would make sense.”

I grab his arm over his tunic. “We have to stop them. The souls are in pain.” I say, picturing them screaming in agony, begging for help.

“Then we’ll stop it. I willnae have a war beginning when the kingdom needs to prepare for the Epoch.” He stares at the *After*. “You say the souls only come at night? Where do they go, you think, when the sun rises?”

I follow his gaze. “I don’t know where they are. Their moans and cries only come when the sun sets, even before they appear this side of the *After*. But they’re silent while the sun is in the sky. Maybe they’re at rest.”

He nods. “Let’s hope for their sake, that’s true.”

50

BEA



Brennen and I haven’t spoken again, though we both sit by the fire, staring into the *After*. It will not be long now until they come. But at least I will not be alone tonight.

I poke at a log with a stick, my mind still reeling from Brennen’s revelation.

Finally, I break the silence. “The deaths have been scattered all throughout the kingdom. Surely whoever’s behind them isn’t traveling village to village picking people at random.” It's a thought that's plagued my mind as the day has passed. “None of the deaths has a cause. It’s not murder. I’ve seen murder. These lives simply end.”

Brennen picks up his bird. “I've wondered the same," he says. But I don’t think whoever it is has to be with the woman at all. The Cutter isn’t, when she severs our threads. I’ve seen her do it.”

He scrapes his knife across the wood, then stares down at his wrist for a long moment.

“Our dedication dàn connects us to the magic within the kingdom, but it also blocks us from accessing that magic freely. We can only manifest it in the specific ways the Fates decide. But if someone figured out how to work outside them, to get magic from the earth itself, their power could be endless.”

“But could they have enough to overpower the Fates’ will?”

He shakes his head. “I dinnae think it’s about having more power at all. All magic is connected. The fairy pools nourish it, and it flows into streams and rivers to feed the earth. The trees and flowers. When the dead pass through the mist, their magic is returned to the *After*. If someone could tap into the same magic the Fates pull from, it’s possible they could translate that power into whatever abilities they wanted, instead of being limited by the Fates’ choices.”

His words make sense, and yet somehow, they only cause more confusion. “But if someone is stealing the Cutter’s magic, you’d think she’d want to know it, wouldn’t you? So she could stop them? Why would she just ignore your warning?”

Brennen’s lips arch into an almost sneer. “The Cutter is prideful," he says, and my mouth drops open in shock.

“I never thought I'd ever hear you speak badly about your queen," I say.

He meets my eyes. “I never thought any of this would be happening.”

I’m about to ask what he means when the wind shifts, and once again, in an instant, I am no longer at the river. A sweltering heat hits me as a blacksmith shop comes into focus, dark except for the orange glow of the fire in the forge. A woman stands over an anvil, a rounding hammer in her hand. She beats at a glowing piece of metal, singing as she works.

So sing till the song takes the life it was due,
Some hands hold the blade, and some hands hold the truth.
When the river runs red and the After draws near,
The darkness will come and bring all that you fear.

A song cannae tell you the time it will end.
As long as you live, a new one can begin.
A thread cannae cut if it cannae be seen.
If I asked it of you, would you hide mine for me?

The song calls to something in me, but I don’t give myself time to think about what it is.

“You have to run," I say. The woman jumps.

“Who are you? How did you get in here?”

“You're in danger, and you will die if you don’t do as I say. Do you understand?” I sound insane, rabid, but I don’t know how else to get her to listen. “You're not safe!” I say again when she doesn’t move, louder this time. “You need to run!”

“You'll not come into my place of business and threaten me," she says.

“I'm not threatening you, I'm *warning* you. Women are dying, have you not heard? And if you don't listen to me, you’ll be next.”

The blacksmith is not amused, nor does she seem concerned.

“Get out,” she says, stalking toward me with her hammer raised. “Out!”

Her dedication dàn flashes as she approaches, and it hits me like a bolt of lightning straight in the chest.

Brennen's words. The dedication dàn tethering us to the magic of the kingdom. All magic being connected. How it gives the Fate’s power over our abilities. The woman from my dreams flashes in my mind, her dedication dàn so disfigured, it’s unrecognizable.

A thread cannae cut if it cannae be seen…

“Get out,” she screams, but I do not listen. I scan the room until my eyes land on a sharp blade cooling in a tin of water. I lunge for it, then turn it on the woman. She raises her hammer overhead and strikes. The metal glances across my forehead, but I don’t stop. My dàn of weapon accuracy flares, and I pin her arm down to the table and dig the blade into her skin, slicing through the dàn with expert precision. She cries out in pain, swinging wildly as I disfigure her flesh, cutting through the dàn until it no longer resembles a sigil at all.

“I'm sorry! I had to—”

She lifts the hammer and, with a roar, brings it down toward my temple. I lunge back, tripping on the uneven flooring, and fall.

She stalks to me, leaning over me and once again raising her now bloody hammer.

I cover my head with my hands, closing my eyes, and then the heat disappears. Brennen is standing above me, his eyes creased with concern.

“You started bleeding. Your skin just opened up, and you were bleeding.” He reaches out as if to wipe the blood away, but freezes.

I scramble to my knees and crawl to the river, my heart racing. The cold water bites into my skin as I hold my breath, a stark contrast to Brennen’s heat as he approaches from behind, but I do not look at him. Can't bear to pull my eyes away from the river.

It swirls, brown and muddy, and the wind gets even stronger, whipping at my hair.

“Please,” I beg. “Please let it have worked.”

There's a moment where the river surges, a wave that flows from upstream and crashes toward the *After*, spilling down into it. And then, the water goes still.

I hold my breath, pulling myself to stand on shaking legs. Is it possible it worked? My eyes search upstream, my heart thundering in my chest. No clothes appear, and the river sighs, caressing my legs like it’s thanking me.

Tears sting my eyes as I turn to Brennen.

His hands are clenched into fists, his eyebrows raised in surprise. But in his eyes is complete awe. Admiration, even. “You did it, didnae you?” he asks, nearly breathless.

A wide smile breaks out on my face. “I think I did,” I whisper, turning back to my river.

Her water continues to flow around my legs, gentle and clear.

And there is no name on the wind.

No face in the water.

No clothes.

Tears burn my eyes because, for the first time in over a century, I am stronger than the river.

51

BEA



The joy of saving the woman warms me almost as much as my dàn. It bubbles along my skin, up my spine, and between my lips, though I'm horrified by the way I had to do it. There's no way she'll understand I was trying to help her, and I'm sure my legend will only grow, though I've decided I'm okay with that. I will continue to be a monster if it means saving these women's lives.

Brennen hands me a blanket, draping it over my wet skirt.

"Another blanket?" I tease, smiling as I wrap it around myself. He throws a few more logs on the fire, grumbling something under his breath, then sits. He's closer than usual, his body angled so he faces the *After*.

"I cannae believe you actually did it," he says, a hint of pride in his voice. "What did you even do?"

I lean toward him. "You gave me the idea, actually."

He tilts his head, eyebrows drawing in in confusion.

"I cut through her dedication dàn. Made it unrecognizable."

"You cut her off from magic?" His eyebrows raise.

"And I do not feel guilty for it. It saved her life. If whoever's behind this is using magic to kill these women, I thought maybe cutting her off from the source completely would save her. And it worked."

"Aye. I'm no criticizing you for it. But how did you ken to cut through it?"

I look down where my own dàn used to be. “I've been having this dream of a woman sitting at a loom.”

“The Weaver?”

“No. Not a Fate. She’s mortal, but I can’t see her face. Someone knocks on the door, and she smiles at them, but whoever it is slits her throat.” I shiver as the memory of her blood pooling around my feet invades my mind.

“She dies every time?”

I nod. “But last time I saw something different. Her dedication dàn was mutilated. And there's a song I hear in my visions.

I clear my throat.

So sing till the song takes the life it was due,
Some hands hold the blade, and some hands hold the truth.
When the river runs red and the After draws near,
The darkness will come and bring all that you fear.

A song cannae tell you the time it will end.
As long as you live, a new one can begin.
A thread cannae cut if it cannae be seen.
If I ask it of you, will you hide mine for me?

“After what you said, it suddenly made sense.”

There's a creak from the *After,* interrupting us. The sound of moaning slithers through the glen, and I shiver, the hair on my arms standing on end. “They're coming,” I whisper.

Brennen's hand is already on his sword, and he slowly climbs to his feet, his shoulders squared as he steps in front of me and stares into the darkness.

“You dare sing our song while we rot in between?” A figure appears in the mist, floating toward me—the tailor's daughter; the others are behind her.

I close my eyes, my joy at saving the woman withering away.

She tilts her head sideways to an unnatural angle. “Why have you done nothing to help us? They still will not let us enter.”

Guilt pools in my stomach, thick and hot. “I'm sorry.”

“You *must* help us, Washwoman.” Her voice rises in pitch, fervent.

“Don’t you see? That’s all I am! The Washwoman! There is nothing I can do. It is no more my fault that you are trapped here than it is yours.”

“You truly believe that?” she asks, gliding closer.

Brennen takes a step forward. “Dinnae speak to her,” he says, but I’m not sure if he’s talking to me or the ghost.

A cruel smile twists her lips, and she begins to sing the melody I know so well from my visions.

The Washwoman kneels with her hands stained in red,

She knows every soul, every face of the dead.

When her mind breaks again, and the river runs dry,

She’ll remember the poor souls who taught her to die.

“When her mind breaks?” I ask, the words sticking to the inside of my throat. A phantom pain shoots through my skull, fear unfurling in my chest.

“That's enough!” Brennen says, and the tailor’s daughter turns to him.

“Careful, Dìdeanair. She’ll be your ruin, too. Tell me—” She winces, her eyes rolling back in her head. “No. Not yet,” she says, dropping to her knees.

“What's happening?” he asks.

“Your Washwoman is not the only one whose mind has been broken. All who dwell in between suffer the same fate. You have to help us,” she begs, her skin turning a deeper grey. “It's all there. Everything you need to know.” She coughs, then wails, her head tipping back as she loses herself completely. When she looks up again, her eyes are as dead as those who stand around her.

“Help us!” she cries, beyond all sense. “It hurts! Help!”

Brennen tucks me behind his back, drawing his sword. “Get in the tent. Now.”

I put a hand on his arm, and he stiffens. “I don’t think they can hurt us here. They can’t leave the river.”

“Inside,” he snaps, but I stay by his side. I know how it feels to stand before the ghosts alone, and I will not leave him to do the same. Brennen’s eyes darken with fear, or anger, or both, and he roughly grabs my arm, pulling me to the tent.

“What are you doing?” I ask, twisting against him, heart hammering against my ribs. “I can't leave you to sleep out here!” I say in disbelief.

“I willnae be sleeping out here. I’ll be sleeping in there. Now go. Inside,” he says. His voice leaves no room to argue, sharp as a blade. “Dinnae make me ask you again.” His order lands deep in my stomach, sudden and hot, curling through me in a way that causes my breath to hitch. My body moves before my pride can stop it, as if it cannot bear to refuse him.

The tent suddenly feels small, and just as before, it shrinks further as he enters, his warmth filling the space. He ties the flaps shut behind him, sealing us in. The world outside dulls, but he doesn’t.

I feel him everywhere. Every shift in his movements. The heat of him. His presence presses in on me from all sides, so strong I can hardly breathe.

I’ve been closer to Brennen than this before, but that was with the sky wide and open overhead. It’s never been like this, trapped so close with nowhere to run, and I’m not sure if the thought thrills or terrifies me.

He removes his sword, tossing it in the corner, but there’s nothing careless in the movement. He’s on edge, as taut as I am. “Are you sure they cannae leave the water?” he asks, all warrior.

All control.

“They haven't yet,” I say, shivering. He crouches in front of me, forcing me to meet his eyes.

“I'm sorry you had to face them alone.”

A lump forms in my throat. “I was alright.”

“No. I doubt you were. And I wouldnae expect you to be,” he says. “We’ll stay in here until sunrise.”

I open my mouth to argue. To tell him I can’t possibly stay in this tiny tent with him. The air is already too thin. I’m too warm, and it feels as if the walls are closing in on me. But the look he gives me causes the words to die on my tongue. His eyes are hard. Focused and unyielding.

“You willnae argue with me about it. I'm not leaving you out there for them to torment.”

I exhale slowly, then nod.

“Good lass,” he says, his low rumble sinking into my skin. Warmth spreads through my core, unexpected and deep, and I blush. Not because I’m embarrassed, but because I find I want his praise. Want to please him.

“You should go to sleep. I need to write Garrick,” he says, oblivious to the heat coursing in my blood. The place my mind has gone.

“Who?” I ask, fighting to turn my thoughts away from the words slipping from his lips.

He meets my eyes and freezes. His jaw ticks, and something dark flits across his face. Can he tell what his words have done to me? “Go to sleep,” he growls, sitting down at his writing desk. I shuffle from foot to foot, unsure where he wants me, and he sighs.

He squeezes the sides of the desk, refusing to look at me. “Lie down, Bea.”

“Where?” I ask. My voice comes out shaky. Breathy.

“Where do you think? In the bed.”

In the bed.

In *his* bed.

I take a single step back, and he tilts his head, misunderstanding the movement. “You dinnae need to be afraid. Even if I *were* that kind of man,” he says quietly, “I cannae touch you.”

My cheeks flush, and my skin flashes with heat, pricking as if it wishes that weren't the case. *I don’t want him to touch me*, I remind myself.

My dàn for detecting lies flares.

I cannot even lie to myself. “That's not— I wasn't saying—”

“Sleep,” he orders. I lay down, my chain softly clinking, and pull up the soft wool blanket as if it might shield me from him. Still, his gaze presses against my back even through the fabric, hot and persistent, and my pulse leaps. I slow my breathing, willing it to steady. Pretending, and after some time, the sound of a quill gliding against parchment meets my ears.

I do not move when, after what feels like an eternity, Brennen’s chair scrapes backwards. His heavy footfalls approach, and he lowers himself to the bedroll, pausing. The moment stretches on and on, agonizingly endless, before he slides in behind me, his movements cautious. Measured.

I squeeze my eyes shut tighter.

My heart pounds as I picture his broad shoulders taking over the space, his strong chest and thick thigh only inches away, and my body goes rigid. The space between us crackles, thrumming with something dangerous and alive.

I hold my breath as Brennen reaches over me, and when his arm brushes against my shoulder, I wonder if it was intentional. He’s moving slowly

enough he could avoid me, if he wanted, and yet my sleeve scrapes against my skin from the pressure of his graze.

He sucks in a breath, almost imperceptibly. But I hear it. I *feel* it.

He sets something down in front of me, hesitating long enough that I almost turn to him, but he pulls back just before I do. I feel the loss of his contact all the way to my toes.

I finally open my eyes.

In the flickering light, I see a dagger resting on the ground in front of me, the blade wrapped in cloth.

“What's this for?” I ask, reaching out to touch it.

“You'll need it to save the next woman, when another vision comes," he says. “You were lucky today, but you cannae always count on there being a weapon within arm’s reach.” I nod, feeling foolish for not thinking of it myself as I wrap my fingers around it.

“You're not afraid I'll use it on you?” I ask, surprised by the show of trust. “It takes a brave man to hand a murderess their dagger and then fall asleep beside her.”

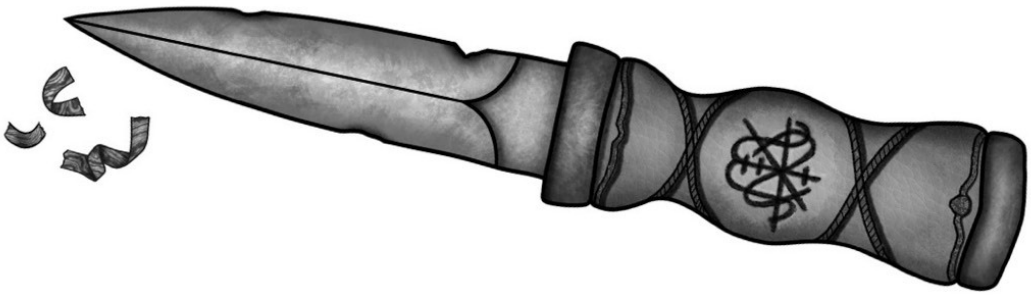
There’s a long beat of silence. Long enough, I wonder if he’s going to answer me at all. He lies still beside me, his breaths even and slow, but I know he isn’t sleeping. I can feel the rapid beat of his heart. His mind churning. “No, little lark,” he finally says, a gruff whisper, and I suddenly can’t breathe. “There’s something else I’m far more afraid of.”

He blows out his candle before I can answer. Before he can see what the name did to me. Not Bea. Not Washwoman. Lark. A songbird, free enough to fly high into the sky. Is that how he sees me now?

Heat pools in my belly, and my heart races, pounding so hard, I wonder if he can hear it. He shifts, and even without my sight, I know he’s rolled to his back. The inches between us feel less with every passing second, but I do not know if the space has actually grown smaller, or if my heart just wishes it would.

52

BRENNEN



My heart pounds as I lie beside the Washwoman, my entire body buzzing, taut as a bow string. It feels as if I'm balancing on the edge of a cliff on a windy day, the loch below rough and deadly. The proximity is too much, and my palm burns with an intensity I cannae ignore.

I hear Marsaili's voice in my mind. *You would sleep beside the woman who took me from you?* she asks.

But the moans and cries of pain outside the tent distract me from the guilt. My dàn of warning has been alerting me to danger from the moment the dead appeared. Right or wrong, I couldnae leave Bea out there alone, and should I have chosen to give her the tent and sacrifice my own shelter, I would freeze to death. The smell of snow hangs in the air, and it's only a matter of time before it begins to fall.

I roll to my back, staring into the darkness. Bea's warmth radiates through the blankets, a heat that begs me to shift closer, and I move another inch away, just to prove to myself I can.

The ghosts continue to wail outside, and I shudder. I picture Bea hiding, only a blanket between herself and the lost souls.

"Did they come every night I was gone?" I ask, sensing she isn't asleep. Bea jumps at the sound of my voice, and my lips tip into a smile. At least I'm not the only one on edge. She's as tense as I am, lying stiffly next to me, hardly breathing.

“No. Only the last few,” she says. “I saw glimpses before. Heard moans and saw figures, but I thought I was imagining things. The night I told you someone was in the *After*? That must have been one of them.”

Her words send a pang of pity through me. Had she been worried she was going mad again, alone here with no one to confirm she wasn’t just seeing things? “How did you hide from them?” I ask.

Her breath hitches. She doesn’t answer immediately, and when she does, her voice is tentative. “I— I slept in here. I know it was an intrusion, but I was so afraid—”

“No,” I say, stopping her before she can apologize. “I'm glad you did.”

She exhales in relief. “Do you think—” she starts, then clears her throat. She takes a deep breath, rolling to face me, but I do not allow myself to do the same. Her gaze tickles the skin of my face, and I know if I just looked at her, her bright blue eyes would be shining.

“Do you think if I can find a way to free them, my crimes might be forgiven?”

I close my eyes. The hope in her voice lands like a blow to the chest, and I want to block it out. “I dinnae think there is anything you can do for the Cutter to let you go.”

“No. Not forgiveness from the Fates. From the Three of the path. Do you think if I can save the women before they are taken and free the ones unable to enter the *After*, maybe they will forgive me?”

Yes. The word comes instantly, and I want to tell her, but instead I remain silent. It’d be unfair to give her hope when I cannae promise her that Am Breitheamh would judge her well. My chest rises and falls with heavy breaths, a war brimming behind my sternum, making my heart pound even harder. “I dinnae know the answer to that,” I say honestly, and I sense her shoulders fall. “Do you still want to die?” I ask.

She's quiet for a long moment, thoughtful.

“Not right now. Not until we free those souls. Not until women are no longer being killed. But, once I've done my part, once I've made things right as much as I can, then yes. I've been alive a very long time, and most of it has been unpleasant. I should think I would like to finally rest.”

Her words should bring relief, but they don’t. Instead, my chest tightens, and my hands itch to reach out to her.

She continues. “I'd like to think Am Breitheamh would grant me peace. That he would forgive my broken mind, and let the lives I save balance out

the ones I never wanted to take.”

My breathing becomes shallow. “I do, too,” I whisper, and I realize it's the truth. I meet her eyes, not because I want to, but because the pull of her gaze demands it. Just as I suspected, bright blue shines back at me, swimming with so many emotions, I can hardly process them all—regret and shame and hope.

She gives me a sad smile, then closes those eyes, and without that brightness, it’s suddenly hard to breathe.

Her own breaths begin to even, and my body relaxes a fraction, hoping that she’s finally falling asleep. I cannae lie here next to her while she is awake. When I dinnae know what thoughts are running through her mind.

“Brennen?” she asks, her voice sleepy. Those blue-grey eyes find mine again, and this time, I cannot place what’s in them at all. Or maybe I don’t want to.

“Aye?”

“I know you think I’m horrible for what I did. For killing those people.”

My mouth goes dry. I dinnae ken how to respond. Of course, I'm angry. The act itself is horrifying. Unforgivable, but also, part of me knows she would've never chosen to have killed Marsaili, or anyone. I’m as certain of it as the unbreakable vow on my hand. So am I angry at her, or at the universe, for wearing her down to a point that broke her?

“I just wanted to say it's alright,” she says. “It’s alright that you think I’m a monster. And I know you still have to kill me,” she says, and in her voice, fuck me, is understanding.

Absolution.

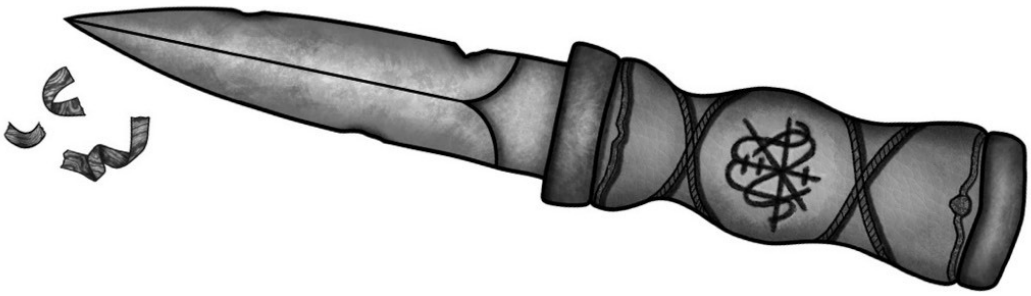
My hand flexes at my side, and something in my chest shatters, but not for Bea. For myself.

Because I dinnae know how I will be able to kill her now. The realization is overwhelming, a fist slamming directly into my stomach. And yet, that wanting changes nothing. My vow is still carved into my flesh. By Samhain next, either the Washwoman will be dead, or I will, my soul eternally a servant to the goddess of death.

And nothing can change it.

53

BRENNEN



A week passes in the same routine. Days of sitting by the fire reading through Harold's journal, Bea beside me, dagger clutched firmly in her hand. Nights where we lie beside each other, never touching. Barely sleeping. Barely breathing.

She's had two visions since the blacksmith, and neither of the women's clothes floated down the river.

Her plan is working.

Though her eyes are tired, her soft smile doesn't fade, and in that smile, I feel I understand her a bit more.

She has a purpose now. A reason to live, and that terrifies me.

As does the way I cannae stop watching her. Every shift catches my eye. Every sound my ear.

As if taunting me, she looks up, and my gaze finds hers immediately. Our eyes lock, and my chest tightens. I clear my throat, standing. I need some space from this. Some distance from the monster who is not a monster at all. I whistle for Sable.

"You're leaving?" Bea asks, stopping me.

"Aye. It's been long enough for me to go back to the village safely. "I should return this," I say, lifting the book. "And I need to get more food."

She ties her hair back, and my hands itch to undo it. To unbind her curls and watch them blow wildly in the wind. It only solidifies my resolve to get some space. I cannae be thinking of her like this. Not now, or ever.

She presses her lips together. “Do you think maybe there are more books where you got that one? Something other than journals? I'd love something to read. But of course I understand if—”

“I'll ask,” I say, growing more desperate to leave the glen by the second. Her gentle smile grows, and the unwanted feeling coiling beneath my ribs twists tighter. I try to ignore it, but even as I walk away, as I ride Sable toward Dalbàsail, pushing her to jump over fallen logs and dart through trees, the feeling stays with me. It refuses to ease. More stubborn than even my shadow.

It isnae until the now familiar gates to the village appear that a small fraction of the pressure in my chest loosens. Here, I can just be. There is no war inside my mind. No one I must kill.

It starts to snow as I tie Sable to Harold's gate and make my way toward the tavern—thick, fluffy flakes, and before I even make it to Theo's doorstep, there's a dusting on the ground.

I push my way inside, kicking my boots against the doorframe. It's still somewhat early, but a few guardians sit around the tables playing a game of knucklebones. I do not recognize them, but based on the single stripes on their uniforms and lack of dàn adorning their necks and forearms, they’re low ranking.

I clear my throat, and they jump to their feet, placing their hands behind their back. It's a sign of respect, one I've performed thousands of times to higher-ranking guardians than I, but in this case, it feels wrong. Forced, almost.

They are here because of Cailleach’s anger at me. Because she wants me to feel the pressure of her presence and remind me that she is always watching.

Remind me that my family’s strings are in her hands.

“Please,” I say, nodding at the chairs. “Sit.”

“Join us,” one of them says. I do not allow my eyes to flick around the room to look for Theo, pulling out a chair even though the last thing I wish to do is share a drink with men searching for reasons to report my misdeeds.

What I want is to talk to Theo. To gather information about what’s happened since I saw him last, and learn the kinds of questions Cailleach’s guardians have been asking.

“I see Cailleach sent me some assistance. What a nice surprise,” I say.

“You didn't know we were here?” one of them asks.

“No…” I let the word trail off, raising my eyebrows.

“Bradley.”

“Bradley. I just arrived back from a visit to my family this morning. I appreciate you all filling in in my stead.”

“It's no trouble,” another one says.

“And you are?”

“Phillip.”

I raise my eyebrows. “You think it's no trouble to guard the Washwoman?” I ask.

“Well, it would be if we were allowed to see her. We were given direct orders. Leave the Washwoman alone. Be here, in case you need our help and—”

“Report my every move back to the Cutter,” I say, folding my hands and leaning on the table. I smile like it's a joke, but they stiffen, their eyes darting between one another.

“Of course not,” Bradley says. “We're simply meant to be available should you need us. It's been quite fun, actually.”

He's a terrible liar. All of them are. Bradley looks to the left while the man who hasn't shared his name fiddles with the buttons on his uniform.

“Och, I'm only joking, lads,” I say, slapping Bradley on the arm a little too hard. “There would be nothing to tell. Though I could use your help.”

They lean forward, intrigued.

“Keep your ears out for information. I'm sure Cailleach told you the Washwoman cannae be killed. The village is afraid of her, but they talk about her often. Write down what you hear them say. Anything at all about her.”

“We can do that," Philip says eagerly, appearing grateful I've moved on from my accusation of them spying.

The man to my left drops his voice low. “Are there any ceatharnaich here?” he asks, eyes darting around excitedly.

Bradley laughs. “That’s Jamie. Ignore him. He's bored. He doesnae like to drink, and doesnae like the lasses, either. There’s not been much to do here other than that.”

I force a laugh even though I find his bright-eyed question repulsive. Why would he wish for there to be ceatharnaich? So he could execute them to pass the time?

“Sorry to disappoint you, but no. There are no ceatharnaich here. I've been watching the people here for weeks. It's just a small town with villagers whose biggest concern is putting food on the table and staying safe from the Washwoman.” I stand. “Now, keep your ears out for me. I need to speak with the barkeep about replenishing supplies.”

They nod, turning to one another and going back to their knucklebones. I keep one ear on their conversation, but can only hear bits and pieces.

“Washwoman.”

“She’ll want to know.”

And then a relieved voice. “Didnae come back early.”

Good. Let them tell her I followed her rules. Garrick will corroborate it.

I take a seat at the bar, and after a few moments, Anna approaches, giving me a broad smile. Her bruises are gone, and her face appears less gaunt, as if she’d had a few good meals since leaving.

“It’s nice to see you again. Can I get you anything?” she asks.

I return her smile. “No, I’m here to speak with Theo. You look well. How are the bairns?”

Her eyes light up. “Happiest they’ve ever been. Theo has been letting Billy help with odds and ends around here. Giving him a purpose. It’s done wonders.”

“Aye. It’s good for children to learn responsibility,” I nod, thinking of my siblings.

“You speak as if you know first hand. Do you have children?” she asks, wiping the counter.

“No. I have younger siblings, though, back home in Vengach.”

Theo appears, carrying a box down the stairs. He lets loose a breath when he sees me, relief settling over his features. Anna nods at me, moving on to tend to a patron at the other end of the bar.

“Brennen. Havenae seen you in a while. I was starting to worry,” he says, and I force a laugh.

“Took an unexpected trip to visit my family,” I say, glad that he, too, can confirm that I didnae defy the Cutter’s orders.

“Here for supplies?” he asks, his eyes flicking to the guardians seated behind me.

“Aye.” I give a sharp nod.

“They're in the back. Come with me,” he says, leading me around the bar and through a separate door. I follow, and we walk in silence, twisting

through a long dark hallway until we come to a damp store room.

“Can they hear us?” he whispers.

I pull out my carving, wanting to busy my fingers to dispel some of my nervous energy. “No. They're too low ranking for the Cutter to give them a dàn of hearing.”

His face relaxes. “Good. Where have you been? Did you truly go to see your family as they said?”

I rub my hand down my face. “I did, but not because I wanted to. It was on Cailleach’s orders.”

He raises his eyebrows. “Why would she do that?”

“She didnae like that I questioned her.”

“I dinnae like them here. They’ll bring nothing but trouble," he says.

“Aye. And not just because they're watching me. They were just asking if there are rebels here,” I say.

Theo’s eyes go wide. “Of course there aren’t.”

“I dinnae ken if it matters. You know as well as I do that Harold's journal is enough for the Cutter to think there is, should she find out about it.”

He shakes his head. “It's just his grandda's journal. You can't fault him—”

I narrow my eyes and cross my arms. “It's more than that, and you ken it,” I say. My statement hangs there between us, loaded with meaning. Because while I know there aren't rebels lurking about planning to overthrow the queens, I also know that the people here do not consider themselves her loyal subjects, either.

Theo’s jaw works, his hands clenching into fists. “No one here would dare risk their lives to defy the Fates.”

I lift my hands in front of me. “I know. And you're all safe. With *me,* at least. But you need to understand the gravity of the situation you are all now in. Cailleach is watching me closely. If she gets any suspicion the people here are against her, she'll have Athair burn this entire village to the ground in a single breath, and she willnae lose a wink of sleep over it.”

“But you’re one of her top Dìdeanair. Why would she be watching *you*?”

I take a second to listen, making sure none of the guards have followed. My dàn of warning remains silent. “Bea has been having visions. The

women who are disappearing, she sees them. Every single one. But she sees their lives instead of their deaths, and then she's sent their clothes to wash.

Theo pales. "What do you mean? The disappearing women are… They're all dead?"

I nod. "Aye. And the Cutter refused to hear of it."

Theo rubs the back of his neck. "What does this mean?"

"It means someone has magic like this," I say, holding up the book. "Someone is killing outside of the Fates' power. But the women's souls are not passing into the *After*. They're trapped, haunting the river. And the Cutter is too prideful to do anything to stop it." Just saying the words makes anger ignite in my chest.

Theo shakes his head. "That will only make the ceatharnaich more active. If they find out the Cutter is doing nothing to stop their women from disappearing—"

"It will be all-out war." The statement settles between us, filling the dank space with a violent intensity.

Theo begins to pace. "What do we do? How can we stop it?"

His nervous energy bounces off me, and I lean against the wall, suddenly exhausted. "I dinnae ken. Have you heard of any other disappearances?"

"Not for several days. And the guards talk when they're drunk. I'm sure I'd have heard if there'd been another."

"There was no blacksmith who disappeared?"

He shakes his head, eyebrows scrunching together. "No. No blacksmith."

Pride swells in my chest. She really did it. "Bea is stopping the deaths. She learned if you destroy a dedication dàn, it disconnects you from magic completely. Whoever is doing this, they cannae reach you if your dàn isnae intact. Which is exactly why Harold's book is so dangerous. Whoever is doing this, they've found a way to manifest magic outside the Fates."

"Harold would never hurt anyone."

"I know that. But it doesnae matter. If Cailleach starts searching for people using magic outside their design, she will kill him without a thought. He needs to burn it." I pull out the book. "This, and anything else he has that could link him to magic. Will you tell him?"

"Aye. But he said he found something else. He wants to talk to you."

I sigh, rubbing the back of my neck. “Bea told me. But I can't go to him now, not with the guards watching.”

He stops pacing. “He comes in every evening. I'll tell him you'll come in the night.”

I appraise Theo for a moment, his eagerness to help. To do the right thing. It’s admirable, and I find that I trust him more than I’d have thought possible. “Have him leave the door unlocked. I'll find him when it's safe.”

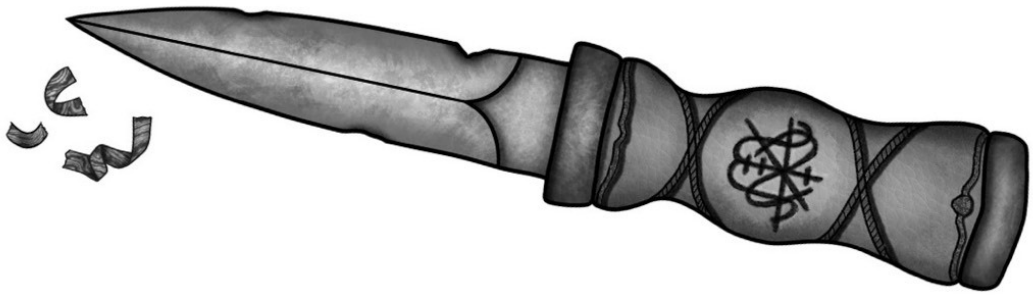
Theo walks to the corner where a stack of supplies sits, as if he'd been preparing for this for days. Dried meats and fruit. Bread and nuts. He hands it to me.

“I think you’re right about the guardians. The Cutter is having them watch you. They've been asking after you. About Bea, as well.”

I hold his stare. “You need to be careful then, because after meeting with me, I'm certain they're watching you now, too.”

54

BRENNEN



Theo's warning plagues me as I ride back to the river, Sable's saddlebags full.

They're asking after Bea and me. Except, something won't settle in my mind. The pieces won't click into place, but I dinnae ken why.

The Cutter is prideful, yes, but would she really not want to stop someone from using magic outside of her and her sisters' will? They've killed for far less. Is it possible that she *wants* a war? Wants the rebels, or anyone even considering joining their cause, to be flushed out and executed? Because if that's the case, what I'd said to Theo wasn't wrong.

The loss of life would be staggering.

The sound of Bea humming floats through the glen as I approach, a happier tune than the magical song of mourning she usually sings. I hop off Sable, giving her an apple from the bag, and remove one of the satchels to carry to the river.

My grip slips when I see her, the bag nearly falling to the ground as the air is stolen from my lungs.

Bea is standing in the middle of the river, the water hitting just above her knees, and her face is tipped toward the falling snow. Fat flakes stick in her fiery red hair, only lasting a moment before melting into nothing, her dàn of warmth heating her to even the tips of her curls. But it's not the serenity on her face that makes me pause. That makes me clench my hands, and my mouth goes dry.

It's that she's bathing, and she’s not wearing her dress.

My chest tightens, my cock growing hard as my eyes skate across her pale, bare legs. Her arms and torso, and I suddenly wish I’d had a dram at the tavern. Maybe it would have dulled my senses enough to douse the fire the sight of her ignites in my blood.

The dàn on my hand burns, my vow reminding me of how wrong what I’m doing is, watching her like this, but I cannae look away. Even worse, I dinnae *want* to. Her skin is the color of buttermilk, and my fingers crave to touch it. To feel her warmth. Her softness.

She rubs a bar of soap lazily up and down her arms, between her breasts over her dàn of immortality, then takes a few steps toward the deeper water, diving in and fully submerging her head. When she reappears, drops of water trail down her freckled face. She rubs the bar of soap between her hands, lathering it, and begins to wash her hair.

My body begs me to take it from her. To wash her myself. To thread my fingers through her curls so I will finally know if her hair is as soft as it looks.

It doesnae feel like a fleeting, careless want, but a desperate need. Like my heart will stop beating if I dinnae take care of her. And in more ways than just washing her hair.

I imagine my mouth on her. My fingers inside her.

My breaths go ragged as I think of what it would be like to watch her come undone. To give her respite from her endless torment. My cock aches at the thought, and the dàn on my palm flares so hot, I nearly drop to my knees. Shame settles in my stomach, trying to burn my desire away from the inside out.

I shouldn’t feel like this. Not about anyone, but especially for the woman who killed Marsaili. Even if she hadn’t done it on purpose. Even if the curse had driven her to madness. And still, her body calls to me, like she is her own type of magic that has burrowed inside my bones and corrupted my heart and mind.

It takes every bit of my self-control to remain still for one heartbeat. Then two. I should turn away, but I'm certain if I move, I will go to her instead. Run my hands along the small swells of her breasts, take the soap from her and rub it across her belly. Between her legs.

There's a rustling from the other side of the river, and Bea looks toward it, a wide smile spreading across her face as a fox appears through the

heather.

“Well, hello there. I don't think I've met you before,” she coos.

The fox tilts its head, watching her for a moment, then turns its head and yips. Three chocolate brown foxes emerge, babies, and Bea’s eyes turn concerned.

“Poor things. You're hungry, aren't you?”

It's only then that I notice how thin the mother fox is, likely from nursing her babies. Without enough food to eat in this frigid, snowy weather, it's likely they won’t survive.

“Stay there,” Bea coos, standing. “I’ll get some food for you. I know how it feels to be hungry.”

I hear her stomach growl at the mention of food, and I suddenly feel like I cannae breathe.

“I don't think Brennen will mind,” she continues. I don’t miss that she has never stolen food for herself, but is willing to do so for a wild animal. She must be starving, I realize. She’d said she didn’t *need* food, and her body isn’t gaunt or frail, but it must be because of the curse. Her body doesnae change, and she cannae die, even from hunger. I dinnae know why I hadn’t thought of it before. And here I am, thinking about putting my hands on her body instead of how I can get food inside of it.

“And if he does,” she continues with a shrug, “he already hates me.”

Her words make my chest hurt, a pang of guilt slicing straight between my ribs.

She turns toward the tent, and I take a step back, but it’s too late.

Her eyes lock onto mine, but she doesn't cover herself. She holds my gaze, too steady to be surprised. How long has she known I was standing here?

Facing me, I can see every curve and hollow even more clearly. She’s painfully stunning. More beautiful than I could have possibly imagined beneath her clothes.

The thought sends a fresh wave of guilt pulsing through me.

Her dàn for immortality becomes more visible on her sternum, right where the villagers tried to carve it from her skin. I imagine the puckered skin of a slit throat. Her blue face when she had drowned.

And yet she stands tall. Unafraid.

“The babies are hungry. The mother needs food.”

I force myself to exhale. “Take whatever you need,” I say, taking a few steps forward to set my satchel of supplies down. “There's more in here.”

Her eyes soften. “Thank you," she says, and I avert my gaze, turning around. Water sloshes as she makes her way toward me.

I swallow. “I’ll um— I’ll go hunt for dinner. Give you some privacy,” I say, ducking into my tent and grabbing my bow and arrow. She doesnae answer me, and the weight of shame on my shoulders grows heavier. *He already hates me.*

When I return outside, I pause, but don’t turn around. Facing the trees, I clear my throat, and the sound of Bea shuffling through my bags halts. I feel the weight of her eyes on my back, waiting.

“I dinnae hate you, Bea,” I say, my voice as rough as tree bark. “I should. But I don’t.”

55

BEA



Snow continues to fall, covering the purple heather in a thick white sheet. Normally, this is my least favorite time of the year. The months I spend frozen to the bone, my teeth chattering and my limbs shaking. But with my dàn of warmth, I find I quite enjoy it. The snow is beautiful, and it brings a peace to the glen I've never allowed myself to notice before.

I add a log to the fire, then lean back, reaching my palm out to catch the snow. The shimmering flakes melt on my skin instantly, leaving behind little specks of water that remind me of dew drops.

Brennen hasn't returned from hunting, and my skin tingles at the memory of him watching me. I'd seen him long before I turned in his direction. And yet, I hadn't said anything, wanting to know why he stood there, staring. Hoping that maybe it wasn't just me who's been feeling this pull between us. It'd been thrilling, for those few long, tense moments.

But when I came up from the water, it hadn't been lust on his face at all. It was disgust.

It had been physically painful to see, carving out a hollow spot where I'd placed the bits of hope that we were forming a friendship. Maybe something more. It's why I'd told the mother fox Brennen hated me, even though I no longer believe he truly does. At least, not in the same way he used to. I'd said it because I knew it would hurt him. Had wanted him to feel the sharp bite of disappointment, just as I had when I'd seen his face.

Is it possible I’ve been wanting his affection so badly, I’ve been seeing something that wasn’t truly happening?

It stings more than I anticipated, but I try to lock down the pain. The embarrassment that I’d actually thought I was beginning to matter to him, and remind myself that I’m merely an assignment. A prisoner.

I glance across the river where the foxes have curled inside a log, their bellies full. If nothing else, at least Brennen being here allowed me to feed them. Maybe they'll stay. Maybe, unlike my dragon, someday they will come close enough for me to touch them. To have some sort of connection.

I pick at the hem of my dress, trying to push the image of Brennen's appalled face from my mind.

There's a thud behind me, and I jump, turning around. An already gutted and cleaned boar speared onto a thick stick lies on the ground at Brennen's feet, and without a word, he shoves two Y-shaped branches into the ground on either side of the fire. He picks up the hog, grunting as he fights to line the spear into the grooves. He doesn’t look at me, his movements fast and focused. His hair is wild, his face tight, and I search it for emotions.

He’d sounded so sad when he walked away. So conflicted, but now he looks like he’s running on something primal. Like something is clawing it’s way out of the depths of his soul to escape his tight lid of control.

“What's this for?” I ask, my mouth watering at just the thought of roasted hog. “Did you catch it for the foxes?”

“No,” he says gruffly, wiping his sweaty brow with his forearm. “I caught it for you.” He picks up his canteen, his throat bobbing as he drinks deeply.

I suck in a breath. “For me?” He’s been here for months and has never once shared his kills with me. So why now?

Brennen’s jaw is set in a hard line, the muscle in his cheek jumping. He looks angry, but I'm not sure what I could've done to cause it, or why it would make him want to feed me. He rotates the hog on the spit.

“I knew you'd been starved, but I didnae ken you were starving *now*. You didn't tell me. I thought you had enough with your fish and your berries. You turned down food once, and you never asked for any of my rations. Hardly even looked at them. I thought maybe you didnae need to eat.”

Part of me wants to laugh at him. To tell him that, of course, I’m hungry. Always. But the heat in his eyes stops me. “Well, technically, I

don’t. But *you* do, and your rations seem to be only enough for yourself.”

He tosses several logs on the fire, shaking his head as if my answer only fuels his anger.

I stutter, trying to think of a response. He’d brought me several things I needed, so why hadn’t I told him? “I didn’t think you would have given it to me if I asked,” I say, testing the waters.

“Aye, I would have, and I think you ken it!” he shouts, throwing his arms out as he finally turns, pinning me with a stare. The words echo through the glen, and a flock of curlews flies away in fear. Brennen’s chest heaves, and there's a fire in his eyes that frightens me.

“You’re right,” I say, keeping my voice strong, even though guilt scrapes down my spine. “I'm sorry I didn't tell you I was hungry,” I say softly. “I’ve asked other men who visit for scraps before, but they never oblige me.”

“Well, I'm no other men.” He stiffens. “And what do you mean, visited you?” His fingers curl into white-knuckled fists.

This question, I do not answer.

He already knows what I mean.

“No,” he shakes his head, rubbing the back of his neck. “No.”

The word is a stab to the chest, and I bring a hand up to my sternum to rub away the pain, the stinging so much worse than the cold wind against my cheeks.

“I was beautiful, once, you know. Before the bloodstains. Men would come here occasionally, looking for a thrill. Could they bed the Washwoman?”

“Stop,” he says.

“Why? Most men aren’t as honorable as you. I didn’t let them, if that’s what you’re worried about. Or are you confused about how anyone could possibly want me? Is that why you were so disgusted when you saw my body?”

“Disgusted?” he says, his voice lowering dangerously, pulling the hair on my arms to attention.

I do not look away. I know what I saw, and I will not back down. “Aye. I saw your face when I came out of the water.” I put my hands on my hips. “You were standing there for far longer than just the moment the foxes appeared.”

“You think I’m disgusted by you?” he growls, his voice bringing gooseflesh to my arms. “That I dinnae think anyone could want you?” He stalks forward, grabbing my wrist over my sleeve.

He leans down, his fingers squeezing my arm, so hard it’s almost painful, and when he speaks again, it’s nothing more than a low rumble. “It’s not you I’m disgusted with. I'm disgusted with *myself*.” He lets go, beginning to pace. “Because I saw you, and *I* wanted you.” He shoves a finger into his own chest. “Because it’s not the first time I’ve wanted to wrap your curls around my hand. To examine that dàn between your breasts with my tongue, and taste that beautiful mouth you never stop talking with. Because you are nothing like the woman I thought I would find here. You're smart and sharp-witted. As beautiful as you are strong, and somehow, even after all you’ve been through, you’re bloody standing.”

He stops abruptly, rubbing his forehead, then turns and meets my eyes. Eyes replete with what I can only describe as utter devastation.

“You’ve become the searing heat of flames against my skin, growing stronger each day, devouring all the oxygen in your wake, consuming everything you touch. Every fiber of my being, until my mind can hold nothing but you. I can hardly breathe in your presence for my wanting you. *That* is why you saw disgust on my face. Because I was sent here to kill you. Because I *have* to kill you. And instead, I want you more than even the breath I cannae find.”

My pulse roars in my ears, drowning out everything but Brennen. His anger and frustration. I’m frozen, as if I’ve forgotten how to move completely.

He *wants* me.

Me.

My chest tightens, something dangerous unfolding inside it. A need I don’t recognize. A yearning to be looked at like this forever. To be wanted by a man like him.

No, not a man *like* him. Just *him*.

He holds up his hand, his scarred palm lined with black.

“How weak of a man am I,” his voice cracks, defeat in every syllable, “that I still want you, even when I have no choice but to end your life.”

Tears sting my eyes, even as I have to press my legs together to ease some of the ache building between them. “I told you, it's okay. I *know* you have to kill me. I won’t try to change that. But,” I swallow. “But until it’s

time to finish what you came here to do, you can allow yourself to want me, too."

The words feel dangerous as soon as they leave my lips, wisps floating away like dandelion seeds in the wind, but it's too late to take them back.

He steps back as if I've burned him.

"You dinnae understand," he says, his voice pained. "If I'm going to—" he cuts off, his jaw tightening. "I *need* to hate you, but I can't. I don't."

His confession carves straight into my heart, a deep sorrow for the battle he's fighting over what he views as right. Tears sting my eyes, blurring the edges of him.

"Then don't," I whisper.

He closes his eyes, shaking his head as he drops down by the fire. I follow him, placing my hand on his sleeve, begging him to listen to me with my touch. "If you have to kill me, so be it. It's what I've wanted, Brennen—rest. You'd be easing my suffering, in the end."

The words should feel heavier than they do, but they don't. It has been a long time since the thought of dying scared me more than the thought of living forever, but I feel it now, creeping into my chest.

"You could ease my suffering now, too," I say, somehow brave and terrified to speak the words aloud all at once.

He doesn't answer, his chest heaving as he continues to stare at my hand like the touch is too much and not enough in the same breath, but something in his eyes tells me he wants to say more. That he's holding back.

My heart aches at the war he's clearly fighting, and I scoot closer. "It's been a very, very long time since anyone has looked at me with anything other than hatred and revulsion. Just as long since anyone touched me with anything other than anger."

I scoot even closer when he doesn't respond, my knee now almost touching his thigh, and he looks at that inch of space between us.

"You don't need to hate yourself for whatever it is you're feeling. For your vow. Or for wanting me." A flush creeps up my neck, and I have to look away, afraid that if I see his resolve to hate me strengthen, it will destroy me. "Because even knowing what you have to do, I want you, too."

He closes his eyes, breaths shaking. "You've really only been touched in anger for over a century?" he asks, his voice rough.

I don't answer. I don't need to. I know what was in that journal he read, the details of all the ways people have tried to kill me. That's not the half of

it.

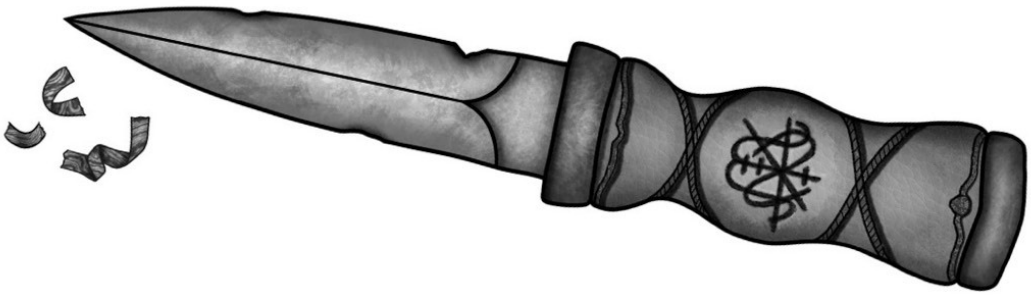
His hand lifts, the space between his palm and my cheek almost nothing, as if he's going to damn it all and touch me. My breath catches, my heart pounding, but his fingers curl into a tight fist. With a slow exhale, Brennen shakes his head.

He pulls his hand away fully, grabbing his wood carving from the ground and squeezing it in his fist, as if he needs something to hold onto, *anything*, other than me.

And it hurts more than anything written in that journal had.

56

BRENNEN



My cock throbs. I’m so hard it aches, but I refuse to go to my tent, even if all I want right now is to take myself in my palm and ease the pressure. I hang my head in my hands, forcing myself to picture Marsaili’s face. To replace Bea’s red curls in my mind with blonde. Blue-grey with brown.

Because how can I betray her memory like this? How can I be having these thoughts?

It's not that I think Marsaili would fault me for having feelings for someone else. I'm certain she'd want me to be happy. She would want me to experience all that life and love have to offer.

But not with *her*. Even if Bea didn’t mean to do what she did.

I dig my knife into my wood carving, but I cannae focus, slicing too large a piece out of the wing.

The wind stirs, and Bea looks up from where she’s drawing in the mud, searching the river for the clothes that will soon follow. We haven’t spoken again, and it nearly kills me. The defeat in her posture. The pain in her eyes.

I’m unable to stop myself from watching as she rises and moves to the river, accepting a dress into her delicate hands. She stiffens, and I straighten as she pulls what looks like several sticks bound together from a pocket. Bea raises it into the light, twisting it back and forth.

“What is that?” I ask, peering over her shoulder.

She takes a deep breath before speaking, as if mustering up the nerve. “I think it’s a “Seun a’ chaorainn. The charm of the rowan.” Bea’s eyes narrow, and she looks up into the mist of the *After*.

“The charm of the rowan?” I ask, and she nods.

“Old rune magic. Three rowan sticks with a piece of bone bound to them with rowan berry thread, warded with dàn to keep away spirits.”

I peer closer, looking at the tiny dàn etched into the sticks. I don’t ask her how she knows about it. It’s magic, just as illegal as the spells I found in Harold’s book, but I no longer care.

Bea runs her fingers along the knobs of the branches, tilting her head. “Would you get a large stick? Tall enough to shove into the riverbed? And do you have any twine?” She finally meets my eyes, and I nearly flinch at the shadows beneath them.

Some nights need an alpha, some a billionaire, and some a heroine who scares both.

Choose tonight's company at **Lokepub**.

“Aye,” I say, hurrying to grab the supplies from my tent, glad to have something I *can* do for her. If I cannae offer her what she truly wants, the least I can do is help her when she needs it. When I return, Bea is wading into the river as far as her chain will allow, still feet away from the inky mist of the *After*.

Realization dawns on me. “You think it will keep the souls below?” I ask.

She doesn’t look at me. “Do you think it will work?”

I peer into the dark mist, in awe of her brilliance. “I dinnae ken, but it’s worth a try.”

She nods. “It’s quiet during the day. I told you I think when it’s light, they sleep. It's not until just before the moon rises that they wander the shore, and I hear their moans. Maybe if we can keep them on that side of the *After*, they can rest until we learn how to free them.”

I nod, holding a hand out, and Bea drops the charm into it. I walk past her, stopping less than a foot from the inky darkness. It does not reach out to me like it does to her, but still, I’m careful not to touch it as I firmly push

the stick down into the river’s floor. Once I’m satisfied the current won’t be able to knock the branch over, I tie the charm to it.

The bright red thread is stark against the black of the *After*, and it sends a shiver down my spine.

Bea calls to me from the end of her chain. “If we hear their cries of pain tonight… If I'm wrong about them sleeping down there and they cannot escape once the sun sets, will you take it down?”

“You want them out here?” I ask, turning to her and raising my eyebrows.

She twists her hands together. “No. I don't. But I don't want them trapped, either. I know what it's like to not be able to go where you wish. I do not want that for those souls.”

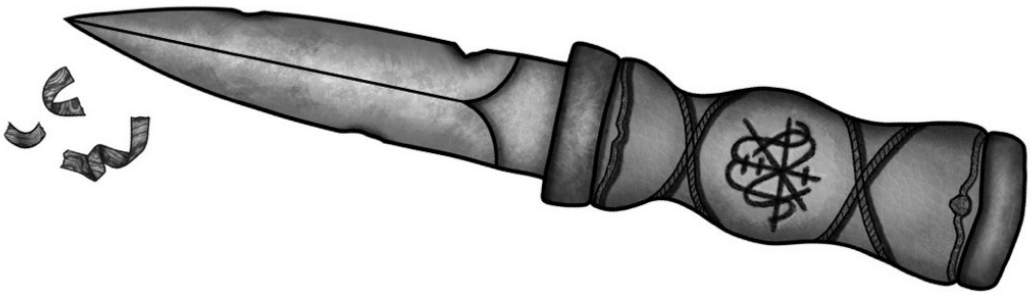
Her words somehow only make me want her more. She’s willing to live in fear and feel the pain of the dead, to suffer, so that those souls don’t. “Aye,” I say, wading back to Bea. She stiffens when I place my hand at the small of her back. The touch isn’t intentional. It wasnae a choice, but still, I cannae pull away until she is safely to shore.

The contact is brief, but it burns my hand, my vow searing with pain. Even once the pain fades, tingles remain, energy crackling along my skin.

I shake my hand as I return to the fire, flipping the boar over to cook the other side as if nothing happened. As if none of this day had happened.

57

BRENNEN



Bea and I stand facing the *After* as the last hints of light disappear behind the ridge, the moon glowing through the fog.

Closing my eyes, I listen, activating my dàn of hearing. I notice then that Bea isnae breathing. I cannae hear the scrape of her inhales and exhales, but I can hear the racing of her heart.

“I think it’s working,” I say. Bea gives me a sharp nod, but she doesnae appear convinced. She remains by the fire long after nightfall, and so I join her, unable to fathom leaving her out here alone.

We don't speak, but my need from seeing her today doesnae ease.

Bea busies herself staring into the sky, but her gaze drifts into the *After* every few minutes, I think, watching for souls, making sure she doesnae hear them, but as the hours pass, her trepidation seems to lessen. Once again, I think Bea figured out a way to solve one of our many problems.

I try to focus on my carving, but every few seconds, my eyes flick to her, her soft features glowing in the light of the fire. She's somehow almost more beautiful in the night. Her long eyelashes leave behind shadows on her cheeks, as do her full lips, and her freckles are somehow even more noticeable on her pale skin in the moonlight.

She meets my eyes, and I expect her to look away, but she doesn't. She holds my gaze, and the pressure in both my chest and cock builds.

“You're staring,” she says, her lips quirking and her cheeks flushing, and goddess, if it doesn't send more blood straight between my legs. Some of

her sorrow seems to have faded away, and I find I’m grateful she’s back to teasing me.

“I'm not,” I say, looking down at my bird.

“I wouldn’t hate it if you were,” she says, the tips of her ears turning pink.

I press my lips together, forcing my gaze from her face. It lands on her chain, and my stomach twists.

“I haven't found a way to escape, if that’s what you’re checking on,” she teases, and I grunt, because at this point, I almost wish she would. If she disappeared, I wouldnae be able to kill her. I could run to my family, cut their dedication dàn and hide, protect them until Ban-dia a’ Bhàis came for me. Would that save them from death by the Cutter’s hand? If I could only be certain, I would do it in a heartbeat. Ban-dia a’ Bhàis can have my soul. At this point, I dinnae think I care.

She stares at the bird in my hand, tilting her head.

“If I’m a lark… what kind of bird would you be? A robin?" she asks.

“I'm not a bird,” I say, and Bea leans back, assessing me.

“What are you then?” she asks. I take another scrape of wood.

“I'm a wolf,” I say, and she laughs. Actually laughs at me. “I wouldn’t give yourself too much credit, oh, terrifying wolf. You’ve yet to hurt me.”

I freeze. “But I will.”

She makes a noncommittal noise, fidgeting with her hem. “I think you're all talk. You want me, yet you're on the other side of the fire. You're going to kill me, but you’ve done nothing to try to end my life. In fact, as you pointed out, you’ve saved it.”

“Not technically,” I grumble, and she laughs again.

“You act as if it's simple,” I say, eyes trained on my carving even though all my attention is on her.

“Isn’t it?” she asks, but I ignore her. I dinnae have an answer for that. Not when I know I havenae been trying to learn how to kill her as I should be.

She sighs at my non-answer. “I act as if it’s human,” she continues, “to want things you should not want. To be trapped between hard decisions. It doesn't make you a bad person.”

Once again, I dinnae answer her.

“You're a good man,” she says.

“I'm not,” I snap, ripping the wing off the bird beneath my blade. I grit my teeth, throwing it into the fire, and sparks flick into the sky.

She grabs another piece of wood, tossing it to me. “You are. You cannot convince me otherwise,” she says, and I nearly growl at her attempts to show me I’m not despicable for my feelings.

“You’ve helped me more times than I can count. Even when you hated me.”

And suddenly, I understand why her sorrow has faded.

She’s convinced herself she can make me see the grey.

But there is no grey here.

“You should be afraid of me,” I say, quieter now, more warning than threat. Or maybe it’s a plea, because I need her to fear me, unsure I can trust what I’ll do if she keeps speaking of my wants.

Her breaths go shallow, but she shakes her head. “Well, I’m not.”

My heart stutters, and I go still, my hand hovering over the wood. How can she not be, when I will be her undoing? When I *will* hurt her.

I drop the wood, stalking over to her. I grab her arm, moving her hand toward my groin, slowly enough that she could easily pull away if she wanted to.

She doesnae.

Her fingers touch me over my kilt, her lips parting in a soft O.

It is nearly my unraveling, that parting of her lips. I am hard as stone beneath her hand, pulsing with desire, but there isn’t an ounce of fear in her eyes. There’s only hunger.

She meets my gaze. “I’m still not afraid of you,” she says, breathy, and I kneel before her. Her red hair tickles my face, the scent of juniper enveloping me, and I grow impossibly, painfully, harder.

“If you knew the things I’ve thought of doing to you,” I keep my voice low, “the images that have been flashing through my mind all day, you would be.”

Her cheeks flush, but she doesnae look away, and fuck, does it burrow beneath my skin. This is a mistake, all of it. Getting so close. Allowing her to touch me, and yet I cannae pull her hand away.

“What have you thought of doing to me?” she whispers, and my cock twitches. It's a challenge, but a gentle one.

Fine. Maybe if she knows exactly what my body craves, she'll feel the fear she should. She *has* to, because this? Crossing this line? It would ruin

us both. How can she not see it?

I lower my chin, moving to crouch before her and leaning in until my nose is only inches from hers.

“I've thought about spreading you wide, bare beneath me, and feasting on you until I’ve had my fill. And I am a verra,” my voice grows thick, almost a growl, “verra hungry man.” She squeezes her legs together, her eyes flashing with heat.

“What else?” Her breath is warm on my face, and I lean into it.

“I’ve pictured pinning you beneath me, taking you so rough, you scream. So gently, you cry. And every way in between. Making you forget your name. Your curse. This tormented existence you’re living. Plunging inside you again and again until you're sweet, wet heat tightens around me. And even then, I wouldnae give you rest. I’d keep going, deeper and harder until I have marked myself inside your body for eternity.”

Her mouth opens, and her breath goes shallow. “You think this is frightening me?” she asks.

“It should,” I say.

“It doesn’t. You don't scare me, Brennen. Not one bit.” She stands, brushing off her skirt and heading toward the tent. She pauses just before entering. “Even if you truly want to do those things, you can’t. I wouldn’t let you touch me again. Not when it would cost you your magic. Not when we don't know what we're facing, and you'll likely need it. So you can forgive yourself, Brennen, for wanting a monster,” she says, and I’m certain she’s seeing into the deepest parts of me.

She smiles sadly, disappearing inside.

I almost do it right then. Pull out my cock and search for relief from this torment, if only so I can stop the insanity churning in my mind. I cannae think. Can hardly breathe. Because this is no longer a want, but a need. An overwhelming and all-consuming, relentless craving.

And yet, I dinnae allow myself to find release. It wouldn't be right. Not when I still have a duty to fulfill.

58

BEA



My body is on fire. Brennen's words—his threats—ignited a spark somewhere in the deepest parts of me, and it cannot be doused. I roll to my side, pressing my legs together to try to ease the ache, but the friction only makes it worse.

It's unbearable.

I listen for movement outside, but it's completely silent other than the crackle of the fire. And so, for the first time in so long, I slide my hand between my legs. Even I'm surprised how warm my skin feels as I spread myself with my fingers and find the delicate bundle of nerves at my center.

My cheeks flush at my own brazenness. The object of my fantasies is just outside the tent, but the idea of stopping is unfathomable. The pressure is too great, the need to ease it unlike anything I've ever experienced.

I have to bite back a moan as I press and circle, imagining it's Brennen's fingers touching me instead of my own. A pleasant heat spreads from those nerves through my core, and my toes curl, my breaths going shallow. The tent flaps rustle as they open, and I pull my hand away, my heart leaping into my throat.

Brennen pauses before entering, and I squeeze my eyes shut. Is it possible he knows what I was doing in here? He doesn't say anything as he enters, tossing his sword into the corner, but his movements are stiff. His presence fills the tent, spreading until it's suffocating. I can barely breathe as I lie there, frozen.

My body tenses when Brennen lowers himself behind me, sliding beneath the thick blanket. Energy buzzes between us, and he shifts. Did he move closer, or further away?

The bedroll crinkles as he lifts his head, and his gruff rasp breaks through the dark. “You’re playing with fire, little lark. Go to sleep,” he rasps, and my mouth goes dry. So he must know what I was doing. But how?

I cannot bring myself to answer in my embarrassment, squeezing my eyes shut. I sense him cross his arms and lay his head back down, and I focus on slowing my breathing. My heart still bangs against my ribcage, but I close my eyes, taking slow inhales and exhales.

Brennen doesn’t move again, and as his breaths begin to even, I relax a fraction, but the ache inside me persists. Grows until it’s unbearable. I can smell him beside me. Feel his heat.

I wait another minute. Then ten. Then twenty, but Brennen’s breathing remains steady. It’s not until I’m certain he’s deeply asleep that I slowly move my hand back between my legs. I hold my breath as I begin to move my fingers once more.

Brennen shifts.

“Don diabhal e,” he growls. *To hell with it.* There’s no time to react as Brennen’s hands wrap around my waist, and he pulls me back against his chest. He’s hard as the riverbed behind me, his breath hot on my neck, and I gasp.

He’s careful not to touch my skin as he pulls up my dress, leaving only the thin fabric of my shift between his hand and my center.

His touch is fire, even through the wind-chilled linen. “Brennen,” I pant his name, arching into him.

“Mo chreach,” he rasps, *my ruin,* pulling my legs apart.

He begins to rub, rough, greedy circles, and any thoughts forming from his words dash from my mind.

I lean my head back as his fingers work, warmth flooding my entire body.

“You can stop— You don’t have to—” I can’t even finish the sentence, the words shifting into a moan as bright colors dance behind my eyelids.

“No. I cannae *stop*,” he growls, his other hand gripping my hip tight enough to bruise, and I do not have the strength to try to convince him he’ll regret this. I groan as he changes his rhythm, his thick, hard length digging

into my backside as he rolls himself against me. I groan at his evident desire, pushing back against the proof of what *I* am somehow doing to *him*.

He presses harder, a rumble leaving his chest as I grind against him.

I moan his name, and he curses, his hand coming up to cup my breast as pressure unlike anything I've ever felt before coils deep inside me. I don't have time to think of what this means or why Brennen gave in as his other hand slides from my hip to my belly, pinning me against him like I might slip away if he eases his pressure at all. It is my undoing, the feeling of his desire against my back, the rumbles in his chest as his fingers work in delicious circles. I cry out as release slams through me, violent and sudden.

But Brennen doesn't stop. He continues to swirl his fingers over the soaked fabric until I still, breathless.

His breaths are ragged against my neck, and I twist in his arms to look at him. I need to see what he's thinking. How he's feeling.

His eyes are dark, and he leans forward as if to press his forehead against mine, but stops just short.

"Brennen—"

"No," he stops me, closing his eyes. His nostrils flare as he takes several deep breaths, as if searching for a single scrap of control. "Sleep now, Bea." He tucks my hair behind my ear tenderly, so careful to avoid my skin.

"But—"

"Please. I have far less restraint than you realize." There's pain in his voice. A tension I don't understand.

My ruin, he'd called me.

I think he just might be mine, too.

I roll over, my body tired, but Brennen is restless. He shifts back and forth, and I'm just about to ask if he regrets what happened when he stands, softly stepping over me so as to not wake me.

"Where are you going?" I ask, and he pauses.

"I need to take a walk," he rumbles. "Sleep. I'll be back." But as he disappears through the tent flaps, I cannot help but notice the stiffness of his movements and his fingers flexing at his sides. I sit and listen, pulling a tartan around me.

Has it happened already? Has shame settled onto his shoulders, his conscience revolting against what he chose to do, and now he needs a moment away from me to process it all? I don't like how the idea makes me feel. I'm not something to be ashamed of, nor does he deserve that guilt.

I know what just transpired between us didn’t change anything about his orders, and I won’t let him wallow in self-depreciation because of it.

Pulling the tartan tighter, I slide outside the tent. Brennen is standing to the side, close to the river, one arm braced against the trunk of a pine. His head is bowed, and sadness tugs at my heart.

“Mo chreach,” he says, rough and uninhibited, and I freeze. It doesn’t sound like he’s processing his guilt at all. It sounds like…

For a second, I consider turning around, but my body doesn’t allow it. Quietly, I make my way to his side. My heart pounds, my mind racing and my mouth going dry when I see exactly how wrong I was.

A mixture of stunned amazement and recklessness floods my entire body. His kilt is lifted, and he holds himself in his hand, thick and heavy, pumping furiously, his eyes closed tight. I suck in a sharp breath.

He stops, his gaze shooting to mine.

“Bea,” he pauses, but he doesn’t let himself go.

I watch his ragged breathing. The wildness in his eyes, and it makes me feel bold. Beautiful and *wanted*.

“You were right,” I stalk forward. “You’re not a robin.” His eyes follow me. “Nor a lark. You’re not a bird at all.” I see it now. In the way he watches and waits. Always controlled, until he isn’t, waiting to pounce until his animal instincts demand he make the kill. A predator through and through. “You’re a wolf.” I unlace the front of my dress, pulling the collar down over one shoulder, then the other.

Brennen’s eyes darken, and I lift off my dress and shift, tossing them to the ground. I am bare before him, wearing nothing but moonlight.

This time, there’s anything but disgust in his expression. His gaze slowly rakes across my skin, so intense it almost feels like the rough scrape of his fingertips.

“Keep going,” I whisper, slowly pushing my hair behind my shoulders so he can see all of me.

There’s a single moment where I once again see the war inside him. The battle between what he perceives as right and wrong.

And then he glides his hand up and down. I do not shy away from watching as he increases the speed of his strokes. His length is impressive, and he’s so hard, I think it must be painful. The swollen tip glistens, and my stomach clenches, something stirring deep in my chest. Not at the way he

slowly begins to stroke himself, but how he's looking at *me*. The way his body is reacting to *me*.

My lips part as my breasts grow heavy, heat curling in my core once again. He pauses, as if afraid he'll frighten me, chest rising and falling like he cannot get enough air.

"Don't stop," I say, running a hand along my breast, then slowly trailing it down my own body.

He hesitates before moving his hand again, but not for long. Tentatively at first, he slides his palm up and down, his eyes never leaving the trail of my own fingers. I move them back to my breasts, squeezing.

"Yes. Touch yourself, Bea," he says, his voice gruff, and this time, I don't feel shame or embarrassment. I hold his stare as I lower my hand to my center, groaning when I touch the sensitive bundle of nerves. I swirl my fingers, then push one inside myself. I imagine it's Brennen, matching his pace, and his mouth drops open on a near growl.

"Brennen," I groan as pressure begins to build inside me once again.

"No. It's no enough. I need to touch you," he rasps. The primal tone of the words sends shivers down my spine, and I look around, my eyes landing on my shift. I lift it from the ground, then hold it out to him.

He lets go of the tree, sliding his hand inside the thin fabric, and then, he takes his wish. He pulls me against him, rubbing his fabric-covered palm across one breast, then another. He twists me so I am pressed against his hip, his other hand still sliding up and down his length almost violently, and I lean against him, bringing my fingers back to find my own release. The pressure builds, overwhelming, almost unbearable.

He pinches my nipple, thrusting into his own hand until he stiffens, but this time, I am not his ruin.

"Mo chridhe," he whispers. *My heart.*

I explode into millions of shiny pieces, my knees nearly buckling as my release slams through me, his words amplifying the pleasure still pulsing inside me.

I don't think he said them on purpose. Not when his breaths are still ragged, and his eyes are hazy with pleasure.

But I hold onto them anyway. Even if he didn't mean it, I can still pretend.

59

BRENNEN



Shame burns in my chest, my palm on fire as I lie next to a sleeping Bea. I hadn’t *technically* touched her at all. I think it’s the only reason I’m able to live with myself, and yet, I’d still felt her. Experienced her in a way that was wholly inappropriate.

She’s the woman who killed my geallta, and even knowing that down to my bones, I’d fucked her anyway. Not in the way my body had demanded, but she’d still come against my fingers, and I’d held her as if she was my deepest desire, pretending the hand around my cock was her, wet and hot and *mine*.

And now I cannae stop hearing the sounds she made. The sharp breaths she’d taken.

I shouldn't know these things. I shouldn't know what the Bean-Nighe looks like when she comes undone. I'd thought it when I slid my hand between her legs, but even knowing it, I hadn’t been able to stop myself. I’d ached to touch her since the moment I'd seen her bathing in the river. Before, even.

I’d thought that maybe, if I could bring her pleasure just once, I could put the need to feel her body behind me.

But it’s the complete opposite. I want to wake her. To touch her again, this time without anything between us. Dàn be damned. I dinnae care if she takes them.

But I do care about continuing to betray Marsaili.

I shake my head, the tent suddenly suffocating. I can still smell her desire in the air. On my fingers.

“Bea,” I say, shaking her.

“Hmm?” she says sleepily. Sated.

“I’m going to meet Harold. I’ll be back later.”

She nods, making a soft noise of acknowledgement. I do not try to wake her further. I’ll likely be back before she realizes I’m gone.

I stand, walking to the river to wash Bea’s scent off my fingers, but as I lean down, I find I cannot force my hands into the water. If this is all I can have of her, then let me hold onto it for a few hours longer.

I turn to leave, but the circle of branches sticking out of the ground catches my eye. The memory of forcing Bea to walk her perimeter flashes through my mind, gutting me. Not only had I caused her pain, her shackle cutting into her skin with every agonizing step, but I had erected an unending reminder of her prison walls.

I shouldnae waste time before going to see Harold, not when he’ll be waiting for me, but before I can stop myself, I’m marching toward the boundary, ripping the branches from the ground. I cross the river, my legs freezing, but I barely feel it, the shame in my blood growing hotter with each stake I remove.

It’s not until every last stick has been taken down that I whistle for Sable and mount, breathing a little easier as the mare gallops toward town. Bea will never again wake to those damned branches taunting her, constantly reminding her that she will never again go beyond her shore.

Well before we get to the village gates, I stop Sable, hopping off so as to not alert anyone to my presence with the beat of hooves. My dàn of warning remains silent as I approach Harold's house, but still, I try to keep my footsteps quiet.

If all goes to plan, no one will know I was here. I do not knock, instead slipping through his front door unannounced.

Harold looks up as I close the door with a quiet click. He’s seated by the hearth, a dram in each hand. He holds one out to me, and I take it, moving to the opposite chair.

“I didnae think you were coming.” He stifles a yawn.

I take a sip, and the liquid burns my throat. “I wanted to be sure there’d be no prying eyes. Theo said it was important.”

“Aye,” he says. “I think I have learned how to kill the Washwoman.”

I almost drop my glass. Just moments ago, I'd been pleasuring her, and now I'm to discuss how to kill her? "What do you mean? She cannae be killed."

"No, she just cannae be killed *yet*. But you know all magic can be undone, Brennen. That includes whatever it is keeping her alive."

I set my glass down, my stomach twisting. "You're speaking in riddles. Tell me plainly," I say, though I dinnae want to know. Want to return to the river, oblivious to whatever information Harold has uncovered.

Harold stares into the fire. "The journal I gave you, it's not the only one I have." He meets my eyes. "There are things you dinnae ken, Brennen. Things you need to learn about the Fates you serve."

Garrick's words echo in my mind.

"Whatever you have, Harold, you need to burn it. Anything you're hiding here. I wouldn't be surprised if the guardians start searching houses for their own entertainment."

"It's hidden well enough."

"You're putting yourself and your family at risk."

"My family knows nothing of it. I'm certain they'll be fine. As for me. I think there are some things worth risking your life for."

I lean forward, forcing him to meet my eyes. He's outmatched here, and I do not want him to lose his life for nothing. "No. Not when you cannae change anything. The Fates hold all the power."

"Not all of it. That's what I'm trying to tell you. The Fates were not meant to control all magic."

"I know this already. Magic was once part of the fabric of the kingdom, and they took it."

He takes a slow sip. "Aye. But did you know there's a place they cannae control? A place where magic flows free."

He pulls out a small book and opens it. There's a square carved out of the middle, and inside, folded up parchment and what seems to be a dragon scale. "I was going through my things, making sure nothing was visible in case your friends did decide to search the village, and I found this." He holds it up. "This book has sat on the top shelf my entire life, and I've never opened it." He unfolds the pages, and the parchment matches that of the journal.

"This is what was ripped out of the back."

"Aye." He hands them to me.

I have finally found a way to kill the woman at the river. It is rumored a dragon scale dipped in the Faerie Pools under a half moon and the blessing of the fair folk can end any life. I believe the dragons will lead me there, but only once the Epoch ends and travel is safe will we go.

My blood runs cold. Could it be this easy? Could this really be the key to ending the curse? The idea doesn't fill me with relief. It fills me with terror, and my palm burns as I pick up the onyx dragon scale. Magic pierces my skin. A warm buzz, so intense, it almost aches.

I snap the book shut and hand it back to Harold, pocketing the scale.

“You’ll do it then?” he asks.

My throat burns. “In time.” The words taste like poison as they leave my mouth, and Harold's eyebrows draw together.

He shakes his head. “No. She killed my wife, Brennen. End this.”

I don’t bother telling him again it’s not true. “There are things I need to learn first. Things Be— the Washwoman can help me with. She’s having visions of the disappearing women.”

“Och. Why do I not feel the fire of vengeance in you anymore? The Washwoman is *evil*. You need to remember that. You say she has a connection to the women going missing? I believe it. She is the cause of *all* of this, Brennen. Dinnae let yourself forget it.”

Pressure builds in my chest, and my mind spins.

“I know what she's done,” I say, standing.

My vision tunnels as I leave, the unfairness of it all heavy on my shoulders. Bea’s moment of madness that ended in the deaths. If her mind was broken, was it even her fault? She didn't choose to kill them.

I'm so lost in my thoughts, I almost miss it. My dàn of warning tingles, and I freeze. In the pitch black, I cannae see who may be out there, but I *feel* their eyes on me. The tingling of the dàn turns to a fiery burn.

I pick up my pace, certain I need to get back to the river, but it is too late. I've already been seen.

The question is, by who?

60

BRENNEN



Bea is awake when I return.

She sits up when I enter the tent, but I cannae bear to look at her.

“What did Harold have to say?”

I do not answer, removing my sword belt and throwing it to the ground.

She jumps to her knees, sensing that something is wrong, and the sight causes me to feel as if I didnae ease the pressure in my cock only hours ago. It’s as present as ever. Worse, even.

“Brennen, what's happened? Are you in danger?”

I scoff. “Of course I'm in danger. You’re in danger. This whole Fates-damned village is in more danger than they could possibly know!” I close my eyes, taking a deep breath to calm myself.

“What did Harold say?" she repeats, and I turn to her. Her eyes are wide, her cheeks flushed, genuine concern in every line of her face.

I shake my head, unable to speak. There’s not enough air in my lungs.

“Brennen,” she says, “whatever it is, it’s okay.”

My heart cracks because she doesn’t understand. None of this will ever be okay. It’s simply not possible.

“He told me how to kill you,” I say, my voice hoarse. Bea flinches, but her shock only lasts a moment before her expression is neutral again.

“You should be happy, then,” she says calmly, and I loathe how there's no bite to her words. She truly does not blame me for what I must do, and it

makes all of it feel worse.

I cannae stop the cruel, disbelieving laugh that slips from my throat. “No. I’m no happy. I haven’t been happy since the day you killed those people. I've no had a single day's peace,” I say, rubbing a hand down my face. I feel as if I’m crawling out of my skin. As if there is something inside me desperate to escape, and it will rip my verra flesh apart to achieve it.

Her eyes glisten with tears. “I’m sorry,” she whispers, but it isnae enough.

“I need you to remember why you did it, Bea.”

She shakes her head, wincing against the voices and pain that always come when I ask about that night. “I already told you. I *have* tried. I really have. I want to know as much as anyone else. You couldn't possibly want to know more than I do. This is *my* story. Of course I want to know why I was taken by madness!”

“Do you? Then remember!” I scream, six years of rage exploding out of me. Because this is the core of it all, is it not? She murdered Marsaili and her entire family in cold blood. And yet, I want her. *Need* her. There *has* to be a reason buried somewhere in the recesses of her mind. Some sort of explanation that will make all of this okay.

Bea’s lip trembles. “Why do you need to know so badly? Why must it come back to this, again and again? Have we not spoken of it enough? Why can't you simply believe me? I didn't *want* to do it. I didn't *mean* to do it. But it was these hands that killed them.” Bea lifts her stained palms. “There's something broken in me, Brennen, but I cannot name it. In the end, I’m simply the monster everyone thinks I am.”

“No” I growl, stalking forward. “That's the problem! You’re no a monster at all! You’re good, and kind, and strong. And yet, you ended their lives. I need to know why.” I’m nearly begging now, but I dinnae care. My soul cannae continue to be torn in two by these feelings for Bea churning inside me. I cannae burn for the one who killed Marsaili if there isnae a reason that proves it wasn’t her fault. I dinnae think I will survive living in the grey.

“Why do you care so much about the why?” She stands, throwing her arms out. “It happened. It will not change. That's the end of it.”

“It's no the end of it. It’ll never be the end of it!” I say. My lungs constrict, and suddenly, I cannae breathe.

“Why not?” she screams back.

“Because it was my geallta you killed!” I roar.

Bea flinches as if I slapped her, her breath leaving her lungs in a single whoosh. She goes pale as my voice echoes outside the tent and through the glen, forcing her to hear my confession again and again and again, slowly getting softer with each chorus of accusations.

The words hang between us, the edge of the blade about to swing.

“I—” She swallows. “I killed your geallta?” Her voice cracks on the word.

I do not have to answer her.

“Who was she? Leslie?”

I shake my head.

“Marsaili?”

I stiffen at the sound of her name coming out of Bea’s mouth, and her eyes fill with tears, her hands violently shaking as she wipes them away.

“I killed your geallta. Your betrothed. You’ve been so kind to me, and I killed— I'm sorry.” She stands, curling in on herself as a sob breaks free. She fights to hold them back, as if she doesn’t deserve to be the one to feel sadness. Her eyes go glassy, almost as if she’s withdrawn inside herself, like I’m not here at all.

“I'm so sorry. So, so—” She bites back another sob, ducking outside the tent into the snow. I sit down, placing my head in my hands.

My body trembles with rage. So much, I dinnae know where to place it. Should I be angry at myself? At Bea? Maybe both of us deserve it.

Maybe neither of us do. Maybe the world is simply broken, and there is no order or reason to things like I’ve always believed. The thought settles heavy on my shoulders, the idea that the code I have lived my life by could be so wrong. And beneath it is a brokenness I’m beginning to believe I willnae ever be able to fix.

Because If someone as caring as Bea could do such a horrible thing, is anyone good? Who's to say my own mind couldn’t break under strain like this? That I couldnae end up in the exact same position as Bea in another life?

I dinnae know how much time passes, but eventually, the fire inside me burns out into exhausted embers. I stand, leaving the tent.

“Bea,” I start, but she is across the river at the end of her chain, lying in a heap on the opposite shore. A coating of snow already covers her body, and my heart shatters completely.

“Come back in the tent. You’ll freeze out here!” I call, but she doesn’t answer.

Doesn’t move at all, and a mix of worry and frustration burns inside me, the urge to dive in and force her back into the tent overwhelming. I hadn’t told her to cause her pain. I hadnae meant to tell her at all, and I want to go to her. To apologize.

But as much as I want to, I cannot swim to the other side of the river without my dàn of warmth.

It will kill me, and I fear my death would weigh on Bea even more than Marsaili’s.

“I dinnae blame you,” I call. “Not anymore,” I add, a whisper only I can hear. Once again, she doesnae move. “Come in when you're ready. I’ll be here.” But morning comes, and the other side of the bed remains empty.

61

BRENNEN



Bea is still on the other side of the river when I leave the tent in the morning, my head pounding from lack of sleep just as much as from my mind turning and twisting all night. She sits with her back to me, arms wrapped around her legs, her head on her knees. If I hadn't already been sure she regrets her past before, I certainly am now.

It's in every shuddering breath she takes, the stoop of her spine, and I wonder if, could she die, her guilt might be the thing to finally kill her. She does not respond when I call her name. Doesnae even flinch.

“Please talk to me. It wasnae your fault,” I say, but she doesn't answer, nor does she answer as I speak to her throughout the day. It’s as if she's not even here, eyes staring blankly at her feet, and after hours of watching her silently cry, I cannot handle it anymore. Every time I speak, her cries grow more pained, as if my verra presence is causing her agony, and it makes me feel like I’m dying.

“I'll give you some time, but I’ll be back,” I say, heading to the tavern. I could use a dram. Maybe two. And a moment away from this place to think.

I sit down at the bar, waiting for Theo to notice.

“Something troubling you?” he asks, eyebrows furrowing as he pulls out a mug for ale.

“Whiskey,” I say, stopping him before he can pour the drink. His brown eyes narrow in concern, and he looks around at the guardians casually enjoying their own drinks around the tavern.

“Good stuff’s in the back,” he says, inclining his head. “Come with me.”

I dinnae argue, following close behind him until we enter the storeroom. He pulls two chairs from against the wall, searching the stacks of bottles until he finds the one he wants and uncorks it.

He blows the dust from two glasses, then pours several fingers. “What's happened?” he asks, sitting down.

I sit and take the glass from his hand, immediately downing the contents. Theo leans back.

“That bad?” he asks.

“Aye.” I stare into my empty glass. “I told Bea she killed Marsaili. That she took the woman I loved from me, and I think it broke her.”

Theo refills my glass, then takes a long sip from his own. “That’s who you lost, then? A woman? At Bea’s hands?”

“My geallta. When Bea escaped six years ago,” I say, following my confession with a long pull from my dram. “Would a murderer react that way? With complete and utter devastation?”

“I dinnae know the answer to that, but if it helps, you're not alone in your doubts. I've always felt she was misunderstood.

“I *have* to kill her.” I hold out my palm, and Theo stares at my blood-sworn oath. I watch as the pieces connect in his mind. The reason I’m *really* here, apart from the Cutter and her mission. “I have no choice. But even after everything she's done, I dinnae think she deserves it.” I look down at my hand. “There is right and wrong. Justice. It’s how I have lived my entire life. I’ve always been so certain of it. But with Bea, it doesn’t feel like there’s a clear answer. Is it justice for her to be killed for something she never meant to do? She's suffered for more years than Marsaili would have even lived. That has to count for something, doesn't it? At what point does the suffering become too much?”

Theo exhales, his expression as conflicted as I feel. “Maybe killing her will be a mercy.”

The words slice sharper than a knife directly into my chest, and I take another sip, holding the whiskey in my mouth to feel the burn. I take another, longer drink, rubbing the back of my neck.

“That's what she says. She wants to rest after we put the kingdom right again. After we learn who's killing the women, but—” I meet his eyes. “I dinnae know if I can be the one to do it.”

Pity fills Theo’s eyes, and I look away, unable to bear it. “The oath is unbreakable, isn't it? The black running through your veins… That's what it means?”

“Aye.” I take another long drink.

“If you don't kill Bea, your soul will belong to Ban-dia a’ Bhàis. You’ll serve her forever, never to find peace.”

“Hence why I'm drinking,” I say, tilting back my glass and swallowing the rest of the amber liquid. I grab the bottle to fill it again.

“You care about her,” Theo says, studying me.

“I don't,” I say, but I know it isn’t the truth. I’ve told Bea that much already. What I really should have said is, *I do, but I shouldn’t.*

“Brennen.” Theo leans forward, putting a hand on my arm, stopping me from downing another full glass. “It's alright to care.”

I shrug off his arm and take another sip. “No. I dinnae think it is. Not for her.”

“What would Marsaili say?" he asks, and my throat burns. Not from the whiskey, but pure sorrow.

“Marsaili was the most forgiving woman I've ever met. Always had an excuse for why people behaved how they did.”

He tilts his head. “Do you think she'd want you to suffer like this? To be unhappy? Now, I didnae ken her, but I dinnae think she would.”

I shake my head, blood warm from the alcohol. I dinnae want to think of the Washwoman right now. I dinnae want to think of Marsaili or my vow to avenge her. For just a moment, I dinnae want to think about anything. What I want is to forget.

I reach for the bottle, my glass once again empty, but Theo takes it away.

“All right. Let's get you an ale. Take a break from the whiskey.” He inclines his head back toward the main room.

I stand, grumbling under my breath, but I follow behind anyway. Ale will get the job done as well. I'll just need more of it.

Harold is in his seat at the bar when we return, and he grins when he sees us. “A round for everyone! On me,” he says, popping up and slapping Theo on the back.

“For everyone?” I ask, wondering if I can convince Harold to make it a round of whiskey.

“Aye, for everyone. We’re celebrating! My oldest grandson just told me they’re having another bairn. I'm gonna be a great-granda again!”

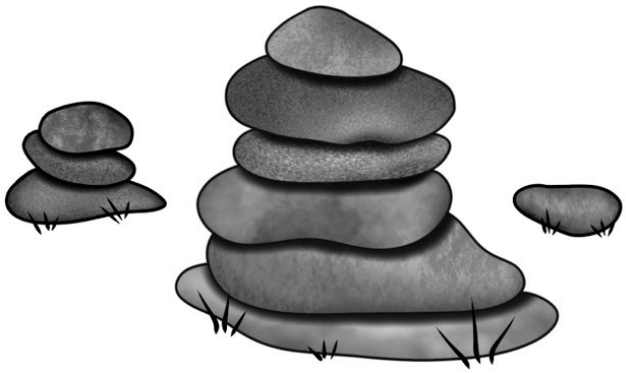
“Congratulations.” I extend a hand to Harold. “We'll drink to their health, then. Theo, whiskey for me.”

Theo ignores me, handing me an ale before passing around mugs to the rest of the bar. The patrons raise their glasses in a toast, and with my mind slightly fuzzy and blood warm from the alcohol, I decide to join them. Because this is what life should be about.

Camaraderie. New beginnings.

And so, not wanting to darken this moment or call the attention of misfortune, I take another drink, and force myself to forget everything but the here and now.

BEA



The only thing that could cause me to rise is the river. She calls with the strongest of winds, and her magic pulls me to my knees. My hands are pushed into the water, and the cold bites into my skin, but I hardly feel it.

I am a shell. Numb to everything but my grief.

There was a time, when I was first sentenced here, that I believed life couldn't get any worse. I was hollow, desperate for escape.

Those days are nothing compared to the vicious hole inside me now. I no longer crave rest, because I do not think I will find it. When I die, I will only find judgment, and I deserve it.

The water turns a muddy brown, and even then, I do not have the energy to dread what will come next.

My vision shifts, and I am no longer kneeling in the river. Instead, I'm standing in a village. One that looks very familiar.

I freeze, heart thundering. I'm not in just any village. I'm in Dalbàsail, standing in the town square directly in front of a tavern. It's changed since I saw it last. There are more buildings, what looks like a bakery and some houses, but I recognize the cobblestone street and ancient trees surrounding it instantly.

A pub song floats through the tavern door, and I push my way inside, searching for the woman who's in danger. I only have minutes before I'm

pulled back to the river, if not less, and I'm determined to find her. To push through my pain, put aside my sorrow so I can help her.

Confusion swirls through my mind as I search the crowd, growing stronger by the second. There are only men. Guardians and villagers, drams raised, all seemingly celebrating.

A singsong breaks out—*a song cannae tell you the time it will end.*

A rough voice cuts through the ruckus, a rich, deep timbre I recognize in my bones.

"Brennen?" I whisper, his name catching in my throat, shock ricocheting through my body.

I don't know how he hears me, but he stiffens at the sound of my voice, his eyes going wide as he turns. He looks around at the guardians enjoying their ale, but by the grace of the goddesses, none seemed to have noticed me. His face drains of color, and he tilts his head toward the door that leads back outside. I understand his meaning instantly.

Go, before they see you.

As inconspicuously as I can, I duck my head and slip out, darting around the corner. Brennen is standing in front of me only moments later.

"Is this a vision?" A flicker of what looks like peace crosses his face as he looks down at my missing chain.

I nod, but I'm still not able to meet his eyes. The shame of how I hurt him is thick and hot in my throat, but I force it away for the sake of whoever is about to die, refusing to waste time. "Yes. Are there any women inside? I only saw men."

His brows draw together. "Aye. There's one upstairs. Anna."

I start toward the doors, but he stops me. "You cannae let them see you," he says, his voice somehow sharp and soft at the same time. "They willnae just hurt you. They'll tell Cailleach, and she'll go after my family. Go back to the river. I'll take care of it."

His family.

The words hit like a blow to the chest, guilt nearly dragging me under. It's not only Marsaili's life I ended, but possibly his siblings, if the Cutter thinks I've escaped.

He reaches out, his hand hovering so close to my jaw, there's a phantom sensation of his touch. Even without looking at him, I *feel* his eyes gliding over my face, licking along my skin like flames. "Bea, please look at me," he says, a heavy desperation in his voice, but I can't.

I’m not sure I’ll ever be able to look at him again, now that I know what I did. How deeply I hurt him.

He takes a small step forward, the buzz between his skin and mine growing stronger.

“Look at me,” he demands, firmer this time, and when I don’t, he curses under his breath. He shakes his head, closing the space between his hand and my face. I try to pull away, but I’m too late. He cups my cheek, and the shock of his touch is instant. Energy crackles beneath his fingers, sending heat through my chest, my belly.

I lean into his caress, unable to stop myself, my body begging me to get closer, even though I know I shouldn’t. That I don’t deserve it.

“You took down the boundary,” I whisper, tears burning my throat. I don’t know where the words come from. There are so many other things I should be saying, but I’d noticed it as soon as I’d left Brennen’s tent, desperate to escape the reality of what I’d done to him. Who I’d taken from him. The sight had been salt pressed into a wound, an act of kindness I hadn’t deserved, searing and sharp.

”Aye. I did. I should have done it sooner.” He tilts my head back to meet his eyes. “I’m glad you’re speaking to me again,” he says gently. The sincerity in his voice nearly brings me to my knees, and the knife in my chest twists.

How is he glad about anything? How does he not hate me? His voice is soft when he speaks again. Earnest. “I’m so sorry, Bea. For shouting at you. For telling you that way. I was—” He takes a deep breath. “It was wrong of me, and I’ll regret it until the day I die. Please accept my apology. Please don’t pull away again,” he says, almost begging. There’s whiskey on his breath, but his eyes are alert. Searching.

I don’t have the strength to tell him I think I already have given up. Not in saving the women, but saving myself.

He leans forward, and I gasp as he trails a thumb across the freckles on my cheek. He opens his mouth to say something else, but in a flash, I am pulled back to the river.

The burn in my cheek from Brennen’s touch lingers, a phantom hand on my skin. A touch I don’t deserve. A touch— I jump to my feet, examining my body for dàn. I search my arms and legs, my torso, and there it is. A collection of wavy black lines staining my ribs.

It’s sore to the touch, and I wonder how I missed it being branded on my skin. Was the burn of his touch so intense I’d missed the pain of his magic transferring to me altogether?

The wind shifts, carrying a raven's caw through the glen, and I turn upstream, holding my breath, but as I wait to see if he found Anna, my mind spins.

Brennen had *chosen* to touch me.

Knowing I would take his magic, he’d placed his hand directly on my skin and hadn’t cared about the consequences.

I don’t know how to process it. How to merge the guilt and shame I’m feeling with the hope and joy that single caress caused. But beneath it all, worry gnaws at my stomach. In those precious moments he had touched me, he’d wasted time. What if he hadn’t made it to Anna?

Please, let Brennen have found her, I silently beg.

The river flows on, and hope flickers in my chest, but then I see it. Dark clothing, swirling in the muddy stream.

“No,” I whisper, rushing to grab the clothes, sorrow piercing my heart. It had been one thing, washing these clothes before I knew how to save them. But washing them now because I failed to get to her in time? I almost crumble beneath the weight of it. I am failing. Brennen. Anna.

I spread the garments out in the water, wanting to be able to describe the clothes to Brennen, but it takes significant effort. They’re heavier than I expected. Thicker.

My breath catches as the rough tweed scratches my fingers, and I pull the bundle apart.

Shock and confusion ricochet through my chest, building by the second as my mind searches for answers. The river tries to pull them from me, as if it doesn’t want me to get a good look, but I do not allow it. I hold on, just long enough to see the clothing clearly.

Trousers and a brown tunic, and there isn’t a speck of blood.

Fighting against the magic of my curse, I search the pockets, but there’s nothing inside to hint at who they belonged to. I close my eyes as the river rips the clothing away from me, trying to remember what the tavern’s patrons had been wearing, but it had all happened so fast. I’d seen Brennen and ceased to focus on anything else.

Nausea rises in my stomach, acrid and hot.

Because these aren’t a woman’s clothes at all, but a man’s.

BRENNEN



I run up the stairs, dagger in hand, desperate to get to Anna. The moment with Bea had sobered me. Shock at seeing her. Utter relief that she'd spoken to me.

I'd wasted time touching her, but I cannae make myself regret it. It had been necessary to bring her back to me. To ease her guilt and pain and show she is worthy of so much more than she believes. Respect. Affection.

Love.

I dinnae allow myself to dwell on the word.

I'm about to kick open the first door in the hall when chaos erupts downstairs. The beating of dragon's wings shakes the building, and the floor trembles beneath my feet. I turn toward the stairs.

Panic surges through my blood. Why would a dragon be landing so close?

Shouting drowns out the pounding of my heart, but even through the mayhem, I hear it.

A name.

Cailleach.

It *can't* be her. Surely my dàn of warning would have alerted me if she were here. Except… I lift my tunic.

The mark is gone.

"Mallachd ort!" I curse, racing down the stairs, dagger in hand. Of all the dàn I could have lost, why did it have to be the only one that could have

saved me from the surprise of the Cutter’s arrival?

I’m not sure what to expect when I stumble back into the main room of the tavern. Chaos, certainly. A scene of some sort, but what I find is so much worse.

“Let go of me, you bastards!” Harold shouts, but the guardians restraining him kick the back of the old man’s knees and yank him outside into a crowd of villagers and Dìdeanair. At the edge of them stands a man I think I recognize. One who shouldnae be here. Is it Hamish? It’s hard to tell with his head turned. The door closes, blocking him from my sight.

“What’s happening?” Theo shouts, running out of the back room, but I dinnae answer, darting outside. The man I’d been watching is gone, but there’s no time to feel relief. Not when I’m met with a sight so much worse than that wretched man returning.

My blood runs cold as Athair lowers his head, peering at Harold with dark, fist-sized eyeballs. The Cutter sits atop him, her lips tipped down in disgust.

“Search him,” she demands, and with a sickening thud, they throw Harold to the ground. His forehead hits the dirt, his thin skin breaking open, and blood trickles down his face. They ignore his obvious injury, patting him down and searching his pockets, and fear grips my heart. Had he done as I’d instructed? Did he burn the books I warned him would bring a fate like this?

“It's not on him,” one of the men says.

I keep my expression neutral despite my relief, but the feeling is short-lived.

Jamie, the guardian who’d been so keen to find ceatharnaich, steps forward, holding out a book. “That’s because I have it. I found this in his home.”

“How dare you enter my house?” Harold shouts.

If enemies to lovers or fated mates is calling, there is no need to overthink it.

Look up **Lokepub** on Google and start browsing.

“Silence!” The Cutter holds her jeweled hand up, and the square goes quiet. “Give me the book,” she orders, flipping her hand over.

A lump forms in my throat as Jamie approaches, handing over the small book containing the ripped-out pieces from Harold's journal.

Cailleach's eyes flare with rage as she reads the words describing how to end any life. Thank the goddess I'd taken the dragon scale from the book. It's tucked safely away in my tent at the river.

This is all my fault, I realize. I led Jamie right to Harold's doorstep. But if that's true, why is Cailleach going after him? Why isn't she coming after me?

"A traitor." Cailleach stares Harold down, but he doesn't cower. He holds her stare, head held high. "All my sisters and I do for this kingdom, and it is never enough. Bring him to me," she snaps, and Phillip and Jamie pull him to his feet, pushing him forward. Athair's head twists from side to side as he approaches, ready to make the kill.

"You are sentenced to death." She says bluntly, and it takes every bit of my training to remain silent and keep my face impassive. Speaking out now cannot save Harold, but it *would* give Cailleach a reason to kill my family. Horror settles heavily on my shoulders, but I remain still, fighting the nausea threatening to bring the contents of my stomach up. There is no changing this.

"May the Three grant you mercy," Cailleach says, but she doesn't mean it. Her voice is flat, almost bored. Athair opens his mouth, taking a deep inhale, but Cailleach stills him with a hand on his neck, pulling out a long thread.

"Let this be a warning to all of you. I am watching you." Her eyes lock onto mine, and her lips twist into an eerie smile. "I am watching *all* of you. There is not a single person in this kingdom that is out of my reach." She moves her gaze across the crowd, but I can still feel her attention on me. She's looking for a reaction. Any reason at all to doubt me.

Why isn't she killing me? Is it because I am higher ranking than these men? Because she is so certain my need for vengeance, my unbreakable vow, will keep me in line? Because I am her only hope for ending Bea's life?

I place my hands behind my back in a display of respect, playing the part.

It almost kills me. Bile rises up my throat, and my heart pounds furiously, begging me to do something. Anything.

“Good,” she says, running her fingers along the thread. “That’s settled, then. This is your final warning. Now for the traitor. Any last words?” She stops her movement, feeling for whatever indicates where a life has been measured to end, then goes up several inches and pinches.

Harold opens his mouth to speak, but the thread turns to dust, and he collapses to the ground, his eyes rolling back in his head. In seconds, his body turns black, crumbling into ash and disappearing into nothing, just like the thread.

My heart stalls, my breath hitching in shock and head spinning.

How is this possible? Harold is simply gone, as if he never existed at all. I clench my hands into fists to stop myself from pulling my sword as another wave of nausea washes over me.

“No!” Harold's grandson surges forward, but I grab him, stopping him. I lean low to whisper in his ear.

“You cannae help him. Your wife needs you. Cailleach will kill you if she thinks you knew of Harold’s treason, and she will enjoy it. Think of the bairn.”

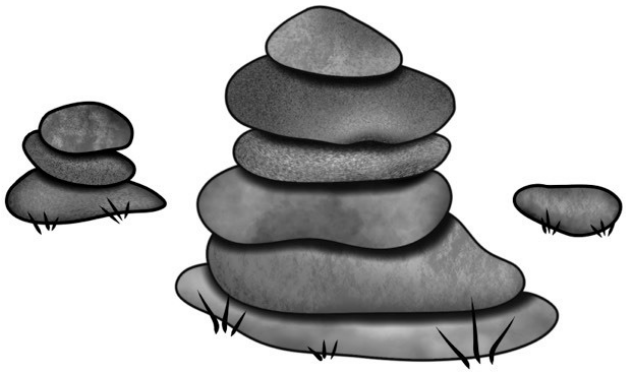
He swallows, tears filling his eyes.

“Go home. Burn anything Harold might have kept. And do it now. It’s what he would want,” I say, and thank the goddess, he listens. The Cutter meets my gaze, holding it for another long moment, then smiles.

“Fly, my darling.”

64

BEA



My chain drags heavily as I pace back and forth, waiting for Brennen to return. With each step, my ankle stings, but I hardly notice. My mind is too preoccupied with worry, my heart racing and stomach bubbling with fear. Lolly seems to feel the same, streams of fire flying from her mouth as she dives through the sky, circling low

What is taking him so long? Every few minutes, I glance upstream, just to make sure I don't see his green kilt appear. Is he in danger? It certainly feels like it, though I can't explain why.

Relief slams into me when he breaks through the trees, safe. He doesn't seem injured. At least, not physically, but his hands are shaking, and his eyes burn black with a fury even more potent than when he first arrived here. I feel it tunneling into my bones.

Before I realize my feet are even moving, I run to him, ankle be damned. He meets me halfway, grabbing my forearms and pulling me hard against him. His heart races against my cheek, and I savor the steady rhythm. It means he's alive. Safe, even if he's just as afraid as I am.

"It wasn't a woman this time, was it?" I ask into his shirt, my words muffled.

Brennen pulls back, shaking his head. "No. It was Harold," he says, voice rough.

Harold. The man with the journal. I'd never met him, but it's clear Brennen's hurt by his death. "What happened?"

He closes his eyes, wincing as if reliving it. “Cailleach came.” There’s a bite to his words I've never heard before, and it sends a chill down my spine.

“The Cutter?” I shake my head. “I don’t understand. Did she not tell you she knew nothing of the women’s deaths?”

Brennen begins to pace, his boots crunching on the pebbles at a frantic pace. “She did, but she was here, in the village.” He rubs his forehead, then stops, finally meeting my eyes. “How did you know it wasn’t a woman?” he asks.

I close my eyes, picturing the trousers and tunic I washed. Too big to have belonged to a woman. “The clothes that came down belonged to a man,” I say, “but I didn’t know whose they were.”

Brennen goes still, taking in the information the way he always does—piece by piece, methodically analyzing each one to see where they fit.

“What happened after I was pulled back here?” I ask.

He shakes his head. “It happened so fast. I went to find Anna, but the Cutter arrived. They showed her Harold’s book. She already had his thread.” He takes a step closer to me. “She knew she was going to kill him before she even came here. When she pinched his thread, he dropped dead in an instant, and his body turned to ash. She didn’t even give him a moment to say goodbye. To let him speak his final words.”

I squeeze my hands together to stop them from shaking. My knees tremble, so weak, I fear even my dàn of steadiness will not be able to stop me from dropping to the ground. Is it truly that easy for Cailleach to end a life?

“But… I had a vision. I was brought to the village, and I washed his clothes. That would mean,” I swallow, afraid to even speak the words aloud. But it’s the *only* explanation. This death fits the pattern.

Brennen nods, his expression pure darkness. “The Cutter is behind the disappearing women. She’s the one killing them.”

My mind spins, searching for a reason, any reason, she would do such a thing? “Why?” I ask, breathless. “She cuts *every* thread at the end. Why would these deaths be any different? Why would it cause my visions?”

Brennen’s eyes dim, his mind going somewhere else, and his jaw tightens. “Because the Cutter isnae meant to decide when someone will die. That is the work of the Weaver and the Measurer. There are laws between them. She told me herself. Laws written by the goddess. Cailleach can only

kill outside of her sisters' will if whoever she's killing is a threat to the kingdom. But Harold wasnae a threat to the kingdom. Neither were those women."

"But how do we know this wasn't measured?" I ask, my mind struggling to keep up. Why would she want to kill innocent people who weren't a threat? It makes no sense.

"I've seen Cailleach cut threads before. She slides her fingers along the length until she feels something. Something to indicate where the end of life was marked, then pinches it off right there." He pinches his pointer finger and thumb together. "Exactly where the Measurer willed it. But today she found the place Harold's thread was meant to be severed, and went back up. Inches. *Years* of life he had left." His voice shifts, beginning to shake. "Years. She cut that thread before it was meant to be cut. I'm certain of it." He steps forward, wrapping his hands around my biceps and squeezing.

"I think that's the cause of your visions. You're not seeing a natural cause of death, because there isnae one. You're seeing the moments before the Cutter ends their life. Before she kills them, and they scatter into dust. It's not someone outside of her power at all who's severing those women's threads. It's Cailleach severing them outside of her sisters' design."

I press a trembling hand to my mouth. If what he's saying is true, how will we ever save these women? These people? The Cutter has endless power. "No. There has to be another explanation," I say, closing my eyes. It's naive. Ridiculously so, but I want to believe it so badly. Some ceatharnaich I'm certain Brennen could defeat, but a Fate?

He pulls me against him, his chin resting on top of my head, holding me together. "It's the *only* explanation that makes sense. Once the Weaver and Measurer have done their part, the threads remain in the Cutter's castle. I've stood beneath them, thousands upon thousands of shimmering strings." I sense the moment his rage shifts to self-blame, his body going taut. "I cannae believe I didn't think of this before."

"But why only women until now? And why Harold?"

His voice drops impossibly low. "Harold was a warning to me. To stop asking questions and follow her will. But the women…" he shakes his head. "I dinnae ken. But whatever the reason, it isnae good enough. We have to stop her."

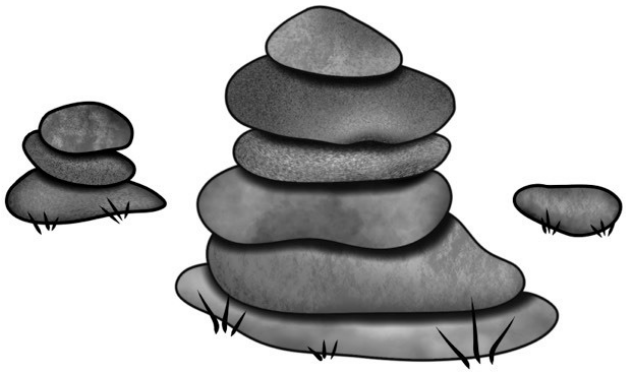
I nod, but don't tell Brennen what I'm thinking. About the fear coiling in my gut.

He needs to be careful, because if Cailleach believes he is against her, no one will be safe. Not him, and not his family. There is no balance in the system where Cailleach breaks the rules. She can sever any thread she wishes, even before its time, with no consequences.

Any thread but mine.

65

BEA



Familiar golden sunlight spreads across the floorboards, and I know I'm dreaming before I even hear the humming and tapping. The now-familiar loom comes into focus, but this time, the woman moves, and I see her face.

She is young, stunning, with hair the color of gold and eyes so blue, they look like the depths of the sea. I try to open my mouth to speak. To warn her, but once again, no sound comes out. My feet will not move. As always, I can only watch.

There's a knock at the door, and tears well in my eyes at what I know will come next, except this time, I do not see her death immediately. This time, when she opens the door, the Faerie Pools come into view, unmistakable as the brightest star. Turquoise water sparkles in the sun, waterfalls and springs cascading into one another with tall pines surrounding them.

I hold my breath, straining to see through the doorway, but I still can't tell *who* is standing outside. The blonde woman smiles warmly. “Did you climb all the way up here just for a visit?” she asks, and suddenly, I know who I’m seeing.

There’s a hut hidden atop the cliffs—shaded by pines. A kind woman lives there. She will help you.

My words to Kenna circle in my mind. This *has* to be the woman I sent her to.

But why am I dreaming of her?

A gloved hand draws a blade across her throat, and I close my eyes. I do not want to see the blood, but I still hear her gasp of surprise, the thud of her body falling to the ground. I struggle to keep my breath steady, reminding myself it's only a dream.

For now, at least. I have seen her death, but I have not washed her clothes. Hope flickers in my chest. Maybe I can still save her.

My resolve strengthens at the thought. I *will* save her.

I repeat the words in my head again and again, trying not to think of what I would see before me if I opened my eyes. It's only when I feel the cold air of the river once again that I do.

Brennen is shaking me, his face only inches from mine. "Bea!" he shouts, and I push myself upright, grabbing his arms, needing to hold onto something solid and real.

The edges of his eyes are creased with concern. "Fates, there you are. I couldnae wake you. Was it a vision? Normally, your visions dinnae happen while you sleep," he says.

I shake my head, trying to find my voice. "No. It was a dream. Or, a nightmare. I've been having it for months."

His lips curve into a frown. "I'm sorry," he says, and hearing *him* apologize to *me* almost breaks me.

"It's not— Someone's in danger."

He straightens. "In your nightmares?" he asks, his eyebrows drawing together.

I nod. "I don't think they're nightmares. They feel too real. I think… I think I'm having them so I can prevent the death I see. Remember I told you I sent Kenna somewhere safe?"

His eyes flash with anger. "Kenna's in danger? If it's that bastard of a husband, I'll—"

"No." I stop him, pulling the blankets off me, suddenly too hot. "It's not Kenna. It's the woman who lives above the Faerie Pools."

Brennen looks taken aback, his eyes going wide. "The Faerie Pools? How could you possibly know that?"

"Because Kenna asked me her question. She caught me and said the words needed to trigger the curse. 'Tell me, Washwoman, the answer I seek.'" I close my eyes, trying to remember the details of our interaction. "She asked me where to go to be safe from her husband, and I saw it clearly

in my mind. The woman who lives at the Faerie Pools would help her. I've been having this dream for *months*, but it wasn't until tonight that I realized it was the woman's cottage I was seeing. It has to be."

Brennen stares up at Lolly circling the moon, his jaw going tight. "I thought I saw Hamish in the village today. I'm not certain, but—"

I grab Brennen's arm. "Then you have to go to her. It can't be a coincidence. What if it's Hamish who kills the woman in my dream? If he somehow learned where Kenna fled to, maybe he's coming for her."

He stiffens, shaking his head. "No. I willnae be leaving here." His voice drops low. "Not when Cailleach is killing people. Not when she just executed Harold. What if she finds a way to kill you and comes for you next?"

I grip his arms tighter. "What would it matter? Either she kills me, or you do."

He closes his eyes as if my words physically pain him. "Bea. Don't—"

I slide my hand down and flip his arm over, careful not to touch his skin. My heart aches at the agony in his voice, evidence of the constant battle that rages inside him. A battle I can end.

"You *are* going to kill me," I say, keeping my voice gentle, though the words sting as they leave my throat. Fear slips down my spine, but I steel myself against it. For so long, I have wanted to go to my rest on my terms. To complete the spell and die peacefully.

And yet, Brennen has changed everything. Some deep part of me wants to live now. Fears the death I once craved. But I've started to think that maybe I've been wrong all along. Maybe *this* is my penance, allowing Brennen to complete his duty and still find peace.

I will still go to the *After* on my terms. It will still be my choice.

And I choose death at the end of Brennen's sword, so that his soul may be free.

The thought tempers my fear, relief suffocating it like water thrown onto a fire. If my death will save him, then I will give him no other option.

"Do you think I don't know what this is?" I look down to his scar, where the black lines that seep from it pulse along with his heartbeat, as if there's poison living in the puckered skin.

He shakes his head, his eyes so unbelievably sad, I want to look away. But I don't. This isn't his burden to carry, and I don't want him to feel guilt for it. "I've lived long enough to know what a bargain with the goddess of

death looks like. I'll not allow your soul to belong to her because you want to save me. And I won't risk your family's lives because you didn't do what the Cutter commanded. This is *my* choice. You *will* kill me when the time comes. But this woman in my dream, whoever she is, she's going to be murdered in cold blood if we don't stop it."

Brennen closes his eyes again, pulling me against his chest and squeezing tight, as if he can somehow force our circumstances to change. I twist in his arms, ducking my head to make sure our skin doesn't touch.

"I cannae go. Please, dinnae ask it of me." His voice is nothing more than a rasp.

"Brennen—" I start.

"I willnae go. But," he pauses, looking toward the village, "I think I know someone who can help."

66

BRENNEN



The guardians are in good spirits when I arrive at the tavern, likely still riding the high of Harold's execution. My blood runs hotter with every mug raised in celebration, every cheer, but I force myself to smile and nod to them as I enter.

If they weren't watching me before, they certainly are now.

Jamie meets my eyes, his expression guarded.

"Good work finding the book," I say. Speaking the words aloud nearly makes me vomit, but as much as I loathe it, I have to play the Cutter's game if I want my family to survive.

Jamie smiles, clearly relieved by my praise. Maybe he hadn't known it was me at all when he'd seen someone outside Harold's house in the night. Maybe he'd simply found someone sneaking around so late to be suspicious. The thought gives me hope.

"Can we get you a round of ale?" he asks, pointing to their nearly empty glasses, and I hold my hands up.

"No. Going straight to whiskey tonight," I say.

"The Washwoman giving you trouble?" he asks, raising his eyebrows suggestively, and fury churns in my chest.

I give him a tight nod. "You have no idea," I say under my breath as I head to the bar where Theo is furiously drying the inside of a glass. He doesn't even look at me as I approach, and I can only guess why.

“I'll be needing a dram of what's in the back,” I say, my voice firm, and he looks up. I flick my eyes toward the door, hoping he can see the regret in my face. The seriousness of what's happening.

“Aye,” he says, putting the glass down. “Follow me, then.”

The storeroom is damp and cold as we enter, and I shiver. Theo turns around, eyebrows raised and arms crossed.

“Did you know they were coming for Harold?” he asks. The look he gives me would bring weaker men to their knees.

“Of course I didnae ken,” I say, my words a harsh whisper. “You think I wouldn’t have warned you? Warned Harold?”

He rubs the back of his neck, the steel in his gaze easing a bit. “It cannae be by chance they found it.”

“It wasn’t. I was seen visiting Harold. I didnae ken they would come for him, but it’s still my fault.”

Theo exhales, closing his eyes. “I’m sure you didnae—”

I hold up a hand. “I don’t need your forgiveness or your excuses. What I need is your help.”

His spine straightens. “My help? With what?”

My eyes flick to his shoulder where I know a dàn hides. “Your dàn of the traveler. How accurate is it?”

He crosses his arms. “It can lead me anywhere in the kingdom I wish to go. I only need to think of my destination.”

The hope I’ve been holding onto grows a fraction. “Hollow Hill,” I say. “Have you heard of it?”

He lifts his chin. “Aye. What is it then? You need me to lead you there?”

“No. I need *you* to go there.”

“I dinnae understand,” he says, voice hesitant.

“The women who are disappearing,” I say, leaning forward, keeping my voice quiet. “They're dead, just as we thought. But its no someone else with magic in the kingdom killing them. It's the Cutter.”

Theo's mouth cracks open in shock, his face paling. “Why would she do that?”

“I dinnae ken, but Bea’s been having visions of the moments before the Cutter severs their threads. She was there at the Tavern before Harold was killed.”

“It cannae be—”

“But it is.” I stop him, holding his stare. “Bea was brought to the tavern. We thought we were looking for a woman. But it was Harold’s clothes that came down the river, and the Cutter severed his string above where the Measurer marked it. It followed the exact same pattern as Bea’s other visions. The Cutter *has* to be the one behind it.”

Theo begins to pace. “And what if you’re wrong?”

“I’m not. I’ve been to the castle. Walked beneath the Cutter’s threads. They are bound to her. Guarded not only by her most trusted guardians but also by her dragon, Athair. I dinnae believe it’s possible someone else has stolen them. Harold’s thread was cut, and his clothes were washed.”

Theo rubs his scruff. “Alright. What do you need me at the Hollow Hill for, then?”

My shoulders loosen a fraction in relief at his acceptance of my accusations against the Cutter. “Bea said there's a woman who needs help. She believes she’s going to be murdered. We have to warn her.” I pull out the letter in my pocket. “I need you to find a guardian named Garrick. Give him this. Everything he needs to know to find the woman is inside. Last I saw him, he was headed to The Faerie Mounds, but I dinnae ken if he'll be there still. If he's not, you'll have to go on to Dùn an t-Snàth. He's stationed at Cailleach’s castle, but you cannae go there. There's a tavern he frequents. I've drawn it on a map for you.”

Theo doesn’t take it. “Send *me* to warn the woman. All this,” he points at the map, “even with my dàn of the traveler, it will take time to get to Hollow Hill. Longer to get to Dùn an t-Snàth, if he’s not there. And then we have to find the woman. Where is she?”

I put the map away. “The Faerie Pools.”

“Aye. That settles it, then. I can make it there on my own. Sending me alone will give the woman far more warning.”

I lean back, assessing him. He’s strong. Built like a soldier, even, but he has no training. “It’s no safe. And it’s verra possible you’ll run into trouble.”

Theo ignores me. “Anna can keep the tavern running while I’m gone. If what you’ve said is true, this woman might not have much time.”

“You'd really do that? What if whoever is coming for the woman finds you there?”

“I dinnae care. If I can save her life…” He trails off, his eyes going misty. “I couldnae help Harold. Didn't even try to stop them, and I will

regret it until the day I die. With my every breath. He was like a father to me, and I did *nothing*.” His voice cracks, and he closes his eyes.

Emotion swells in my throat. “I feel the same. But you couldnae have stopped it. You wouldn't be here now if you'd tried. Neither would I.”

“Some things are worth dying for,” he says, and his words cause my chest to tighten. Harold had said the same thing. Were these two men—men who have never faced battle—braver souls than I, believing in something so strongly, they would give their lives for it?

No, I realize, they're not. I would do the same for the ones I love. For my beliefs. But I think maybe, until now, I've held the wrong ones.

“Aye. Go to her, then. If you should find her well, tell her to destroy her dedication dàn. It’s what connects us to the magic of the kingdom. She’ll lose any power she has, but she’ll be safe from the Cutter severing her thread before her time. Tell her of Bea’s dream. She's sitting at her loom on a sunny day. There's a knock on the door, and she answers. She smiles. And then her throat is slit. Whoever plans to do it, the woman knows them. She's not safe from anyone.”

Theo nods, a steely expression spreading across his face. “I'll leave tomorrow.”

“Be careful,” I say, but I dinnae think I need to warn him. He already knows. It's evident in his stiff posture, his rapid breaths.

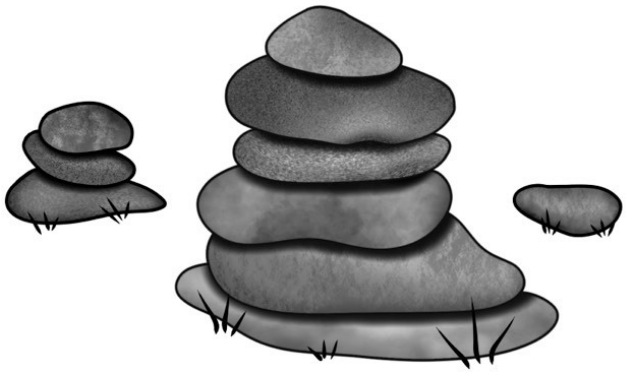
“After I warn her, what do we do?” he asks, and I know he's not asking about what to do with the woman. He's asking about the Cutter.

I pause, in complete disbelief that I’m about to say the words I have thought, but not yet said aloud.

“I’ve turned it around in my mind a hundred ways, but I dinnae think Cailleach will stop. She will seek power until the realm’s power is bled dry, I'm certain of it. So after we warn the woman, we find Cailleach’s thread,” I say, my voice, low and sharp, “and we sever it ourselves.”

67

BEA



Brennen has only been gone a short while when I’m alerted to the sound of footsteps approaching through the woods.

“That was quick. Did he agree to help—” My dàn of warning flares, and I turn toward the pines, trailing off as a man appears. A man I've seen before.

Kenna's husband Hamish stands before me, his cheeks red with fury and a long dagger glinting in his hand.

“What are you doing here?” I ask, my voice catching. He stalks forward, malice etched into every line of his face, and I scramble back.

“I know you sent my wife away.” He flips the dagger in his hand, and it smacks with a thud against his palm. “Do you think I'm stupid? I've been searching for her, but no one has seen her since she was sent here. Did you think I would give up?”

I do not answer, the only sound in the glen the river and my ragged breaths. My heart pounds against my ribs, so hard I fear they might split wide open. Every instinct screams for me to run, but where would I go? Two dragon lengths away? Fleeing will do nothing, so I straighten my spine and choose to fight. “I never saw your wife. I don't know—”

“Stop lying to me!” he roars. Spit flies into my face, his breath rancid as he leans forward, stopping only inches away. “She is *my* wife, and you will tell me where she went. Do you understand me?”

“I never saw her—”

The blade is pressed beneath my breastbone before I can blink, its sharp tip already cutting through my dress and piercing my skin. I gasp in pain, taking a step back, but he grabs my arm, yanking me forward.

The blade pushes deeper, and he twists it, then yanks it out. Hot blood blooms around the wound, making my dress stick to my stomach.

“Move again, and I'll gut you like a fish,” he hisses.

I can barely feel the pain through my fear. Not fear that he'll stab me again, that feels like an inevitability at this point, but that he will know he has to catch me and ask me where his wife is.

Is that how my nightmare will come to be? I’ll be forced to tell him where Kenna went, and he will go to the Faerie Pools in search of her? I can only hope she is far away by now. Somewhere safe, hidden away where she can never be found. But what of the woman who lives there? I cannot fail her.

He leans down, lowering his voice to a near growl. “Now, this is your last chance.” He grips my arm tighter. “Tell me, Washwoman, the answer—”

Dread pools in my stomach, hot and sticky, and I scream, cutting off his words.

I grab the knife from my apron pocket, my dàn of weapon accuracy igniting as I stab it directly into the side of his neck, exactly where I aimed. Hamish shouts, knocking my hand away from the hilt of the dagger.

“You wretched bitch!” he screams, ripping it from his neck and throwing it to the ground. Blood spurts from the wound, not enough to kill him, but maybe it will slow him down. “Where is she?”

“I'll *never* tell you! I'd rather die!” I shout, turning and trying to break free of his grip. Maybe I can get to the knife and strike him again. The worst he can do is injure me, and if I lose enough blood, I'll hopefully go unconscious before he can ask me his question again. Or maybe his anger will overcome him, and he’ll strike me hard enough to allow me to enter the sweet oblivion of unconsciousness.

He yanks me back, stabbing the dagger into my stomach.

“Brennen!” Pain blinds me, ripping through my body and turning into a scream that tears from my throat.

It's utter agony, but I have felt it before and survived.

I fight back, reaching my bloodstained hands out to claw at his face.

“You fucking whore!” he seethes, ripping the dagger up toward my sternum. He takes it out again, stabbing me through the side of my rib cage, the angle changing as it hits bone. I scream again, my vision going black and fuzzy at the edges.

“You bastard! You'll never know where she went!”

“Never. Is that right?” he laughs, an evil, maniacal sound as he stabs me again, this time in the upper chest. Blood squirts on his shirt, bright red against the white. My legs give out from under me, and the man doesn’t bother to try to hold me up as I fall onto the hard ground, stepping back to leer at me. “How many stabs will it take to break the Washwoman?” he taunts, leaning down and placing his blade across my neck.

I look toward the river, just out of my reach. If I could get there, would it sweep me away from him? Or even better, could the current carry him off into the *After*?

“Tell me where she is, and maybe I won't slit your throat.”

I spit in his face, and he roars in anger, butting the hilt of his weapon against my head. My skull cracks, and black dots blur my vision, but the world does not fade to black. He raises the dagger overhead, blind with rage, and begins to swing it down towards my face.

But it never reaches me.

It falls to the side of my head, the man's scarred hand still wrapped firmly around it. He screams in agony, blood spurting from the stump of his arm, and I scramble back.

The man is on his knees now, a sword across his throat. Brennen stands behind him, chest heaving and eyes black with rage.

My relief is sudden and overwhelming, and somehow, expected. Of course, Brennen is here to save me. Of course, he will make everything better.

“Apologize,” Brennen growls, his voice as sharp as the blade in his hand.

“I’m no apologizing to that monster!”

Brennen shoves him onto his stomach, digging a knee into his back and grabbing him by the hair. He lifts his head, returning the sword to his throat.

“You *will* apologize to her. You will apologize for hurting her. For being far worse than anything she could *ever* be. She's no the monster. *You* are.” His words are low and dark, and more dangerous than the blade in his hand.

“Apologize, or I’ll slit your throat. And I’ll enjoy doing it. I will relish every second of ending your wretched existence.”

Shock ripples through me. This isn’t the Brennen I know. The one who believes in justice so strongly, he’s often blinded by it. The one who would never enjoy causing someone physical pain. Who certainly wouldn’t *enjoy* ending a life.

Except… I think maybe this time, he would.

The man sputters, and Brennen drags the blade to the side, blood trickling from the small wound that opens up beneath it.

“Alright! I'm sorry,” he hisses. “Just let me go. You already took my hand, is that no enough?”

Brennen pauses for a moment, his eyes meeting mine. They trail across my wounds, the blood oozing from my chest and abdomen, flashing with darkness.

“No,” he says, his voice deadly as he pulls the blade firmly across the man's neck. Blood gurgles from the open wound, horrible wet gasps coming from his throat as he fights for air he will never find.

The magic of the curse tugs at me as the wind picks up, a stab of pain pulsing behind my breastbone, but I barely feel it. Shock crashes over me at what I just witnessed, so violent, it rips a gasp from my throat. Brennen just killed a man—slit his throat without any sort of trial or order. He’d executed him. We were no longer in danger, and still, he ended Hamish’s life—because of what he did to *me*.

Brennen drops Hamish’s body to the ground along with his sword as clothing appears upstream. I'm too weak to move, and yet the river doesn’t care. It lifts me, forcing me to my knees, and Brennen snarls.

“No,” he says, the word brimming with venom. “You willnae wash *his* clothes.”

He reaches his hands into the water, and to my surprise, the curse relaxes. Brennen takes the clothes, and with a deep voice, he sings my song, rubbing the fabric along the riverbed.

“May Am Breitheamh judge you fully and find you worthy only of suffering,” Brennen says, shoving the clothes back into the current. “I know I would.”

My chest tightens. For Brennen to say such words is no small thing. Not sparing the clothes another look, he lifts me, cradling me to his chest. With steady hands, he grabs the dagger from his thigh sheath, but I am not afraid.

Not even as he brings the tip of the knife to my breast. He lifts the blood-soaked dress from my skin, aligning the edge of the weapon with the middle of my neckline, then, in one swift motion, cuts down, exposing the entirety of my chest and abdomen.

“An diabhail!” His eyes flash with pure, undiluted rage as he takes in the multiple stab wounds, blood seeping from each one.

“Death wasnae enough for that bastard,” he hisses, pressing a blanket to my wounds, but they saturate too quickly to allow the cuts to clot. “I should have been here to stop him.”

I don't answer. I can't. The pain is too intense, and the blood loss too rapid. I will not die, but I will sleep until my body heals. It is all I can hope for, to fade into the darkness and escape this agony. Brennen’s face blurs as he reaches out to cup my cheek.

“You can't,” I try to say, but it comes out as a moan.

“Hold on,” he says, his eyes never leaving mine as he rolls up his sleeve with shaking fingers. “You’ll be okay soon, my lark.” Before I realize what he’s doing, he presses his dàn of healing directly against my wounds.

I don’t have time to protest. To tell him to save his magic. His skin touches mine, but nothing happens.

Brennen’s eyes widen with panic, and he presses harder. “What? No!” he says, lifting his arm and bringing it back down to my injuries. “Why isn’t it working?” he asks. I shake my head, unable to answer him. The river surges, a wave that appears from upstream, rippling over the banks and onto my feet, a shock of cold.

I suck in a breath as my body suddenly ignites, the power of Brennen’s dàn tunneling into my skin, but as the water recedes, the sensation stops. Brennen pauses, his brows furrowing.

“It was the river that gave us our dàn,” he whispers under his breath, eyes darting to the water. “I’m sorry, Bea. This is going to hurt,” he says, lifting me. The moment he picks me up, a fresh wave of pain sears through my wounds, and I cry out.

“Shhhh. You’ll be okay soon,” he says, kneeling and lowering me into the river, my head resting on shore. Stars dot my vision as, once again, he presses his forearm against my torso. The feeling of magic branding into my skin once again rushes through me, a searing pain I cannot endure.

I try to pull away, but Brennen presses his other arm firmly across my chest, locking me in place.

“Dinnae move,” he orders, and I still at his command. Not because I want to, but because my entire being is on fire. So much magic flows through my blood, it's hard to breathe. I lock eyes with Brennen, grabbing his forearms, squeezing as I fight against the pain, but it’s useless. The magic sharpens, the sensation of it unbearable.

I cannot breathe. I can hardly think. Somewhere in the back of my mind, I wonder if, between the pain of the stabs and the transfer of magic, this might actually do the impossible and kill me.

Brennen strokes my hair, and I turn my head to look at him.

But where his stern features had been creased with worry and fury only moments ago, I now see only relief. He cups my cheek.

“It will be over soon,” he promises.

And then, as if he spoke it into existence, the pain begins to ease. I follow his gaze to the injuries that are already closing. The flow of blood slows, then stops completely.

“It worked. You’re healed,” Brennen breathes, pulling back to examine the spot his dàn once sat on his right forearm. He flips my arm over, tracing the delicate lines.

“How did you know to put me in the water?” I ask, my voice still strained.

Brennen shakes his head. “It’s something Garrick told me, but I didnae realize it until now. Every time you’ve taken my dàn you’ve been in the river. Even when I touched you in the vision, your body was here, waiting for Harold’s clothes.”

“You’re saying it was the river that gave me your magic?”

“Aye,” he says, his voice gentle.

“I told you I didn’t steal it,” I try to joke, but my voice comes out flat. Worried. “You shouldn’t have given the dàn to me, Brennen. What if you need it? What if you get wounded in battle, or the Cutter—”

“I dinnae care,” he says, his words sharper than Hamish’s blade.

I lie my head back down, too exhausted to hold it up any longer. “I would have healed.”

“It would have taken too long.” Brennen leans forward, pushing my hair from in front of my eyes. His voice lowers to a rough whisper. “How can you no see it? I cannae watch you suffer.” He closes his eyes.

“But how did you know to come to me?” I ask. If he’d been only moments later, Hamish would have gotten his answer. Either that or

Brennen would have come across my unconscious, bloody body.

“I heard your call in my bones. I dinnae ken how to explain it. I should have been too far away, but it was like I felt your pain, and…” He can’t seem to finish the sentence, but he doesn’t have to. I can feel his meaning—that Ban-dia a’ Bhàis herself would not have been able to keep him from coming to me. He shakes his head, the shroud of control he always wears nonexistent in this moment.

He presses his forehead against mine, and magic pushes against my skin, trying to take root. There’s a burning on my arm, but I fight against it with every bit of strength I have left. I refuse it. Imagining a shield around my body, I shove it away.

There is only his touch on my skin, and nothing more.

No magic. No power.

I will not take anything else from this man who has given me so much.

“When I saw you, lying there bloody…” His words come out choked. “I dinnae ken how I had the self-control to make him apologize before I slit his throat. Why were you taunting him like that?”

“He caught me. I couldn't let him say the words that would make me tell him where Kenna went. I was hoping I'd go unconscious before he was able to trigger the curse.”

“You are the bravest person I’ve ever met,” he says, his gaze trailing down my face, to my mouth, and then to my now healed wounds on my chest and stomach.

My cheeks flush. I suddenly feel exposed, my breasts and belly visible between the layers of my torn dress and drying blood. I try to pull it back together, but he stops me. “I'll get you another one.” He caresses my cheek. “Look away,” he says.

I close my eyes as he stands, my mind racing. He’d pressed his dàn into me. Had *chose* to give me his magic.

I shove away the thought, afraid if I examine it too closely, I’ll put myself in a position to *actually* get hurt. Not my body, but my heart.

There’s a splash, and I wince, my stomach roiling as I realize what the sound was. Brennen throwing the man into the river, sending his body into the *After*.

He reappears a moment later with a touch to my shoulder, a bar of soap in his hands.

“Let’s get you clean. I cannae bear to see all this blood on you,” he says. “I’ll give you something of mine to wear after.”

“That’s not necessary. I can clean myself,” I say, suddenly self-conscious. It’s nothing like what we did days ago, before he’d walled himself off. Before he’d confessed who I had killed. But him washing the blood from my battered body in the light of day feels almost more intimate. Without the cover of darkness, I cannot hide.

“No,” he says, and his stern tone makes me pause. His mouth is tight, and shadows bruise beneath his eyes. “Let me.”

Heat creeps up my neck as a memory of him pleasuring me flashes through my mind.

“I need to wash you,” he continues, his voice rough, almost begging. “Please.”

My throat tightens at his words. I’ve taken so much from this man, but this is something I can give him. Something to ease the torment inside him.

I nod, and his shoulders relax as he picks up his dagger. Careful not to break my skin, he cuts through the rest of my dress. It falls from my legs, and Brennen shrugs the top from my arms.

I wait for the shame to appear. To feel self-conscious with my body on full display in the light of day, but it never comes. Instead, I feel safe. Cherished.

Brennen lowers me back into the river and kneels beside me, the water turning red downstream as it runs over my body, washing away the blood, and I close my eyes, letting the overwhelming sensation of being cared for fill me. If this is all I get for another century, I think it might be enough.

He picks up the bar of soap. “May I?” he asks, and there's a vulnerability in his endless green eyes I've never seen before. His grip is tight, his posture stiff.

“Yes,” I say, breathless, and he relaxes. He pulls me to him, gently, allowing my head to rest on his thigh.

He lathers the soap in his hands, the scent of juniper filling the air, then, beginning at my abdomen, he begins to wash. I push away his magic again, biting back a moan, just the feeling of his rough hands on my skin moving in slow, intentional circles enough to make heat gather between my legs.

His touch is gentle, but it isn’t soft. He moves with a firm pressure and an assertiveness and dominance that matches him perfectly.

I look away so he can't see my blush as he moves the bar of soap over the worst of my healed wounds, just beneath my breasts, his fingers grazing my immortality dàn. A rumble leaves his chest as he quickly and efficiently washes the blood from each breast.

I try not to squirm. To remain still. But what my body wants is so different from what he is offering me.

This is an act of tenderness. Of caring, and I'm grateful for it, even if I wish it could be more. But how could it, with the past that lies between us? Now that I know what I did to him?

I shake the thought away, trying to ignore the way his touch makes me feel like I’m about to take flight. It’s enough that he cares for me in this way —to give me *this* kind of touch. It has to be.

He quickly washes my legs, avoiding the sensitive area between them, and I’m glad. I’m not sure how I would douse the fire inside me if he touched me there.

Ever so gently, Brennen scoots me higher, tilting my head back over his leg.

My hair falls into the current as he lifts my chin up. Once I'm in the position he wants me in, he uses his hands to cup water and pour it over the still-dry hair on top of my head.

Snow begins to fall as he once again rubs soap between his hands, and I wonder if he’s cold. He must be, and yet his fingers are warm and steady as they thread through my tresses, tangling in the long red strands as he rubs circles on my scalp.

“I’ve wondered if it's as soft as it looks,” he says, so casually, it’s as if he didn't mean to say it out loud.

“And is it?” I ask, my mouth dry.

“Aye. Softer, even,” he says, and I close my eyes, reveling in his touch.

But even without my sight, I feel his gaze as it roams my body. My cheeks flush, and he must notice because his hands still in my hair.

“I—I'm sorry. That wasnae gentlemanly of me,” he says.

“Wolf,” I tease, my lips tilting into a smile. “Have you been meaning to be a gentleman this whole time? You should've told me sooner. Might have saved us a bit of trouble.”

“I tried to be one,” he says, but I stop him, meeting his eyes.

“You are. I do not mind if you look,” I say, my voice nothing more than a throaty whisper, and he swallows, his chest rising and falling with heavy

breaths.

The tension between us grows so tight I wonder if it's about to snap like the driest of twigs. My hair now clean, I roll toward him.

“You can… You can touch me again,” I say, blushing. “If you want to, that is.”

“Bea—”

“When you cupped my cheek, I focused on your magic, and I was able to push it away. I think our skin can touch without transferring your power, if I focus—”

“Bea,” his face crumbles, and I know instantly I’ve said the wrong thing.

“Right. I’m sorry,” I say, sitting up and pulling my knees to my chest. I wrap my arms around myself as the shame comes. He only wanted to help me. To take care of me. It’s who he is, after all. But he can’t want more. He’s been honest about that.

“No. It’s just,” he rubs a hand through his hair. “I wish I could. In a different world, I would feel every inch of you—”

“You don’t have to say that. It’s okay,” I say, blinking back tears. “It was foolish.”

“No. It wasnae,” he says, reaching out and lifting my chin, and my traitorous body leans into the touch. “It’s not that I don’t want to. Goddess, do I yearn to touch you. But this vow. My family. I dinnae ken how to have you, and keep them safe.” He looks down at his palm.

I jump back as a sudden flash of pain shoots through the dàn on my back. I hiss, my hand flying to it.

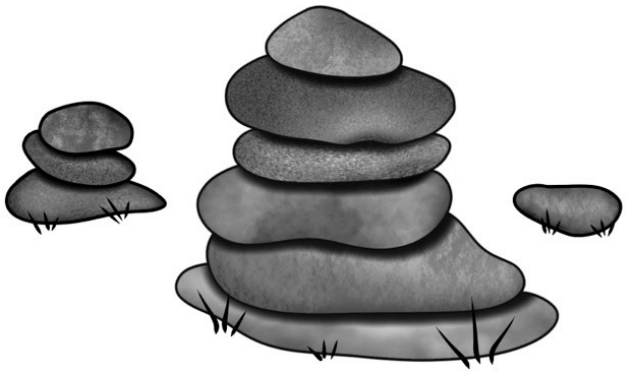
Brennen's eyes go dark as he scrambles to his feet, his hand flying to his sword.

“That’s the dàn of warning. To tell you of danger.” He turns to face the trees. “Mallach ort!” he hisses under his breath as a dark figure disappears into the woods.

“Who was that?” I ask, my heart pounding. Surely not a friend, or they wouldn’t have run.

“It doesnae matter who,” he says. “We've been seen.”

BEA



The days pass in tense silence, both Brennen and I jumping at the slightest snap of a twig or rustle of leaves. I try to distract myself with building cairns or drawing in the mud, but my eyes continue to flick to the trees, waiting for my dàn of warning to activate.

“Could it have been Theo?” I ask when Brennen returns from a supply run in the village, handing me a new dress and apron. It’s similar to the last, a beautiful deep green, with gold thread along the neck and sleeves.

“No.” He shakes his head. “He already left to go to the Faerie Pools. Even if he hadnae, he would've shown himself. Best we can hope is that it was a child from the village. Anyone other than a guardian.”

I slip inside the tent to change, pulling off his long tunic and replacing it with the dress. Brennen hands me a bowl of porridge with nuts and dried fruit on top when I emerge. It's still steaming, and despite my nerves, my stomach grumbles.

“From the tavern?” I ask.

“Aye. Anna’s recipe.”

I take the bowl, the growl in my stomach turning into a roar. “Did anyone say anything?” I ask.

“No. Everyone acted as usual. No one seems to be questioning why Theo is gone, either.” Some of the worry has lifted from his features since returning from Dalbàsail this morning. “They think he went to visit family.”

Relief settles in my chest, and I take a bite of my porridge, smiling as sugar coats my tongue.

“You like it? I had Anna add brown sugar and molasses. Thought maybe it'd been a while since you tasted something sweet.” He smiles at me, a real, genuine smile that steals the breath from my lungs. I look down at the bowl, kicking myself for my racing heart.

“It's perfect. Thank you.”

“You're welcome,” he says, pulling out his wood carving and scraping his knife across it. He's ruined at least four birds since we were seen, his hands too unsteady to perform the delicate carving needed for the robin’s small features.

The wind shifts, and I put down my bowl to make sure my dagger is in my apron pocket. The visions do not scare me anymore, not now that I know how to save the women.

A face flashes in the water, and I hear a name—Saoirse. Her eyes look familiar, and I try to place where I’ve seen them before. They’re green, the color of the deepest parts of the forest. The same color I’ve come to know as distinctly Brennen.

My vision goes fuzzy. “No,” I say, my voice shaking as the child’s death plays out in my mind—a little girl walking in a garden, engulfed in a sudden blast of fire from an enormous black dragon’s mouth. “No, no, no—”

Brennen leaps to his feet as a shriek leaves my throat.

“No!” I scream, trying to stand, but the magic of the river is stronger than ever, holding me firmly in place, reminding me I have no choice. This isn’t a vision, and I can’t stop it. A sob breaks free, an awful, guttural sound.

“What is it?” Brennen says, crouching in front of me.

“No,” I say again, unable to say the words aloud. My entire body shakes as I look upstream, unable to speak as a soft white frock appears, tiny purple flowers embroidered into it.

Brennen follows my gaze, the color leeching from his face.

“No!” he shouts, his voice raw as he rushes into the river and grabs the clothes. It’s the only word we seem to be able to say. The only word I can think.

No.

Because this can’t be happening.

Brennen rips the dress out of the water, unburdened by the curse that prevents me from doing so.

“Oh, Saoirse.” He pulls the dress to his chest. His gaze finds mine, demanding. Panicked. “What do I do, Bea? How do we send it back upstream?” he asks, his eyes wide with terror.

With unspeakable pain.

I open my mouth to speak, but there isn’t enough air in my lungs to form words.

He steps forward, grabbing me. “Bea, what do I do?” His voice breaks.

Tears well in my eyes, and my lips tremble as I let out a slow breath. I shake my head, meeting his gaze. “I have to wash it,” I whisper.

“No,” he growls, his fear morphing into resolve. “I willnae allow it. There has to be something that will stop this!”

I place a hand on his forearm, my tears now freely running down my face.

“There isn’t. I’m so sorry.” My heart cracks as his entire body stiffens, a sob bursting from his throat. “If her clothes aren't cleansed, if they don’t enter the *After*, she will still…” I can hardly bring myself to say the word, and I swallow. “She’ll still die. But she will wander in between forever, lost. She’ll be afraid. She’ll be like the souls we sealed down below.”

“No.” He shakes his head in disbelief. “No! I willnae allow it!” he shouts, as if he will force the magic of this death into bowing to him by sheer will.

The pain in his voice is so visceral, I can’t bear it. My heart longs to take it from him. To carry the sharpness of it myself so he doesn’t have to.

“I’m so sorry,” I say again, but it’s not enough. Nothing will ever be enough to fix this. To heal the wound this loss will cause.

Brennen falls to his knees, hands shaking.

“Oh, Saoirse,” he says, bringing the dress to his chest. He pauses, pulling a small wooden figure from her pocket. A lamb.

He closes his eyes, sorrow evident in every line of his face. “I dinnae want to let her go,” he whispers.

The river turns angry, the *After* writhing, and I place my hands on top of his.

“I know,” I whisper. “But you have to. For her sake. I have to cleanse her. Am Breitheamh will judge her well. He will take care of her. She’ll be happy, with your parents.”

Brennen doesn't look at me as he continues to stare down at the clothes, the fury and grief in his eyes so intense, it steals the breath from my lungs.

Agonizing sorrow pushes out of his skin and needles into mine as he tucks the lamb back into Saoirse's pocket with trembling fingers and begins to whisper. "Tha mi duilich, a phiuthar. Dh'fhàillig mi thu." *I'm sorry, sister. I failed you.*

I can no longer see through my tears as I watch Brennen let go of the dress, blaming himself instead of the Cutter as it falls into my hands.

As gently as I am able, I cleanse the fabric, singing my song. Brennen watches my every move, and I keep my voice soft, hoping it sounds like a prayer rather than a song of mourning.

I give him a second to caress the fabric once more, then, with a sorrow so intense, my heart feels as if it is being carved from my chest, I let the dress go.

The river calms as it swirls softly downstream, disappearing into the *After*. I whisper the prayer of the Three, dipping my fingers in the water and tapping my chest, lips, and forehead.

Brennen stands behind me, and I turn to him, reaching out. Tears stain his cheeks, and his throat works as he swallows.

"Brennen," I whisper, unsure of what to say. Afraid of what he may do in his grief.

He doesn't look at me, but stares into the black mist, unblinking. "She asked me to make her a second lamb." His voice breaks. "Said the one I made for her birthday needed a friend. But I didnae do it. I thought I had time."

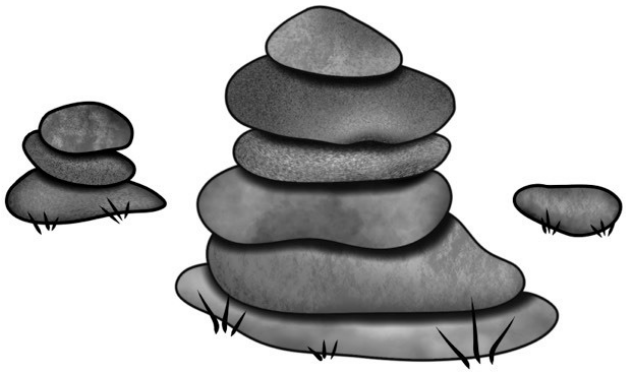
I close my eyes, my heart shattering for the man in front of me. At the guilt and regret in his voice. "You couldn't have known."

He holds his hands up in front of him.

"I don't—" He continues to look into the *After* for a long moment before turning, stalking into the treeline.

"Wait!" I stand, running after him. I do not want him to be alone, but my chain catches, throwing me to the ground. The rocks scrape my hands and elbows, and when I look back up, Brennen is gone, and I cannot go after him.

BEA



I stare after Brennen long after he disappears, my heart torn in two, tears stinging my eyes. I don’t think I’ve felt sorrow this potent since my childhood friend Emma’s passing several decades ago. I hadn't expected it, the day the wind had called me, and it had been her face that appeared in the water.

She died of old age, the best way to go to your rest. Still, it had fractured something inside my chest when a woman I recognized from another life stared back at me in the river, her features both familiar and not, aged in a way I never would experience.

I turn toward the fire, Brennen's carving knife glinting beside it along with a block of wood, and I stand, brushing off my dress. He's already started the carving, one side whittled into the smooth arc of a bird’s breast, the other still blocky and angular. I pick it up, looking into the *After* where Saoirse’s soul now rests, thinking of the little lamb in her pocket.

She'd asked me to make it a friend. Brennen's words echo in my head. They’d been so heavy with regret. Is that what he’s thinking about now? That he let his littlest sister down, and will never be able to make it right?

I grab the knife.

This won’t help. I know it won’t. I can feel his devastation pulsing through the forest, so intense, I know nothing will make it right. But still, I have to do *something*.

Holding back tears, I settle beside the fire. My hands shake as I scrape the blade across the wood. It's softer than I expected, and the blade slips, lancing into the meat of my thumb. I hiss in pain, placing the small cut in my mouth until the bleeding stops. With my dàn of healing, it only takes a few moments, and I wipe off the blood and begin again, more gently this time.

The night is quiet, heavy, and wind rustles through the heather like a dirge, as if the river and her glen are mourning alongside us. As if the goddesses themselves are. Lolly circles the stars, staying close, and I'm grateful. Even if Brennen wishes to be alone, I do not. Not when it feels as if the foundation of the earth is shattering.

Dragon fire—that's what killed Saoirse, and it's not a coincidence. First Harold. Now this.

The Cutter is responsible.

Fury slashes through my sorrow, and I scrape too hard, almost cutting off one of the lamb's ears, ruining the carving just as Brennen has for the last several months. I stop for a moment, taking a slow breath to steady my hands.

The time for anger will come, but not now, when Brennen needs me.

I bite my lip, focusing, and to my surprise, a shape begins to emerge. Curved edges, four uneven and somewhat blocky legs. A head, too large for the body.

I carve out two ears, then narrow the nose, and by the time I finish, I think I've done it. It's not perfect by any means. The lamb doesn't look realistic, or even good, but you can tell it's a lamb, at the very least.

I turn it around in my hands, marveling at the little carving. I think Saoirse would be happy with it, even if it's not as good as the one Brennen made.

Thinking his name sends a jolt of worry through my blood. He's been gone for hours. Over half the day. What is he doing out there in his sorrow? Has he left to return to his siblings? Am I only feeling the remnants of the pain he left behind? I'd go to my family if it were me. Destroy their dedication dàn and disappear.

I scan the treeline. Listen for movement within the forest. My chain sits heavy on my ankle, taunting me. Reminding me that I cannot follow him. Even if he shouldn't be alone right now.

And he shouldn’t. Not after experiencing such a great loss. *Especially* when I’m certain he's blaming himself.

I stand, my hands tired from the carving, and grab a thin, buoyant piece of wood, then kneel. The tears I’ve fought to hold in fall as I place the little lamb on top of it.

It feels like too little, this gift to a child who deserved a full, happy life.

“I'm so sorry, sweet Saoirse,” I whisper. “I'll try my best to take care of him and the rest of your family, too.” I place the wood plank in the river and am about to release it when a hand on my shoulder stops me.

“What's that?” Brennen’s voice is strained.

I exhale, relief that he’s returned wrapping around my heart. I turn to look at him. To make sure he’s okay. His hair is wild, as if he’s run his hands through it a thousand times, and his face is lined with grief and exhaustion, but he appears to be uninjured. He’s staring at the piece of wood in my hands intently, his eyebrows lowered, and suddenly, I fear I crossed a line. I hadn’t asked Brennen how he would like to honor his sister. Maybe this isn’t what he envisioned. Maybe he planned on doing it himself.

I hold it up, keeping my voice soft. “I know it’s not perfect, but I tried to carve—”

“A lamb,” he finishes for me, his voice cracking. He closes his eyes and squeezes my shoulder. “You carved a lamb for Saoirse. So hers could have a friend.” He reaches out, caressing the crude angles with his fingers. “Thank you,” he rasps, his eyes shining with unshed tears.

I nod, my throat so full of emotion, I don't think I can speak without falling apart completely. Brennen kneels behind me, his chin resting on top of my head. His chest presses against my back as he wraps his arms around me and lays his hands on mine. His magic immediately floods my body, but I do not allow it to settle. I push it back into his skin, and it listens.

Our fingers linger on the wood for what feels like an eternity, as if holding onto it might change something.

As if it can undo what’s already been done, even though we both know it cannot. I don’t push him, giving him all the time he needs to mourn.

“I dinnae think I can let go,” Brennen finally says.

I close my eyes, the pain in his voice worse than a thousand cuts of a blade. “Do you want me to do it?” I ask. His breath shakes as he exhales, and he nods, sliding his hands back just slightly so that they no longer touch the wood.

“Rest well, Saoirse,” I say, then with a silent prayer, I set the wood adrift in the moonlight. Brennen wraps his arms around my waist, clinging to me as if I am the only thing that can hold him up, and I bring my hands to his biceps. If I must be a pillar for him, I will. I will become whatever he needs me to be.

We cling to one another as the wood slowly floats downstream, and as the *After* accepts our offering, I close my eyes.

We kneel together in silence for a long time, our breaths syncing, his chest warm against my back. In the heavy sorrow, there's the smallest hint of peace.

Carving the lamb changed nothing. Brennen’s sister is still gone, and nothing will ever fill that hole. But at least he’s not alone. This man, who shoulders the heaviest of weights. Who carries the burdens of those he loves. Who holds himself to the highest standard. He has allowed me a glimpse of vulnerability that, even a week ago, I would never have believed.

And even though I could not save her, I have hope my steadiness can be a tourniquet. Something to slow the flow of blood from the wound left behind when you lose someone you love.

After what feels like hours, Brennen finally speaks. “I cannae stay here,” he says, his voice rumbling through his chest into my back. The words sting, but I do not let my shoulders fall. I will not add to his sorrow. “My family will need me.”

“I understand,” I say, but my voice falters. After what he lost, I should be grateful he came back to say goodbye. “You don't have to explain.”

He turns me around, cupping my cheek. He searches my eyes for a long moment.

“Aye. I do. Because I want to take you with me.”

My mouth opens in shock, my breath hitching. Take me with him?

“I’ve thought it through from every angle. I willnae leave you here when the Cutter may come for you. When others may, as well. Even if they cannae kill you, they can hurt you. We’ll find my family and flee. Destroy our dedication dàn. Find a ceatharnaich group and join their cause. But Bea,” his eyes are sad as he tucks a strand of hair behind my ear.

“I know you never meant to hurt anyone. But I willnae be able to live with myself if I help you escape and the curse comes for your mind, and I

dinnae think you could either. If you find yourself lost to the madness once more and kill someone else, even if you dinnae mean to."

Shame burns through my blood, the hope his confession brought evaporating in seconds. "You'll leave me here, then?"

My control fractures, desperation seeping into my voice. It's *always* my past that haunts me. My mistakes. And I will never, ever escape them, even if I atone. Even if I would do anything to take it all back.

He brings his other hand up so that he's cradling my head, swiping his thumb across my cheek. "No," he says, fervor in his tone unlike anything I've ever heard. "I said I willnae leave you, and I meant it. Nothing you could say would change how I feel about you. There isnae a single word you could utter that would cause me to see you as anything more than the woman I know you to be. My beautiful, strong, and unbelievably kind lark. But to keep everyone safe, I have to make a plan, and to do that," he searches my face, desperation etched into the lines around his eyes, "I *need* you to remember what happened the night they died. I need you to remember what happened, every detail, so I can find a way to keep it from repeating. Can you understand that?"

The screams come all at once, clanging around in my skull, and an agonizing headache accompanies the shrill sound. I close my eyes.

"No." I try to pull away, but he doesn't allow it. "Stop! I've tried to remember. You know I've tried!" Panic rises up my throat, choking me. Drowning me. I can feel the heat of blood trickling from my nostrils, and the pain in my head grows indescribably worse.

"I know, Bea." He slides his hand down, gently grabbing me around my forearm. My eyes open wide as he tightens his grip. "I'm sorry," he says, his voice shaking, and fear grips my heart.

"No—" I rasp, my vision tunneling. Panic rises within me, a pandemonium of screams and terror.

Brennen's eyes glisten. He's holding back tears, I realize. This strong, confident man who always has such tight control of his emotions is breaking, and it nearly destroys me.

"Mo chridhe, I *have* to do this. I have to know if it will happen again. I have to find a way to keep everyone safe. My family. The people of my village. *You*." He closes his eyes in a wince, as if the thought of harm befalling me causes him physical pain.

Even through my panic, I see it. The weight of the entire realm settling on his shoulders. The marrow-deep responsibility—his absolute need—to do what's right for everyone, even when it's impossible. Because the truth is, even if he will not admit it, I cannot exist within his world. Not when I'm not certain anyone would ever truly be safe around me outside this glen.

I want to pull away. To turn and run, because he can't ask this of me. I may have said I wanted to know why I did it, and part of me does, but really, my lack of memory has been a gift. The only way I've survived the past six years. What if I remember how it came to be for my hands to end those poor lives, and I learn it wasn't the curse at all? What if I learn that I really *am* the monster everyone believes me to be?

"Please don't," I beg. A rough, pained whisper.

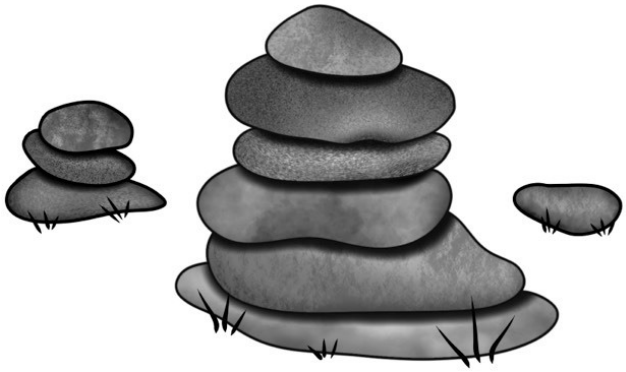
He scrunches his eyes closed, his lips twisting into a grimace as if he can't bear to watch what he's about to do. The pain he knows it will cause me.

"I'm so, so sorry," he rasps, then takes a slow, shaky inhale. "Tell me, Washwoman, the answer I seek." The curse's hooks dig into my skin instantly, and I gasp at the abrupt prickle of pain. Brennen's lips twitch in a silent apology as he opens his eyes. "Why did you kill them, Bea?"

70

BEA

SIX YEARS AGO



My entire body aches as I sneak through the trees, my shoulders relaxing a fraction as the sun slips beneath the horizon. In the darkness, I'm safer. Less likely to be seen. I'm not sure where I'm going as I flee. Where I'll be able to escape the Cutter, but at least wherever I hide, I'll no longer be at that Fates' damned river.

The sound of shoes crunching on stone in the distance stops me in my tracks, and I duck behind a thick tree. I peek around it to where a lantern light flickers in the distance, illuminating a sturdy cairn of stones that appears to mark the edge of a small village. It's tall, rising to at least the height of my shoulders, and the lichen growing along it tells me it has been there a very long time.

I squint into the night at the two people leaning against it, sharing a kiss. I cannot make out their features, but even so, my heart aches at the sight. The taller one, a man, reaches out to caress the woman's cheek, and she places her hand on top of his. My own palm tingles, as if my soul wishes I could be the one experiencing such an embrace.

What would it be like, to be touched so tenderly? For a man to linger at my side in the darkness of night, showing me such love and devotion? He gives her one last kiss, then turns away, disappearing with a pack on his

back. He’s leaving, then. Saying goodbye before taking some sort of journey.

The ache only grows at the thought of such freedom.

The woman remains as the man disappears, staring into the night long after he’s gone.

Is she hoping he’ll come back, or is she waiting for someone else?

Sudden fear prickles along my neck at the thought that someone could be coming. That the Cutter could be coming. I’ve stopped moving for too long, standing here spying on them. Foolish when I’m still within the Cutter’s domain. She’ll know I’m gone by now. That her wards failed, and I’ve escaped.

Keep going.

I hear the words with every beat of my heart.

Keep going.

Keep going

Keep going.

They clang through my skull—a warning. No. That’s not strong enough—a premonition. My pulse thrums like the wings of a hummingbird, too fast, and my breaths go shallow as panic grips my lungs. I need to go. *Now*.

I do not think—I run, racing toward my favorite constellation. The arching lines of stars to the east I call the lark, the points reminding me of a bird taking flight, soaring into the heavens. For years, I have dreamed of doing just that.

This might be the closest I ever get.

My feet fly over grass and stone, and I look over my shoulder, the shadow of danger growing closer, breathing down my neck. I’m moving so fast, I don’t realize there’s someone in front of me until I crash into them in the darkness. We tumble to the ground with a thud, the air whooshing from my lungs as my back hits the dirt.

“I’m sorry!” I say, scrambling to my feet. “Are you alright?” I glance over my shoulder.

The woman from the cairns pulls herself up, assessing me. She must have moved since I last saw her, closer to the village now, the cairns a dragon’s length behind us. She seems to notice my fear, because her eyes dart in the direction I came from. “Are you in danger?” she asks.

The woman is beautiful, with long blonde hair and gentle eyes. Even with her brows furrowed in confusion, she gives me an encouraging smile.

I do not answer her.

“You are,” she says, stepping forward. “Come, then.” She grabs my hand, yanking me up a worn path in the earth before I can protest.

“I can’t—”

“I can help you. We’ll lock the doors. Whoever’s coming will never find you,” she says, and my heart leaps. I want to believe her so badly. Want to believe that hidden away in this stranger’s home, I will be safe. Invisible.

Is it possible this is the answer I’ve prayed for? Maybe the goddess led me here on purpose—to this kind woman who just happened to be waiting directly in my path. It has to be so.

Hope soars in my chest. “Thank you,” I whisper, my voice shaking as I continue to follow her up into the village.

“Here,” she says, stopping abruptly and pulling me through the door of a dark cottage. It’s large, with several rooms and a small fire in the hearth. “My family is sleeping, but I’ll find you a cot. You can rest by the fire tonight.” She locks the door, and my heart rate slows a fraction. For a split second, I think this is it. I’m safe, at least, for now.

Maybe this woman and I will be friends. I can help tend to the house. Disappear into oblivion, just another villager in a tiny town. One among hundreds in the kingdom. I’ll need to find gloves to hide my hands. Maybe a way to dye my hair to hide the red, or keep it covered.

Possibilities of a future I never let myself imagine unfold in my mind, tears stinging the back of my eyes at my relief. My hope.

And then I hear it.

The thunder of dragon wings. A roar, and the crackle of fire.

“No,” I whisper, darting to the window. Every last sliver of hope melts into terror as Athair appears in the sky, Cailleach straddling his back. They’re circling overhead, Athair’s gaze locked directly on this house.

How do they know I’m here?

He roars again, and flames shoot from his mouth, a trail of fire with heat so intense, sweat breaks out on my brow. The crackle of flames reaches my ears as the roof begins to smoke.

“You have to get help,” I say, turning back to the woman. “The houses here are too close together. If this fire spreads, your entire village will burn to the ground.”

“Ma!” she screams, darting forward, but I grab her arm and shake her.

“Listen to me! Do you have a warning bell?” I grab the woman’s hands.

She nods, eyes darting to the hallway once again. “By the cairn.”

“Go. Ring the bell, then hide behind the cairn. The Cutter is coming.”

“I can’t leave them!” she sobs, fighting against me to race toward the back of the house.

“I will get them out. But you have to go warn your village. I don’t remember the way back to the cairn. You have to alert everyone before this fire spreads and it kills every last person in this town.”

Her eyes snap wide, her mouth opening on a gasp, but she moves to the door. I run back to the window, where Athair still circles overhead, getting closer with every rotation.

“You swear to me you’ll get them out?” she asks.

“I swear it to you.” I wait until they turn. “Now! Run!”

She hesitates only a second, then, with one last glance toward the hall where her family sleeps, disappears. I do not waste a moment, racing to pound on every door in the hallway. “Fire! Wake up!” Footsteps sound as the woman’s family wakes, and five people stumble into the hall—two adults and three children, arms across their noses to block out the smoke growing thicker by the second.

“Marsaili!” the older woman screams. She meets my eyes. “Who are you? And where is my daughter? Where is Marsaili?”

“She’s waiting for you down the hill. At the cairn on the edge of the village. Go out the back, and stay hidden. The Cutter is here.”

The woman stiffens.

“Go now. You cannot let her see you.”

Without waiting to see if they listen, I dart out the front door, waving my arms in the air. “Looking for me?” I scream into the night.

Cailleach’s eyes lock onto me in an instant, narrowing into hate-filled slits. She shouts something I can’t hear, and Athair’s head whips to me. He banks, diving in my direction so fast, I barely have time to scramble back. The realm trembles as the enormous beast lands, smoke curling from his nose.

“You,” Cailleach says, a single word brimming with so much disgust it slides along my skin like oil. Her tone is sharp, as if I am the utter bane of her existence.

In my periphery, I see the woman’s family creep around the house, staying low to the ground. I step forward, trying to keep Cailleach’s attention on me.

“How did you find me?” I ask.

“Stop!” she orders, her eyes never leaving mine.

The tang of magic fills the air, prickling along my skin, and as one, the woman’s family freezes.

I hold my breath. “I broke into their home. They have nothing to do with this.”

Cailleach smiles, and it feels as if the world falls from beneath my feet. “Leig loisg iad,” she says. *Let them burn.*

“No!” I scream, rushing forward, but my voice is lost to the roar of fire leaving Athair’s gaping mouth. I drop to my knees, watching in horror as the woman called Marsaili’s entire family is engulfed in flames. Their screams ring out into the night, pure agony that stabs through my skin and seeps into my blood.

I will never, for as long as I live, forget this sound.

The smell of burnt flesh makes me retch as their cries fade into moans, then silence.

“Ma! Da!” A sob breaks through the quiet.

My heart drops with horror, plummeting into the very earth I stand upon.

“Don’t look!” I scream, standing to try to block her from the sight of her family’s charred remains. “Go back! Run!” She doesn’t listen, scrambling around me, collapsing next to the smoking corpses of her mother and father. Her entire body shakes as she reaches toward them, skin burning as she tries to pull them out.

Cailleach lifts her chin. “They’re dead. Get up,” she orders Marsaili. Once again, magic permeates the air, and she is yanked to her feet, her body held up by the Cutter’s wicked power.

Her eyes slide to me, and she pulls a sharp, bloodstained dagger from her waist, tossing it at my feet. “Pick it up.”

“No,” I gasp, but Cailleach’s magic spreads, wrapping around me like a serpent, forcing my body to bend to her will. My fingers wrap around the cold dagger, and a cold sweat breaks out along my neck.

The Cutter tilts her head, her lips twisting into a cruel smile. “Kill her.”

The breath is stolen from my lungs, my vision turning black at the edges. “What? No—”

“Slit her throat.”

“No. Run to the cairn!” I scream to Marsaili, but the Cutter flips a finger, and she stills. I grit my teeth against the magic, but my feet move of their own volition. I dig my heels in, trying to refuse. “Goddess, help me,” I beg, but it’s no use. The strength of her magic is more than I can bear, and before I know it, I’m standing behind the woman, blade against her throat.

“This is your fault, you know. You escaped. And now her, and her entire family’s deaths will stain your soul forever, just like your filthy hands.”

Tears prick my eyes, the magic forcing me to press the dagger harder against her neck, and the woman gasps.

“Please don’t kill me,” she begs. Not to me, but to the Cutter.

I fight to pull my arm back. I will not kill this woman. I will not send her below before her time. My muscles burn, my temples throbbing in agonizing pain, but somehow, my hand moves back a fraction. A gap forms between her neck and the blade, then grows another finger-width bigger.

“Kill her!” Cailleach roars, but I do not listen.

I fight even harder, tunneling into every bit of strength I have. Blood streams from my nose in rivers, the pain in my head spreading down my spine. Maybe this will kill me. I do not wish to die this way, but I will. I will die a thousand deaths if it saves this kind soul who offered me help with no questions or accusations. This woman who looked at me with kindness instead of fear and hatred.

I somehow manage to take a single step back.

“Try to run, Marsaili. Fight!” I beg her, but she remains still as stone, her eyes wide with terror.

“Run!” I scream. “You can fight it!” I prepare to turn around. To hurl the dagger at Cailleach. To dive at her. To fight until my dying breath, long enough to allow the woman to escape. But in a blink, there’s a body pressed against my back, and a cold, jewel-encrusted hand on top of mine, violently ripping the dagger across the woman’s neck.

I feel the blade tear through muscle and tendon, not a smooth, quick movement, but rough and violent and uneven. It’s sickening. Horrifying.

Hot, sticky blood spurts onto my hands, and bile rises up my throat as the woman crumples. I catch her, pressing my hands to her neck, desperate to stop the flow of blood, but it gushes through my fingers, trickling down my forearms. A scream rips from my throat, violent and savage.

“I’m sorry,” I sob, but the word turns into wet gurgles as the blade is drawn across my own throat, and the world goes dark.

BRENNEN



Bea's gaze goes glassy for a long moment, and I hold my breath, guilt already coursing through my body. Her eyes widen, and her breath hitches as she lifts a trembling hand to cover her mouth.

"What?" She breathes. "I don't—" Her entire body begins to shake, tears filling her eyes, then spilling over.

A sob bursts from her throat, a rough, painful sound that resonates deep within my chest, and I pull her to me, wrapping my arms around her to hold her together. Her sobs only grow, and the regret is unbearable. Bitter, and I wish I could take my question back. I shouldnae have asked. It's the reason I hadnae when she told me how to trigger the curse to begin with. I knew it would cause her pain. That it would betray her trust.

By the time I didnae care about losing more magic, the reason wasn't important anymore. Not when I know in my heart who she is. Not when I know she would never have *chosen* to do what she did.

I'd only asked now because I need to protect my family. If the curse is what caused her to kill, I need to know so I can find a way around it. But there were other questions I could have asked. If she would ever hurt anyone again. If there was any chance her mind could break once more. Ways I could confirm what I needed to know without forcing her to relive it all.

"It's okay, mo chridhe." I cup the back of her head, speaking into her hair as I rock her gently back and forth. "Whatever you saw, we will find a

way through it. I can keep you away from people. I'll find a way to keep you—and everyone—safe. I willnae leave you alone."

She can hardly catch her breath through her sobs, her fingernails digging into my skin as she clings to my arms like everything she loves has been ripped violently from her hands, and she's scared I will be, too. Tears burn my own eyes. There is supposed to be right and wrong, but in trying to do the right thing, I've hurt her. Caused her pain beyond anything else I could have done, and I'm not sure I can undo it.

"I don't— I don't think I did it," she says through her sobs. "No, I'm certain. It wasn't me who killed them."

The world stops. The wind stills, and the rush of the river ceases to exist. Even the *After* seems to go completely still, waiting on bated breath. There is nothing but the pounding of my heart and Bea's anguish.

There is only her and me.

"What do you mean it wasnae you?" I whisper.

She finally looks at me, her eyes red and swollen from crying. She tries to speak again, but only another sob escapes.

I cup the sides of her face, forcing her to meet my gaze. "Breathe, mo chridhe. You're alright. I'm right here."

Taking a deep breath in, I wait for her to follow. It takes a few tries, but eventually, she matches her inhales to mine. Her breathing slows, but she doesnae stop crying.

Bea wraps her arms around herself, pinching at the skin of her arms as if her whole world is falling apart and she's trying to piece it back together.

I tuck her hair behind her ears, desperate for her to go on. For her to tell me what she saw, because surely what she's saying cannae be possible. I have spent the last six years hunting her. Believing she so cruelly murdered the woman I loved. She admitted it, more than once.

And it wasn't even the truth?

"I dinnae understand," I say, my voice strained, as if my life is fracturing in two alongside hers. Into before and after.

She takes a slow, shaky breath, trying to find the words. "I— That night came back to me when you asked. All of it. Every horrible moment."

She pauses, then meets my eyes. "Brennen, it was Cailleach who killed them. She's the one who killed Marsaili."

My vision goes red, my heart stopping.

Cailleach. The woman I have dedicated my life to serving. The one who sent me here, using my vow to avenge Marsaili to find a way to kill Bea.

Unfettered rage unlike anything I've ever felt before builds inside me, multiplying until I fear I might explode.

"Cailleach," I growl, her name a threat as it comes off my tongue. I will *end* her for this.

Bea nods, sniffling as she wipes at her eyes with the heels of her hands. "I escaped as I remembered. A ward failed, and I was able to pass through. I fled. Ran for days, trying to get to the Measurer's domain, and I bumped into a woman. Your Marsaili." She grabs my arms, closing her eyes. "She saw I was afraid and offered to help me. And then I heard the beat of dragon wings. I knew the Cutter was coming for me." She winces, as if the memory causes her physical pain. "I told her to run. To ring the warning bell by the cairn at the entrance to the village, and that I would wake her family."

She shakes her head, and the air is stolen from my lungs. Is that why she builds them? Because her mind has been desperately trying to pull her memories of that night back to her? To help her remember? I try to ask, but my voice sticks in my throat.

"I told her I'd come get her when it was safe. She didn't want to leave them, but she could see my panic, I think. Hear in my voice that the entire village was in real danger."

Her bottom lip begins to tremble. "Cailleach burned her family alive, and then made me—" Bea's voice breaks on a sob. "She used her magic to try to make me kill Marsaili. But I fought it. I was winning, and the Cutter knew it. She grabbed my hand," Bea stares down at her stained palms. Another guttural sob escapes, and it breaks me. "She grabbed my hand and pulled the blade across Marsaili's neck."

Her face crumples. "How could I have forgotten this? The way it felt to have no control, to be forced to feel what it's like to end a life. All that blood…"

"No," I say, my voice a rough whisper, and Bea closes her eyes—I think, because she cannae bear to hear my pain. But it isnae my pain I care about. It's hers.

It doesn't feel like you think, cutting through a throat, she'd said. But she shouldn't have to know how that feels. How much blood comes from a severed vessel.

“She slit my throat as well, but I didn’t die. She used her magic to make me think—” She can’t even say the words.

Every breath is a struggle as my reality shatters. My identity. The torment I have felt about my feelings for Bea these past months over something she didn't even do pressing against the inside of my skin, eating me alive. The fact that she’d not only been forced to witness Marsaili’s death, but feel it beneath her hands, is unthinkable.

And yet, I believe her story. Every detail.

She hadn’t been the one to kill Marsaili. She’d been fighting it so hard, she was somehow resisting Cailleach’s magic—a Fate’s magic—and still, she’d been forced to experience every moment of it.

“Bea,” I whisper, pulling her forehead to mine, our sorrow and pain morphing together, building and thickening until it lodges in my throat.

“She couldn't kill me, so she made me think I did it. Made the entire kingdom think I did it so they would fear me. But I did *nothing*. How could she violate my mind like that. My body.” Her voice cracks. I wipe her tears with my thumbs, and she grabs my forearms. “I tried to help Marsaili, but I couldn’t stop the bleeding, and then Cailleach took me away. I *couldn’t* get her help. I would have—”

“I know. I *know* you would have.” Marsaili’s face flashes in my mind. The blood on her neck. On the ground. Her lifeless eyes. I have spent years grieving her death. Years blaming the woman in my arms for it. Wasted so much time seeking revenge on the wrong person.

And yet those years wasted are *nothing*.

Not when Bea has suffered for over a century, bound to this Fate’s damned river, for *nothing*.

I was going to kill her for *nothing*.

I pull her roughly against my chest.

The sobs return, and I lift her tired body, pulling her close and carrying her into the tent. I lay her down on the bedroll, stroking her hair, whispering my apologies. For everything I’ve done to her. For everything I haven't.

“What does this mean, Brennen?” She finally asks, her voice shaking. “Why would Cailleach target me like this? Just for removing the clothes from the river to save someone I loved? It wasn’t my place, but does that crime justify everything I’ve endured?”

“No,” I rasp. “*Nothing* justifies even a second of what you've endured,” I say, the heart I thought was already broken fracturing even more. I thread

my fingers through her hair, holding her close as she grieves the life that was stolen from her.

I do not care if she forgets to resist and takes my magic.

She can have it all. Every last piece of me. My tattered heart. My soul. My blood.

My vengeance.

Vow or not, I will destroy Cailleach for what she did, not just to one woman I loved, but two.

The realization hits me like an arrow in the chest, unstoppable. Breathtaking. But I cannae deny it. I love the woman in my arms in a way I cannae even fathom. This beautiful, tormented woman in my arms, whom I would kill for. Die for.

“I will take care of you, mo chridhe,” I whisper, holding her tight until her shuddering breaths still. We lie together for a long time in silence. Hours, maybe, both of us trying to understand what has happened. How things could have gone so terribly, terribly wrong.

“Thank you for asking me,” she says after a long while. “For using the curse. I’m— I’m sorry I fought you. I was afraid to relive it all. That I'd see myself hurting them.”

I tilt her head up to meet mine. “I think deep down, I didnae think you were capable. I think I knew there was an explanation we hadn't thought of.” I cup her cheek, my unbreakable oath peeking out from beneath the curve of her chin.

A fake marriage, real jealousy, and one hidden heir waiting to complicate everything.

See where the trouble starts on **Lokepub**.

I stare at it, a new realization crashing over me. A bright star in the darkest, stormiest of nights.

“Bea.” Her eyes meet mine, the purest blue-grey. “My vow was to destroy the monster who murdered Marsaili.” Even through the pain of this revelation, of everything that’s happened, relief wraps around my heart.

Her mouth opens, and she sucks in a sharp breath. “You don’t— You don’t have to kill me?” she asks, so tentative, it’s as if she’s terrified to hope.

I press my forehead against hers, our noses touching. “I wouldn’t have been able to,” my voice a rough whisper, because I need her to know I mean every word, “even if it meant Ban-dia a’ Bhàis would own my soul. But she willnae. I will keep my vow if it’s the last thing I ever do. Cailleach will burn for this.”

Bea looks up at me with eyes so full of trust, it almost breaks me.

“I'm sorry for everything you've lost," she says, reaching up to cup my cheek, and I shake my head. Even now, when she’s just learned her life was stolen from her, she’s worried for me. “I'll help you, however I can, for what she's done to you.”

“No. For what she’s done to *you*. She’ll pay in blood for it.”

She opens her eyes, holding my gaze. “Yes, she will,” she says.

“My strong, brave lark,” I say, and before I can stop myself, my lips are on hers. Warm, eager lips that fit with my own as if they were created as a pair, meant to fit only with one another.

My heart stops beating, my palm igniting with white-hot fire. Her lips are softer than a petal from a primrose, and suddenly, I dinnae understand how I have survived without feeling them before. I would give her every morsel of my magic a thousand times over before sacrificing feeling them again. I dinnae need any of it.

I only need her.

I breathe her in for one long moment before, all at once, her arms are around my neck, and my hands are in her hair. We tangle together, our bodies melding as if our joining was woven into our very threads.

Bea moans, and it is my undoing. Her lips part for me, and I claim them, my tongue exploring her mouth like a man starved for centuries. And I have been. Starved. Utterly famished.

How have I lived this half-life, so verra hungry for something I didnae even know I was missing? A groan leaves my throat as her hands slide down my arms. Delicate, stained hands, covered in blood she did not spill.

A fire erupts in my chest, the knowledge that anyone ever dared hurt this woman stoking flames so hot, I fear it will light the glen on fire, spreading until the entire kingdom is burned to nothing but ash and stone.

“I will avenge you,” I say, trailing kisses down her neck, between her breasts. “I will make her rue the day she ever turned her eyes your way. I dinnae care that she holds the fate of the realm in her hands. If the realm must end to get your justice, so be it.”

She doesn’t answer, gasping as I kiss her dàn of immortality, and she arches against me, threading her hands in my hair. I lower the front of her dress, exposing her breasts. I kiss her pebbled nipples, exploring her body with my mouth and tongue. I want to take my time, to explore every inch of her skin, but there’s a need building inside me I've never felt before.

I suck a nipple into my mouth, feral. Nothing more than an animal, driven by a pure, primal need.

“Fates,” she says, as I suck harder.

“No.” I pull back, staring into her eyes. “*I* am your fate,” I growl, chest heaving. She nods, and the need to claim her with not just my body, but my words grows overwhelming. I pull off her dress fully, my hand dipping between her legs, and curse when she’s wet and warm against my fingertips.

She sucks in a sharp breath, and I still, but she pushes her hips up, a soft moan slipping between her kiss-swollen lips.

I'm reminded of the noises she made when I touched her above her clothing. The night I thought I’d doomed my soul to hell for pleasuring the woman I’d vowed to kill.

She'd been more restrained then. But now she is uninhibited. More gorgeous than I could've ever pictured, her cheeks flushed and her body writhing beneath my hand. Could it be possible she needs me as much as I need her? No, I dinnae think it is.

I have never needed anything like I need this.

Not even my vengeance. Something I was determined to risk my verra soul for.

And yet, I would risk so much more for this woman.

I plunge a finger inside her, unable to wait a single second longer, and she cries out. The sound shoots straight to my groin, but it’s not enough.

I need more. Need to hear my name tumble from her mouth as she comes undone. Need to taste her. To mark her as mine, and mine alone.

My cock strains as I lower myself, spreading her legs.

“Brennen.” She looks at me, eyes almost sad through her haze of desire. “You just lost… You don't need to—”

“Dinnae need to?” I growl, spreading her wider. “I need to taste you unlike I’ve needed anything before. I need to taste you more than I need my next heartbeat.” I dip my head, pressing a kiss to her center. “I dinnae *want* my next heartbeat if I cannae have you first.”

I lean closer, speaking against the side of her thigh, “You have carved me hollow, scraping me raw until I’m empty, nothing more than a vessel waiting to be filled by you. You cannae possibly understand how *much* I need to,” I say, and her head falls back as my tongue finds the sensitive bundle of nerves between her legs. She cries out as I once again press a finger inside her, and the sound she makes is everything.

She is *everything*.

More than I could have ever hoped my broken heart would find again, and I feel like I am the one going mad as she moves beneath me, tightening around my fingers. I flick and swirl my tongue, devouring her, pressing my hand down on her stomach to keep her from bucking away, and finally, she cries out my name.

The pleasure of that sound on her lips unravels any control I have left, and I quirk my fingers, sending her over the edge. She arches up, near out of control as her walls tighten and pulse, the most beautiful noise I've ever heard leaving her throat. She rides my hand through the waves of pleasure, and I keep my fingers pumping, wringing out every last bit I can manage.

But I am far from done with her.

When I crawl back up her body, there's hunger still burning in her eyes. She reaches toward me, but I stop her. “Stay there,” I say, needing to look at all of her. To take in the sight of her bare before me, this time, without the guilt and shame.

Never taking my eyes from her body, I remove my tunic, my boots, and the dagger at my thigh. She watches me, her eyes dark, her chest rising and falling.

“Are you sure this is what you want?” I ask. Stopping now would surely kill me, but after everything she’s been through, I cannae bear to make another move without her knowing exactly what I crave. Without her being in control.

She nods, letting her legs fall apart, and I grow impossibly, painfully harder. “Goddess below,” I rasp. I dinnae even have the willpower to remove my kilt. Kneeling before her. I lift her leg, pressing a kiss to the marred skin of her ankle.

“I will free you from this chain if it’s the last thing I do,” I rasp, trailing my tongue up her calf, her thigh. I kiss her center, still sensitive, her breasts. I taste every freckle across her nose and cheeks, and then, once again, I claim her mouth, my hands fisting in her wild, beautiful hair.

“I'm sorry I ever doubted you. I know who you are.” I say, lining myself up with her entrance. “I've known it for a long time. I just couldnae see clearly enough to realize it.”

“Don't apologize,” she says, trailing her hand down my face.

I turn my head to kiss the palm of her hand. “I'll spend every day apologizing for the hurt I've caused you. I will give you more joy, more pleasure than you can possibly imagine.” I press into her, only an inch or so, and it is the most divine moment I have ever experienced. “A century’s worth. Two,” I say, pushing in further, savoring the way her body stretches around mine. The heat that envelopes me is a gift from the goddess herself, a pleasure I have never felt before, and as I find the end of her, I pause, committing every sensation to memory.

“You are mine, mo chridhe,” I whisper into her neck.

“Yours,” she echoes, pushing herself down, taking me impossibly deeper, and it breaks me.

I slide out, plunging into her again, steady and deep, my whole body buzzing as if magic is wrapping around us, binding us closer. As if our joining doesn't need the Fates to bless it, because we are creating the magic ourselves. Magic that belongs to only us.

Bea moves with me, panting and moaning as I whisper in her ear. Apologies and praises. Devotion and longing. And when her walls begin to tighten once more, her lips parting and her head thrown back as she finds her release, I lose myself within her.

I have said enough. My vow to avenge her is clear. My regrets and love have been spoken.

So now, with my body, I make a different sort of vow to this woman.

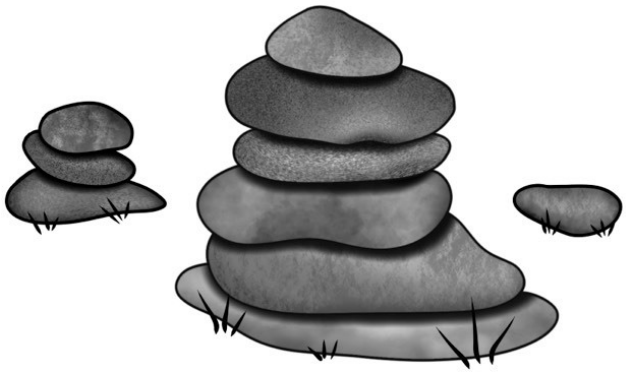
I will worship her.

I will take care of her.

I will protect her.

And as I spill myself within her, our climax coming as one, I force myself, for just a moment, to forget everything that came before this, the pain and suffering of my past, and allow myself to live and love again.

BEA



I snuggle against Brennen's chest, feeling truly safe for the first time in a century. Longer, even, but I cannot fully relax into the feeling. Too much has happened. Too much has been revealed.

Soairse's death. The Cutter's actions.

Brennen's fingers trail up and down my arms as we lie in silence, his breaths deep and even. His hand stops, and I wonder if he fell asleep.

I hope he did.

Maybe in his dreams, he can rest from the horror of losing his sister.

"Where's your mind gone?" he asks, his deep timbre rumbling through my body.

I kiss the sprinkling of hair on his broad, muscular chest. "It's here with you," I say, and somehow, I *feel* his answering smile. He pulls me closer, resting his chin on top of my head.

"Where's your mind?" I ask, holding him tighter.

He sighs. "With you as well. But also with my family. With…" he trails off, and my heart aches for him.

"Marsaili. You can say her name. It will not break me," I say, pressing another kiss to his chest.

"No. I wasnae thinking about her. Marsaili would want me to be happy. And this thing between us, it's… I cannae describe it. It's different from what I've felt before." He squeezes me a little tighter. "I just dinnae ken how I served the woman who has taken so much from me. Years of my life

wasted on vengeance against the wrong person. Your freedom. And I dinnae understand how Saoirse is—" He stops, unable to continue, and he takes a deep breath. "When Cailleach sent me here, she held my siblings' strings and said, 'Such long threads.' She should have had a full life. If she'd ended it early, you would have had a vision. You should have been able to stop it."

I close my eyes, holding back a wince. There's no cruelty in his words, but he's right, I should have been able to stop it. "I wish I could have. But it was Athair's fire that killed her. I saw it. Someone saw us touching, and Cailleach is punishing you for it." My voice comes out choked, the guilt so heavy it almost crushes me, but I take a deep breath. This isn't either of our faults. The blame belongs to one person, and one person only.

"If the visions come from Cailleach, severing threads independent of the Weaver and the Measurer," I continue, "maybe that explains it. If Cailleach convinced her sister to change her measurement, the clothes would come as they always do. Or it could be that this was always her fate. Maybe her thread wasn't as long as the others. Maybe this was always going to be her time, no matter what we did."

He exhales, and even though I know it's not the truth, I hope Brennen thinks it could be. If the thought of this death being fated at her weaving brings him even a sliver of comfort, if it lifts a fraction of the blame I'm certain he will carry for the rest of his life, I will hope he believes it.

"We have to find a way to free you, Bea. Cailleach willnae rest until you're dead, and I'll no allow that to happen. I willnae lose anyone else." His voice goes tight, and my heart aches from the pain I feel radiating from him.

I sit up, grabbing Brennen's hand, my heart racing and hope flickering in my chest. "I already know how to break the curse," I say.

"You—" His eyes widen in shock. "What do you mean, you ken how to break it?" he asks.

I shake my head, a plan forming in my mind. "There's a spell that can undo it. I've been gathering the pieces for as long as I've been sentenced here," I say.

Brennen sits up. "You ken how to break the curse…" he says, his tone one of complete disbelief.

"I didn't tell you because I wanted to do it on my own terms. I wanted to atone by finding each piece myself, but I have nothing to atone for. I dinnae believe Am Breitheamh would send me to suffering only for

removing Molly’s clothes.” I swallow, a hint of fear trickling into my belly. “I’m not positive it will work if you’re the one to gather the items, but it’s our only choice.”

“You know how to break the curse,” he says again, but this time, the smallest smile graces his lips, and my stomach squeezes tight.

I nod. “Every curse must have a counter. There was a note left for me the day I was sentenced here.” I close my eyes and picture the words I’ve read a thousand times. “Gather the pieces of a life completed—a vessel that carries breath, a name given in love, a piece of home and hearth, a promise broken, and an ending mourned. Bind them in tartan. Seal them in true faith and a changed heart, and send them into the *After*. I’ve been trying to find them. It was my penance, to struggle day after day, always searching. I wanted to show the Three how much I wanted forgiveness. Maybe if you bring them to me, we can still break the curse. I can still be free.”

His eyes flash with horror. “No,” he growls, gripping my hands. “You cannae go to the *After*. You have to *live*, Bea. Stay here with me. The rest of your life will be nothing like the century of endless torment you've endured. I'll help you—”

I shake my head. “Of course I’ll stay. I'll help *you* stop Cailleach. I'll help save your family.”

He squeezes my hands tighter. “And after?” he asks.

I take a second to think about my answer, because I’ve never had a reason to believe anything other than a peaceful end was possible. Rest is all I’ve wanted for as long as I can remember. To escape the evils of this world, the wickedness of it, and find peace.

“What if—” I swallow, my doubts bubbling up unbidden. I clear my throat, keeping my voice light. “So much could happen. We’ve never left this river. What if all this passes, and you don't, well… What if things change for you? You've already had your one great love.”

I try to smile, to show him I wouldn’t blame him, but it feels wrong on my lips. I wish I could say his heart was only mine to claim, but it cannot be. Not when it’s buried in the ground with the woman he already promised to spend his life with.

His voice is soft as he grabs my chin, lifting it to meet his gaze.

“Just because I loved someone before, it doesnae mean I cannae love again. I wanted you, even before I knew it. Even when I shouldn't have. I wanted you, even when I was sworn to kill you. I wanted you even when it

wounded me. When it threatened to decimate me. When I *despised* myself for it. Me wanting you, loving you—”

He tucks a strand of hair behind my ear, and my breath hitches. “It willnae change. This feeling,” he places my hand over his heart. “It’s deeper than anything I imagined. I feel as if you’re a part of me. We'll have a life together, mo ghràidh. A happy one. I’ll make sure of it. ”

The sadness in my smile fades as his words wrap around me, squeezing tight. *Loving you*. Could it really be true, that after all this suffering, something good has found me? Something so pure? I sniffle, holding back tears. “Then aye. I think I'd like to stay with you. Very much.”

He leans his forehead against mine, his breath whooshing out in relief as he cups my cheek. “Mo chridhe,” he whispers against my lips, and my soul soars as he kisses me, deep and firm, pushing any doubts from my mind that *I* am who he wants.

He finally pulls away, chest heaving. “What items are you missing?” he asks, and I almost laugh at his need for control. To form a plan here and now. I think I would, if we weren’t in so much danger.

“A name given in love, and a promise broken,” I say. “I’ll need more tartan, as well.”

Brennen meets my eyes, cupping my cheek. His eyes soften. “I can find you those things. I can give you one of them now, mo chridhe,” he says, standing and walking to his desk. The broad muscles of his back flex, his kilt swishing as he bends forward to pick something up.

His eyes are determined as he returns, kneeling before me. He presses a kiss to my brow, pushing something rough into my hands. I trace the object with my fingers before I look at it, smooth wood with soft ridges and angular edges.

I open my hand and flip it over, my heart skipping a beat when I realize what I’m holding.

It’s a bird, no bigger than the size of a plum, wings tipped up and feathers wide as it soars high above the clouds. A skylark.

My eyes fill with tears. “When did you do this?”

Brennen shakes his head. “I didnae even realize the bird had changed, at first. It was subtle. A shorter beak. Wings spread out. And somewhere along the line, the carving became something else entirely. Morphed from a robin to this,” he says, his voice thick with emotion. He grabs his carving knife, flipping it over and digging the tip into the belly of the bird.

Slowly, he carves a *B*. An *E*. I can’t see the last letter through the tears, but I know what it is without a single doubt.

He finishes, pressing it once again into my hands.

A name given in love.

A lump forms in my throat as I stare at the bird, twisting it in my fingers. Could it *really* be true? That when he’d said the word before, it hadn’t just been a slip of the tongue, and this man really, truly *loves* me? I want to believe it. More, even, than I want to break the curse. More than I want to be free. And I think I do. He’s shown me, with his actions, words, and body.

My answering kiss is soft. Lingering, and he pushes me back, proving to me that he means every word.

BRENNEN



It’s torture, waiting for enough time to pass to return to the tavern, but I endure it nonetheless, not wanting to change my routine and alert the guardians that something is amiss. Not when we’re this close. With the help of the goddess, I'll gather the last item Bea needs to break the spell, and the Cutter will have as little warning as possible before we flee. We’ll find my family, cut away our dàn, and disappear.

My fingers itch to do it here and now, but the Cutter would know. Surely, she would sense it and punish my family before I could get to them. So I wait, watching the woman who restarted my heart.

Bea is on edge as she tends to her washing, but I find that I cannot keep my hands off of her. Caressing her cheek. Running my fingers through her hair.

Every fiber of my body begs me to take her far, far away from here. To rip her chain apart link by link with my bare hands, but I have already tried and failed. My dàn of strength is no match for the Cutter’s magic.

“Where will we go?” Bea asks as we sit on the shore, waiting.

I pull her closer. “To the Faerie Pools,” I say, even though speaking the words aloud feels like a risk. “Harold believed a dragon scale dipped into their waters could sever any magic. Maybe it’s the key to killing Cailleach.”

“It seems too easy,” Bea says, but I dinnae allow her disbelief to penetrate my skin. I have to believe this is the answer. It was right there in Harold’s journal, and he was killed for it.

The sky darkens, and I look up, expecting to see the dragon or a cloud passing over the sky, but it's empty except for the thick layer of smir always present.

Still, the glen fills with shadows, as if something is draining the light from the world, consuming it bit by bit, moment by moment. Prickles of anticipation cause the hair on my arms to stand on end, an ominous feeling washing through the valley, as thick and damp as an incoming storm. But there is no wind. Instead, the air is almost unnaturally stagnant.

"Do you feel that?" Bea asks, and I nod, sitting up straighter.

The hair on my arm stands on end. "Is your dàn warning you of danger?" I ask, scanning the trees. The *After*. Something isnae right. I close my eyes, using my dàn of hearing to listen for anything amiss, but the world is preternaturally still. The woodpeckers have stopped their steady rhythm, and the red squirrels have ducked inside their hollows.

"No. But, something feels different," she says with a shiver. She wraps her arms around her middle, and I pull her to me, pressing a kiss to her hair. The need to make sure she's safe from whatever is happening is overwhelming, threatening to drive me mad.

"I dinnae like this," I say. "I think I should go. Get in the tent. I'll get back as quickly as I can, and then we'll do it. Complete the spell, and get far, far away from whatever *this* is." I gesture to the dark glen.

She shivers again, and I grab a tartan from near the fire, wrapping it snugly around her shoulders.

"Be careful," she says, and I nod, giving her one last, lingering kiss, then help her stand and lead her to the tent. Her chain clinks on the rocks as she walks, not a single argument coming from her stubborn lips, and it makes me uneasy. Even after everything Bea has been through, she's afraid.

"Brennen," she stops me. She presses her lips together, as if stopping them from trembling. "If something goes wrong, I just need to say something."

"No." I stop her. "Dinnae say my name like a farewell. I *will* return," I lean down to meet her eyes, "and when I do, we will end this. Together."

"I have a bad feeling," she says, rubbing her arms at the chill invading the air. It grows worse by the second, her breath coming out in white puffs.

"Aye," I say, caressing her cheek, then whistling for Sable. I dinnae need to tell her I feel it too. That the world seems to be shifting. Is that what this is? A warning from the goddess that we need to run, *now*?

Every step I take away from Bea feels like carving through muscle and bone. It’s as if my body knows what my mind is fighting. That I shouldnae leave her here by herself. Not now, or ever again. Still, I jump on Sable’s back, my heart pounding as I race toward the village, growing more anxious by the second. Even my mare seems to know something is amiss, her ears perked forward and her head shifting around nervously.

I dinnae allow myself to think of what could go wrong. Not when every second feels like there’s a demon breathing down the back of my neck. Every fiber of my being begs me to turn back, but what good would it do? Without the final item of the spell, Bea is trapped.

I steady my resolve, sending a prayer to the goddess. If something *does* come, whether it be mortal or Fate, I cannae save her unless she is free.

I race through the gate to the village, jumping off Sable and running straight into the tavern, forcing myself to slow as I approach the doors. The guardians present incline their heads to me when I walk in, seemingly unaware of the chill in the air. The darkness. But I do not miss the way their eyes dart amongst one another. The way Philip’s shoulders square and Bradley’s hand drifts toward his sword.

They know something.

My blood runs cold, but I keep my expression neutral as I walk to the bar, greeting Anna. “An ale, please,” I say, then lean closer. “Do you still have your old handfasting tie?”

Her eyes widen, but she nods. “Aye.”

“I need you to get it for me. Go calmly, but quickly. Dinnae act concerned.”

She must sense the urgency in my voice, because her eyes widen a fraction, her mouth drawing in, but she doesn't ask questions, putting the ale down in front of me and slowly and silently disappearing up the stairs.

Harold’s grandson sits a few stools down, and a sense of duty surges through my blood. I need to warn him. It’s a risk, but I cannae stop myself from taking it. I owe that much to Harold.

I walk toward him, leaning down to speak into his ear. “You need to listen to me. Destroy your dedication dàn. Yours, your wife’s, and your children. Cut through them so they are unrecognizable, and leave here. Hide. Do not dedicate your unborn child to the Fates. You're not safe. No one is.”

“How did you know—” he starts.

“About the bairn? Your granda told me. He was verra proud of you both. He’d want you to be safe.”

“Where do we go?” he asks, already standing to leave, and I’m glad he’s listening. I close my eyes, guilt flooding my body. I wish I could do more. I should have something else to offer them.

“Go to the Weaver or Measurer’s domain. Hide anywhere within their boundaries you can. The smaller the village, the better.” I say, giving him a stiff nod before returning to my spot.

I force myself to take a sip, the ale immediately going sour in my stomach. Every moment is torture, and I grip the counter, willing myself to remain calm. Anna returns only a few moments later, sliding the rope across the bar with a discreet swipe of her hand.

“Thank you," I say, taking a sip of my ale. I do not want to drink it. I dinnae want to waste a single second before returning to Bea, but what will happen if I run off? It will only give the guardians more reason to alert the Cutter, and I willnae give her more time to stop us.

I take another sip, then lean close. “This isnae going to make any sense, but if you sense anything amiss, you need to flee.” I say. As quietly and quickly as possible, I explain the Cutter’s actions, and how to protect herself and her children from them. I tell her that soon, anyone associated with me will likely be considered the enemy. Her eyes widen with fear, but she nods.

“Thank you. For everything” she whispers, schooling her features into a mask of neutrality.

“Be safe,” I say, taking a step towards the guardian’s table. If they are going to spy, I will force them to look me in the eye as they betray me.

“Gentlemen—” I pause at the sound of wings. The Dìdeanair stiffen, and Bradley hops to his feet.

“What is that?” he asks, eyes wide. “Dragons?”

“No,” I say, craning my head to listen closer. My dàn of hearing flares, the noise becoming clearer. The sound is different, not deep and thundering like that of a dragon’s wings, but smaller and higher-pitched.

The ground shakes violently, toppling chairs and mugs, and a shrill scream rings out beyond the tavern’s walls. Drawing my sword, I race outside. Overhead, dozens of creatures fly through the sky. Creatures born from storybooks and legends. Some nearly a quarter the size of dragons, with white hair covering their thin, cat-like bodies and skeletal wings. Some

without wings at all, writhing through the air like serpents in a way that shouldn’t be possible. A grey, fleshy beast the size of an eagle swoops down, and I swing my sword, stabbing it through the chest.

It crumples to the ground, black blood squirting onto my face and clothes, and my stomach turns at its thick, sludgy appearance. The monster's eyes look as if they’ve been pecked from its skull, only stringy tendons remaining, with razor-sharp claws and a bloody, serrated beak, as if it has just been feasting on flesh.

Bea.

The air is stolen from my lungs at the thought of her, alone and afraid. I start to run, but there's another scream.

Anna’s. And then, a baby’s.

I curse, turning back as she runs around the side of the tavern, bairn in her arms and her face pale. Something stalks behind her. Not walking, but dragging itself on heavy limbs—dark, almost skeletal remains with wide white eyes and a hollow mouth split nearly to its ears, with skin hanging in strips as if it was carved into ribbons.

There is no blood on this monster, but that doesnae make it any less horrifying. It lets out a guttural roar, lunging at Anna with its wide, gaping maw.

My dàn for speed flares, and I leap forward, arcing my sword down. Its head falls to the ground with a hollow thud, its body following shortly after.

Anna screams, her entire body trembling as she collapses, but I catch her, grabbing her by the upper arms. “You need to find Billy and get to the cellars. Bring any weapons you can.”

The earth shudders once again, and the sky grows impossibly darker, turning completely obsidian in the span of just a few moments, blocking out all light. There is no moon. No stars. Not a single pinprick of anything to indicate that the entire world has not been plunged into the blackness of the After.

I hold my breath, turning in a slow circle, sword in front of me. I cannae see my own arm. My hands. Screams of pain and terror pierce the darkness, echoing around me, but I am helpless to stop it.

I shuffle to the side, trying to find a building to place at my back, I will not be eaten alive by a beast in the darkness, but I don’t make it more than a few steps before the sky tears open wide, a violent chasm ripping through

the black, streams of red bursting outward until the entirety of it has turned the color of blood.

I still, heart pounding, blood racing.

The Epoch has begun.

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“Get everyone to the cellars!” I roar, ushering the women and children around me toward the closest shelter.

Philip runs past me, and I grab his arm. “Go door-to-door. Warn whoever is inside to get below ground.”

He nods. “What are you to do?” he asks, and there seems to be genuine worry in his creased eyebrows.

“I've been given a duty, and I willnae forsake it,” I say, but the words don’t feel right. My duty is so much more than what he believes it to be. No longer to the Cutter, but to Bea. To this entire kingdom that deserves so much more.

“Dìonadair bless you,” he calls after me as I take off toward the river, sending up my own prayer on his behalf. The Cutter’s guardians may be on the wrong side of this war, but wasn't I only days ago? It isnae their fault they are blind to the truth, and I do not wish for harm to befall on them more than anyone else.

The monsters continue to fly overhead as I search for Sable, relief washing over me when I find her alive and uninjured. We dinnae miss a beat as I launch onto her back, and she races toward the glen at a pace I’ve never seen before.

“Get me to her,” I urge, and she listens, hooves beating faster than should be possible.

The river appears in the distance, and the temperature rises. A dragon roars, savage and wild, and the sound of flames crackling hums beneath the furious sound.

Hope surges in my chest.

Lolly is fighting the monsters.

I break through the treeline, searching desperately for Bea. Above my head, charred bodies evaporate into thin air, turning to ash that rains down into the valley.

“Bea!” I shout, and she stumbles out of the tent, her eyes wide and face pale. There’s a scrap of tartan in her shaking hands, cut from one of mine and weighted down with the items of the spell. Something in my chest loosens so violently, it almost brings me to my knees.

She’s okay, I tell myself, but it's not enough. I need to hold her. To feel her warmth and the beat of her heart.

I turn to Sable, placing a hand on her forehead. She whinnies, and I send a prayer to the goddess of protection to keep her safe. “Wait here. If something happens to me, get to my family,” I say, pressing a kiss to the bridge of her nose.

Bea stumbles forward, eyes wide with horror, and I race to her, lifting her into my arms.

“What’s happening?” she asks, breathless.

“The Epoch.” I hold her tight against my chest as I carry her to the river, savoring the tickle of her hair against my chin and the steady rise and fall of her chest. She’s okay. She’s alive. The monsters did not get to her.

“Do you have everything?” I ask. It comes out rough, urgent and afraid, because this is it. What if we’re wrong? What if the *After* doesn’t accept her offering?

She nods, her wild curls whipping around her face. “How has the Epoch begun? It should have been several more years,” she says, eyes darting to the monsters still soaring overhead.

I pull her gaze back to mine. “I dinnae ken. Perhaps it's a blessing from the goddesses. This will create a distraction. The Cutter willnae leave her castle so long as monsters flood the Earth.”

“But what about your family?”

Pain shoots through my chest, but I shake my head, pulling out the broken hand-fasting rope. “They’re prepared for this. My village will help them, and the Cutter will be so busy severing the threads of those who will

die, she willnae have time to think of anything else. Not for days, at least. We'll get to them in time."

Bea nods, taking the rope. She adds it to her bundle of tartan and binds the ends together with twine, then picks up a flat piece of wood to set it on. Her entire body trembles as she takes a few steps deeper into the river, staring into the *After* for a long moment. I follow her, placing a hand on her back.

I hold my breath as she lowers her hands, but she freezes.

"What if it the curse doesn't break? How can I have a changed heart when I wasn't ever guilty?" she asks, her voice tight, and for a single moment, I almost tell her the truth. That she isnae alone in her fear. That I have never wanted something so fervently as her freedom in my life, and I'm terrified it willnae work, too.

Instead, I step forward, folding myself around her and placing my hands on top of hers. "Maybe your heart hasnae changed, but you've changed mine, mo chridhe."

She straightens her spine, turning to me. Her breaths go shallow, and she closes her eyes, but I refuse to give in to my fear. To feel anything other than my adoration for Bea and the steadiness of my belief that this *will* work, because it's true. For the past six years, my dead heart has been nothing but a blazing, endless inferno of grief and vengeance, but somehow, she walked through the flames and burrowed into the center of it, cooling the white-hot grief and coaxing the stagnant muscle into beating once more. I love this woman with a fervor I didnae think I would ever feel again. Stronger, even, than what I felt before. But I dinnae feel guilt for it.

Bea is mine, and I am hers.

She nods, tears swimming in her eyes, almost as if she can read my mind, before turning back. And together, we set the bundle adrift. "An Glèidheadair, accept my plea," she whispers.

Or you will answer to me, I silently add.

Time stands still as, hand-in-hand, we watch the tartan float into the mist.

I dinnae blink. I dinnae breathe.

All I can do is watch. Hope, and pray, and wait. It's as if my entire life has narrowed to this singular moment, a divide between freedom and ruin.

The darkness swells as if waking, reaching out with long, black fingers. They wrap around Bea's ankles, and my lungs constrict. I try to pull her

back, but she stops me.

“No. They are my friends,” she says, caressing them, and as if agreeing with her, a long string of mist reaches out and pushes a strand of hair from in front of her face.

The realm shudders—a bone-crackling rumble that begins in the *After* and spreads outward. I pull Bea against my chest, shielding us as branches fall from above. Her chain turns orange, then white, glowing so bright, I’m forced to close my eyes to block out the blinding light. Rocks tumble from the hillside, crashing into the water.

Trees explode in a perfect oval around the valley, the ones warded to keep Bea trapped. Bark shoots out in all directions, but none of it touches us, as if we are protected by the goddess herself.

The water warms as Bea’s chain melts away, and I watch in wonder as it disintegrates like it was never there at all. Her eyes fill with tears as she stares down at her bare ankle, and I look at her in awe, this strong, beautiful woman, who, for the first time since I met her, is no longer chained.

Her gaze meets mine, a joy shining in her smile I have never witnessed before, and it feels as if the sun is emerging after years of darkness.

Her body glows, a soft, warm light spreading through her skin, and then, everything stills.

“We did it," she says, looking up at me, breathless. “We actually did it. I’m free.” Her voice cracks, and a tear trails down her cheek.

I pull her against my chest. “You're free, Mo ghràidh,” I say into her hair, holding her so tight I fear I’ll harm her, but I cannae let go. Never again.

An ear-shattering roar shakes the ground, and we both look up to where Lolly battles the monsters.

Except, she is no longer fighting.

Ice-cold terror fills my veins as the purple dragon dives toward us, wings spread wide and talons extended.

“No!” I scream, pulling Bea into my arms and sprinting toward Sable. My mind shifts through dozens of plans in an instant, searching for the best way to escape. My dàn of speed activates, and I head toward the trees, hoping that if we can make it, the beast's wings will be too broad to allow it to pass through.

But the dragon bellows, flying so fast my eyes can hardly track her, throwing me to the side with a brush of its enormous wing.

Bea flies from my arms as I crash into the rocks, the edge of its razor-sharp tail catching my thigh. The beast's claws wrap around Bea, plucking her out of thin air, and I scramble to my feet. “No!”

But I am not fast enough. Not strong enough. With or without my dàn, I am no match for this dragon.

With a single beat of Lolly’s wings, she surges forward and dives into the *After*.

“Bea!” I roar, sprinting after her. I dinnae care if no one can survive the darkness.

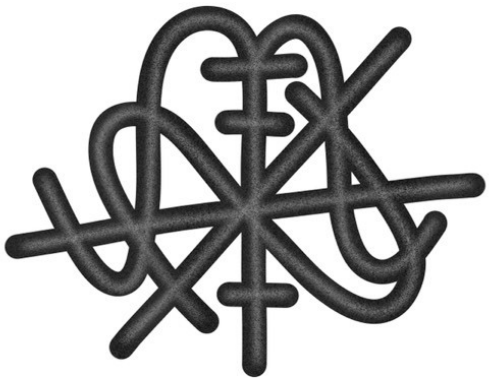
I dinnae care if the guardian slays me on sight.

Where she goes, I will follow.

I do not even hesitate as I race into the black and jump into whatever comes next.

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BRENNEN



Time no longer exists as I hurdle through the air, falling and falling until I wonder if falling is all I will ever experience again. I do not know if seconds or hours or days have passed. Time has ceased to exist, and then, I land. The air is ripped from my lungs as I crash onto my back on soft, glittery, silver sand.

My skull hits the ground with a thud, and I see stars, but I force myself to roll to my side, willing my vision to clear. I groan, my entire body aching and skull throbbing. Shaking my head, I beg the dizziness to ease.

“Bea!” I shout, my voice echoing outward.

The realm comes into focus as I scramble to my feet, and my mouth drops open. I dinnae ken what I expected, but I have fallen into an entirely new world—the black of the night so dark, it’s almost purple, with endless stars in a sky bigger than I’ve ever seen. The water from the river turns to silver sand as it drops from above, and darkness wraps around me, caressing me as if welcoming me home. A pair of enormous gates loom before me, gold, arcing metal created from thousands of interconnected dàn.

And kneeling before them is Bea, Lolly slowly stalking toward her, head lowered.

The dragon is massive. So much bigger than she ever appeared in the sky or on the ridge, and I bring my hand to my sword.

Bea’s eyes widen with fear as Lolly approaches, her hands in front of her as if she can hold the enormous beast at bay by sheer will.

My sword scrapes against its sheath as I draw it, the sound breaking through the almost eerie silence. The ground shakes with each step the dragon takes, and I creep closer, moving slowly so as to not startle her into attacking.

“Dinnae move, my lark,” I say, keeping my voice calm. The dragon lowers her head, smoke curling from her nose as her eyes lock directly onto Bea.

“Stop,” I order, louder. Maybe I can direct the dragon’s attention to myself and give Bea time to flee. I take a bigger step forward, desperate to get to her, to put myself between them, but Lolly whips her head to me, growling.

“Don't hurt him,” Bea says, and the dragon seems to listen, her eyes softening as they connect with Bea’s once more. She continues forward, and I hold my breath. Every inch of me yearns to run to her. To throw myself between them, but something gives me pause. It isn’t hunger I see in the beast's gaze. Nor is it malice, and Bea no longer seems afraid.

Confusion swirls in my stomach, my heart pounding against my ribs as the magnificent creature lowers her head, and…

Bows.

My breath catches as I take in the sight of Lolly, a ferocious, fire-breathing creature, submissive and yielding before Bea.

The dragon keeps her head lowered and eyes closed for a long moment before opening them again, and Bea reaches out a tentative hand, placing it on the beast's snout. Lolly sighs, nuzzling her, and Bea’s lips curve into a gentle, awe-filled smile.

“So we finally meet,” Bea says.

Lolly pushes her nose harder against Bea’s palm, and then I hear it. A melodic voice, spoken directly into my mind.

I have long searched for you. Protected you from above. You were hidden from my sight, but behind the wards, I could feel *you, An tè a tha an dàn dhi—The one to whom it is fated.*

I suck in a sharp breath. An tè a tha an dàn dhi—The one to whom it is fated.

Bea stiffens, her eyes opening wide. “Fated?” she whispers, saying aloud the question ringing through my mind. “Fated for what?”

There is no reply, but a prickle of magic seeps into the air, thousands of tiny needles scraping my skin. Black lines appear on Bea’s body, creeping

across her hands and arms, her neck—hundreds of dàn swirling together in an iridescent tapestry painted on her skin. Wind whips her hair around her face as they dance, shifting and changing until finally, they merge together, spinning tight like a spool of thread until they become a single symbol on the palm of her hand.

My heart pounds as I try to take in the shape, to make sense of what is happening, but I am too far away to see clearly. Though what I can see seems familiar, tickling a memory buried deep in my mind.

I take another step closer to Bea, prodding for Lolly's reaction, but the dragon doesn't seem to notice me, too busy watching Bea as she stares down in wonder, tracing her fingers along the delicate lines.

We belong to one another, now, the dragon says.

A song begins to float through the darkness, a woman's voice I dinnae recognize.

We are not alone down here.

A shiver runs down my spine at the threat of the unknown, and I take another tentative step forward. The dragon looks at me, tilting her head, but there's no threat in her eyes. Only what I can describe as a curious permission.

"Thank you," I whisper, racing to Bea and pulling her against me. "Mo chridhe," I say into her hair, relishing the solid warmth of her body. The scent of juniper and river.

She is safe.

And she is free.

The song grows louder, and I tuck Bea behind me. Holding my sword in front of us, I turn toward the sound and peer into the darkness.

The false queen will fall when the true one awakes.
She'll sever the threads that the liar still makes.
With blood on her hands and blue in her eyes,
And no mercy for those who built thrones out of lies.

A tall woman with a stern face steps out of the darkness, with long, straight hair the exact color as the silver of the sand we stand upon and eyes of gold, so brilliant, they hurt to look at. A dagger rests in a sheath at her hip.

A dagger I have held in my own hands.
Ban-dia a’ Bhàis blade.
The goddess of death lifts her chin.

So sing till the song takes the life it is due.
Some hands can hold blades and still hold onto truth.
When horizons turn red and the After is here,
The darkness will come and bring all that you fear.

“It was you. You sent the song,” Bea says, her voice barely a whisper. I tuck her further behind me.

Ban-dia a’ Bhàis nods. “There is magic in music. I couldnae come to you. There would have been too many consequences. But without speaking the truth directly, and through song…” she trails off, eyes sparkling as they meet mine.

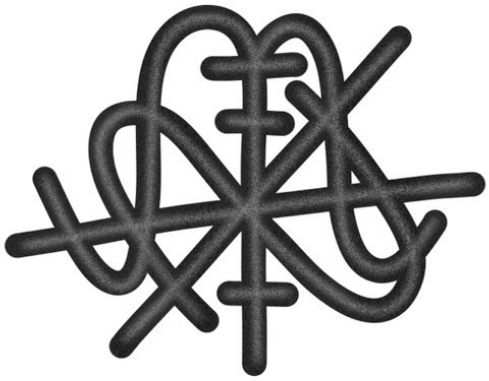
She smiles, broad and bright, as if we’re old friends reunited after years apart. The skin around her eyes crinkles, and she walks to me, her steps light as air, reaching out to take my hand.

“It is so good to see you again. You did well, delivering her to me,” she says, and the moment her skin touches mine, I remember.

76

BRENNEN

191 YEARS AGO



The fire is warm as I settle down in my chair, pouring myself a dram. It's been a long day of judgment. Decisions that weren't as clear as I like for them to be. It's challenging when a soul is both dark and light. There should be a clear line, or at least, I *want* there to be. One that is either crossed or not, but mortals dinnae seem to be like that.

Horrible consequences can come from good intentions, and the unfortunate truth is, that must be considered if I am to be fair.

I kick my feet up onto the table just as there's a knock at the door. I sigh, putting down my dram. "Back so soon? I call, flicking my wrist. The chair I sit in morphs into my throne, a ridiculous black monstrosity made of hardened shadows meant to inspire fear, though I'm not sure why. It is not my desire to judge anyone poorly, and it is their own choices that lead to my verdict in the end.

I pick up my gavel from the armrest, waiting for an answer, but one never comes. My mood turns serious.

With the pure souls, the ones I judge to go to peace, my brother An Treòraiche is generally jovial. He teases me before I even open the door, his voice light to try to put the souls he guides to me at ease. It is only with those he fears I will sentence to suffer that he remains silent.

“Enter,” I say, sitting up straighter. The door unlocks at my command, swinging inward, and I stiffen. Theo’s face is drawn in, and a young woman with blonde hair and sad eyes stands next to him. But that is not what causes my concern. It’s the goddess of death standing beside them, her face sharp with anger.

It’s happened again.

“Come in," I say, keeping my voice measured and calm even though rage burns inside me hotter than thousands of stars. It is not this young girl's fault humans cannae seem to withstand the allure of power. Not even the Fates.

“Hello,” I say, ducking my head in a nod and giving the young girl a gentle smile. “I see my friend here has brought you to me for your final judgment. Would you like to plead your case?” I ask.

The girl wrings her hands together, clearly nervous, but before I even use my magic, I know I will judge her well. Her aura is clean, almost as white as fresh snow.

“I think I lived a good life,” she says, tentative. “Or, I've tried to, at least.”

“Then I'm sure you have nothing to fear,” I encourage her, extending my hand. She looks to my brother, Theo, an action that isn't uncommon. He’s the gentlest among us, after all, though it should not be mistaken for weakness. He’s as deadly as any of us, but souls feel comfortable with him, often looking to him for approval or advice. He is the guide, after all.

He nods, giving her a kind smile. “Go on, then. I'm sure it will be just fine.”

The girl takes a deep breath and steps forward, her hand shaking as she reaches out to lay her palm on top of mine. I bring our joined hands to my forehead, and it begins, just as it always does. Her life flashes before my eyes. Every decision she’s ever made, and the consequences of those choices.

I see her helping her little sister. Offering food to a young boy at school who was hungry. I see small lies to her parents—normal things, for a child. I see overwhelming goodness. It doesn't surprise me. The goddess would not have picked the next Cutter to be unkind.

“Bidh sìth agad,” I say with a smile. *You will have peace.*

Her eyes light up immediately, and I wave my arm to the right. A door appears in the mahogany wall, swinging open wide, and beyond it is what

can only be described as paradise. Highlands and moors and lochs all in one landscape. All so stunningly beautiful, one could spend the rest of eternity marveling in the glory around them and never tire of it. “Go on,” I encourage her. “All you could ever want, you will find just through there.”

“Shanni?” a voice calls out. The girl freezes, her smile growing.

“Mother?”

An older woman appears in the doorway, eyes bright with joy.

“Oh, mother!” Shanni races through without another glance, and even though her life ended too young, I’m glad she isnae alone. The door disappears, turning back into rich wood, and any lightness in the room brought on by the girl's happiness at seeing her mother flickers out.

I snap my fingers, and the room of judgment morphs once again, my throne turning back into my armchair. Two matching ones appear in a circle with a table in the middle. Ban-dia a’ Bhàis and Theo approach their seats, and when they sit, a dram appears in each of their hands.

“How did she find her? I thought you hid her this time,” I ask, though it’s not accusatory. This is the second time Cailleach has found the woman who was Fated to be her replacement and eliminated her.

She sighs. “I'm embarrassed to say I do not know. I chose someone deep in the Measurer’s kingdom. A tiny village of no more than fifty.”

“How old was she?” I ask, and the goddess's eyes flash with anger.

“Three days shy of her twenty–third birthday.”

A growl rips from my throat. We were three days away. Three fucking days, a blink to a god or goddess, and the girl would have begun to come into her powers. The dàn bearing her sigil would have begun to appear in her mind. A new one, specifically for her to mark her as a Fate, and had she accepted it before her twenty-fourth year, she would have been brought here to pledge herself to Ban-dia a’ Bhàis. I grip my glass tighter.

“The Epoch will begin soon, then,” Theo says, his voice strained. Of the three of us who govern the path, the consequences of the Cutter refusing to step down bothers him the most. The sheer number of lives that will be lost.

Ban-dia a’ Bhàis nods grimly, taking a long sip.

“Do you think it will change anything? That it will cause Cailleach to see what she is doing to her kingdom?” he asks.

“We can only hope,” Ban-dia a’ Bhàis says. “Blàr says she’ll make sure of it. That this one will ravage the kingdom. Thousands upon thousands will die.”

“And it willnae be enough,” I say, my voice sharp. “Her soul is too corrupted by power. She willnae stop unless *we* stop her.”

“What is it, then, that you suggest?” Ban-dia a’ Bhàis snaps, her ethereal face somehow haggard. “I have tried all I can think of. I have hidden the ascending Cutter as well as I can, but she always finds her. This isnae how it’s meant to be. The ascending should make their pledge, and the Cutter willingly step down. Pass on her power. That was my design.”

I look at Theo, then the goddess. “Then we must change your design.”

Ban-dia a’ Bhàis leans back in her chair, eyebrows raising. “I’m listening.”

“Make it so the next ascending cannae be killed,” I say.

Ban-dia a’ Bhàis shakes her head, her frustration growing. “You know magic doesnae work that way. To do something to alter the threads so severely, there *must* be a bargain.”

“Then I will make it." I take a pull of whiskey. The words come out casually, but I know the weight of what I am offering. What I’m risking. This is not a decision I’ve made based on emotion or impulse. Cailleach must be stopped.

The room goes completely still.

“What is the bargain you propose?” she asks, but there’s curiosity in her voice.

“Make it so the next Cutter cannae die, and I will vow to you that I will find her and protect her. I will ensure she accepts her position so that the ascending Weaver and Measurer can begin their ascent. Maybe together, the three of them can change fate.”

She tilts her head, swirling her glass. “You cannot go above. Not without becoming mortal. And even then, there are too many variables. How can you be certain you’ll succeed?”

“With another bargain,” Theo says, and my eyes flick to his. He’s staring at the goddess, determined, without an ounce of fear. “Mine. Weave it into Brennen’s thread that he will find me. That he will use me in whatever way he needs to be successful in our quest. That I will help protect the ascending.”

Warmth fills my chest. “Thank you, brother,” I say.

The goddess straightens, listening now. “Even if you both succeed, it isn’t only a matter of finding them. What about this realm? Who will guard the path? Who will guide the souls that pass through and judge them?”

My throat tightens because of all the things that could cause me to change my mind, this is it. My purpose, my duty. It isnae just what I do, but who I am. Can I trust anyone else to do it well? The souls who pass through this room deserve nothing less than everything I can give them.

But do the living not deserve the same?

"Make that my bargain, then." Our eldest brother and the guardian of the gates, Garrick, enters with a cocky grin, flicking his wrist. A fourth chair appears, and he sits, a dram appearing in his hand. "I'll join them in the mortal world to protect the ascending as well, and I will ensure we find a way to convince the reigning Cutter to step down. He leans forward. "Either that, or I will find a way to kill her. In return for my assistance, transfer our magic to your sisters until we succeed. Tie my magic to Dìonadair and Dorchadas. When a life is completed, and its thread is severed at its time, the souls will be allowed entry into the *After*. It's simple enough."

"Solas could guide them," Theo says, narrowing his eyes in thought. "She can light the way and lead the souls to judgment." They both look to me.

My jaw clenches, but I consider my options. "Ceò would make a fine judge until I return. She's used to peering through the mist to what lies beneath it. You can lend my magic to her as well, and return it to me once my bargain has been fulfilled."

Ban-dia a' Bhàis eyes sharpen, flicking between us. "It could work. If we can find a way to ensure the next ascending Cutter survives long enough to accept her role and awaken the next Weaver and Measurer, it is possible that together, they will be able to overthrow Cailleach. Though I cannae guarantee we will succeed. I can weave the possibilities into your threads in exchange for your bargains, but I'll have to be careful. If I upset the balance, it could have catastrophic consequences. It could be the end of the realm as we know it." She closes her eyes, shuffling through visions of the future. What is likely dozens upon dozens of possible outcomes. "Yes. I can see it will be challenging. And it will not be pleasant. Each of you will be forced to make sacrifices, and they will not be easy."

"It doesnae matter," I say, jaw tight. "We will do as we must. Cailleach has to be stopped, no matter the cost."

Ban-dia a' Bhàis stares off into the distance for a long moment. "This Epoch will be brutal, and it has already been set in motion. Let us give Cailleach one more opportunity to do what's right. If she doesnae step down

at the next exchange of power, then we will risk this plan. You will all be born mortal in time to prepare for the next transition."

"So it's settled then?" I ask.

One by one, we raise our drams. "Let us toast to bind our intentions. Do we all agree?" Ban-dia a' Bhàis asks.

"Aye," I say.

"Aye," Theo and Garrick echo.

"Then let it be done," the goddess says, and we bring our drams together.

"Aye!" Mire appears, a dram appearing in her hand. She clangs it against the four of ours. I try to pull back. I dinnae know her intentions, nor do I trust them, but she is too fast. Whiskey spills from the rim of her glass, splashing into ours.

Whatever her addition to the bargain is, spoken or not, it is too late to undo.

"Mire!" Ban-dia a' Bhàis snaps before I have the chance. "I did not call on you!"

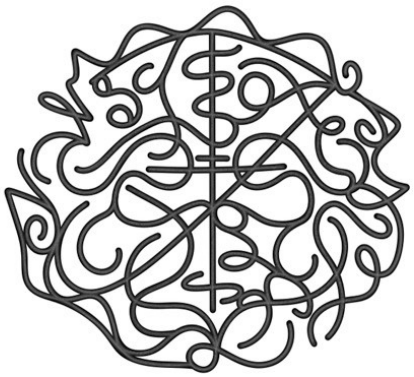
Her eyes glint, wild with chaos. "Since when does madness require summoning?"

"What have you done?" the goddess of death demands, her voice full of horror, but her sister only smiles.

"Dinnae fash, sister. You'll see."

77

BEA



Delivering me to her? What is she talking about?

Brennen stiffens, and a surge of protectiveness washes through me as the goddess squeezes his hand. It's too familiar a gesture, casual, as if she's done it thousands of times before, and I find I do not like it one bit. Lolly must sense my unease, because she lowers her head, a growl rumbling in her chest.

Do you want me to stop her? she asks directly into my mind, and I shiver, wholly unused to the intrusion.

“Dinne be foolish,” the goddess snaps, giving her a withering stare. I open my mouth to tell her not to speak to *my* dragon that way, but she shifts her glare to me as if reading my intentions. I bow my head and avert my eyes, unsure what this woman’s powers are. With the aura of anger around her and the Epoch raging overhead, my guess is I am standing before Blàr, goddess of war and monsters. Who knows the wicked things she could do to me if displeased.

“It’s alright, Lolly,” I whisper, and she huffs, smoke curling from her nose.

Eiridh.

What? I think the word, and am about to speak it aloud, when the voice slides into my mind again.

My name. It is not Lolly. It’s Eiridh.

My eyes stray from Brennen and the goddess for the briefest moment, only long enough to look at my dragon.

You can read my mind, too? I ask, once again speaking the words only in my mind.

Eiridh nods, remaining silent.

Are you sure I can't call you Lolly? It suits you.

She huffs, smoke wafting from her nostrils, and I turn my focus back to Brennen. His gaze is far away, his eyes glassy, as if his mind has gone somewhere else altogether. I step closer, unease wrapping around my heart. What is the goddess doing to him? I clench my hands into fists, goddess of war and monsters be damned, and am about to demand she take her hands off him when his skin begins to glow.

It starts beneath the goddess's touch, spreading up his arm into his torso and neck, a shimmering web of light that surrounds his entire body, pulsing in white translucent waves. It expands as if taking a deep breath, then snaps into place, burrowing into his skin.

It's stunning, a type of light I have never seen before that takes my breath away, somehow warm and cool at the same time, every shade of every color you could think of. Some of them I have never even imagined, and suddenly, I cannot conceive of pulling him back.

His eyes close as his always-stern expression shifts to contentment, and the light softens.

A gasp leaves my lips as the dàn I stole reappear on his skin, along with one he hadn't had. It stains the palm of his unscarred hand, exactly where the one that just appeared on my own body sits.

The entire *After* ceases to exist. I do not see the stars or the goddess, nor the silver sand beneath my feet. My vision tunnels onto the mark, one I've seen written in ancient texts, known throughout the entire kingdom—the judge's sigil.

The entirety of my time with Brennen flashes through my mind. His insistence on justice over cruelty. His agonizing struggle with his feelings for me when he thought I had murdered people he loved in cold blood. The complete lack of grey in his view of morality.

"You're Am Breitheamh," I whisper. "You're the judge." I begin to drop to my knees, his presence overwhelming, but he stops me with a hand around my arm.

He meets my eyes—eyes that have morphed into the most shocking shade of green I've ever seen, more stunning than emeralds, with flecks of gold in his irises the same color as the goddesses. “You willnae kneel for me,” he says, his voice somehow deeper. Rougher. “Not now. Not ever.”

He holds my stare, refusing to look away until I give him a tentative nod, and he softens.

“We did it,” he says, his voice filled with disbelief as he turns to the goddess.

“We did,” she says, but Brennen doesn’t give her more than a second’s glance. He stands taller than before, more commanding, and the aura of power radiating off his body threatens to once again bring me to my knees.

Brennen leans down to speak into my ear. “Dinnae even think about it. If either of us will be kneeling for the other, it will be me,” he says, reaching out and cupping my face with both hands, threading his fingers through the curls at my nape.

“What’s happening?” I breathe, examining the angular planes of his face. Sharper than before. Even stronger.

He presses his forehead against mine.

“I was sent to find you,” he says. “I remember now.”

“Find me?” I ask, my mind reeling. Why would a god be sent to find a mere mortal? Why me? And why did he not remember until now? If he were a god, how could he not know it?

“Yes. You,” he says, trailing a thumb across my cheek. Sparks ignite along the line of his touch, more intense than ever. “You. Always you. I finally understand,” he says, the smile gracing his lips a gift from the gods.

My god.

The thought comes unbidden and unexpected. Could he ever be truly mine if he belongs to this world?

I shake the thought away, desperate to ask him to explain, to share his understanding with me, but the words are dead on my tongue. I can hardly speak with his power needling into me, his hands on my skin hotter than flames.

He must sense my struggle, because his eyes crinkle, and my knees nearly buckle.

“Dinnae fash, my lark. All is well now.”

Warmth fills my chest at his nickname for me.

“Poor dear looks like she might faint. Best start from the beginning,” the goddess says, folding her hands together.

Brennen slides his hands down to my shoulders. “Right. I’m sorry. Remembering it all at once. It was…overwhelming.”

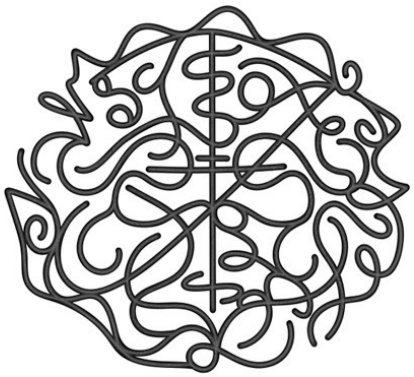
“Remembering what?” I ask, finally finding my voice.

He takes a deep breath, holding onto it for a moment as if whatever he’s about to say will take effort. “Everything,” he says. “Everything we’ve wondered. The reason the Cutter hid you away a century ago. The reason she couldnae kill you. The reason you're so strong.” He leans forward, his gaze boring into mine. “So brave.”

He caresses my face with his eyes, from my brow to my nose to my lips, with such pride, my heart aches. “The answer was always right there. *You*, mo chridhe, are fated to become the next Cutter.”

78

BEA



“The next…” My words fade on an exhale, a wave of dizziness washing over me. What he’s saying can’t be true. Can it? Because how in the goddess's name could *I* be a Fate?

And yet, I never would have believed Brennen was a *god*, either, and here he is, standing next to me, emanating power unlike anything I’ve ever felt.

Brennen. The only person I trust. Explicitly and wholly. If he’s telling me this is the truth…

Fated one, Lolly— I mean, Eiridh had said.

“Me?” I breathe, my entire body tensing.

“Aye, m’ anam.” *My soul.* “You.”

The words hit low in my belly, but I cannot truly feel them. Cannot appreciate the immensity of their meaning as my disbelief morphs into frustration. I didn’t ask to become a Fate, but even if I had, of the three of them, why would I be destined to fulfill the one role I would never, ever want? I shake my head.

“I’ve seen enough death. I despise it,” I say to the goddess, anger bubbling in my chest.

She gives me an approving smile, leaning forward and dropping her voice to a near whisper. “*Exactly*. You appreciate death. You respect its role. Its power. There is no one better suited, after the life you’ve lived, to fulfill this sacred duty,” the goddess says, something akin to pride in her voice.

I want to strike her across her cheek, this woman who has ripped my reality apart, but I bite my tongue.

Brennen chuckles, lifting my hand, caressing the new dàn on my palm. Pulling my focus away from the goddess, I focus on the lines, examining the way they swoop and curl, but the symbol means nothing to me.

Not until, tucked into the intricate design, I see a long vertical stroke, then an arched one across the top. From the right edge of that one, a line runs down at an angle, looping up at the bottom.

Shock and recognition ripple through my body. “This is the dàn I picture. The one I can never complete.”

He nods. “It would have begun to appear in your mind before Cailleach found you. Had you been given more time, you would have realized what it was, and your magic would have awoken. If you had chosen to accept the role, the cycle would have begun. She found you too soon.”

I bring it closer, staring, the shape somehow so familiar and not at the same time. It doesn’t look like Cailleach’s sigil at all; the marking far more intricate, with so many loops and swirls, I could find a hundred different designs within it if I searched. “How could she take it from me?” I ask, trailing my fingers along the fine lines.

Brennen’s voice drops low. “She stole the dàn from your mind, just as she manipulated your memories to make you believe you killed those people.”

The goddess places a hand on her chest. “I am so very sorry for what you’ve endured.”

I shake my head, unexpected tears burning the backs of my eyes at the sorrow in her voice. Is it possible Blàr means it? That the goddess of war and monsters cares this much about the pain of mortals?

“Tell me everything,” I say, turning to Brennen, and he squeezes my hand.

“Prior to the last Epoch, we made a plan. We knew that cycle would be brutal, and the Cutter would be given one more chance to step down. It would have been far easier if she had done it of her own will, with less of a chance of destabilizing the magic of the realm. Even Ban-dia a’ Bhàis cannae use her power unfettered without consequence.”

Ban-dia a’ Bhàis.

The name makes my heart nearly stop. The silver hair and gold eyes.

This isn’t a lesser goddess at all. I am standing before the very creator of our realm. The goddess of death.

I look down at my feet, suddenly unable to breathe. I had been cross with her. Had almost demanded she not touch Brennen, and that she respect my dragon.

“Dinnae fash,” Brennen says, as if reading my mind. He tilts my chin back up. “She willnae harm you. She is the one who sent me to find you.” He tucks a strand of hair behind my ear.

I shake my head. “But why? Why would a god come to the mortal realm?”

“Ban-dia a’ Bhàis’s magic, if she uses it for anything that changes the fate of her kingdom, requires a bargain. When the Cutter wouldnae step down, I offered one. Only one Cutter is fated prior to each Epoch. We were determined not to lose another to Cailleach’s greed. She was to weave it into the next Cutter’s thread that she couldnae be killed, and in exchange, I would find her and bring her here to step into her power. That thread was yours.”

“Wove it into my thread… Is that why I have an immortality dan?” I ask, my mind struggling to keep up.

The goddess places a hand to her sternum. “Aye. But it didnae appear until Cailleach tried to kill you, and *she* couldnae see it. I tried to hide you so it would never come to that. A Fate can sense their replacement once they place eyes on them. I’d hoped she wouldn’t find you at all. I almost succeeded. Made you a nobody. No family to miss you. Just a girl adrift in a kingdom that doesnae care for those without power. But when you took your friend’s clothes from the river in your attempt to save her, Cailleach felt you. Only one fated to touch death would have been able to remove the clothes. Even with my magic hiding you, she knew who you were.”

The statement is a knife between my ribs, shockingly, deeply painful. How different would things be if I’d made a different choice? A better one? My friend had died anyway, and my entire life was ruined.

“She hid you somewhere you willnae find on any map and turned you into a legend the entire kingdom feared,” Ban-dia a’ Bhàis says.

“But what about her sisters? Why have they done nothing to stop her?” I ask, trying to complete the picture forming in my mind. Ban-dia a’ Bhàis stiffens, but she doesn't answer.

“Each Fate is duty-bound to find their own ascending, but it is only once the next Cutter accepts her dàn that the women destined to become her sisters awaken,” Brennen says. “Without an ascending—”

“Wait,” I say, pressing a hand to my forehead, trying to keep up.

“Breathe, m’ anam,” Brennen says. I drag in a shaky breath, but my mind doesn’t still.

“When there is no Cutter to ascend,” he continues, “the cycle resets. Cailleach’s sisters would have been forced to continue their rule alongside her.”

I close my eyes, creating a map of connections in my mind. “When I couldn’t be killed, she started looking for the women who would become the Weaver and Measurer, should I accept the role.”

Brennen nods.

Once again, anger flickers in my chest. “Why do I have to be the one to accept the dàn first?” I ask. Must the burden rest on my shoulders, always? Why could the Weaver or Measurer not be the one to carry it for a while? Why must I endure a century of a cursed existence before their trials even begin?

Ban-dia a’ Bhàis tilts her head. “I know it doesnae seem fair, but this is how it has always been. Without death, there cannot be life. A thread cannot be woven and measured if I am not certain there will be someone to sever it. No one is meant to live forever. Not mortals. And not the Fates.” She takes a step forward, pointing into the endless sky. “Your sisters are up there now, waiting for you without even knowing it. Their dàn will appear to them, too, for them to accept or reject, should you choose your calling.”

I shake my head, trying to wrap my mind around her words. The immensity of their meaning.

My *sisters.* A family I never really had. One fate chose for me.

The thought overwhelms me, and I sag against Brennen. All I want is to feel his calm. His sturdiness.

He doesn’t let me down, wrapping a protective arm around my waist and pulling me tightly against him. My heart rate calms almost instantly.

“The missing women. The deaths.” A web more layered and intricate than I could have ever imagined unfurling in my mind. “They’re women she thinks could be my sisters, aren’t they? She’s desperate, trying to eliminate anyone who could overpower her, and so she’s killing them.”

The goddess's eyes flash with anger. "Aye," she confirms, her voice dark.

"Where are they?" I ask. "The souls who couldn't pass on?"

The goddess gestures in the opposite direction of the gates, toward the misty black sand flowing from above. "Thanks to you, they rest in the darkness. Only those who pass at their time can enter until An Glèidheadair returns."

"And Saoirse?" I ask, eyes flicking to Brennen. He stiffens, his arms tensing as he squeezes me tighter.

Ban-dia a' Bhàis gives him a gentle smile. "She has found peace with your mortal parents. She is happy," the goddess says softly.

The tension eases from Brennen's grip a fraction, and while relief wraps around my heart, it doesn't last long. All of this is wrong.

I'm glad she has found peace, but she shouldn't be here at all. Saoirse should be alive. Those women, and Harold, should be alive.

"Does the Cutter know what she's doing to those souls? That she is the reason they cannot enter the *After*? That her refusing to step down is the cause of the Epoch?" I ask, my voice turning sharp. How much suffering will that woman cause? And for what? Power?

What good is power when the kingdom loathes you? When you refuse to use it to help anyone but yourself.

The anger in Ban-dia a' Bhàis eyes grows hotter, the gold in her irises flickering like flames. "She knows. About the women, *and* the Epoch. The alignment of the moons once served as a time of celebration. A day the Fates would hand over their crowns to those who pledged to me they would take their place." Ban-dia a' Bhàis's jaw tightens. "It wasnae until the Fates refused to step down that it became a time of death and mourning. It was your time to ascend over a century ago, when the last Epoch occurred. But you were trapped at the river—unable to die, but unable to ascend to your rightful place. It's why I added to your curse. Made it so catching you would give Brennen his answer. I gave you the spell to be set free. Not to die, but to *live*. To reign. It's the reason Am Breitheamh pledged to bring you to me. I couldnae interfere with your life, or the Fates, any more than I already had. Too many threads would have unraveled."

It feels as if I cannot breathe, my lungs too stiff to expand. "*You* left me the spell?" I ask, the memory of finding the separate piece of parchment

tucked away in the rocks flickering into my mind. “The Cutter didn’t know about it at all?”

“Aye. It was me. I couldnae free you, but with Brennen’s help, and when the time was right, I could give you the chance to free yourself,” she says, and the anger that has been simmering in my chest grows.

Cailleach hadn’t just cursed me to the river. She’d doomed me there forever, with no intention of giving me any sort of chance to escape. And because of her greed, the monsters have come once again. The Epoch didn’t have to be like this—a time of death—and yet, she chose for it to be, all to stay in power.

“How do we stop it?” I ask, a sudden urgency erupting in my chest. So many will die, and all because of one power-hungry woman.

Brennen squeezes my hand. “It depends on what you choose. We cannae force you to accept your calling. It must be done willingly. The decision belongs to you, and you alone.”

I close my eyes for a moment, taking a deep breath. All I have wanted for so long is rest. Peace. Becoming the Cutter, the one who will end every life in the kingdom for the next century, goes against every thought and feeling and want I have ever had. What she’s asking of me, it’s more than I think I can take.

“And if I refuse?” I ask.

The goddess's eyes turn sad. “The Epoch will continue for years to come. The Cutter will rule, and we will be forced to stand by, helpless, and watch the kingdom burn.”

I pinch at my arms, willing myself to wake up from this nightmare. The habit is familiar, but this time, I picture my fingers pinching a thread, watching it turn to dust.

Could this be even worse than my curse? Another battle for me to endure, when I am already so very tired. Lives I will not only wash, but end? I look to Brennen, silently begging him to tell me what the right answer is, but he only runs a thumb across my hand.

The women’s faces from my visions flash in my mind. Lives ended too soon by the Cutter. Women who deserved so much more than the fate they received.

Betty.

The woman in love at the pub.

The mother kissing her child.

The tailor’s daughter.

The woman twirling in the green dress.

Women who had begged me to help them.

Resolve ignites in my chest, growing larger by the second until it fills my chest and solidifies. I refuse to fail them again.

“I accept.” The words leap from my throat before I’ve fully decided to say them, my voice shaking, but I cannot say no. If this is truly my fate, then I will not fear it. I will not cower.

The moment I speak the words, the dàn on my hand begins to sting, then burn. A white-hot agony that spreads into my arms. My torso and legs. My head. My vision turns red behind my eyelids, and the air is ripped violently from my lungs. I nearly collapse. I would, if Brennen didn’t catch me, pulling me into his arms and tucking my head beneath his chin.

I wish for death. Beg for it. For anything at all to end this agony.

“So strong, m’ anam,” Brennen whispers into my hair. “So brave. The pain will end soon. I’m here.”

And even though I am certain it will never end—that it will only get worse until my mind and body shatter—slowly, it begins to fade. My heart slows, my breaths once again growing steadier.

When I open my eyes again, the world is different. Sharper. The stars twinkle in shocking shades of yellow and purple and pink, and the silver sand shimmers as if made from gemstones. The fatigue has drained from my body, and my muscles feel strong in a way I’ve never experienced.

I meet Brennen’s eyes. Eyes so full of awe and adoration, I want to bottle the way it makes me feel so I can carry it with me on my darkest days.

“It is done. There isnae time to waste. She must go,” the goddess says to Brennen, and he stiffens.

“Where she goes, I will follow,” he says, straightening as if daring the goddess to defy him. Her eyes flick to our joined hands.

“Interesting,” she says, tilting her head. “Are you certain? You could return to your home. Resume your duties to the souls that pass.”

“No,” Brennen almost growls, and my heart swells. Could it really be possible there’s a place for us, after all? “Did I not jump into the *After* to follow her, thinking it would lead to my own death? I dinnae care if you strip me of my duties. If you refuse to make me immortal again. I willnae be leaving her side.”

The goddess presses her lips together for several long moments. “If you are to continue on this quest, know I cannae help you. There are things you do not know. Things I cannae tell you. There will be danger. ”

Brennen pulls me closer. “Aye,” he says. “Whatever the consequences are, I’ll accept them.”

The goddess nods, though she doesn’t look pleased.

She turns her attention away from Brennen, meeting my eyes. “You must find your sisters in fate and destroy their dedication dàn so the Cutter cannae reach them.”

“If cutting the dàn makes it so they are untethered from magic, does that not make them immortal?”

“No. It removes them from the magic gifted by one of the Fates, their direct connection to them, but the Cutter can still cut their thread as it was measured. That was my design. Travel through the *After* and complete the Trials of the Three. Only then will you be granted passage through where life begins. Find the one destined to weave, then go beyond, to where pain dwells, to seek out the one who will measure. Help them awaken the dàn in their minds, and their magic will return to them.”

Brennen tilts his head. “Life begins at the Faerie Pools, but where does pain dwell?”

Ban-dia a’ Bhàis’s eyes turn sad. “You know I cannot tell you the answer to that. All will be learned in time. But you must hurry. The Cutter will not surrender. Only with your sisters at your side will you be able to defeat her.”

“We will,” Brennen says, his voice so confident, I’m almost convinced he believes it. Because how are we supposed to find two women we do not even know? How are the three of us supposed to defeat an all-powerful Fate who has been ruling for hundreds of years? One even the goddess of death has been unable to sway for centuries?

“You must be careful, Bea. When you broke the curse, you shattered the magic that bound you, but also that which protected you. Where you once stood on the precipice of death, near her, but never touching, you are now firmly within her realm. Once you pass through those gates…” she waves a hand toward the enormous arches at her back. “If you die down here, or beyond, either of you—”

“Our lives will be over. Cailleach will continue to rule, and our people will suffer,” I finish for her.

“Aye.” She gestures toward the gates. Brennen moves to my side, grabbing my hand as they creak open, exposing the vast, misty darkness beyond. “Welcome to the River’s End.”

EPILOGUE

THEO



FIVE DAYS EARLIER

Water trickles in little streams down the hill, and the tang of magic brushes against my skin, almost painful. Anticipation prickles along my neck, dancing down my spine.

I'm getting close.

I pick up my pace climbing the steep, ancient path, hoping I'm not too late to save the woman from Bea's dream. I've hardly slept since I left, stopping only when Rowan, my chestnut stallion waiting below, needed rest. Those hours had been uncomfortable, the pull in my chest to continue onward all-consuming, as if I were running out of time.

The top of the cliffs appears through the trees, giving me the burst of energy I need. I scramble upward, and then, as if the sun is escaping from behind storm clouds after weeks of being hidden beneath their murky gray, the Faerie Pools appear.

My breath hitches as I take in the pure beauty of them. The impossibly clear water, a shade of blue there is no name for, shimmering as if infused with flecks of pure gold. Smooth pebbles make up the floor; every color imaginable, stones of pink and green and purple, a field of wildflowers within the depths.

The pools are stacked in levels along the brae, the higher ones cascading down in a whoosh of falling water as soothing as a lullaby. Some of the tension I've been carrying eases.

I made it.

I scan the pools, at least a dozen of them, searching for the cabin I was sent to find. It's hidden at the very top, only a stone chimney peeking out from the rocky outcropping of the highest pool, and my heart thunders as I make my way toward it. What will I find when I knock on the door?

Once again, I wonder, what if I'm too late?

I crest the last pool and freeze when I see her. A strange ache erupts in my palm as I take in the most stunning woman I've ever laid eyes on. She's lying on her belly, her long golden hair gleaming in the sunlight, fingers trailing through the water as she tends to the pools. She's speaking quietly as if she's having a conversation, and I glance around, gasping when I see them.

Fair folk. Three tiny winged creatures dance by her arm. On instinct, I take a step forward to get a closer look, and a piece of rock tumbles into the pool, ripples pulsing outward until they meet her submerged hand.

The faeries disappear into the forest in a blink, and the woman freezes, her frost-blue eyes widening in what I can only describe as absolute, undiluted terror.

Her fear nearly destroys me as a single thought enters my mind—it's *you*.

ALSO BY MEGAN SHADE

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If you enjoyed this book, consider leaving a review on AMAZON and GOODREADS or the review platform of your choosing, and follow me on Facebook, Instagram, and Tiktok @meganshadeauthor. Sign up for my newsletter HERE

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GLOSSARY

Terms:

- **An Diabhal** (un JEE-uh-vul): Devil
- **An Diabhail!** (un JEE-uh-vul): An expletive; roughly, “fuck!”
- **Triùir na Slighe** (an TROOR na SHLEE-uh): The Three of the Path
- **Anam Cara** (AH-nam KA-ra): Soulmate
- **Bàsail** (BAH-sil): Death
- **Brae** (bray): A hillside; a sloping rise of land
- **Dìdeanair** (jee-JEE-an-er): Guardian/soldier
- **Ceatharnaich** (KEH-her-neekh): Rebels
- **Dàn** (dahn): Magical runes inked into skin like tattoos, gifted by the Fates
- **Geallta** (GYAL-tuh): Betrothed
- **Mallachdaichte** (MAL-ukhk-EECH-tchuh): Cursed; damned
- **Mallachd** (MAH-lukhk): To curse
- **Mallachd ort!** (MAH-lukhk orsht): “Damn you”
- **Mo chreach** (muh-KHREKH): My ruin; an expression of grief or despair
- **Mo chridhe** (muh KHREE-uh)**:** My heart
- **Mo ghràidh** (muh GHR-EYE): My love
- **Mo rùn** (muh ROON): My darling
- **M’ anam** (MAH-num): My soul
- **Smir** (smeer): A fine, drifting rain; a mist that clings to skin

- **Tha mi ’gad mhallachadh** (ha mee gad VA-lukh-ugh): “I curse you”
- **Eiridh** (AY-ree): Awakening

Characters:

- **Athair** (AH-her): Cailleach’s dragon
- **Brìghde** (BREE-juh)**:** One of the three Fates, The Weaver
- **Cailleach** (KAL-yukh): One of the three Fates, The Cutter
- **Measaire** (MAY-sser-uh): One of the three Fates, The Measurer
- **The Washwoman/Bean-Nighe** (behn-NEE-uh)/**Bea** (BEE-uh): A washer at the river’s edge, bound to cleanse the garments of the dead

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Goddesses (The Naoimh (NEEV)): Sisters

- **Ban-dia a’ Bhàis** (BAN-jee-uh uh VAASH): Supreme Goddess, eldest sister and Goddess of life and death
- **Dìonadair** (JEE-un-uh-der): Goddess of protection. Lesser Goddess
- **Dorchadas** (DOR-uh-khuh-dus): Goddess of the darkness. Lesser Goddess
- **Mire** (MEE-ruh): Muse of love and madness. Lesser Goddess
- **Solas** (SOH-lass): Goddess of light. Lesser Goddess
- **Uisge** (ISH-ka)**:** Goddess of water. Lesser Goddess
- **Blàr** (blahr)**:** Goddess of battle and monsters. Lesser Goddess
- **Ceò** (kyoh): Goddess of the mist. Lesser Goddess
- **Talamh** (TAL-uv): Goddess of the earth. Lesser Goddess
- **Beathag** (BEH-hak)**:** Goddess of beasts. Lesser Goddess

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Places:

- **Na Trì** (nah TREE): The Kingdom of the Three
- **Tìr an Gearradair** (cheer un GYAR-uh-der): The Cutter's domain
- **Tìr an Tomhais** (cheer un TOH-ish): The Measurer's domain
- **Tìr an Fhigheadair** (cheer un EE-uh-der): The Weaver's domain
- **Vengach** (VEN-a-ghakh): Brennen's home village
- **Dalbàsail** (dal-BAS-suhl): The village by the River Bàsail
- **Dùn an t-Snàth** (doon un tnah): Capital city of Tir an Gearradair
- **Taigh na Beathaga** (tie nuh BEH-huh): Capital city of Tìr an Fhigheadair
- **Caisteal na h-Ùine** (KASH-chul nuh HOON-yuh): Capital city of Tìr an Tomhais

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Military rankings:

- **A' Chiad** (uh KHEE-ud): First
- **An Dàrna** (un DAHR-nuh): Second
- **An Treas** (un TRESS): Third
- **An Ceathramh** (un KEHR-uhv): Fourth
- **An Àrd** (un AHrd): The supreme; the highest military rank

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Three of the path: Brothers, Old Gods

- **An Glèidheadair** (un GLAY-uh-dur): The Keeper; god and gatekeeper of the *After*
- **An Treòraiche** (un TROH-ree-khuh): The Guide; god who leads souls along the path of the *After*
- **Am Breitheamh** (um BRAY-huv): The Judge; god and judge of the *After*

- **Prayer of the Three:** An Glèidheadair welcome him, An Treòraiche guide him, Am Breitheamh have mercy on him.

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